
Six Worlds

A Writer's Guide to the Game

Prepared for Alice

A tactical RPG roguelike of rebirth through the six realms
Everything the game is, and everything it contains so far

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Welcome, Alice

Alice, thank you for taking this on.

This document is the whole of *Six Worlds* as it stands, written for someone who will be writing inside it. It explains what the game is and how it works in terms a player would recognise, with no code and no numbers you don't need. Then it sets out everything the game already contains: the realms, the births, the backgrounds, the companions and every event written so far.

The game is a passion project by Olaf, who has written most of what is here. The remainder was drafted by an AI assistant and is waiting for a human hand; wherever that matters, this guide says so (see chapter 28). Your voice is wanted most in the two places the game leans on hardest: **characters** (the companions you can recruit, the births and backgrounds that define who you are) and **events** (the short branching scenes you meet while travelling).

How to read this guide

- **Parts I and II** are context: what the game is, and how its systems work. Read them once, then keep them for reference.
- **Part III** walks through the realms and prints *every event written so far*, verbatim.
- **Part IV** prints every birth, background and companion, verbatim.
- **Part V** covers what needs writing, the conventions to follow and how to send work back.

Verbatim means verbatim. Where this guide prints game text (event scenes, choices, descriptions, companion bios) it is copied straight from the game's data files, unedited. Small grey lines under it, such as ids and karma, are reference labels added for you and are not game text.

Every event, companion, birth, background and trait carries an `id`. If you write a replacement or a new version, quoting the `id` is all that is needed for it to find its place.

Part I: The Game in Brief

1. The premise

Six Worlds is a tactical role-playing roguelike set inside the Tibetan Buddhist wheel of life. The wheel has six realms of rebirth: the hells, the hungry ghosts, the animals, the humans, the jealous gods (asuras) and the gods. The player does not play one hero. They play a stream of lives. A character is born into one realm as one kind of being, travels and fights and chooses, and sooner or later dies. Then they are reborn, and *where* they are reborn is the game's central question.

The game is played in three modes that alternate:

- **Overworld.** A map of one realm, crossed in real time. Towns, shrines, wandering monsters, hidden places and portals to the next realm.
- **Events.** Short scenes in the style of *FTL*: a paragraph of description and a handful of choices. Most of the game's writing lives here.
- **Combat.** Turn-based fights on a grid, with spells, weapons, positioning and a party of up to several characters.

It is built in the Godot engine. The visual style is a **thangka** painting frame (ornate borders in deep red, gold and indigo) around classic **pixel art** characters and landscapes.

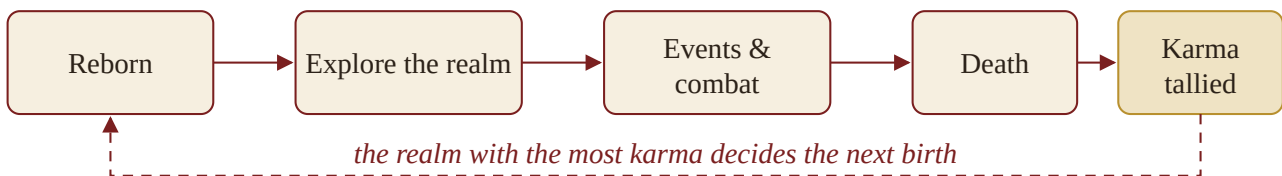
The central design idea: Buddhist concepts are not decoration on top of the game; they *are* the mechanics. Karma decides your next life. There are no levels, because cultivation is gradual. Your emotional state (the five poisons and five wisdoms) changes how you fight and what you can do. Writing for the game means writing inside that cosmology.

2. The loop

A single run of the game is a loop that repeats across lifetimes:

1. **Reincarnate.** The game picks a realm, a birth (the kind of being you are) and a background (what you did in life). See chapter 5.
2. **Explore.** You cross that realm's map: three to five regions, each with its own feel, monsters and people.
3. **Meet events.** At places on the map, a scene opens. You read it, pick a choice, and something happens: a gift, a fight, a recruit, a wound, a change of heart. Each choice quietly shifts your karma.
4. **Fight, rest, recruit.** Combat is turn-based. Between fights the party makes camp and recovers, and companions can be hired in towns and met on the road.
5. **Cross the realm.** At the far end of each realm waits a portal to the next. Some are guarded by a boss.
6. **Die.** When the party falls, the life ends. Karma is tallied; the realm where it is highest becomes your next birth.

The loop is roguelike: you start over, but not from nothing. Some things carry across lives, and the player's own knowledge carries most of all. The realms you have visited are the ones you can be reborn into, so the more of the wheel you have walked, the more of it can claim you.



3. Tone and visual identity

Tone

The game is serious about its subject and not solemn about it. The hells are cruel but they are also bureaucratic, absurd and occasionally funny: a demon who files every permit, a torturer who is merely good at his job. The hungry ghosts are pitiful and uncanny. The animal realm is predatory but also tender and territorial. A good scene in this game can make you wince and laugh in the same paragraph.

A few rules of thumb, drawn from what already works:

- **Impermanence over spectacle.** Things are always falling apart, being reborn or being forgotten. Endings are rarely clean.
- **No moralising.** The game never tells the player a choice was good or bad. Karma is hidden. The consequence is simply what happens next.
- **Beings have reasons.** Every monster is somebody: a soldier, a mother, a clerk, a pack leader. Even the cruel ones are in the realm they are in because of what they did and what they wanted.
- **Craving, hatred and delusion are the engine.** The realms are made of the same poisons you can feel in yourself. Let them show up as human, specific and slightly embarrassing motives.
- **Practice is real.** Mantras, offerings, mandalas, meditation and rites are treated respectfully and accurately. Sacred names of deities are *translated* into English, never printed in the original.

Visual identity

Think of a thangka: the ordered, gilded frame around a scene. The interface is that frame, with deep reds, golds and indigos. Inside the frame is pixel art, in the manner of classic 16-bit role-playing games. Writing should suit both: crisp and compact, ornament held back for where it counts. Event text appears in a window the size of a few paragraphs, so brevity is a virtue.

4. Where the game stands

The game's systems are all built and the engine runs; what is thin is *content*. A snapshot:

Realm	Status	Births	Events	Companions
Hell (Naraka)	Complete first pass	6	79	24
Hungry Ghost (Pretaloka)	Complete first pass	14	150	23
Animal (Tiryakloka)	Complete first pass	18	86	52
Human	Empty	4 defined	0	0
Asura	Empty	2 defined	0	0
God	Empty	3 defined	0	0

In addition there are 33 cross-realm events that can occur anywhere, and 118 traits, 120 backgrounds and 600-odd perks.

The game has not yet been played from start to finish. Each system works on its own, but the complete loop (reborn, explore, fight, die, reborn) has not been sat down with. Expect the first real playthrough to find rough edges. Part of the reason for this guide is to get a human reader's eye on the content before it does.

Three realms (Human, Asura, God) have no map, no enemies and no events yet. They are the largest gaps and the most exciting places to write. Chapter 22 describes what is intended for them.

Part II: Core Systems, in Player Terms

5. Karma and rebirth

Every realm has a hidden **karma** score. Nearly every choice in an event nudges one or more of them up. For instance, giving food to a starving ghost raises human and god karma, while attacking the weakened thing raises hell. The player is never shown the numbers. They find out only when they die.

When the party falls, the game checks which realm's karma is highest among the realms the player has visited. That realm is where the next life begins. Within it, the game rolls a **birth** (some births are common, some rare) and then a **background**. A fraction of the karma persists into the next life, so habits and tendencies carry over: a player who steadily feeds the hungry will drift towards the human and god realms, while one who steadily harms will remain among the hells.

The six karmas

Realm	The poison behind it	Typical acts that feed it in events
Hell	Hatred, anger	Violence, cruelty, vengeance, killing the helpless
Hungry Ghost	Craving, greed, clinging	Hoarding, grasping, refusing to share, clinging to the past
Animal	Ignorance, instinct	Trickery, theft, base appetite, avoiding thought
Human	Desire and a mixed life	Ordinary decency, trade, kindness with self-interest
Asura	Jealousy, rivalry	Competition, ambition, fighting for status
God	Pride, comfortable bliss	Compassion, generosity, practice, release

The Human, Asura and God rows are provisional, since those realms have no content yet. This table is a writer's guideline, not an exact rule. Every choice can move several karmas at once, and the karma lines printed under each choice in Part III show how Olaf has used it so far. Good writing here means the choice reads as natural and the karma is a quiet echo of it.

One open design question: should deep practice (Yoga) ever let a character glimpse their own karma? For now, no. The mystery is part of the point.

6. The character: attributes

A character has no level. Instead, they have **seven attributes**, a set of **skills** (chapter 7) and a pool of **experience** they spend freely on improving either. Because XP is spent, never "banked until the next level", growth is gradual and reflects the idea that enlightenment is not a threshold you cross.

The seven attributes

Attribute	What it means in the fiction	What it does
Strength	Raw muscle, force of body.	Hitting hard in melee, carrying more.
Constitution	Toughness, endurance, a body that holds up under strain.	Hit points. Half of stamina.
Finesse	Agility, speed, coordination, light-footedness.	Dodging, acting first, moving farther, critical hits. Half of stamina.
Focus	Concentration, discipline of the mind, will.	Spell power, how strong your magic is.
Awareness	Perception, intuition, sensitivity to what is around you and within you.	Mana pool, acting first, noticing things on the map and in events, critical hits.
Charm	Presence, warmth, the ability to move people.	Social choices in events, leadership.
Luck	The way things fall for you. Not a skill; a tilt in the world.	Critical chance, quality of loot.

Derived measures

A few bars on the character sheet are built out of the attributes: **HP** (life), **Mana** (the well magic is drawn from), **Stamina** (what physical actions cost), **Initiative** (who acts first), **Movement** and **Dodge**.

Power without levels

Because there are no levels, the game describes how strong someone is *relative to you* in words: "slightly stronger", "vastly weaker", and so on. This appears when hiring mercenaries or sizing up an enemy. If you write a line in which a character judges an opponent, use that register.

Attributes in events

Events can open a choice because someone in your party has a high enough attribute ("Charm 15"). Rolls (yellow choices) take the best party member's attribute plus a d20 against a difficulty. See chapter 13.

7. Skills and the five elements

There are **35 skills**, seven for each of the five elements. A point in a skill does two things: it makes the character better at the thing the skill names, and it adds to that element's **affinity**. For example, Maces 2 + Earth Magic 3 + Summoning 1 gives an Earth affinity of 6, which pays out in broader benefits (Earth, for instance, favours hit points and wealth). Characters therefore drift towards an elemental temperament by what they practise.

The five elements

The elements come from the Tibetan tradition, where each is tied to a mental poison and the wisdom it can turn into. This shapes both skills and the emotional life of characters (chapter 10).

Element	Poison	Wisdom	Character
Space	Delusion	Openness, clear awareness	Subtle, transcendent, mind and perception. Healing, curses, persuasion and yoga.
Air	Envy	Skilful action	Quick, restless, clever. Lightning and wind, stealth, knowledge, wit.
Fire	Desire	Discernment, warmth	Passionate, forceful, charismatic. Flames, brute strength, leading, performing.
Water	Aversion	Mirror-like clarity	Flowing, adaptive, subtle. Ice, healing arts, grace, thievery.
Earth	Pride	Equanimity	Solid, patient, material. Stone, armour, trade, smithing, summoning.

Skills at a glance

Each skill is listed with the element it belongs to, a plain description of what it does for a character, and the attribute it leans on most. Some skills have special value in events (a high Medicine opens healing options; a high Comedy opens a joke that defuses the situation).

Space skills

Skill	What it does for a character	Leans on
Swords	Fighting with bladed weapons. Precise, clear-headed, the swordsman's discipline.	Finesse / Strength
Martial Arts	Transcendent unarmed and weapon-less fighting in a wuxia spirit: flying kicks, leaping strikes, a body trained until it seems to move on its own.	Finesse / Awareness
Space Magic	Magic of void, distance and dimensions: teleporting, blinking, rifts, illusions of space.	Focus / Awareness
White Magic	Healing, protection, sacred light: the benevolent magic of blessing and mending.	Focus / Charm
Black Magic	Curses, debuffs and necromancy: harm that works through the unseen.	Focus / Constitution
Persuasion	Talking people round with words and presence. Opens social choices and gets better prices.	Charm / Awareness
Yoga	Internal cultivation: mantras, meditation, insight into karma, and peaceful solutions. Gives resistance to mental harm.	Focus / Constitution

Air skills

Skill	What it does for a character	Leans on
Ranged	Bows, crossbows and thrown weapons.	Finesse / Awareness
Daggers	Small blades and quick strikes. Close, fast and often sneaky.	Finesse / Awareness

Air Magic	Wind and lightning. Fast, high-damage magic that can stun and scatter.	Focus / Finesse
Ritual	External ceremony: drawing mandalas, using material components, boosting spells. The craft of rites.	Focus / Awareness
Learning	Knowledge of realms, monsters and lore. Helps in lore-based choices and improves how fast the party learns.	Focus / Awareness
Comedy	Wit, humour and trickster dialogue. A well-placed joke can defuse a fight; also nudges luck.	Charm / Awareness
Guile	Stealth, sneaking, intrigue. Slipping past, lying well, being where you are not expected.	Finesse / Awareness

Fire skills

Skill	What it does for a character	Leans on
Axes	Axes and heavy chopping weapons.	Strength / Constitution
Unarmed	Fighting with bare hands, fangs or claws. Passionate, direct combat.	Strength / Finesse
Fire Magic	Flame and heat: burning, wide-area damage, and the charming fire of the lotus.	Focus / Strength
Sorcery	Direct magical power: spells that simply happen (a Fireball, a bolt). The workhorse of attack magic.	Focus / Strength
Might	Feats of strength and endurance: lifting the gate, wrestling the beast, outlasting hardship.	Strength / Constitution
Leadership	Inspiring and commanding others in battle and beyond. Lets a character lead a larger company.	Charm / Strength
Performance	Passionate artistic expression: song, dance, seduction. Moves crowds and lifts morale.	Charm / Finesse

Water skills

Skill	What it does for a character	Leans on
Spears	Spears, halberds and polearms. Reach and discipline.	Strength / Finesse
Water Magic	Water and ice: freezing, flooding and controlling the battlefield rather than raw damage.	Focus / Awareness
Enchantment	Spells with duration: buffs, wards, shields, charms. Changes that last for a while.	Focus / Charm
Grace	Agility, balance and flowing movement. Makes a character harder to hit, quicker to act and faster across the map.	Finesse / Awareness
Medicine	Healing arts: treating wounds and illness, making the party's recovery better. Uses up herbs.	Awareness / Focus
Alchemy	Brewing potions and transmuting materials.	Focus / Awareness
Thievery	Lock-picking, pickpocketing, acquiring things that were not offered. Finds better loot and spots traps.	Finesse / Luck

Earth skills

Skill	What it does for a character	Leans on
Maces	Blunt weapons and crushing blows.	Strength / Constitution

Armor	Wearing armour and shields well. Better protection from the same gear.	Constitution / Strength
Earth Magic	Stone and earth: spikes, walls, tremors, bark skin, and the sturdiness of the ground.	Focus / Constitution
Summoning	Calling creatures and objects into being: imps, nagas, guardians, hosts.	Focus / Charm
Logistics	Provisioning and moving a party: stretching food, travelling faster. Uses up food.	Awareness / Charm
Trade	Bargaining, valuing, finding rare goods. Better prices when buying and selling.	Charm / Awareness
Smithing	Making and mending: repairs equipment and restores ammunition. Uses up scrap.	Focus / Finesse

8. Magic

Magic in the game is organised by **schools**. There are ten: the five elements (*Space, Air, Fire, Water, Earth*) and five further disciplines that cut across them: *Sorcery, Enchantment, Summoning, White* and *Black*. Spells are tagged with more than one school. A Fireball is Fire *and* Sorcery; a stone shield might be Earth *and* Enchantment. To cast a spell the character needs at least one of its schools at the spell's required level; every matching school the character has adds further bonuses to damage or cost.

Spells are bought from guilds and spell trainers in towns, learned from events, or come with a birth or a background. There are about 370 of them, in five tiers of power (levels 1, 3, 5, 7 and 9).

The ten schools, with sample spells

Space

Void, distance, illusion, perception. Spells that move you, hide you or confuse the enemy.

- **Magic Missile** level 1 (also Sorcery): Reliable space damage, guaranteed hit
- **Blink** level 3 (also Sorcery): Teleport oneself medium distance
- **Dimensional Rift** level 7 (also Air): Tear in space scatters enemies to random locations

Air

Wind and lightning. High damage with stun, scattering and speed. Also birds, flight, sound.

- **Gentle Breeze** level 1 (also White): Minor heal, restore Stamina
- **Lightning** level 5 (also Sorcery): High air damage with stun chance
- **Garuda** level 9 (also Fire, Summoning): Summon a mighty Garuda

Fire

Flame, heat, radiance. Burning damage over time in wide areas, plus charm and warmth from the lotus family.

- **Firebolt** level 1 (also Sorcery): Fire damage + burning
- **Fire Lotus** level 3 (also Sorcery): Nova - ring damage, safe center
- **Balefire** level 7 (also Black): Cursed fire that prevents resurrection, destroys corpse on kill

Water

Ice, flood, vajra-thunderbolt. Less damage than other schools but strong at control: freezing, binding, pushing.

- **Ice Bolt** level 3 (also Sorcery): Ice damage + freeze chance
- **Naga** level 3 (also Summoning): Summon a naga
- **Rain of Revival** level 7 (also White): Moderate heal, buff initiative, add one action in AoE

Earth

Stone, plants, metal, glass. Sturdy protection and solid damage; also growing things and wealth.

- **Stone Spike** level 1 (also Sorcery): Physical damage to one target
- **Stone Wall** level 3 (also Summoning): Summon a stone wall
- **Earthquake** level 7 (also Sorcery): Physical damage in large area

Sorcery

Direct, instant magical power: bolts, balls, blasts. If it just happens, it is probably Sorcery.

- **Fireball** level 5 (also Fire): AoE fire damage + burning
- **Mark for Death** level 3 (also Black): Mark a target with the sigil of ending. No damage — but the next time the target is struck, that hit deals 50% additional damage of its original type. Consumed on trigger. The mark lasts up to 3 turns.
- **Voidbolt** level 1 (also Black): Fire a bolt of void-darkness at the target. Reliable single-target black damage.

Enchantment

Changes that last: buffs, wards and charms that hold for a number of turns.

- **Haste** level 3 (also Air): Speed and initiative boost
- **Mirror Image** level 5 (also Space): Create illusory copies, attacks may hit copies instead
- **Berserk** level 7 (also Fire, Space): Target attacks closest creature indiscriminately

Summoning

Creatures and objects called out of nowhere: imps, skeletons, nagas, hosts and guardians.

- **Imp** level 1 (also Black): Summon an imp - flying, high dodge, low damage, annoying
- **Skeleton** level 3 (also Black): Summon a skeleton
- **Agnideva Lord** level 9 (also Fire): Summon a powerful fire spirit lord

White

Healing, protection, blessing and sacred light. Also dealing with the dead and the departed.

- **Cure** level 1 (also Sorcery): Heal moderate HP and reliably remove one negative effect.
- **Pacify** level 3 (also Enchantment): Chance to make enemy disengage from combat
- **Cleansing Fire** level 7 (also Fire): A wave of purifying fire washes over the area. All allies are cleansed of every negative effect and gain the Cleansed status (2-turn immunity to debuffs). Enemies take minor fire damage.

Black

Curses, poison, necromancy and debuffs. The craft of harm and decay.

- **Life Drain** level 3 (also Sorcery): Steal HP from enemy
- **Hands of the Damned** level 5 (also Sorcery): Black damage and fear in AoE
- **Festering Wound** level 3 (also Water): Poison DoT that increases each turn

The domains: spells that cross two elements

Beyond the ten schools there are **ten special domains**, each born where two elements meet. Domain spells are *not* sold in ordinary guilds. They can only be learned through rare events in the world, each tied to a place, such as a crystal cave or a smoking mirror, and some are sold afterwards by the people you meet there. A domain is as much a place and a story as a set of spells.

Crystal Earth + Space

Clarity, resonance, precision. Crystal focuses and reveals.

Where earth is compressed to perfection by space, crystal grows — ordered, resonant, and perfectly transparent. Crystal magic is a discipline of clarity: it reveals what hides, focuses the mind to a razor edge, and defends by refracting rather than absorbing. The Crystal Guardian is its emblem: patient, immovable, and lethal at a distance.

Spells: Scattered Light, Crystal Guardian, Crystal Diadem, Crystal Light | **Found through the event:** Crystal Cave

Glass Earth + Air

Precision, fragility, reflection. Glass wounds and reveals.

Where earth is seized by air and made impossibly thin, glass is born — transparent, silent, and lethal when broken. Glass magic is precise and reactive: a shard in the dark, powder in the eyes, a globe that waits to shatter. It punishes the enemy for coming close and the ally for taking hits.

Spells: Glass Shard, Powdered Glass, Globe of Glass, Glass Mine | **Found through the event:** Glass Mountain

Smoke Earth + Fire

Concealment, suffocation, transformation. Smoke obscures and corrupts.

Where fire meets earth, smoke is born — neither solid nor flame, a thing between states. Smoke magic inherits fire's hunger and earth's patience: it lingers, it blinds, it creeps into lungs and minds. The Smoking Mirror is its emblem: a surface that shows not the world but what the world hides.

Spells: Smoke Cloud, Smoke Imp, Choking Smoke, Smoke Form | **Found through the event:** The Smoking Mirror

Mud Earth + Water

Corruption, weight, tenacity. Mud endures and smothers.

Where earth and water meet without ceremony, mud is born — patient, heavy, and suffocating. Mud magic combines the endurance of earth with the corrosion of water: slow but relentless, hard to wash off.

Spells: Mudling, Metal to Mud, Rain of Mud, Mindmuck | **Found through the event:** The Pit

Cloud Water + Air

Transience, sovereignty, height. Cloud moves freely, belongs nowhere, answers to no one.

Where water surrenders its weight to air, cloud is born — neither earth nor sky, neither solid nor gone. Cloud magic is the discipline of the in-between: it slips past barriers, sheds damage like rain, carries the party home on a breath of wind, and answers a call with something vast and serpentine that lives between the rain and the stars. The nagas who dwell in cloud are rare and sovereign; they do not welcome interruption, but they respect those who know how to approach.

Spells: Cloudstep, Cloudform, Cloud Serpent, Cloud Gate | **Found through the event:** Cloud Palace

Steam Water + Fire

Purification, eruption, transformation. Steam cleanses and scalds.

Where water meets fire, steam is born — neither liquid nor flame, a force that cleanses and scalds in equal measure. Steam magic purifies and erupts: healing mists that strip poison from allies, geysers that hurl enemies skyward, and lingering fog that sears those who linger.

Spells: Steam Jet, Fragrant Sauna, Geyser, Scalding Fog | **Found through the event:** Waterworks

Rainbow Space + White

Prismatic chaos, revelation, transcendence. Rainbow dazzles and illuminates.

Where space refracts through white light, rainbow is born — not one thing but all things at once, shimmering and impossible to hold. Rainbow magic is wildly unpredictable: each spell rolls its own dice, choosing from a palette of effects that might blind, charm, heal, or burn. Those who master it learn to see reality itself as a display of light.

Spells: Rainbow Orb, Rainbow Spray, A Vision of Reality, Rainbow Cloak | **Found through the event:** Skygazing Gompa

Tummo Fire + Air

Inner heat, yogic fire, self-transformation. Tummo burns from within.

Where fire meets air within the body, tummo is born — the inner heat of yogic practice, the flame that melts the crown and blazes upward from the secret chakra. Tummo magic transforms the caster rather than the world: resistance to the elements, transfer of vitality, and ultimately the blazing and dripping of the inner channels.

Spells: Inner Flame, Heat Transfer, Flash of Radiance, Blazing and Dripping | **Found through the event:** Snowcapped Hermitage

Luminosity Fire + Space

Clear light, perception, mental mastery. Luminosity reveals and protects the mind.

Where fire illuminates space, luminosity is born — not the light of sun or flame but the clear light of awareness itself. Luminosity magic grants vision that pierces all deception, an aura that shields the mind from manipulation, and illusions so vivid they confuse even those who know what they are seeing.

Spells: Clear Mind, Divine Eye, Radiant Visage, Shining Mirage | **Found through the event:** Dark Cave

Sound Air + Space

Vibration, mantra, resonance. Sound shatters and commands.

Where air vibrates through space, sound is born — not mere noise but the primordial vibration that shapes reality. Sound magic is the discipline of mantra and resonance: battle chants that sharpen the will, dirges that sap the spirit, sonic blasts that shatter armor and silence, and the legendary eleventh note that transcends all structure.

Spells: Battle Chant, Eerie Dirge, Sonic Boom, Up to Eleven | **Found through the event:** Court Of The Musician Prince

9. Perks and traits

Traits

A **trait** is a standing fact about a character: something they are or have become, not something they have bought. Traits are the main way a character feels like a *person* in a scene. They show up in events (a character who is *curious* sees options that an *incurious* one does not), shape how companions get along, and subtly tilt the emotional life described in chapter 10.

Traits come from several places:

- **Inborn:** rolled at creation: one *physical*, one *personality* and one *behavioral* trait.
- **Racial:** come with the birth (a *dura* is *armored*, a *gana* has the *colony mind*).
- **Acquired:** earned during play. A scar after a severe wound, a limp after losing a limb, *death-touched* after surviving a fatal blow, *long-marched* after thirty rests on the road, *bloodied* after killing a boss. Events can also grant or remove traits.

Traits are one of the most useful things for an event writer, because an event can open (or close) a choice depending on whether a party member has a given trait, and companions come with their own. The full list follows.

9.1 The full trait list

All 118 traits in the game. “Effect” lists the stat changes a trait carries; “mind leans toward” shows which way it tilts the emotional scales of chapter 10 (a trait that makes a character more prone to pride, for instance).

Physical traits

Trait	Description	Effect on the character	Mind leans toward
Strong strong	Doors seem a little narrow.	Strength +1	—
Frail frail	A fragile constitution, easily tired and slow to heal.	Constitution -1	—
Clubfooted clubfooted	An awkward gait that hampers quick movement.	Finesse -1	—
Quick quick	Naturally fast reflexes and light feet.	Finesse +1	—
Sharp-eyed sharp_eyed	Nothing escapes their notice.	Awareness +1	alertness (more)
Hard of Hearing hard_of_hearing	Weary of asking others to repeat themselves, they begrudgingly accepted their condition.	Awareness -1	—
Iron Stomach iron_stomach	Five second rule!	—	—
Attractive attractive	A pleasing appearance opens many doors.	Charm +1	pride (more)
Light Sleeper light_sleeper	Sleep with one eye open, gripping the pillow tight.	Awareness +1	envy (more)
Night Owl night_owl	The owl of wisdom flies after midnight.	—	—
Chronic Pain chronic_pain	Dull, throbbing, always there.	Constitution -1; Yoga +1	aversion (more); pride (more)

Impaired Vision impaired_vision	Struggles in the dark, misses details and enemies.	Awareness -1	—
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Personality traits

Trait	Description	Effect on the character	Mind leans toward
Hot-tempered hot_tempered	Quick to anger, slow to forgive.	Charm -1	aversion (more)
Patient patient	Once you endure the first impulse, you can wait almost indefinitely.	—	clarity (more); warmth (more)
Brave brave	Faces danger without flinching.	—	alertness (more); clarity (more)
Timid timid	Easily frightened; prefers to avoid confrontation.	Charm -1	envy (more)
Curious curious	Irresistibly drawn to the unknown.	Learning +1	openness (more)
Stubborn stubborn	Hard to sway in any direction — for good or ill.	—	pride (more)
Trusting trusting	Extends goodwill freely, perhaps too freely.	Charm +1; Awareness -1	alertness (more)
Suspicious suspicious	Trusts no one at face value.	Charm -1; Awareness +1	envy (more)
Greedy greedy	Always calculating what they stand to gain.	Trade +1	desire (more); pride (more)
Generous generous	Gives freely, expects little in return.	Charm +1	equanimity (more)
Melancholic melancholic	A deep sadness runs beneath the surface.	—	aversion (more)
Vain vain	Takes great pride in their appearance and reputation.	Charm +1	pride (more)
Forgetful forgetful	Details slip away; rarely remembers what was said.	Learning -1	delusion (more)
Sharp Memory sharp_memory	Remembers everything — names, faces, slights.	Learning +1	openness (more)
Content content	When you don't have what you like, like what you have.	—	equanimity (more); warmth (more)
Warm-hearted warm_hearted	Easy to like, and easy about liking other people.	Charm +1	warmth (more); clarity (more)
Clear-eyed clear_eyed	Sees what is in front of them without dressing it up.	—	clarity (more); openness (more)
Covetous covetous	Measures their life against other people's, and comes up short every time.	—	envy (more); pride (more)
Incurious incurious	At first, asking questions was difficult, then it became impossible.	—	delusion (more)
Grudge-bearer grudge_bearer	Forgets nothing that was done to them, and keeps the ledger current.	—	aversion (more); envy (more)

Craven craven	Runs first and reasons afterwards. Whatever else is true, nothing has ever caught them.	Finesse +1; Might -1	desire (more); pride (more)
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Behavioral traits

Trait	Description	Effect on the character	Mind leans toward
Gourmand gourmand	Takes great pleasure in fine food and good company at table.	—	desire (more)
Bird Lover bird_lover	Aren't those beady eyes just adorable?	—	—
Gambler gambler	Did you know most gamblers walk away from the table right before a big win?	Luck +1	desire (more)
Storyteller storyteller	Always has a tale ready — some true, most embellished.	Persuasion +1	alertness (more)
Collector collector	Compelled to gather and catalogue curious objects.	—	desire (more)
Superstitious superstitious	There are no coincidences, only signs!	—	delusion (more)
Night Drinker night_drinker	When the sun goes down, the glass goes up.	—	desire (more)
Paranoid paranoid	Always watching. Always expecting the worst. Wait, did you hear that?	Awareness +1; Charm -1	envy (more)
Dreamer dreamer	Feels more at home among the visions than the flesh.	Focus +1	delusion (more)
Fastidious fastidious	Particular about cleanliness and order; unsettled by squalor.	—	pride (more)
Present present	Here and now.	Awareness +1	openness (more)
Celebrant celebrant	Takes uncomplicated pleasure in other people's luck.	—	alertness (more)
Tea Ritualist tea_ritualist	The drinking is only the last part of the pleasure.	—	clarity (more)
Poet poet	Composes constantly in their head, and occasionally, without warning, out loud.	—	—
Duelist duelist	Prides themselves on never turning down a challenge.	—	—
Braggart braggart	Improves the story a little every time it is told.	—	—
Pilgrim pilgrim	The party schedule will wait, the shrine must be circumambulated.	—	—
Debtor debtor	Owes money somewhere, to someone with an unusually long memory.	—	—
Flirt flirt	Incurably charming, and worst of all at the least convenient moments.	—	—
Homesick homesick	The farther away you are from your home, the easier it is to see it through rose-colored glasses.	—	—

Early Riser early_riser	Early bird gets to gloat when others wake up.	—	—
Ascetic ascetic	Eats little, sleeps hard, and wants less than the people around them.	—	—
Mourner mourner	Keeps the dead's days. Leaves food out on the right nights, wherever they are.	—	—
Gossip gossip	Knows everyone's business within a day of arriving anywhere.	—	—
Scrimper scrimper	Cannot part with money without a grimace.	—	—
Beast-tender beast_tender	Good with animals, and they appear to know it right away.	—	—
Sworn Vegetarian sworn_vegetarian	Will not eat anything that had a mother.	—	—
Secret-bearer secret_bearer	Carrying something they have told nobody, and have no plans to.	—	—
Bhang Enjoyer bhang_enjoyer	Takes it only at the festivals - and isn't every day a festival of its own kind?	—	delusion (more); clarity (more)
Hunter hunter	Reads ground the way other people read letters. Knows what passed, how long ago, and whether it was hungry.	Ranged +1	—
Pet-lover pet_lover	Has never once passed an animal without stopping.	—	clarity (more)

Acquired traits

Trait	Description	Effect on the character	Mind leans toward
Haunted haunted	Disturbing memories surface at the worst moments.	—	aversion (more); delusion (more)
War-hardened war_hardened	Violence no longer shocks, only excites the senses.	Constitution +1	aversion (more); alertness (more)
Grief-struck grief_struck	Carrying a loss that has not yet found its shape.	—	aversion (more)
Blood-handed blood_handed	Has taken lives that weigh on the soul.	—	aversion (more); pride (more)
Oath-breaker oath_breaker	Has broken a solemn vow. The weight of it is visible.	Charm -2	pride (more)
Devout devout	A sincere and practiced faith shapes every act.	Yoga +1; Ritual +1	openness (more)
Lapsed lapsed	Once practiced, now adrift. The forms remain but the heart has gone.	Ritual -1	delusion (more)
Composed composed	A hard-won calm. Seldom ruffled by what once would have stung.	—	warmth (more); clarity (more)
Enlightened Insight enlightened_insight	A rare flash of clarity left a permanent mark.	Focus +1	openness (more); warmth (more)
Addiction addiction	Dependent on something — herbs, drink, or something stranger.	—	desire (more); pride (more)

Oath-keeper oath_keeper	Has held to a vow through the circumstances that made holding it expensive.	Yoga +1	equanimity (more)
Renunciate renunciate	Has put down something they wanted badly, on purpose, and did not pick it back up.	Yoga +1	warmth (more); equanimity (more)
Merciful merciful	Has spared someone who could not have stopped them.	—	clarity (more)
Scarred scarred	The wound closed. The body it closed on is not quite the one they had before.	—	—
Maimed maimed	Something is gone that used to be there. Warmth still seems to linger in the void.	—	pride (more)
Death-touched death_touched	Was owed to something, and was not collected. It has changed how they walk into rooms.	—	clarity (more); delusion (more)
Steady Practice steady_practice	Sits every night, whether or not the night deserves it.	Yoga +1	openness (more)
Mantra-worn mantra_worn	Has said it enough times that it says itself now, under everything else.	Yoga +1; Ritual +1	openness (more)
Ash-marked ash_marked	Has done the purification rites often enough to stop finding them strange.	Ritual +1	equanimity (more)
Slayer bloodied	Has killed something that everyone agreed could not be killed.	—	aversion (more)
Sole Survivor sole_survivor	Walked out of something that nobody else walked out of.	—	aversion (more); delusion (more)
Long-marched long_marched	Has been on the road long enough to stop thinking of settling down.	Logistics +1	—
Touched by Grace touched_by_grace	Met something that had no business being kind to them, and was anyway.	—	openness (more); clarity (more)
Harrowed harrowed	Something happened. They have not described it, and are not going to.	—	aversion (more); envy (more)
Beauty-struck beauty_struck	Saw something that quietly reordered what they had thought possible.	—	openness (more); warmth (more)
Drunk drunk	Past enjoying it, now it's just an everyday fact.	—	desire (more); pride (more)

Racial traits

Trait	Description	Effect on the character	Mind leans toward
Hell-born hell_born	Forged in the fires and torments of hell. Instinctively at home in its rabid violence and hierarchy.	—	desire (more)
Serpentine serpentine	A body built for water and coiling grace, equally at home in the deep as on land.	—	aversion (more)
Aquatic aquatic	Born of the water. Breathes and moves freely in aquatic environments. If the entire party shares this trait, the party may traverse water tiles without penalty in both combat and overworld.	—	aversion (more)

Flying flying	Sustained winged flight. If the entire party shares this trait, the party may traverse air tiles and elevated terrain in combat and overworld.	Finesse +1	envy (more)
Armored armored	Dense natural plating — chitin, thick hide, or bone — makes this creature hard to put down.	Constitution +2; Finesse -1	—
Predator's Grace predator_grace	The natural speed and precision of a born hunter.	Finesse +2; Constitution -1	—
Colony Mind colony_mind	Born into a collective, this creature is never truly alone. Shared purpose dampens individual anxiety.	—	desire (more); aversion (more); pride (more); envy (more); delusion (more)
Bulky bulky	A massive build that weathers punishment others could not survive.	Constitution +1	—
Venom Ward venom_ward	Generations of hunting venomous prey have made this creature resistant to poisons.	—	—
Nimble Mischief nimble_mischief	Quick hands and a quicker mind.	Guile +1	—
Taloned Strike taloned_strike	Natural weapons of uncommon sharpness.	Unarmed +1	—
Swift Wing swift_wing	Exceptional speed even among the creatures of the sky.	Finesse +1	—
Night Vision night_vision	Sees equally in darkness and light, perceiving what others miss.	Awareness +1	—
Undead undead	The body is dead, or was never fully alive. Disease and poison find less purchase; the usual urgencies of flesh have gone quiet.	—	aversion (more)
Incorporeal incorporeal	Barely present in the physical world — more dissolution than body. Food, wealth and violence seem somehow exotic.	Constitution -1	pride (more)
Ancient Memory ancient_memory	Long ages of accumulated experience have sharpened recall and insight. What others learn in a lifetime, this being has lived through many times over.	Awareness +1; Learning +1	—
Insatiable insatiable	Mouth like a gate, throat like a needle.	—	equanimity (more); clarity (more)
Armory Rights better_starting_weapon	Some lives grant wisdom, others grief - this one grants you a superior weapon.	—	—
Hoarder's Instinct extra_starting_gold	Maybe they inherited it, maybe they've hoarded it by themselves - the important part is the weight of the purse.	—	—
Hunter's Yoga hunters_yoga	Lifetimes of the twisted disciplines — breath held to stillness, hunger cultivated rather than sated, the body worked into a shape that only makes sense mid-leap. It is a real practice. It is simply pointed the wrong way.	Strength +1; Yoga +1; Unarmed +1	desire (more)
Guardian's Geas guardian_geas	Bound to a place, a hoard, or a promise made before memory. The binding is not resented; it is the shape of the self. Ask what is being guarded and the answer comes back older than the question.	Charm +1; Ritual +1	equanimity (more)

War Banner war_banner	Where this one stands, a line forms. It is not courage exactly — closer to the certainty that the fight has already been decided and everyone else is simply catching up.	Charm +1; Leadership +1	warmth (more)
Corpse Rider corpse_rider	Wears the dead the way others wear a coat, and has worn many. Something of each one stays behind in the way the hands move.	Focus +1; Sorcery +1	aversion (more)
Sovereign Grudge sovereign_grudge	Ruled something once and has not accepted the loss of it. Every room is a court held in absentia, every slight a matter of record.	Charm +1; Leadership +1	delusion (more)
Deep Current deep_current	Thinks in pressures and distances no surface creature has words for. The magic that comes of it is correspondingly difficult to explain and difficult to argue with.	Focus +1; Water Magic +1	clarity (more)
Hoard Keeper hoard_keeper	Wealth is not spent here, it is accumulated and remembered. Every piece of it has a provenance, and the provenance is the point.	Awareness +1; Trade +1	equanimity (more)
Void Touched void_touched	Stood too near the place where things stop and came back with the cold still in them. Silence follows this one into rooms.	Focus +1; Black Magic +1	delusion (more)
First to Know first_to_know	The head comes up before the sound arrives. Alertness inherited rather than learned.	Awareness +1	—

9.2 Perks

Skills also unlock **perks**: special abilities bought with experience once a skill is high enough. There are around 600. Some are passive (a standing bonus), some active (a technique used in combat), a few are *mantras* (spiritual practices). Perks are the "purchase" side of a character: a trait is what you are, a perk is what you learned to do.

Roughly 500 of them have an empty flavour line waiting for a human voice. A flavour line is one evocative sentence under the mechanical description. Below, two perks from each skill give the idea. (The mechanical wording is Olaf's shorthand and is not the final player-facing text.)

Swords

Measured Strike skill level 1: Active (3 Stamina). Make an attack with +20% accuracy. On hit, gain +15% Armor for 1 turn.

Final Cut skill level 10: Active (8 Stamina). A precise strike that ignores 50% of Armor and 50% of Resistances. If it kills the target, refund 4 Stamina.

Martial Arts

Flowing Footwork skill level 1: Passive. +1 Movement and +10% Dodge while unarmored or in light armor.

Heavenly Counterflow skill level 10: Active (8 Stamina, once per combat). Until your next turn, the first melee attack against you is automatically Dodged, and you immediately reposition up to 2 tiles and counterattack with +30% damage.

Space Magic

Derealization skill level 1: Passive. Space magic debuffs applied to enemies reduce their Initiative by 2 for the duration.

The Door Stands Open skill level 10: Active (once per combat, 15 Mana). Open a gate between any two tiles you can see. It persists for 3 turns; any unit may step through, and allies who do gain +2 Initiative.

White Magic

Clear Light skill level 1: Passive. White spells you cast cannot be interrupted by damage on the turn they are cast. Any damage taken that turn resolves after the spell completes.

Breath Easy skill level 10: Active (once per combat, 12 Mana). For 1 turn, all allies take 90% reduced damage and are immune to status effects.

Black Magic

Blood Pact skill level 1: Lifesteal effects heal 25% more HP.

Soul Feast skill level 10: Damage from Black spells heals the caster for 15% and allies within 3 tiles for 10% of the damage dealt.

Persuasion

Friendly Aura skill level 1: +10% success chance on dialogue checks.

The Word That Turns skill level 10: Passive. Once per event, a failed Persuasion roll may be re-rolled. Blue Persuasion choices unlock two levels below their stated requirement, and hostile NPCs will always hear one sentence before acting.

Yoga

Calm Mind skill level 1: +15% to all mental saving throws.

The Ground of Being skill level 10: Passive. Emotional pressure decays toward baseline at triple rate, and you are immune to crisis states in every element. Once per rest you may extend this immunity to the whole party until the next combat ends.

Ranged

Steady Aim skill level 1: If you did not move this turn, +10% damage on ranged attacks.

One Breath, One Kill skill level 10: Active (once per combat, 6 Stamina). Spend your whole turn aiming. The shot ignores cover, line of sight, and Armor entirely, and critically hits if the target is below half HP.

Daggers

Soft Step skill level 1: While stealthed, enemy detection checks only trigger when passing within 1 tile (instead of 2).

Thousand Cuts skill level 10: Passive. Every dagger hit on a target that is already Bleeding refreshes and deepens the bleed instead of reapplying it (stacking to 5). At 5 stacks the target takes double bleed damage and cannot be healed above half HP.

Air Magic

Sharpened Aim skill level 1: Active (3 Mana). Buff the caster's Attack by +15% and crit chance by +10% for 2 turns.

Conduit of Rudra skill level 10: All allies' attacks deal an additional 5% of weapon damage as Air damage and have a 10% chance to stun for 1 turn.

Ritual

Residual Power skill level 1: After casting a spell, regain 5-10% of the mana spent (random within range).

The Rite Completes Itself skill level 10: Passive. Mandalas and ritual circles you create persist for the whole run rather than a single use, and any ritual you begin continues correctly even if you are interrupted, unconscious, or elsewhere.

Learning

Ask the Right Question skill level 1: +10% to social checks in dialogue involving knowledge, lore, or investigation.

Nothing Is Withheld skill level 10: Passive. Skill checks that use Learning may be attempted twice, taking the better result. XP costs for all skills are reduced by 15%, and you may read any text in any realm regardless of language or age.

Comedy

Comic Timing skill level 1: 15% chance to distract an enemy attempting a melee attack against you, cancelling the attack. The enemy wastes their action.

The Last Laugh skill level 10: Passive. Enemies that would land a critical hit on you must first save or lose the attack to a fit of something they cannot name. Once per combat, one enemy simply refuses to keep fighting you.

Guile

Blend In skill level 1: You can enter stealth in combat (costs 1 action) and attempt stealth-based decisions in dialogue.

Never Was Anyone skill level 10: Passive. You may enter stealth in plain sight, once per combat, even while observed. Enemies who lose track of you forget you were present at all and revert to their pre-combat behaviour.

Axes

Heavy Swing skill level 1: Successful axe hits reduce the target's Armor by 5% until end of turn (stacks with multiple hits).

The Whole Arc skill level 10: Passive. Axe kills no longer end your momentum — momentum stacks persist through a kill and carry into the next turn. At 5+ stacks, every axe hit cleaves one adjacent enemy for full damage.

Unarmed

Hard Knuckles skill level 1: Unarmed attacks ignore 25% of target's Armor.

Empty Hand, Full World skill level 10: Passive. While carrying no weapon in either hand, gain +1 action per turn, and unarmed strikes count as magical for resistance purposes.

Fire Magic

Kindled skill level 1: Burning effects last 1 additional turn.

The Fire That Does Not Consume skill level 10: Passive. Your Fire spells no longer damage allies or destroy terrain you wish to preserve. Burning you apply lasts until dispelled, and enemies killed while Burning explode for half the spell's damage.

Sorcery

Clean Cast skill level 1: Sorcery spells cost 10% less mana.

The Word and the Silence skill level 10: Passive. Once per combat, a single-target Sorcery spell may be cast with no mana cost and no chance of failure. If it kills its target, you recover the mana of the most expensive spell you have cast this combat.

Might

Put Your Weight Into It skill level 1: Melee attacks have a 15% chance to knockback 1 tile or stun for 1 turn (Constitution save negates).

What Cannot Be Carried skill level 10: Passive. No weight limit applies to you, and you may lift, drag, or break anything a party of four could. Enemies attempting to move, grapple, or knock you down fail automatically.

Leadership

Formation Discipline skill level 1: Adjacent allies gain +5% Armor and +5% resistance. Bonus increases by +2% per additional adjacent ally.

The Company You Keep skill level 10: Passive. All allies gain +2 to every derived stat while you are conscious. When you fall in combat, allies immediately gain an extra action rather than losing morale.

Performance

Rousing Display skill level 1: When combat starts, allies within 3 tiles gain +5% morale and +2 Initiative for the first round.

The Performance of a Lifetime skill level 10: Active (once per combat). Hold the field. All enemies who can see you must save or spend their turn watching; allies gain +25% damage and immunity to fear for 2 turns.

Spears

Long Memory skill level 1: Reaction attacks (from First to Strike, Set for Charge, etc.) gain +15% damage.

The Line Holds skill level 10: Passive. Your threatened area extends to 3 tiles. Enemies entering it are Slowed for 1 turn, and any reaction attack you make from a braced position cannot miss.

Water Magic

Creeping Cold skill level 1: Ice spells that deal damage also apply -1 Movement for 2 turns.

The River Has No Shape skill level 10: Active (once per combat, 15 Mana). For 3 turns you cannot be Immobilized, Rooted, Grappled or Knocked_Down, you move through occupied tiles freely, and every Water spell you cast costs half.

Enchantment

Weakening Gaze skill level 1: Debuffs you cast are 10% more effective (higher penalties).

The Binding Holds skill level 10: Passive. Buffs you cast have no duration — they last until dispelled or the combat ends. Debuffs you cast cannot be cleansed by anything short of a dispel.

Grace

Light on Your Feet skill level 1: Ignore difficult terrain movement penalties.

The Water Finds the Crack skill level 10: Passive. You cannot be flanked, surrounded, or caught in an AoE you can see — you always slip to the nearest safe tile. Movement never provokes reactions.

Medicine

Field Medic skill level 1: Active (1 action). Heal an adjacent ally for 25% of your Awareness as HP.

Physician of the Dead skill level 10: Passive. You can treat any wound or disease regardless of its cure level, in the field, without supplies. A party member who would bleed out in combat instead stabilises at 1 HP once per combat.

Alchemy

Quick Brew skill level 1: Craft potions in half the normal time between encounters.

The Perfected Solution skill level 10: Passive. Potions and bombs you brew are always one rarity tier higher and cost no reagents on a Logistics-conserved step. Consumables you use affect the whole party at half strength.

Thievery

Nimble Fingers skill level 1: Can attempt to pick locks. Success based on Finesse + Thievery vs lock difficulty.

Everything Is Carried Loosely skill level 10: Passive. Theft and lockpicking attempts cannot critically fail. Once per location, you may take one item you could not otherwise afford or reach, and nobody notices it is gone until you are elsewhere.

Maces

Concussive Force skill level 1: Mace hits have a 20% chance to apply Dazed (-10% accuracy, -10% Dodge) for 1 turn.

The Mountain Answers skill level 10: Active (8 Stamina). Strike the ground rather than a target. Every enemy within 2 tiles is Knocked_Down and takes crushing damage equal to your Strength; structures and obstacles in the radius are destroyed outright.

Armor

Heavy Armor Training skill level 1: Reduce movement and dodge penalties from heavy armor by 50%.

Unbroken skill level 10: Passive. The first time each combat you would drop below 25% HP, you instead stop at 25% and all your Armor values double until end of turn. Wounds inflicted on you are downgraded one severity.

Earth Magic

Iron Shirt Training skill level 1: Earth defensive spells (Stone Skin, Iron Will, etc.) gain +15% effectiveness.

Root and Summit skill level 10: Passive. While standing on earth, stone or ground you have shaped, you cannot be moved against your will and gain +30% to all Resistances. Your Earth spells treat the battlefield's terrain as one tier more favourable.

Summoning

Resilient Summons skill level 1: Summons gain +10% damage resistance.

Host of the Faithful skill level 10: Passive. You may maintain twice your normal number of summons. When a summon of yours dies, the next one you call this combat arrives with full HP and an extra action.

Logistics

Efficient Packing skill level 1: Party weight capacity increased by 20%.

The Road Provides skill level 10: Passive. The party consumes no food on overworld movement. Rest restores an additional 25%, camp activities cost one fewer resource, and you always know the shortest safe route to any discovered location.

Trade

Know the Market skill level 1: See the true value of all items. Overpriced items are highlighted in shops.

Trade Empire skill level 10: Passive income: gain gold at the end of each in-game day equal to 3% of your current gold (minimum 50).

Smithing

Apprentice Smith skill level 1: Can craft basic weapons and armor from common materials.

Legendary Artisan skill level 10: Once per rest, craft an item of rare quality with a unique name and enhanced bonuses.

10. The inner life: poisons and wisdoms

Beneath hit points and skills, every character has a quieter set of numbers: a **mind**. Five scales, one per element, each running between a poison (*klesha*) and the wisdom it can become. Events and fights press on these scales (*pressure*), and the scales slowly drift back towards a baseline the character's birth and traits set. A character whose pressure is pushed far enough tips into a named state. A character who is happy and well might sit in a wisdom state; one under strain may become *Irritable*, then *Grief-struck*, then *Poisonous*. These states change what they can do in a fight and which options an event offers.

There are 30 named states: five elements × two poles × three intensities. This is the canonical five-poisons / five-wisdoms scheme:

Element	Poison	Poison states: minor / major / crisis	Wisdom states: minor / major / crisis
Space	delusion	Confused / Dissociated / Absent	Clear-headed / Open / Luminous
Fire	desire	Restless / Craving / Consumed	Warm / Magnetizing / Radiant
Water	aversion	Irritable / Grief-struck / Poisonous	Focused / Clear-eyed / Compassionate
Earth	pride	Insecure / Arrogant / Humiliated	Grounded / Equanimous / Unshakeable
Air	envy	Anxious / Paranoid / Envious	Alert / Inspired / Brilliant

In practice, when writing an event the useful question is: *which of the five does this situation touch, and does it make the character better or worse at it?* A scene about a bereaved parent presses on Water; a scene about a rival's success presses on Air. Events can push a character's mind in either direction as a reward or a cost.

Relationships between characters

Companions also form bonds with each other. The game scores their rapport on shared interests and temperaments (vices, devotion, martial pursuits, the arts, scholarship, sociability, solitude, grief, order, animals, hardship, wonder) and sorts each pair into *rival*, *cool*, *neutral*, *warm* or *sworn*. Certain pairings trigger short events at camp; more of these are welcome.

11. Body, wounds and illness

Bodies matter. Characters can be **wounded**, and wounds are not just lost hit points: a deep cut, a broken arm, an infection or a disease stays with the character, can worsen if untreated, and needs a healer or rest to mend. Where a wound lands (head, torso, arm, leg and so on) changes what it costs them.

Not every birth has a human body. The game has **body plans** (human, four-armed, serpentine, avian, mantis and others), so a naga does not wear gloves and a four-armed yaksha can hold a weapon in each pair of hands. Equipment and wounds follow the plan.

Permanent injury leaves marks that can themselves be characterful: a scarred veteran, a maimed survivor, a character who has grown a prosthetic. Writing that acknowledges the body (a limp noticed by a guard, a missing arm mentioned by a healer) adds weight to a scene.

Wounds and illness are one place the game currently has *too few* realm-specific varieties. Frostbite and burns for hell, malnutrition for the hungry ghosts and parasites for the animals are all wanted (chapter 28).

12. Combat

Combat is a turn-based tactical battle on a grid. Both sides take turns in an order set by initiative. On a turn, a character can move, strike with a weapon, cast a spell, use a skill or item, or hold position. Position matters: who is adjacent, who is flanked, what the terrain is.

- **Weapons** follow the weapon skills (swords, spears, axes, maces, daggers, ranged, unarmed). Different weapons have different reach.
- **Spells** may hit a single target or an area, apply lasting *statuses* (burning, frozen, stunned, blessed and many more) and can be resisted by a saving throw.
- **Terrain and auras** change a fight: cursed soil that raises the dead, a circle that protects allies from magic, a shroud of darkness.
- **Enemies** are generated from *archetypes* (a Demon Warrior, a Preta, a Gana Alpha) with roles such as frontline, ranged or support. Their strength is built to the party's own, so they are neither pushovers nor walls.
- **Bosses** guard the portals between realms and are meant to be set pieces. Their special mechanics are mostly still to be designed.

The writer's job in combat is mostly through *names and framing*: the names of enemy types, what a pass-guardian says before the fight, what an event describes just before blades are drawn, and what is said after victory. Combat outcomes in events specify which group of enemies appears and how hard the fight is.

13. Events and dialogue

Events are the heart of the writing. An event is a short scene that opens when the party walks onto a particular place on the map, or sometimes when they camp. It has a **title**, a **body** (usually one to four paragraphs), and a set of **choices**. The player picks one and gets an **outcome**: a few lines of text, plus anything that happens (a fight, a shop opening, a companion joining, items, wounds, a change of mind).

Three kinds of choice

The game follows the *FTL* model, using colours:

Colour	Kind	When it appears	Typical use
GREY	Default	Always available.	The basic options: fight, flee, give, ignore, ask.
BLUE	Requirement	Only if someone in the party meets a condition (a skill level, an attribute, a trait). Always succeeds.	The reward for building a character well: the healer's remedy, the scholar's insight, the yogi's teaching.
YELLOW	Roll	Always shown. A d20 plus the best party attribute or skill against a difficulty.	The risky option with a good and a bad ending. Needs <i>two</i> outcomes written.

The whole party counts

If *any* party member meets a requirement, the choice opens, and the interface shows who enabled it. This is why companions matter: bringing the right person makes whole branches of the game appear. When writing a blue choice, consider which kind of character would naturally have that knowledge and let the line reflect it.

Outcomes

An outcome is one of a few types:

- **Text**: some prose, with optional rewards or penalties (experience, gold, items, a trait, a wound, a shift of mind).
- **Combat**: a fight against a named group, easy, normal or hard. May carry a line of prose before it and another after victory.
- **Shop**: opens a merchant or trainer.
- **Recruit**: a companion offers to join, either a specific one or a random one from the zone.
- **Follow-up**: chains to another event.

Karma on every choice

Each choice records which realms it feeds. In Part III this appears as a small line such as Karma: Hell +3, Asura +2. These are Olaf's choices and not rules; if your outcome has a different moral colour, the karma line may need to change with it.

Triggered events

Some events do not live on the map at all. They occur at camp on a rest night: *trait events* (a character with a particular trait is the subject) and *relationship events* (two companions whose bond has reached a certain level). These use `{a}` and `{b}` as placeholders for the characters' names. Eleven exist; more are very welcome.

Practical notes for writing events

- Target at least **two meaningful checks** (blue or yellow choices) per event. About 53 events are currently grey-only.
- Keep outcome text short. A line or two is often better than a paragraph.

- Think about who might be in the party: a yogi, a thief, a hunter, a priest. Give them a moment.
- Remember that choices cost things: a yellow choice may cost gold or food, and the cost appears with the choice.

14. The party

A party is the player's character plus up to several **companions**. Companions are recruited in towns (as mercenaries, for a fee), met on the road (some join through events) or found in guilds. Each is a complete character, using the same rules as the player's: a birth, a background, traits, a build of skills, spells and gear. The only difference is that their story has already been started: they come with a short bio, a personality and often a reason to be there.

This is the main area where your writing lives. A companion bio is two or three sentences that must do a great deal: who they were, why they are here, what they are like to travel with. The best existing ones do it with one telling detail and a dry joke, for instance a butcher "who followed every regulation, filed every permit, and enjoyed his work with a thoroughness that made inspectors nervous."

Companions have **names with meanings**. Hell and hungry-ghost companions have names drawn from Tibetan, Sanskrit and other languages, and each has a short note saying what it means. The animal realm has its own naming traditions for each birth (Appendix C).

Companions also react to each other (chapter 10) and to the events they are part of. They are never silent equipment.

15. Camp, rest and time

Time passes as the party moves. Days and nights accumulate, and the game keeps a **lunar calendar**: new moons and full moons matter, for karma and for certain practices. Resting costs time and supplies.

Rest

There are three tiers of rest: a **Quick Rest** (a partial recovery that costs a little food), a **Camp** (a better recovery that also uses herbs and scrap and mends some gear), and a **Full Rest** (full recovery, a clean slate for the mind, and fully repaired gear, at the highest cost in food, herbs and scrap). Each takes the night. Rest is not free healing; it is a choice about supplies and risk, and things can happen in the dark.

Camp activities

At camp, party members can spend their time on activities that use their skills:

- **Sadhana**: karma-purification practice (Ritual and Yoga).
- **Mantra recitation**: quiet accumulation of mantras; counts build towards the yidam relationship and, in time, earn traits.
- **Spiritual cleansing**: purifying psychic corruption and spiritual miasma.
- **Herb preparation, field surgery, brew potions, brew bombs and poisons**: the medicine and alchemy side.
- **Deep repair and weapon work**: smithing and upkeep.
- **Night music**: performance and morale.

Camp is also where triggered events happen (chapter 13), and where a quiet moment between two companions can show who they really are. Realm-specific "something stirs in the night" events are one of the things still wanted.

16. Items, shops and money

Items

The game has more than 600 items: weapons, armour, talismans (accessories), ritual implements, potions, ammunition and supplies. Many are *procedurally generated* within rarity tiers, so the same sword can come in plain or legendary versions. The four supplies that drive the overworld are **food, herbs, reagents and scrap**.

Ritual implements and talismans are where the Tibetan material culture shows: bells, vajras, skull cups, thighbone trumpets, mandala plates, protective amulets. A ritual item may have a story, and item descriptions are another place a writer can add colour.

Shops, guilds and training

Towns and places on the map contain people who sell or teach. There are several kinds:

- **General merchants:** sell goods only. **Blacksmiths, fletchers and alchemists** sell weapons, armour, ranged gear and potions and also train a related skill; **healers** sell remedies and white magic.
- **Towns:** general goods and companions to hire.
- **Teahouses:** a place to rest, and to recruit companions.
- **Mercenary guilds:** weapons, armour and fighters for hire. **Veteran camps:** combat training and veterans for hire.
- **Spell guilds** teach a fixed curriculum of spells in one school; **spell trainers** teach spells and may sell magical items; **yogini circles** offer spells, magic supplies and spiritual companions.
- **Skill trainers:** pay experience for lessons in skills and attributes.
- **Domain teachers:** appear only after a domain event; they teach the domain's rare spells (catalogued in chapter 23).

Every shop has a name and a short description that greets the player when they arrive. These are catalogued per realm in Part III.

Money

Gold is common to all realms, though what it buys differs. Prices shift with the realm and with the party's Trade and Persuasion. The party can also barter. Money is deliberately scarce and often something events ask you to spend.

17. Practice and devotion

The game treats spiritual practice as a first-class activity, in a few layers.

Ritual and Yoga

These are two different skills, and the distinction matters for writing.

- **Ritual** is *external ceremony*: drawing a mandala, laying out offerings, using material components, and chanting a rite to strengthen a spell.
- **Yoga** is *internal cultivation*: meditation, mantra, insight into karma, patient non-violence. Yoga opens the pacifist dialogue options in events.

Mantras and sadhana

Characters with the right skills can accumulate mantra recitations at camp and perform sadhana, a purification practice that reduces karma (including the karma that would carry them to a lower rebirth). Both have lunar timing: a full or new moon amplifies them.

Yidam and Dharmapala (designed, not yet built)

Two further layers are fully designed but not yet in the game.

- **Yidam** is a personal deity practice. A character develops a relationship with a single meditational deity through five stages: *Heard, Connected, Practicing, Established, Realized*. Deities are translated into English ("Adamantine Terrifier", not their Sanskrit names), each tied to a mantra, a dedicated spell, a possible mask and a quest chain. Commitment to one deity is rewarded.
- **Dharmapala** are protector deities met at shrines on the map. The relationship is *transactional and worldly*, a matter of offerings, and runs through *Stranger, Known, Favorable, Under Protection, Bonded*. Each protector can intervene a limited number of times (rerolling fate, giving a glimpse, weakening an enemy) and asks for vows. Breaking a vow damages the bond.

Both relationships would persist from one life to the next once deep enough. If you write about practice, avoid inventing sacred names; see the style guide in chapter 29.

Part III: The Six Realms

18. The cosmology

The traditional wheel of life shows six realms of rebirth. The game follows them in a fixed *geography of descent and ascent*: the player starts in Hell, and portals lead outward from realm to realm.

Realm	Sanskrit name	Quality	In the game
Hell	Naraka	Suffering of hatred. Torment and punishment, ordered and bureaucratic.	Playable. Combat-focused. Cold hells in the north, hot hells in the south.
Hungry Ghost	Pretaloka	Insatiable craving. Starvation amid plenty; clinging to what is gone.	Playable. Resource scarcity. Swamps, graveyards, charnel grounds.
Animal	Tiryakloka	Instinct and predation. Territory, appetite, no time to think.	Playable. Combat and negotiation. Ocean, forest, meadow, sky.
Human	Manushyaloka	The mixed realm. Pleasure and pain in balance; the realm where practice is possible.	Not yet built. Planned as dialogue- and quest-heavy.
Asura	Asuraloka	Jealousy and war. Titans who envy the gods.	Not yet built. Planned as competitive: duels and rivalry.
God	Devaloka	Pleasure and pride. Long lives of bliss that end in surprise.	Not yet built. Planned as diplomacy and trade, almost no combat.

Realms are connected by **portals** at the far end of each map, sometimes guarded by a boss. Hell leads to the Hungry Ghost realm, which leads to the Animal realm, which leads to the Human realm. The order in which the player encounters the realms is the order of this table. The player may be *reborn* into any realm they have already visited. Reincarnation destinations thus open gradually.

Each realm carries a **theme** that also shapes its play:

- Hell is combat. Hungry Ghost is scarcity. Animal is a mix of fighting and negotiation.
- Human is for dialogue and quests. Asura is competition. God is diplomacy.

The next three chapters present each completed realm: its character, geography, places, creatures, quests and then all of its events in full.

19. Hell (Naraka)

The realm of hatred, punishment and ordered cruelty.

Naraka is split between the frozen wastes of the north and the burning badlands of the south, divided by an impassable mountain range. It is the first realm and the one the game is most thoroughly built around: the hells are mostly combat, but they are also a society, with wardens, clerks, guards, prisoners and the occasional devil who has had enough. Its births are six colours of devil, each belonging to a different hell.

At a glance: 6 births · 24 companions · 79 events · 45 enemy types · 32 places.

19.1 The land and its regions

The Hell Realm of Naraka, split between the frozen wastes of the north and the burning badlands of the south, divided by an impassable mountain range.

The notes under each region are design comments for the writer; the player never sees them.

Cold Hell cold_hell

The northern half of Naraka: frozen wastes, glacier and ice. The party begins here, at the top-left corner of the map.

Divider divider

The impassable mountain range between the cold and the fire. It can only be crossed at a pass, which is guarded.

Fire Hell fire_hell

The southern half: burning badlands. The portal to the Hungry Ghost realm lies at the far bottom-right corner.

Fixed landmarks

Wandering Devil

Scene in Cold Hell; event: The Wanderer

Portal

Leads to the Hungry Ghost realm.

Yama's Lieutenant

Boss in Fire Hell; event: Yama's Lieutenant

Lava Guardian

Pass Guardian in Divider; event: Lava Guardian

Settlement names used on the map

Rokhar, Nagthang, Duryul, Trakkhar, Munkhar, Jiklung, Shithang, Barkhar, Meri, Gangkhar, Drangyul, Draglung, Krodhapura, Dvesanagar, Yamakshetra

19.2 Births of this realm

Red Devil, Blue Devil, Yellow Devil, Green Devil, Black Devil, White Devil. Full entries are in chapter 25; companions are in chapter 27.

19.3 Places: shops, guilds and teahouses

Each of these has a name and a short description shown when the party arrives.

General merchant

Tormented Peddler hell_merchant

A twisted soul who trades in suffering... and useful goods.

Frozen Merchant frozen_merchant

Frost-covered wares from a resilient trader in the frozen wastes.

Ember Merchant ember_merchant

Fire-forged goods from the burning half of Naraka. Everything radiates warmth.

Wandering Peddler wandering_peddler

Eclectic trinkets and supplies scavenged from the frozen wastes.

Devil's Rest hell_tavern

A dim roadhouse where the desperate gather. Someone at the bar looks like they're between allegiances.

Spell trainer

Infernal Magister demon_sorcerer

A powerful demon who teaches the dark arts... for a price.

Skill trainer

Wandering Sage wandering_sage

A mysterious figure who can unlock your hidden potential.

Trains: White Magic, Sorcery, Yoga

Weapon Master weapon_master

A grizzled veteran who teaches combat techniques.

Trains: Swords, Axes, Maces, Spears, Ranged, Daggers, Armor

Warden's Pit wardens_pit

The pit warden runs the eastern patrols and teaches her soldiers to fight. For coin she'll train outsiders too — up to a point. She has standards.

Trains: Spears, Armor, Might

Mixed

General Store general_store

A well-stocked shop with a bit of everything.

Teahouse

Teahouse hell_teahouse_cold

A dim waystation where the desperate catch their breath. The barkeeper keeps a pot of Lapsang Souchong going — its smoke is the closest thing to warmth in the frozen wastes.

Teahouse hell_teahouse_fire

The tea here is brewed in volcanic water. It tastes like char and smoke and something almost familiar. The barkeeper doesn't ask where you've been.

Mercenary guild

Mercenary Guild hell_mercenary_guild

A fortified post where demonic soldiers hire out between assignments. Their equipment is functional, their prices are fair, their loyalty is negotiable.

Veteran camp

Veterans' Camp hell_veterans_camp

A camp of soldiers who survived long enough to have something to teach. They charge for lessons — nothing is free in hell.

Yogini circle

Yogini Circle hell_yogini_circle

A circle of Dakinis — fierce, half-wild tantric practitioners. They trade knowledge for gold and ask no questions about what you plan to do with it.

Town

Town hell_town_weapons

A cluster of hovels that qualifies as a settlement. The main trade here is war.

Town hell_town_magic

A settlement that has drawn more than its share of sorcerers and wandering scholars. The apothecary is always busy.

Town hell_town_supplies

A trading post that survives on practicality. The sign reads: FOOD. TOOLS. NO CREDIT. It is the most honest thing you have seen in hell.

Spell guild

Sacred Grove hell_sacred_grove

The dappled light streaming through the dense canopy seems like living gold. The Yakshas and Yakshinis come to commune with their followers in this place, marked with colored ropes on the tree trunks and prayer flags hanging from the branches.

Temple of the Naga hell_temple_of_the_naga

In every world some beings are born innately attuned to the mindstreams of the Naga. Temples arise where they practice, communing with their reptilian friends and patrons through offerings of saffron milk, fruits and flowers.

Garuda Roost hell_garuda_roost

A tall pole with a horned symbol at the top rises from the ground, sacred stones and offerings heaped at its base, colorful ribbons fluttering in the wind. The worshippers say the Garudas come to perch at the top during their long travels.

Hidden Gompa hell_hidden_gompa

Practitioners come to this place seeking solitude and peace. The ground itself vibrates with the power of their meditation, mantric syllables appearing spontaneously in the rock.

Mirror Lake hell_mirror_lake

Mirages flicker over the mercurial surface of the lake. Followers of the Goddess of Illusion gather around, meditating on the fleeting nature of phenomena and exchanging stories of their dreams.

Crossroads Stupa hell_crossroads_stupa

The wind carries the smell of sacred juniper smoke and sacrificial wine far from this place. As you come closer, you see little heaps of torma and butter lamps, some still burning.

Circle of the Yoginis hell_circle_of_yoginis

The inward-facing side of this circular stone wall is carved with the bizarre forms of sixty four Yoginis. There is no ceiling, so the witches can land when they come flying from vast space to meet their earthly sisters.

Medicinal Garden hell_medicinal_garden

The air is vibrant with the aroma of medicinal herbs and flowers. The healers cultivating them are happy to share some of their knowledge for the benefit of all suffering beings.

Temple of the Eternal Fire hell_eternal_fire

Priests clad in white robes have been guarding the sacred fire since time immemorial. Many come to pay their respects and seek visions in the dancing flames.

Black Lodge hell_black_lodge

The entrance is half-buried in the earth, marked only with a crooked khatvanga topped with a skull and streaming black ribbons reeking of smoke and poison. As you enter, the darkness overwhelms you - until you notice the glint of a sneering smile.

Blacksmith

Infernal Forge infernal_forge

Heat-warped iron, a bone-white anvil, and a demon who hasn't slept in three hundred years. The weapons here are ugly and they work.

Trains: Axes, Maces, Might

Fletcher

Bone Archer Camp bone_archer_camp

A fortified camp of skeleton archers who've been here long enough to start trading. Their fletching is excellent. Their interpersonal skills are not.

Trains: Ranged, Daggers, Guile

Healer

Mercy Ward mercy_ward

A tent with clean bandages, a smell of herbs, and a medic who patches up anyone who can pay — no questions, no karma, no judgment. In hell this is rare enough to be miraculous.

Trains: Medicine

Alchemist

Brimstone Lab brimstone_lab

A rickety structure of cracked glass and boiling tubes. The alchemist here has survived seventeen explosions. This gives them a certain confidence.

Trains: Alchemy

19.4 Bestiary

Enemy types met in this realm. The note under a name is a design comment for the writer and never shown to the player.

Demon Warrior hell_demon_warrior any · frontline

Demon Brute hell_demon_brute any · frontline

Tormented Shade hell_tormented_shade any · frontline

Reworked: now a true shade-tier enemy (was formerly a devil-tier caster)

Demon Archer hell_demon_archer any · ranged

Demon Elite hell_demon_elite any · frontline

Frozen Shade hell_frozen_shade cold_hell · frontline

Burning Shade hell_burning_shade fire_hell · frontline

Shade Whisperer hell_shade_whisperer any · caster, support

Sleet Imp hell_frost_imp cold_hell · ranged, caster

Smoke Imp hell_flame_imp fire_hell · ranged, caster

Static Imp hell_static_imp any · ranged, caster

Gravel Imp hell_gravel_imp any · ranged, caster

Tinnitus Imp hell_tinnitus_imp any · ranged, caster

Ash Imp hell_ash_imp any · ranged, caster

Sloth Imp hell_sloth_imp any · support

Ice Sorcerer hell_ice_mage cold_hell · caster

Frost Guardian hell_frost_guardian cold_hell · frontline

Frozen Revenant hell_frozen_revenant cold_hell · frontline

Ice Archer hell_ice_archer cold_hell · ranged

Ice Priest hell_ice_priest cold_hell · support

Blue Devil Guardian hell_blue_devil_guardian cold_hell · frontline

Blue Devil Ice Mage hell_blue_devil_ice_mage cold_hell · caster

Blue Devil Ambusher hell_blue_devil_ambusher cold_hell · ranged

Lava Golem hell_lava_golem fire_hell · frontline

Fire Sorcerer hell_fire_sorcerer fire_hell · caster

Infernal Archer hell_infernal_archer fire_hell · ranged

Ember Priest hell_ember_priest fire_hell · support

Red Devil Berserker hell_red_devil_berserker fire_hell · frontline

Red Devil Warrior hell_red_devil_warrior fire_hell · frontline

Red Devil Firestarter hell_red_devil_firestarter fire_hell · caster

Yellow Devil Caravan Guard hell_yellow_devil_caravan_guard any · frontline

Yellow Devil Extortionist hell_yellow_devil_extortionist any · frontline

Yellow Devil Transmuter hell_yellow_devil_transmuter any · caster, support

Green Devil Hunter hell_green_devil_hunter any · ranged

Green Devil Sniper hell_green_devil_sniper any · ranged

Green Devil Backstabber hell_green_devil_backstabber any · frontline

Black Devil Sorcerer hell_black_devil_sorcerer any · caster

Black Devil Mindbender hell_black_devil_mindbender any · caster, support

Black Devil Lifedrinker hell_black_devil_lifedrinker any · frontline

White Devil Tempter hell_white_devil_tempter any · support, caster

White Devil Medicus hell_white_devil_medicus any · support

White Devil Illusionist hell_white_devil_illusionist any · caster, support

Chitragupta, Yama's Lieutenant hell_yama_lieutenant fire_hell · boss

Chitragupta (Diminished) hell_yama_lieutenant_weakened fire_hell · boss

Lava Guardian hell_mountain_guardian any · boss

19.5 Quests

The Frozen Prisoner cold_prisoner

A soul encased in ice begs for release. Somewhere in the cold hells lies the key.

1. Find the warden's seal
2. Return to the prisoner

Ember Debt ember_debt

A fire merchant claims a debt owed by a roaming demon. Collect it—by any means.

1. Track down Blisterfang
2. Return the payment

The Lost Mantra lost_mantra

A wandering hermit lost a scroll of protective mantras. Without it, the cold will claim him.

1. Recover the mantra scroll
2. Bring it to the hermit

19.6 Event catalogue (79 events)

Every event written for this realm, in the order they are stored. **GREY** choices are always available, **BLUE** choices need a party member with a skill, attribute or trait, **YELLOW** choices are rolls. The small grey lines are reference labels, not game text.

Demon Patrol hell_demon_patrol

Three demons in frost-crust armor block the path ahead. Their captain, a horned brute with blue-black skin, raises a jagged halberd.

"No one passes without the Warden's permission. State your business or prepare to suffer."

GREY Draw your weapon and attack

Combat: Demon Patrol (hard)

Karma: Hell +3, Asura +2

BLUE Convince them you serve the Warden

Requires: Charm 15+

"Well, if you say so."

Effects: XP 8 · Karma: Hungry Ghost +2, Human +3

YELLOW Throw a bag of gold and slip past while they argue amongst themselves

Roll: Finesse, normal difficulty · Cost: Gold (small)

If it succeeds:

Maybe sometimes it's true that greed is good.

Effects: XP 6 · Karma: Animal +3, Human +2

If it fails: Combat: Demon Patrol (hard)

They look on you with confused pity and draw their weapons.

Karma: Hell +5

GREY Offer them gold to look the other way

Cost: Gold (moderate)

They quickly pocket the gold and step aside.

Effects: XP 3 · Karma: Hungry Ghost +5, Human +2

BLUE Strike fast and precisely — take them down before they can sound the alarm

Requires: Daggers 3+

Combat: Demon Patrol (normal)

You move in fast, targeting the gaps in their armor. They barely have time to react before the first one goes down. The fight continues, but the terms are yours.

Effects: XP 8 · Karma: Asura +3, Hell +2

Ice Spirits hell_ice_spirits

Translucent figures drift above the frozen surface of a vast lake. Their forms shimmer, beautiful and terrible, trapped in an eternal dance. One turns toward you, its hollow eyes filled with sorrow.

"Do not disturb those dreaming below."

GREY Force your way through

Combat: Ice Spirits (hard)

Karma: Hell +5, Asura +3

BLUE Speak to them in the language of water and cold

Requires: Water Magic 3+

They recognize a kindred soul and part. Before you leave, the lead spirit shoves an ice shard in your hand.

Effects: XP 10; items: Ice Shard · Karma: God +3, Human +2

BLUE Sit in meditation and commune with the spirits

Requires: Yoga 2+

Through stillness you glimpse their memories. They become transparent and vanish into the cold mist.

Effects: XP 12 · Karma: God +5, Human +3

GREY Leave an offering at the lake's edge and pray

One spirit touches your forehead: a sensation of cold so deep it becomes warm. They part and let you through.

Effects: XP 5 · Karma: God +4, Human +2, Hell -3

Frozen Merchant hell_frozen_merchant

A bundled figure huddles near a sputtering fire, surrounded by tattered bags. Despite the brutal cold, the merchant seems oddly cheerful.

"Welcome, welcome! Don't mind the cold — it keeps the thieves away! I've got everything a traveler needs to survive this frozen wasteland. Well, almost everything."

GREY Browse the merchant's wares

Opens: Frozen Merchant

Karma: Human +1

BLUE Try to negotiate better prices

Requires: Trade 2+

The merchant nods his head, impressed.

Effects: XP 5; items: Health Potion · Karma: Human +3

GREY Ask about the region

He warns you about ice wraiths, the Lava Guardian, and Yama's lieutenant standing guard in the far south.

Effects: XP 2 · Karma: Human +1

YELLOW Wait for a distraction and pocket some merchandise

Roll: Finesse, easy difficulty

If it succeeds:

The merchant's attention drifts. Your hand moves fast. By the time they look back, you are studying the horizon innocently.

Effects: items: Iron Dagger, Health Potion · Karma: Hungry Ghost +5

If it fails: Combat: Demon Patrol (normal)

The merchant's scream brings a demon patrol at a run. "Thief! THIEF!" There is nowhere to run.

Karma: Hungry Ghost +3

GREY Leave a generous tip — life's hard for everyone in hell

Cost: Gold (small)

The merchant stares at the coins, then at you, then at the coins again. "I... thank you. I haven't had a kind customer since — actually, I've never had a kind customer." They wave you off with unusual warmth.

Effects: XP 3 · Karma: God +4

YELLOW Tell the merchant a joke about freezing to death in hell

Roll: Comedy, trivial difficulty

If it succeeds:

"...and then the yak said, 'at least it's a dry cold!'" The merchant howls with laughter, slapping their knee hard enough to crack ice off their boot. "That's the funniest thing anyone's said to me in three hundred years. Here — on the house." They toss you a health potion.

Effects: XP 4; items: Health Potion · Karma: Human +3

If it fails:

Silence. The merchant stares at you with an expression that could freeze hell twice over. "Get out of my shop." There is no shop. You leave anyway.

GREY Move on

"Safe travels! Try not to freeze!"

The Wanderer hell_lost_wanderer

Sheltering in a hollow near the road, a lone figure sits apart from the cold. They do not look up as you approach.

"Cast out," they say at last. "Showed mercy once when the Guard said not to. Paid for it." A short, bitter laugh. "Been wandering since. No patrol, no master. Just nowhere to be."

GREY "Nowhere to be sounds like a reason to travel with us."

Recruit: a random companion from this zone

They look at you for a long moment, then stand, rolling their shoulders.

"Alright. Can't be worse than this."

No cost. Karma: Human +3, God +2

BLUE You know that particular way of sitting apart.

Requires: Trait: Homesick

You sit down at the same distance from them that they are sitting from everything, which is the only approach that was ever going to work.

They talk for a while about a place that no longer exists. You know the feeling well enough not to correct any of it.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Water +10

GREY "Hell rewards the strong. Find your own way."

They nod, unsurprised. You leave them to the cold.

Karma: Hell +2

Frozen Traveler hell_frozen_traveler

A shivering figure huddles by the roadside, barely conscious. Their robes are torn and frostbitten skin shows through the gaps.

"Please... I've been wandering for so long. I can't feel my hands anymore. Is this... is this what I deserve?"

BLUE Tend to their wounds

Requires: Medicine 1+

You work quickly. Color returns to their face — they look surprised, as if they'd forgotten warmth was possible. They press a trinket into your hands without words.

Effects: XP 8; items: Prayer Beads · Karma: Hell -5, Human +5, God +3

GREY Give them some gold and food

Cost: Gold (small), Food (1)

They weep with gratitude and speak quietly of a lifetime spent hoarding while others starved. They understand now what they didn't then.

Effects: XP 4 · Karma: Hell -3, Human +4, God +2

BLUE Offer them a small purification rite

Requires: Ritual 2+

You bless a little water with mantras and wash their hands and forehead. It's not much — but it's something. They breathe a little easier.

Effects: XP 5 · Karma: Human +2, God +2

GREY Ask how they came to be here

They were a corrupt tax collector. They tell you plainly, without excuses. They understand now what their life cost others.

Effects: XP 3 · Karma: Human +3

GREY Walk past without stopping

They watch you go in silence. The cold feels a little sharper afterward.

Karma: Hell +2, Animal +2

BLUE Help, but count what it costs first.

Requires: Trait: Scrimper

Two rations, a blanket you were not using, and an hour. You total it as you go, out of habit, and find the total does not bother you as much as you expected.

The traveller lives. The accounting is, you decide, still worth having done.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Earth +5

BLUE There is no decision here. Get them warm.

Requires: Trait: Warm-hearted

You are already moving before the question has finished being asked, and the party follows because that is what happens when someone moves first.

They live. They will tell someone about it, somewhere down the road.

Effects: XP 15; mind: Water +12, Fire +8 · Karma: Human +5

BLUE You want to carry them and you cannot.

Requires: Trait: Frail

You get about forty paces before your legs make the decision for you, and somebody else takes the weight without comment, which is worse than comment.

The traveller lives. You spend the evening being unhelpfully angry at your own arms.

Effects: mind: Earth -10; XP 22

BLUE Pick them up. Keep walking.

Requires: Trait: Strong

You pick them up and keep walking and the party rearranges itself around the fact without a word being spent on it.

They are at the waystation an hour before they would otherwise have been, which is the whole difference between the two available outcomes.

Effects: XP 15 · Karma: Human +4

YELLOW Sit with them without rushing — wait until the shock recedes enough for words

Roll: Charm, easy difficulty

If it succeeds:

Eventually they look up. Something surfaces from beneath the shock — a fragment of who they were. They press something into your hands as you leave: a small carved token from before. 'I won't need it here,' they say. It turns out to be worth something.

Effects: XP 10; items: Random Common Talisman · Karma: Human +4

If it fails:

They are too far gone in shock for words yet. But they grip your hand for a long time. When you finally rise to leave, a little warmth has returned to their face. Perhaps that's enough.

Effects: XP 5 · Karma: Human +3

Lava Guardian hell_lava_guardian

A massive elemental of molten rock blocks the passage between the ice fields and the volcanic badlands. Heat radiates from it in waves, melting the frost for meters around. It speaks with a voice of grinding stone.

"NONE SHALL PASS between the realms of fire and ice. This has been the law for beginningless aeons. Prove your worth or be consumed."

GREY Attack the guardian head-on**Combat: Lava Guardian (hard)**

Karma: Asura +3, Hell +2

BLUE Challenge it to an honorable single combat

Requires: Martial Arts 3+

Combat: Lava Guardian (normal)

It fights fairly, with reduced ferocity.

Karma: Asura +5, Human +2

YELLOW Search for an alternate route

Roll: Awareness, normal difficulty

If it succeeds:

You find a hidden passage and discover a talisman left by a previous traveler.

Effects: XP 10; items: Fire Resistance Talisman · Karma: Animal +3, Human +2

If it fails: Combat: Lava Guardian (hard)

Spotted! The guardian attacks.

Karma: Hell +3

BLUE Sit before it in meditation

Requires: Yoga 3+

Hours pass; the guardian recognizes your understanding and silently steps aside.

Effects: XP 15 · Karma: God +5, Human +5, Hell -5

Yama's Lieutenant hell_boss_yama_lt

A towering demon in ornate black and gold armor stands before the Realm Gate. Its four arms hold different weapons — sword, mace, spear, and a mirror that shows nothing.

"I am Chitragupta, Lieutenant of Yama, Lord of Death. I have judged every soul that passes through this gate. Tell me, mortal — do you believe your deeds merit passage?"

GREY Draw your weapon and fight for passage

Combat: Yama Lieutenant (boss)

Karma: Hell +5, Asura +5

BLUE Present your case with eloquent argument

Requires: Persuasion 3+

Combat: Yama Lieutenant Weakened (normal)

It listens, lowers two weapons, giving you a fair chance.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: Human +5, God +3

GREY Confess your doubts honestly

Combat: Yama Lieutenant Weakened (normal)

Honesty impresses him, reduced ferocity.

Effects: XP 8 · Karma: Human +5, God +5, Hell -5

BLUE Sit before the gate and meditate on the nature of death

Requires: Yoga 5+

Hours dissolve into the earth, days dissolve into the sky, finally the boundary dissolves into space.

Effects: XP 20 · Karma: God +10, Human +5, Hell -10

Frozen Cave hell_frozen_cave

A dark cave rimmed with glittering ice crystals yawns in the hillside like a great mouth. From deep within comes a faint glow and the distant sound of dripping water — warm water, impossibly, in this frozen waste.

YELLOW Enter the cave carefully

Roll: Awareness, normal difficulty

If it succeeds:

You spot the trap and walk around it. Soon you find a hidden chamber and leave with a couple potions.

Effects: XP 8; items: Health Potion, Mana Potion · Karma: Human +2

If it fails:

You fall into a lower chamber, find a cache but take a knock.

Effects: XP 4; items: Health Potion · Karma: Animal +2

BLUE Study the entrance carefully before entering

Requires: Learning 2+

You notice a warning in old demon script among the scratch marks on the cave wall. Taking it to heart, you carefully descend into the cave along its left-hand wall and soon emerge back with loot.

Effects: XP 8; items: Health Potion, Mana Potion · Karma: Human +3

BLUE Calm yourself and feel the space of the cave from the entrance

Requires: Space Magic 2+

The details remain hazy, but you quickly perceive the shape of the danger ahead and proceed accordingly. You emerge with a few useful finds.

Effects: XP 8; items: Health Potion, Mana Potion · Karma: Human +2, God +1

BLUE Enter the cave with lightness and poise

Requires: Grace 2+

Nimble avoiding the obvious trap, you move through the cave with ease and soon find the hidden cache.

Effects: XP 8; items: Health Potion, Mana Potion · Karma: Human +2, Animal +2

BLUE Go in first. Somebody has to and it may as well be you.

Requires: Trait: Brave

You go in first. The dark does what dark does and you keep walking through it, and the thing at the back of the cave turns out to be smaller than the sound suggested, which is usually the way.

The party comes in behind you considerably steadier than they would have.

Effects: XP 12; mind: Air +10

BLUE You are not going in there. You are simply not.

Requires: Trait: Timid

You are not, and no argument is going to move you, and the party goes in without you.

You hold the entrance for an hour listening to sounds you cannot interpret, which is very much worse than having gone in, and you know it the whole time.

Effects: mind: Air -15; XP 22

BLUE The floor is ice at an angle and your foot is what it is.

Requires: Trait: Clubfooted

You go down twice on the way in and the second one is bad — a knee into stone, the sound of it loud in the cave.

Whatever lives here now knows the party is present. The rest of the approach has to be made at speed rather than quietly.

Effects: HP loss (tiny, random); mind: Earth -8; XP 22

GREY The cave looks dangerous — best to move on

Discretion is the better part of valor. On your way out you notice a small cache near the entrance someone else left behind.

Effects: items: Health Potion, Mana Potion · Karma: Human +2, Animal +2, Asura +2

Tormented Soul hell_tormented_soul

A ghostly figure sits amid the frost, weeping silently. Unlike the mindless lost souls, this one retains its form — the shape of an old woman in tattered robes.

"Can you see me? Truly see me? So few can anymore..."

BLUE Use white magic to ease her suffering

Requires: White Magic 1+

She dissolves into light with a sigh. In life, she was a healer who once turned away a sick wanderer for a lack of payment.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: Hell -5, Human +3, God +3

GREY Sit beside her and listen

She speaks of small cruelties compounded until her breath grows a little longer and slower.

Effects: XP 6 · Karma: Human +3, God +2, Hell -3

BLUE Perform a ritual to release her spirit

Requires: Ritual 3+

You write a mandala of liberation by sight around her. She dissolves into light, leaving a piece of turquoise behind.

Effects: XP 12; items: Soul Stone · Karma: Hell -10, God +8, Human +3

GREY Walk past — you have enough of your own problems

The weeping grows quieter, then stops. The cold deepens.

Karma: Hell +3, Animal +2

BLUE You know what it is like when the memory arrives uninvited.

Requires: Trait: Haunted

You do not offer advice, because there is none, and you do not tell them it passes, because you would be lying.

What you do is stay until the worst of the current one is over. It is apparently not something anyone has done for them before.

Effects: XP 15; mind: Water +12 · Karma: Human +4, Hungry Ghost -3

BLUE Summon a guide spirit to show her the way forward

Requires: Summoning 3+

You call a guide spirit — one of the patient ones, without agenda — and ask it to wait with her. It settles beside the old woman with the quality of something that has done this before.

She looks at it for a long moment. Then at you. 'You can see me.' Not a question anymore. A fact, confirmed.

The guide spirit takes her hand. Her form steadies. Something releases in her posture.

You leave them together.

Effects: XP 14 · Karma: Hell -7, God +6, Human +3

Crossroads Shrine hell_crossroads_shrine

An ancient shrine sits where the roads cross, half-buried in snow and old offerings. Incense sticks still smolder in cracked holders, faded ribbons hang stiffly in the wind.

GREY Offer a prayer for safe passage

Incense flares briefly, your breath deepens.

Effects: XP 2 · Karma: God +2, Human +2

BLUE Meditate

Requires: Yoga 1+

The shrine seems to glow, a tiny lamp of Dharma lost among the wasteland.

Effects: XP 4 · Karma: God +3, Human +2

GREY Leave a small offering

Cost: Gold (small)

Your coins join dozens of others, united in the intent for a better world.

Effects: XP 2 · Karma: God +3, Hungry Ghost -2, Hell -2

BLUE Implore the shrine's guardians for protection

Requires: Ritual 2+

Vows outlast bodies. The incense smoke briefly dances in the still air.

Effects: XP 4; buff: Constitution +2 · Karma: Human +3, God +2

GREY Continue on your way

You nod respectfully and continue on your way.

BLUE Stop properly. This is what the road is for.

Requires: Trait: Pilgrim

You do it the long way — circumambulation, the full prostrations, the offering placed rather than dropped.

The demons on the road watch with the blank incomprehension of people watching someone garden during a siege. You leave steadier than you arrived.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Space +10, Earth +8 · Karma: Human +4, God +3

BLUE Check which way the offerings are facing before you do anything.

Requires: Trait: Superstitious

Three of them face the road. One faces away.

You do not know what that means, but you know it means something, and you arrange your own offering to match the three. Nothing happens, which is exactly what you wanted.

Effects: XP 15; mind: Air +8

YELLOW Focus on the oldest inscription — worn deep enough to survive centuries of snow

Roll: Awareness, normal difficulty

If it succeeds:

The characters resolve slowly into a specific protective glyph — not decorative but functional, a ward against a category of hell demon you've encountered before. You trace it carefully into memory.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: Human +3

If it fails:

The dialect is older than anything you recognize. The inscription might be a prayer, a warning, or a traveler's name. You can't tell. The incense smoke curls upward unconcerned.

Effects: XP 3

Wandering Peddler hell_wandering_peddler

A hunched figure dragging a heavy sack waves you down.

"Psst! Traveler! You look like you could use some supplies. I've got just the things — all cleaned up nice."

GREY See what the peddler has to offer

Opens: Wandering Peddler

Karma: Human +1

GREY Ask for directions and local knowledge

He starts talking a lot but making little sense. You catch bits and pieces about frozen ghosts on the lake, wandering monks and torture chambers.

Effects: XP 3 · Karma: Human +2

YELLOW Grab his pack and run

Roll: Finesse, easy difficulty

If it succeeds:

You snatch the pack and sprint. Behind you, the peddler's shouts fade into confused silence. The bag contains more than you expected — and something that rattles like it's alive.

Effects: items: Iron Dagger, Leather Cap, Health Potion; mind: Water -15, Earth -8 · Karma: Hungry Ghost +5

If it fails:

Your foot catches on a frozen rut. The peddler watches you sprawl, unmoved. "Not the first time," he says, gathering his bag. "Not the worst, either." He trudges on without another word. You are left with bruised dignity and nothing else.

Karma: Hungry Ghost +2

GREY Mug him outright

Combat: Lost Souls (normal)

The peddler drops the sack. From the shadows, his associates — desperate, hollow-eyed souls — close in. He was never alone.

Karma: Hell +5

BLUE Hagggle for better prices

Requires: Trade 2+

The trader seems amused, and after a short back-and-forth, grants you a discount. "Fine, fine. A fair deal." You walk away having spent less than expected.

Effects: XP 4; gold small · Karma: Human +4

BLUE He has told you the price. Tell him the real one.

Requires: Trait: Scrimper

It takes eleven minutes and involves a detailed excursion into the condition of his sack.

He settles well below where he started, calls you something unrepeatable, and shakes your hand.

Effects: gold small; XP 20

GREY Decline politely and move on

"Your loss! If you change your mind, I'll be around. I'm always around."

Wandering Hermit hell_hermit_monk

A weathered monk in tattered robes approaches, seemingly at peace despite the frozen wasteland. His eyes are bright and clear.

"Ah, hello. How rare to meet someone with open eyes."

BLUE Ask the monk for spiritual teaching

Requires: Yoga 1+

He teaches about suffering and its root, the poisons of ignorance, desire and aversion.

Effects: XP 4 · Karma: God +5, Human +5

BLUE Sit with him in meditation

Requires: Yoga 3+

You sit in comfortable silence. Afterwards, you feel restored and somehow warmed.

Effects: XP 6; full restore · Karma: God +3, Human +2

BLUE Ask about the workings of karma

Requires: Awareness 16+

"Every action, word and thought creates ripples throughout the thousandfold universe."

Effects: XP 8 · Karma: Human +5, God +3

BLUE My eyelids are frozen in place, friend — but you have my full attention

Requires: Comedy 2+

He laughs in surprise — a real laugh, not a polite one. The conversation that follows is warm in a way that has nothing to do with temperature. You both leave a little lighter.

Effects: XP 8 · Karma: Human +5

BLUE He looks at what you are carrying, which is very little.

Requires: Trait: Ascetic

'Ah,' he says, and something in his posture changes from courteous to interested.

What follows is not a teaching so much as a comparison of notes between two people who have both decided that most things are optional. You come away with one instruction, and it is a good one.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Fire +12, Space +10

BLUE He is here. Be here.

Requires: Trait: Present

There is no teaching. You sit down opposite him in the snow and neither of you says anything for a considerable time.

At the end he laughs once, briefly, as though you had told a joke, and goes on his way. You will spend some weeks working out what was funny.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Space +15

GREY Wish him well and continue on your journey

He bows slightly and walks away. You notice there are no footprints left in his path.

Effects: XP 2 · Karma: Human +1

Frozen Waterfall Yogi hell_ice_yogi

Before a magnificent frozen waterfall, a yogi sits in stillness. Ice crystals have formed on their eyelashes and hair, icicles hang from their beard.

BLUE Ask to learn water magic techniques

Requires: Water Magic 1+

Hours pass until you notice the movement hidden in the stillness.

Effects: XP 15; Water Magic +1 · Karma: God +4, Human +3

BLUE Meditate together on impermanence

Requires: Yoga 2+

Time dissolves into the frozen cascades.

Effects: XP 12 · Karma: God +4, Human +3

GREY Watch the yogi's meditation in silence

The cold seems to lessen when you stop fighting it.

Effects: XP 5 · Karma: God +2, Human +2

BLUE Sit down beside them. Do not announce it.

Requires: Trait: Steady Practice

You sit. The cold is immediate and then, some considerable time later, less immediate.

The yogi does not acknowledge you at any point, which you understand by the end to have been the entire teaching.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Space +15, Water +10; gains trait: Enlightened Insight

GREY Leave the yogi to their practice

You bow respectfully and depart.

Karma: Human +1

The Burning Shrine hell_fire_shrine

A shrine wreathed in eternal flames stands among scorched ruins. Unlike the destructive fires around it, these flames burn with an almost sacred quality — steady, contained, purposeful. Ancient mantras are carved into the shrine's stone base, glowing red with heat.

The air shimmers with power. You can feel the fire calling to something within you.

BLUE Channel the shrine's power through your fire magic

Requires: Fire Magic 2+

You reach into the flames with your power, and the shrine responds. Fire dances up your arms without burning — instead, it fills you with understanding. The mantras on the base glow brighter as fire magic surges through you.

When you release the connection, you can feel the fire's discipline has become part of you. Your control over flame has deepened.

Effects: XP 12 · Karma: Asura +3, Human +2

BLUE Study the ancient mantras carved into the stone

Requires: Ritual 2+

The mantras are written in an archaic script — prayers of purification through fire. As you trace the words with your finger, their meaning unfolds in your mind.

These are mantras of transformation, teaching how suffering itself can be fuel for enlightenment. The fire does not destroy — it transforms.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: God +4, Human +3

GREY Kneel and pray before the burning shrine

You kneel before the flames, feeling their warmth on your face. A prayer rises unbidden — not for protection from fire, but for the strength to face whatever lies ahead.

The flames flare briefly, and you feel a surge of resolve.

Effects: XP 4 · Karma: God +2, Asura +2

BLUE Stand at the edge. You have not done this in a long time.

Requires: Trait: Lapsed

The words are there. That is the surprise — you had assumed they had gone with everything else, and they have simply been waiting, filed and dusty.

You say about half of them before you stop. It is more than you have said in years.

Effects: XP 15; mind: Space +12

GREY The flames are too intense — move on

You step back from the searing heat. Some trials require preparation before they can be faced.

The Ember Merchant hell_ember_merchant

A demon merchant sits cross-legged on a fireproof blanket, surrounded by wares that glow faintly with heat. Their skin is deep red, cracked like cooling lava, and their smile reveals obsidian teeth.

'Welcome to the finest establishment in all of burning Naraka! Fire-forged goods, guaranteed to survive anything this realm throws at you. Mostly. No refunds if you fall into lava, that's just poor decision-making.'

GREY Browse the ember merchant's fire-forged wares

Opens: Ember Merchant

The merchant eagerly displays their collection. Everything radiates gentle warmth, from weapons tempered in volcanic forge-fires to armor that drinks in flames.

Karma: Human +1

BLUE Negotiate as a fellow trader

Requires: Trade 2+

'A merchant's eye! I can tell. You know the value of things.' The demon leans forward conspiratorially. 'Between professionals — take this. A little sample of my finest work. Consider it an investment in a return customer.'

They press a warm vial into your hands.

Effects: XP 5; items: Fire Resistance Potion · Karma: Human +3

GREY Ask about the burning realm

'This side of Naraka? Fire, brimstone, the usual.' The merchant waves a hand dismissively. 'The Oni Brute in the western ruins is trouble — stays clear of him unless you're looking for a fight. The Trial of Flames to the south is where demons test their warriors.'

They lower their voice. 'Yama's lieutenant guards the realm gate to the southeast. Chitragupta, they call him. Four arms, four weapons. Make sure you're ready before you go that way.'

Effects: XP 2 · Karma: Human +1

YELLOW Pocket something while the merchant is talking

Roll: Finesse, normal difficulty

If it succeeds:

Demons talk with their hands. You use their hands against them — the fire-bomb slips into your pack right as they gesture dramatically about lava. They never notice.

Effects: items: Fire Bomb, Flame Oil · Karma: Hungry Ghost +5

If it fails: Combat: Demon Patrol (hard)

The merchant's grin turns brittle. 'I have eyes in the back of my head. Three of them, actually.' They snap their fingers. Figures emerge from the smoke. 'No refunds — and no mercy for thieves.'

Karma: Hungry Ghost +3

GREY Draw your weapon and take what you need

Combat: Demon Patrol (hard)

The merchant drops the salesman's smile instantly. 'Oh good. I was getting bored.' Behind you, the exits close. Around the merchant, fire rises.

Karma: Hell +6

BLUE Mostly guaranteed, or guaranteed you'd mostly survive?

Requires: Comedy 2+

The trader chuckles, genuinely surprised. 'Ha! That's... that's actually good.' They root around and toss you something small. 'On the house, clown. First honest laugh I've had in decades.'

Effects: XP 5; items: Earth Charm Common · Karma: Human +4

YELLOW Make a joke about their 'no refunds if you fall into lava' policy

Roll: Comedy, easy difficulty

If it succeeds:

'What if I fall INTO a customer? Does THAT count?' The demon stares at you, then erupts in a cackle that shakes their entire body and singses the awning. 'Ha! I like you. You're terrible but I like you.' They press a warm vial into your hands. 'On the house. First time I've laughed in forty years.'

Effects: XP 5; items: Fire Resistance Potion · Karma: Human +3

If it fails:

The merchant's smile doesn't reach their obsidian eyes. 'That was not funny. I have been in this realm for eight hundred years and that was not funny. Leave.' They turn their back. The temperature near you drops noticeably.

GREY Move on

'Stay warm! Well, you'll have no choice about that down here!' the merchant cackles as you leave.

The Burning Prisoner hell_burning_prisoner

A figure writhes in chains of molten metal, suspended above a pit of glowing coals. Their screams have long since faded to hoarse whispers. Despite their torment, their eyes are clear — filled with pain, but also a terrible awareness.

'Please,' they rasp. 'I know what I did. I know why I'm here. But I've suffered enough to understand. Please... if you can...'

BLUE Break the chains with your strength

Requires: Strength 14+

You grab the molten chains, gritting your teeth against the searing pain. With a mighty heave, the links shatter. The prisoner collapses, weeping.

'Thank you. I was a tyrant — I burned villages and tortured innocents. This was my punishment. But you... you showed mercy even to one who showed none.'

They press something into your blistered hands — a key they'd been clutching all along.

Effects: XP 10; items: Demon Key · Karma: Hell -8, Human +5, God +5

BLUE Use healing magic to ease their suffering

Requires: White Magic 2+

You cannot break the chains, but you can mend what they've broken. Healing light flows from your hands, closing burns and numbing pain.

The prisoner breathes freely for the first time in ages. 'You cannot free me — only I can do that, through true repentance. But this respite... it reminds me what kindness feels like. I had forgotten.' Tears trace clean lines through the soot on their face.

Effects: XP 8 · Karma: Hell -5, Human +5, God +8

BLUE Offer a ritual purification to shorten their suffering

Requires: Ritual 3+

They nod somewhat absent-mindedly, numbed by the pain. You perform the rite as best you can under the circumstances. By the end they seem somewhat relieved — not freed, but perhaps a little less alone in their torment.

Effects: XP 8 · Karma: Human +3, God +4, Hell -3

GREY Ask what crime brought them here

'I was a warlord,' they whisper. 'I burned a hundred homes. I thought fear was power. Now I know — fear is just fear. And cruelty is just cruelty dressed up as strength.'

They look at you with haunted eyes. 'Don't make my mistakes, traveler. Power without compassion is just a longer chain.'

Effects: XP 4; mind: Water -20, Space -8 · Karma: Human +3, Hell -2

BLUE Use your gauntlets to grip the molten chain

Requires: Armor 3+

You know exactly where to grip through the gauntlets — the cooler sections, the fulcrum points. It takes strength and technique both. The chain holds long enough to matter, then a link gives way with a sound like a bell. The prisoner slides free and looks at their hands as if seeing them for the first time in a long while.

Effects: XP 10; items: Demon Key · Karma: Hell -6, Human +5, God +4

BLUE You are not going to be able to walk past this.

Requires: Trait: Merciful

You are not. Everyone in the party works this out at approximately the same moment you do, and the argument that follows is short.

The chains are hot enough to cost you. The prisoner is down and breathing before you have finished deciding whether it was wise.

Effects: XP 30; HP loss (light, random); mind: Water +15; gains trait: Merciful · Karma: Human +6, Hell -4

GREY Turn away — this is their punishment

You walk on. Behind you, the prisoner's whispers fade back into the crackling of flames. The heat feels heavier on your shoulders.

Karma: Hell +3, Asura +2

The Trial of Flames hell_fire_trial

An arena of scorched stone rises from the lava fields, its tiers filled with demons of all shapes and sizes. They roar and stamp at the sight of you — fresh blood for their entertainment.

A massive demon in ceremonial armor stands at the center. 'FRESH CHALLENGER!' it bellows. 'The Trial of Flames awaits! Prove your worth in combat, or prove your wisdom in another way. Choose!'

GREY Accept the combat challenge

Combat: Demon Patrol (hard)

The crowd erupts as warriors pour into the arena. These are no ordinary demons — they are the arena's champions, hardened by countless trials.

Karma: Asura +5, Hell +2

BLUE Challenge them to a contest of performance instead

Requires: Performance 3+

You step into the arena not with weapons drawn, but with a performance that captures even demonic hearts. You tell the tale of a warrior who conquered not through strength but through art — and the demons listen, rapt.

When you finish, even the arena champion is applauding. 'That took more courage than fighting!' they declare. The demons shower you with prizes.

Effects: XP 12; items: Fire Crystal · Karma: Asura +3, Human +5

BLUE Stare down the champion with raw willpower

Requires: Charm 15+

You lock eyes with the champion. Neither of you blinks. The crowd falls silent. Seconds stretch into minutes. Something shifts in the champion's gaze — recognition, perhaps respect.

'You have the spirit of a true warrior,' the champion says, breaking the silence. 'You don't need to prove anything in this pit.' They gesture, and the arena opens a path for you, the crowd parting with grudging respect.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: Asura +5, Human +3

BLUE Strike the demon down with sorcery before he finishes boasting

Requires: Sorcery 4+

The crowd falls utterly silent. Then it erupts — equal parts outrage and awe. The champion collapses. The gatekeeper stares at you for a long moment, then steps aside.

Effects: XP 12; items: Fire Crystal · Karma: Asura +4, Human +3

GREY Decline and walk away

You turn your back on the arena. Boos and jeers follow you, but no one moves to stop you. Sometimes the bravest choice is the one that looks like retreat.

Karma: Human +2

The Volcanic Cave hell_volcanic_cave

A cave entrance glows red with the heat of magma flowing within. The walls pulse with veins of liquid fire, casting dancing shadows. Deep within, you can hear a rhythmic sound — like a heartbeat, or the slow breathing of something enormous.

The heat is nearly unbearable, but you can see the glint of valuables deeper inside.

YELLOW Brave the heat and explore the cave

Roll: Constitution, normal difficulty

If it succeeds:

You push through the searing heat, your body screaming in protest. The cave opens into a magma chamber where ancient demon forges still glow with purpose.

Among the abandoned tools, you find fire-forged equipment of remarkable quality and a cache of supplies left by the last smith to work here.

Effects: XP 10; items: Health Potion, Fire Resistance Potion · Karma: Human +2

If it fails:

The heat is too much. You stagger back, skin blistered, gasping for cooler air. You manage to grab a few things near the entrance before retreating, but the deeper treasures remain beyond your endurance.

Effects: XP 4 · Karma: Animal +2

BLUE Use fire magic to protect yourself from the heat

Requires: Fire Magic 2+

You weave a barrier of controlled flame around yourself, turning the cave's heat aside like water off oiled cloth. The magma parts before you as you walk deeper.

The cave holds wonders — natural formations of crystallized fire magic, and at its heart, a forge still burning with the flames that were lit when Naraka was young. You take what you can carry.

Effects: XP 12; items: Fire Crystal, Mana Potion · Karma: Human +3, Asura +2

BLUE Listen to the heartbeat sound from the entrance

Requires: Learning 2+

You close your eyes and listen. The rhythm is too regular for a creature, too purposeful for nature. After long study, you realize — it's the pulse of the realm itself. Naraka has a heartbeat, and this cave is one of its arteries.

The knowledge fills you with a deeper understanding of how the hell realm works. The suffering here isn't random — it has structure, purpose, even a kind of terrible beauty.

Effects: XP 8 · Karma: Human +4, God +2

BLUE Move quickly and lightly between the thermal vents

Requires: Grace 2+

Uncomfortable, but nevertheless doable — like so many things in life. You thread between the vents with quick, precise movements and find what you came for.

Effects: XP 8; items: Health Potion, Fire Resistance Potion · Karma: Animal +3, Human +3, Asura +3

GREY The heat is too dangerous — move on

You back away from the cave entrance. The glow within seems to pulse with disappointment, but sometimes survival is its own reward.

The Lava Flow hell_lava_flow

A river of molten rock surges across the path ahead, its surface glowing white-hot. The heat creates a shimmering wall of distortion in the air. On the other side, you can see the path continuing — but crossing seems impossible.

Then you notice: the flow pulses. There are moments when it thins, gaps between surges...

YELLOW Time the surges and dash across during a gap

Roll: Finesse, normal difficulty

If it succeeds:

You watch the rhythm of the flow, counting between surges. Three... two... one... NOW!

You sprint across the brief gap, heat searing your boots but not quite burning through. You make it to the other side with singed clothes and a racing heart — but alive and ahead of those who would turn back.

Effects: XP 8; mind: Fire +12, Air +10 · Karma: Human +2, Animal +2

If it fails:

You mistime the surge and have to leap back as molten rock splashes where you stood. The attempt leaves you with minor burns and a healthy respect for lava.

Effects: XP 3 · Karma: Hell +1

BLUE Time your steps to the lava's rhythm and dance your way across

Requires: Grace 3+

And a-one, and a-two... You cross in a series of precise, unhurried steps that somehow feel like dancing. The lava surges around your feet and misses every time.

Effects: XP 8 · Karma: Animal +3, Human +3, Asura +3

BLUE Use earth magic to create a stone bridge

Requires: Earth Magic 2+

You reach into the bedrock beneath the lava flow and pull. Stone rises, hissing and steaming, forming a crude but solid bridge above the molten river. The lava laps at it furiously but cannot melt it fast enough.

You cross safely, and the bridge will last long enough for others to follow — a small act of kindness in an unkind place.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: Human +4, God +2

BLUE You have always been faster than the situation requires.

Requires: Trait: Quick

The gap is not really a gap. You are across it before it has finished being one, and the second surge arrives where you were standing rather than where you are.

You throw the rope back for everyone else.

Effects: XP 10

BLUE There is a way across. Going around is not a way across.

Requires: Trait: Stubborn

Everyone else has already agreed to go around and you have not, and the argument takes twenty minutes that could have been spent walking.

You are, in the end, correct: the crossing exists. It is also true that the twenty minutes cost more than the detour would have.

Effects: XP 10; mind: Earth -5

GREY Look for a way around the lava flow

You follow the lava flow downstream until you find a narrow point where the ground is merely scorching rather than deadly. After a careful crossing, you continue on your way — slower, but unburned.

Effects: XP 2 · Karma: Human +1

Ancient Stupa hell_ancient_stupa

A crumbling stupa rises from the snow, its dome still intact after countless ages. Tattered prayer flags still flutter from the crown, faded but unbroken. Mantras are carved into every stone.

GREY Walk around it three times in devotion

As you circle it clockwise three times; the cold seems to lessen. You place a small offering at the base and leave.

Effects: XP 5 · Karma: God +3, Human +3, Hell -3

BLUE Meditate at the stupa's base

Requires: Yoga 2+

Seeing the work of so many hands towards creating a better tomorrow fills you with determination.

Effects: XP 8 · Karma: God +5, Human +3, Hell -3

BLUE Study the carved mantras closely

Requires: Ritual 1+

You study the faded letters until they become clearer.

Effects: XP 8; learns a spell (White Magic) · Karma: God +4, Human +3

BLUE Study the prayer flags and what sustains them

Requires: Air Magic 1+

Somehow kept together by their inner charge rather than outer weave, the flags can still teach you something about how intention outlasts form.

Effects: XP 8 · Karma: God +2, Human +2

BLUE Walk the full circuit. Three times, the correct direction.

Requires: Trait: Pilgrim

It takes the better part of an hour in cold that makes an hour expensive.

On the third circuit you notice the thing the first two missed: a niche at the base, sheltered from the wind, with something still in it.

Effects: XP 20; items: Item Random · Karma: Human +3, God +3

BLUE You are carrying something you have been meaning to put down.

Requires: Trait: Renunciate

You put it in the niche. It is not an offering exactly — nobody is being asked for anything — it is simply somewhere to leave a thing so that it stops being yours.

You walk on lighter by an amount that has nothing to do with the weight.

Effects: gains trait: Renunciate; XP 20; mind: Fire +15, Earth +8

GREY Leave a small offering and move on

Cost: Gold (small)

You leave a few coins. The flags flutter in farewell.

Effects: XP 4 · Karma: God +2, Human +2, Hell -2

Demon Checkpoint hell_demon_checkpoint

A wobbly table has been set up across the path. Behind it, a bureaucratic demon in a stained uniform holds a quill the size of a sword.

"Halt. Passage permit, please. Standard Form 7-B, the one authorizing inter-zone traversal for damned entities. You do have a Form 7-B, yes?"

You do not have a Form 7-B. Form 7-B does not exist.

GREY Push past the checkpoint by force

Combat: Demon Patrol (normal)

The bureaucrat sounds a horn taken seemingly out of thin air.

Karma: Asura +2, Hell +2

BLUE Produce a convincing-looking document

Requires: Guile 2+

You manage to quickly fold some parchment into an official-looking shape; the demon examines it upside down with a bored expression and stamps it.

Effects: XP 8 · Karma: Hungry Ghost +2, Human +2

GREY Slip the demon a bribe

Cost: Gold (small moderate)

Gold changes hands; "Everything checks out. Move along."

Effects: XP 4 · Karma: Hungry Ghost +4, Asura +1

BLUE Challenge the checkpoint's legal legitimacy

Requires: Persuasion 3+

A 40-minute forensic argument takes place. The bureaucrat is shaken and visibly tired. Finally, he waves you through, muttering to himself.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: Human +4, Hell -2

BLUE Point out that you cannot be subject to an official without a valid 16-F operating license

Requires: Comedy 2+

Stumped at first, the devil taps his quill against his chin, then nods slowly. Game recognizes game. He waves you through without another word.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: Human +5

BLUE Do not give your name. Do not give any name.

Requires: Trait: Debtor

The clerk wants a name for the ledger and you supply one, fluently, along with a district and a plausible reason for travel.

It is not your name. You have had a great deal of practice at this and it shows in all the wrong ways.

Effects: XP 30; mind: Air -8

BLUE Talk. Keep talking. Do not stop talking.

Requires: Trait: Braggart

Forty minutes later the clerk has heard about three campaigns you were not in, a title you do not hold, and a mutual acquaintance who does not exist.

He stamps the form to make it stop.

Effects: XP 20

BLUE It is a clerk with a form. Let him have his form.

Requires: Trait: Patient

You answer every question in order, including the four that are the same question, and you do not once indicate that you have noticed.

The clerk, who is braced for a fight the way clerks always are, has nothing to push against and stamps the thing in half the usual time.

Effects: XP 10

BLUE You have been standing at this table for a very long time.

Requires: Trait: Hot-tempered

You are two sentences into telling him what you think of the table, the quill and the entire apparatus before anyone can get a hand on your arm.

The form is stamped eventually. It is stamped with an annotation, and the annotation will be waiting at the next checkpoint.

Effects: gold -15; mind: Water -12; XP 10

BLUE Lift the official seal and forge yourself a transit pass

Requires: Thievery 3+

While arguing about Section 12, Subsection B, you palm the bureaucrat's official seal from the desk. A minute later you hand over a transit pass that is, technically, correct in every particular except that you wrote it yourself.

The demon examines it at length. Stamps it. Files it. Waves you through.

'Everything in order. Move along.'

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: Hungry Ghost +3, Human +1

Ice Oracle hell_ice_oracle

A figure is frozen solid inside a pillar of ice — upright, arms folded, expression serene. When you come near, you hear a strange voice from within your head:

"I have been here since time lost to memory. I have watched many pass through, time and time again. Ask, and I may answer."

GREY Ask what lies ahead on your path

"Fear and hope, then hope and fear. Until one day the natural state blooms in your awareness, and you shall be free, as you always really were."

Effects: XP 6 · Karma: Human +3, God +3

BLUE Open your mind and commune with it directly

Requires: Space Magic 3+

You sense countless centuries of sentient beings passing to and fro, their fears and small kindnesses. You settle in a deep clarity.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: God +5, Human +3

BLUE Ask about the nature of this realm

Requires: Awareness 15+

"This realm, like all realms, is a mirror."

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: God +4, Human +4, Hell -3

BLUE You've been here since time immemorial and still haven't found a way out — not sure I should be taking advice

Requires: Comedy 2+

A long silence. Then, from somewhere within the ice, a sound like grinding stone that might be a laugh. "Ha. The first wit in eight hundred years." Something like self-doubt flickers in those ancient eyes — and something else. Respect.

Effects: XP 5 · Karma: Human +2, Asura +1

GREY Thank it for its time and move on

"Seek out situations to exercise compassion."

Effects: XP 4 · Karma: Human +1, God +1

BLUE Listen to the prophecy. Then discount it correctly.

Requires: Trait: Clear-eyed

She says four things. Two are true of anyone, one is unfalsifiable, and the fourth is specific, checkable, and delivered in a completely different tone from the others.

You keep the fourth. It is worth keeping.

Effects: XP 15

BLUE Every word of it matters. Write it down.

Requires: Trait: Superstitious

You get all of it, including the parts she probably did not mean as prophecy.

For the next several days you will be interpreting ordinary events as fulfilments, which is exhausting, and once — just once — extremely useful.

Effects: XP 22; mind: Air -8, Space -5

YELLOW Pose it a riddle in return — meet its strangeness with your own

Roll: Awareness, normal difficulty

If it succeeds:

The oracle is silent for long enough you think you've failed. Then, with something that sounds like appreciation: 'That one I have not heard.' It answers your original question fully and adds something you hadn't thought to ask.

Effects: XP 15 · Karma: Human +3, Asura +2

If it fails:

'I knew this one before your realm existed,' the oracle says without cruelty, and falls silent again. There is nothing further to be gotten from it today.

Effects: XP 4

The Ghost Village hell_ghost_village

Stone buildings stand perfectly preserved — doors hanging open, fires long dead, a well at the center still intact. Not a soul visible, but the air feels thick with watching.

This was a place once. Something happened here, in some other age, and whatever it was left the buildings standing but took everyone away.

YELLOW Search the buildings carefully

Roll: Awareness, easy difficulty

If it succeeds:

You move carefully through the empty houses, reading the signs: a half-finished meal, a child's toy, writing on a wall in a language you only half understand. Someone was in the middle of living here.

In a locked strongbox beneath the largest hearth, you find what they left behind.

Effects: XP 8; items: Health Potion, Mana Potion · Karma: Human +2

If it fails:

You search, but the village gives up nothing. Whatever was here has long since been taken — by other travelers, by time, or by whatever emptied this place.

As you leave, you hear what might be footsteps from inside a house you already checked. You don't go back.

Effects: XP 3

GREY Go to the village center and pay your respects

You stand at the well and bow your head. A prayer rises naturally — for whoever lived here, for whatever ended this place, for the possibility that even abandoned things can be honored.

Something shifts. The watching feeling becomes less like surveillance and more like gratitude.

Effects: XP 5 · Karma: God +3, Human +3, Hell -2

BLUE Call out to the spirits of this place

Requires: Persuasion 1+

You stand at the village center and speak: 'I know you're here. I'm not here to take anything. I just want to understand.'

For a long moment, nothing. Then a presence — not frightening, just profoundly sad — brushes past you like a cold wind with shape.

Images: a flood, a night with no stars, the decision to stay and wait for someone who never came. Then nothing.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: Human +5, Hell -3

BLUE Prepare a smoke offering for the lingering spirits

Requires: Ritual 3+

"Ghosts, gods, lords of this land — come forth and take your fill in peace!"

The smoke rises in spirals more purposeful than the wind allows. The watching presence gathers around the offering. For a moment, the village feels inhabited again.

Effects: XP 8; gains trait: Mourner · Karma: Human +3, God +3, Hell -2

BLUE Compel a spirit to speak directly

Requires: Summoning 3+

You speak the words of compulsion and a presence coalesces at the well — not comfortable about it, but present. A shape like a man, with no features you can hold in mind.

'You pulled me back.' Not angry. Just tired. 'Ask, then.'

You ask what happened here. It tells you, precisely and without sentiment. A plague, a decision, a long argument about whether to stay or go, and the people who chose wrong and knew it immediately. You listen until it dissolves on its own.

The village doesn't feel empty anymore — it feels, now, like somewhere that used to be full.

Effects: XP 12; items: Soul Stone · Karma: Human +4, Hell -3

BLUE Do what nobody has done here in a long time: keep their days.

Requires: Trait: Mourner

You do not know their names or their calendar, so you use yours, and you set out what can be spared at each door rather than at the centre.

It takes all afternoon. By the end the village is not less empty, but it is differently empty.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Water +15 · Karma: Human +5, Hungry Ghost -5

BLUE You know what a place looks like when everyone left at once and nobody wrote it down.

Requires: Trait: Secret-bearer

You find it because you know where a person puts a thing they do not want found: not hidden, just somewhere nobody would look twice.

Under the well's coping stone, wrapped in cloth. An account. It does not make good reading and it is worth carrying.

Effects: XP 20; items: Item Random

GREY Leave the village alone

You walk through without stopping, keeping your eyes forward. Some places hold their silence for a reason.

The watching feeling follows you for a while, then fades.

The Lava Swimmer hell_lava_swimmer

Something enormous moves beneath the surface of a lava flow. As you watch, it surfaces — a serpentine creature forty meters long, its scales glowing like cooling magma, its eyes containing a fire that is not hot but old.

It regards you with what you can only describe as curiosity. It is not aggressive. It has simply noticed you, in the way that very old things notice small things that interest them.

GREY Watch it in respectful silence

You stand still and watch. The creature rises and sinks, performing what might be a display or might simply be how it exists. Its movements are mesmerizing — fluid despite the medium, graceful in a way that should not be possible in molten rock.

After a time, it sinks below the surface. The lava glows a little brighter where it passed.

Effects: XP 6 · Karma: Animal +2, Human +4

BLUE Attempt to commune with it through fire magic

Requires: Fire Magic 2+

You extend your awareness through fire, and the creature responds immediately — not with words, but with sensation: the pleasure of heat, the memory of a world younger and hotter, the understanding that fire is not destruction but transformation.

When the contact ends, you carry something of that understanding with you. Afterwards your experience of heat seems somehow deeper, more meaningful.

Effects: XP 14 · Karma: Animal +4, God +3

GREY Drop something metallic into the lava as an offering

You toss a few coins into the flow. The creature's head rises immediately, watching where the metal sank. It dips below the surface and returns a moment later, nudging something up toward the edge.

A gem — fire opal — glowing with internal heat. It seems this creature values the exchange.

Effects: XP 5; items: Fire Crystal · Karma: Animal +3

BLUE Sit down and begin playing — let the awe move through you into music

Requires: Performance 3+

A melody comes, slowly at first. The creature surfaces again and stays, its great head resting at the lava's edge, watching. Two strange witnesses to each other's existence, sharing something that has no name.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: Animal +4, Human +3, God +2

GREY Attack the creature while it's surfaced

Combat: Lava Guardian (hard)

The creature's ancient eyes shift from curious to something cold and purposeful. It moves faster than anything its size should be able to move.

Karma: Animal -5, Hell +3

BLUE Watch how it moves. Everything that hunts has a pattern.

Requires: Trait: Hunter

It surfaces on a count. Not a regular one — it is hunting the vents, not the surface — but a count, and once you have it you know where it will not be for about eleven seconds at a time.

Eleven seconds is enough.

Effects: XP 20

YELLOW Study its movements carefully — enormous things have patterns

Roll: Awareness, normal difficulty

If it succeeds:

There is a rhythm. Surface, breathe, submerge — every fourteen seconds, always returning to the same channel. You watch long enough to see something you hadn't expected: shapes on its back, almost like writing. Whoever or whatever this creature was before hell, it was marked.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: Animal +3, Human +2

If it fails:

You are still reading its movement when it surfaces directly in front of you — wave of heat, displaced lava, the ground lurching. You scramble back, singed and startled.

Effects: XP 3; HP loss (small, all) · Karma: Animal +1

The Demon Dojo hell_demon_dojo

A stone courtyard surrounded by scorched walls, where a dozen demons practice combat forms with absolute precision. There is something almost beautiful about it — the focus, the discipline, the complete commitment to mastery.

The sensei demon — larger than the others, covered in old scars — spots you and points with a clawed finger. Then gestures inward. An invitation.

BLUE Join the training session

Requires: Strength 12+

You strip off your pack and join the ranks. The sensei demon watches you critically, adjusting your stance twice without gentleness. The training is brutal but honest — no cruelty, just high standards.

An hour later, bruised and exhausted, you bow. The sensei returns the bow — once, precisely. You have been accepted as a student, at least for today.

Effects: XP 12 · Karma: Asura +4, Human +2

YELLOW Challenge one demon to a friendly bout

Roll: Finesse, easy difficulty

If it succeeds:

You bow to your opponent and take your stance. It's a hard fight — the demon is fast and skilled — but you hold your own, forcing it back several times.

The bout ends in a draw by mutual acknowledgment. The other demons stamp their feet in approval. You have earned something here that is not easily named.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: Asura +5, Human +3

If it fails:

You are put flat on your back within thirty seconds. The demon stands over you, then offers a hand up. The others are not unkind about it — they have all been put on their backs before.

'Again,' the sensei says. You last longer the second time.

Effects: XP 5 · Karma: Asura +2, Human +2

BLUE Observe the forms carefully without participating

Requires: Learning 1+

You find a wall to lean against and watch. These forms are old — older than you expected, derived from styles you half-recognize. The demons practice them with perfect fidelity, generation after generation.

You learn more from watching than you could from participation. Certain sequences embed themselves in your muscle memory through pure observation.

Effects: XP 8 · Karma: Asura +2, Human +3

BLUE Demonstrate your empty-hand technique

Requires: Unarmed 3+

You step onto the practice floor without a weapon. The training stops. The sensei crosses its arms and watches. You run through your forms — clean, deliberate, unflinching. When you finish, the demons exchange a look. The sensei inclines its head once.

'Not our style. But real.' You train alongside them for an hour. The forms absorb each other at the edges.

Effects: XP 12 · Karma: Asura +4, Human +3

BLUE Assert yourself as a senior practitioner — take over the session

Requires: Leadership 4+

You step in and redirect the group through a correction sequence — you've seen this error before, in better-equipped dojos. The sensei observes with narrowed eyes. Then steps back.

You run the session for thirty minutes. The demons are better for it. The sensei says nothing at the end, which is the only acknowledgment available.

Effects: XP 14 · Karma: Asura +3, Human +4

BLUE Ask to stand in the back row and do the forms with them.

Requires: Trait: Ascetic

Nobody objects. Nobody helps, either — you get the form wrong for two hours and are corrected exactly once, by a demon who does not break their own rhythm to do it.

The correction is worth the two hours.

Effects: XP 20; Martial Arts +1

GREY Decline the invitation and move on

You bow respectfully at the entrance and continue on your way. The sensei watches you leave without expression. The training continues without pause.

Karma: Asura +1

The Infernal Archive hell_infernal_archive

A tower of black basalt rising from the badlands, its windows glowing orange from within. The sign above the door reads: INFERNAL ARCHIVE — RESTRICTED MATERIALS.

The librarian demon at the desk looks up as you enter. It is ancient, patient, and wearing spectacles that have somehow survived the volcanic atmosphere. It regards you with the professional suspicion of someone who has seen too many people try to steal restricted materials.

GREY Request access to the unrestricted section

The librarian processes your request with the efficiency of someone who processes requests all day, every day, eternally. 'Section Three. No fire. No food. No summoning.' It hands you a reading pass. You spend an hour in the stacks, reading accounts of previous hell realm travelers — their strategies, their mistakes, their occasional triumphs.

Effects: XP 8; items: Scroll Lesser Heal · Karma: Human +2

BLUE Access the restricted collection

Requires: Guile 2+

When the librarian turns to assist another patron, you slip through the RESTRICTED door. The books here are bound in materials you do not want to think about, their titles written in languages that hurt to read.

You find what you're looking for and memorize key passages before returning to your seat before the librarian turns back. The knowledge is valuable. It cost nothing except a small, lingering unease.

Effects: XP 12; items: Scroll Firebolt · Karma: Hungry Ghost +3, Hell +1

BLUE Commission research on local trade routes

Requires: Trade 2+

You pay the librarian's research fee and request maps of commerce through the hell realm. It returns with three scrolls detailing merchant routes, safe passage times, and which demons respond to bribery versus which prefer other forms of persuasion.

The librarian accepts your payment without expression. This is, apparently, a common request.

Effects: XP 6 · Karma: Human +2

BLUE Bypass the physical locks on the forbidden vault

Requires: Thievery 3+

There's a physical vault behind the restricted stacks — older than the archive, predating whatever bureaucracy runs this place. The locks are mechanical, not magical, which means they respond to skill rather than credentials.

Fifteen minutes of careful work. The vault opens on a collection that even the restricted section doesn't have clearance for.

You read quickly, memorize what you can, and leave before the librarian notices the vault is open.

The knowledge is extraordinary. You are also immediately on at least three lists you were not on before.

Effects: XP 14; items: Scroll Firebolt, Mana Potion · Karma: Hungry Ghost +4, Hell +2

BLUE You will not be leaving until you have read something.

Requires: Trait: Curious

The archivist watches you work through two centuries of tax records with the expression of a man who has finally met someone worse than himself.

Between the ledgers: a requisition order, countersigned, for something that was never delivered. You copy the name.

Effects: XP 8

BLUE Read it once. You will have it.

Requires: Trait: Sharp Memory

You read the index rather than the books, which is faster and, for you, sufficient. Nine hundred entries. You will be able to produce any of them on request for the rest of this life.

Effects: XP 12; Learning +1

GREY The archive's atmosphere is too unsettling — leave

You back out of the archive. The librarian watches you go without comment. Behind you, the orange glow from the windows continues its eternal, patient burn.

The Fire Pilgrim hell_fire_pilgrim

A figure in scorched white robes moves through the fire hell on their knees, hands pressed together, murmuring prayers with every measured movement. Burns mark their skin. Their progress is agonizingly slow.

They look up as you approach. Their eyes are clear — no delusion, no despair, just an absolute and deliberate acceptance of each moment of pain.

BLUE Heal their burns and walk with them a while

Requires: Medicine 1+

You tend to their wounds as best you can. They do not ask you to stop the pilgrimage — they do not want to stop. But the relief in their eyes at having another person near them is unmistakable.

You walk beside them for an hour. They speak of their life, their error, their choice to make this journey rather than wait for absolution. When you part, they press a small carved token into your hands.

'Carry it until you don't need it anymore. Then give it to someone who does.'

Effects: XP 12; items: Prayer Beads · Karma: God +6, Human +5, Hell -4

GREY Walk alongside them in silence

You fall into step beside them — upright, while they crawl, but present. They do not ask why you've joined them, and you don't explain.

For a quarter mile, you walk in silence. Their prayers continue without pause. When you must go a different direction, you bow to each other, and they return the bow without interrupting their rhythm.

Effects: XP 6 · Karma: God +4, Human +4, Hell -2

GREY Ask them about their pilgrimage

'I burned a library,' they say simply, without stopping. 'Hundreds of years of knowledge, gone in one night. I was angry at the man who owned it. I didn't think about what it contained.'

A pause in the prayer, then: 'I have been walking since then. I will walk until I understand, truly understand, what was in those books. What was lost. Who was harmed.' Another step. 'I don't know how long that will take.'

Effects: XP 4 · Karma: Human +3

GREY Let them continue their journey

You step aside to let them pass. Their prayers continue without acknowledgment of your presence or your departure. This journey belongs entirely to them.

YELLOW Lower yourself to your knees and walk the fire path alongside them for a while

Roll: Finesse, normal difficulty

If it succeeds:

The fire hurts, but you find the pilgrim's rhythm and hold it. When you eventually rise, they turn for the first time and look at you — really look. They press their hands together and bow. No words. You understand anyway.

Effects: XP 15 · Karma: Human +5, God +3

If it fails:

You manage a few meters before your knees give and you have to stand. The pilgrim doesn't look back, but their murmured prayer seems to include something new in it. Perhaps you contributed something after all.

Effects: XP 6; HP loss (tiny, all) · Karma: Human +2

Bone Arena hell_bone_arena

A frozen pit ringed with bones rises from the wasteland — a combat arena, its tiers packed with demons howling for blood. Two poor souls fight below, stumbling with exhaustion.

A massive gatekeeper blocks the exit path, grinning with entirely too many rows of teeth. "Welcome, welcome! Do you come to bet or to fight?"

GREY Step into the arena and fight

Combat: Demon Patrol (hard)

Effects: gold moderate · Karma: Hell +2, Asura +5

BLUE Issue a formal challenge to the current champion

Requires: Strength 15+

Combat: Demon Elite (hard)

The gatekeeper nods with respect and lets you in.

Effects: XP 12; gold moderate; items: Good Iron Weapon · Karma: Asura +5, Human +3

BLUE Narrate the fight dramatically for the crowd

Requires: Performance 3+

The crowd shifts from baying for blood to hanging on your words; gatekeeper laughs hard enough to let you through without charging.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: Asura +2, Human +5

GREY Bet on one of the fighters

Cost: Gold (moderate)

"Sure, take a seat in the tiers."

Effects: XP 5; gamble · Karma: Hell +2, Asura +2, Human +2

BLUE Enter as a knife-fighter — blades against the arena's weapons

Requires: Daggers 3+

Combat: Demon Patrol (normal)

The crowd goes quiet as you draw blades instead of the expected weapon. Then louder.

Effects: XP 12; gold moderate · Karma: Asura +4, Human +2

BLUE Fight unarmed — no weapons, just technique

Requires: Unarmed 3+

Combat: Demon Patrol (normal)

The gatekeeper grins wider than usual. The crowd loses its mind.

Effects: XP 12; gold moderate · Karma: Asura +5

BLUE You were always going to. Do not pretend otherwise.

Requires: Trait: Duelist

The gatekeeper sees it happen — the moment the decision stops being a decision — and grins with all the rows of teeth at once.

'Oh, you're one of those,' he says, delightedly, and waves you through without the fee.

Effects: XP 20; gold small

BLUE Tell them who they are about to watch. At length.

Requires: Trait: Braggart

Very little of it is true. All of it is delivered well, and the tiers are chanting a name by the end that is only approximately yours.

The purse is larger for a crowd that has already decided how it wants the fight to go.

Effects: gold small; XP 20

BLUE The crowd is not the fight. Do not spend anything on the crowd.

Requires: Trait: Composed

You do not. You go out flat, unhurried and entirely uninterested in the tiers, and your opponent — who has been playing to them for a living — cannot find the rhythm they were expecting.

It is over rather quickly and the crowd does not enjoy it at all.

Effects: XP 12; gold small

BLUE Pick up an arena bone-club — meet them on local terms

Requires: Maces 3+

Combat: Demon Patrol (normal)

You grab a femur from the ground and weigh it in your hand. The arena crowd approves of the improvisation.

Effects: XP 10; gold moderate · Karma: Asura +3, Hell +2

Suffering Sage hell_suffering_sage

A figure sits at the summit of a frozen ridge, encased in ice up to the neck — only their face remains free, eyes open and clear. The oldest devils have forgotten when he appeared. Their expression is that of endless patience. As you come closer, they open their eyes a little.

GREY Ask about the nature of suffering

"All suffering comes from resistance to what is. The cold is not suffering. The resistance to the cold is suffering."

Effects: XP 8 · Karma: God +5, Human +3

BLUE Enter deep meditation to receive their teaching directly

Requires: Yoga 3+

Shivering from the cold gives way to stillness and stillness to a direct transmission beyond words. You see the endless wheels of resistance and acceptance turning. They have been here for a long time, and yet a long time they will stay.

Effects: XP 12 · Karma: God +7, Human +5, Hell -3

BLUE Ask about the history of this realm

Requires: Learning 2+

"I was here when the realm was still young. The first being who entered was a judge convinced he attained true justice. He was here for a very long time."

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: God +4, Human +4

GREY Leave them to their vigil

Their eyes close again.

Karma: Human +1

YELLOW Press forward and place your hand on the ice encasing them

Roll: Awareness, difficult difficulty

If it succeeds:

The cold is immense. But through it — something transmits directly, bypassing language: the sage's full experiential understanding of suffering as ground rather than obstacle. Your hand burns. The teaching lands intact. You will be finding its edges for a long time.

Effects: XP 20; HP loss (medium, all) · Karma: Human +6, God +4

If it fails:

The cold defeats you. Your hand numbs within seconds and you pull back before contact. The sage's eyes follow you — not disappointed, just patient. They have centuries to wait.

Effects: XP 5 · Karma: Human +1

Suspicious Gift hell_suspicious_gift

A neatly wrapped package sits in the center of the path, as though placed deliberately. Red cloth, black cord. A tag: "For whoever needs this most."

The package is warm to the touch. Nothing else in the cold hell is warm.

YELLOW Examine it carefully before opening

Roll: Awareness, easy difficulty

If it succeeds:

Congratulations on your caution. The trap disarmed, you retrieve your loot safely.

Effects: XP 8; items: Health Potion; gold 40 · Karma: Human +2

If it fails:

Triggered; theatrical but not lethal; package empty; a card: "Better luck with the next one."

Effects: XP 3 · Karma: Hell +1, Animal +2

BLUE Check it for traps with trained eyes

Requires: Guile 1+

You find a magic seal and quickly scratch it until it's unrecognizable. The package opens cleanly with a health potion and some coins inside.

Effects: XP 6; items: Health Potion; gold 25 · Karma: Human +2

GREY Open it with reckless optimism

A flash, a sound, blinding cold — then you're standing there holding a health potion and forty gold, entirely unharmed. Sometimes things are exactly what they appear to be.

Effects: XP 4; items: Health Potion; gold 40 · Karma: Animal +2, Human +1

BLUE Cut the cord carefully — avoid any trigger mechanisms

Requires: Daggers 2+

You find the right angle and draw a single precise cut through the cord. The package opens clean, the trap still intact and inert, the contents untouched. A health potion and forty gold, secured without incident.

Effects: XP 6; items: Health Potion; gold 40 · Karma: Human +2

BLUE Assess it with professional eyes — you've handled worse

Requires: Thievery 3+

The trigger mechanism is amateur work — a pressure seal under the bow. You disable it in thirty seconds without opening the package, then open it cleanly. Good loot, poorly protected.

Effects: XP 8; items: Health Potion; gold 45 · Karma: Human +3

BLUE Do not touch it. Find who is watching it.

Requires: Trait: Paranoid

You spend twenty minutes on the surrounding rocks instead of the package, and you find him — a small demon flat behind a ridge with a good view and a bad hiding place.

He runs. The package turns out to be exactly as bad as you assumed, and you do not open it.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Air +10

BLUE It is a box. Walk past the box.

Requires: Trait: Incurious

You walk past the box. Some hours later there is a sound behind you that you decline to investigate.

Whoever it was for, it was not for you.

Effects: mind: Space -5; XP 22

GREY Leave it — gifts in hell are seldom genuine

You step around it cautiously; behind you, the package waits warm and patient.

Karma: Animal +1, Human +1

Ice Demon Toll hell_ice_demon_toll

Three squat ice demons have stretched a chain across the path. The leader holds a sign reading "TOLL — 10 GOLD" in letters of varying sizes.

"Passage fee. Standard Hell Traversal Rate, Section 7, Paragraph 4."

"There is no Section 7, Paragraph 4."

"For you there is."

GREY Refuse and fight your way through

Combat: Demon Patrol (normal)

Karma: Asura +2, Hell +2

GREY Pay the toll and move on

The gold is counted with elaborate care, the chain unhurriedly unclipped. "Watch out for the unofficial toll three roads further on — those ones are criminals."

Effects: XP 2 · Karma: Hungry Ghost +2

BLUE Challenge the legal legitimacy of this checkpoint

Requires: Guile 1+

An argument ensues, moving from the absence of appropriate seals though three different handwritings on the sign, to suspicious provisions. Finally you hear: "You can go. But only because we choose to be magnanimous."

Effects: XP 8 · Karma: Human +3, Hell -2

BLUE Ten gold. For a chain. Explain in detail why this will not happen.

Requires: Trait: Scrimper

You itemise. You are thorough. You establish the market rate for chain, the labour involved in stretching it across a road, and the total absence of any service rendered.

By the end the lead demon is arguing about the price of iron rather than collecting a toll, and the chain has somehow already been lowered.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Earth +5

BLUE **There is a faster way to settle this and everyone here knows it.**

Requires: Trait: Duelist

You name the terms before anyone has decided whether to be offended: one of theirs, one of yours, first to yield, no toll either way.

Theirs is shorter than you and considerably wider. It takes a while. The chain comes down.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Fire +8

BLUE **Offer to pay in entertainment**

Requires: Performance 1+

The demons are transfixed, their leader applauding. One demon presses a coin into your hand: "Best thing that's happened here in a century."

Effects: XP 5; gold 5 · Karma: Human +3, Asura +2

Cursed Pilgrim hell_cursed_pilgrim

A person trudges forward pulling a massive stone block behind them, gouging a furrow in the frozen ground. They are making slow, painful progress.

BLUE **Break the chain by brute force**

Requires: Strength 15+

After a long struggle, a link in the chain shatters. The pilgrim sits down heavily and breathes, then presses a carved token into your hands: "I had forgotten what it felt like to rest."

Effects: XP 12; items: Random Common Talisman · Karma: Hell -8, Human +5, God +5

BLUE **Examine the curse**

Requires: Black Magic 2+

You recognize a particular class of binding spells, resistant to direct force but vulnerable to patient unraveling from within. Once you explain it to the pilgrim you see a glimmer of hope in their eyes. "So there is a way!"

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: Human +4, Hell -3

GREY **Walk with them a while and listen**

You hear a story of a deal with the devil. "I thought I was clever. I had found the loophole. The one it wanted me to find, unfortunately." You walk together for a while and leave them with a faint feeling of relief.

Effects: XP 5 · Karma: Human +4, Hell -2

BLUE **Read the binding structure**

Requires: Enchantment 2+

The chain is an enchantment you can read, if not immediately undo — a layered binding keyed to the pilgrim's own guilt, tightening every time they try to escape and loosening, slightly, when they accept the weight of what they did. You explain this to the pilgrim. Their breathing changes.

'So it responds to understanding, not force,' they say. They look at the chain differently. You leave them with a map.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: Human +5, Hell -3

BLUE **Ask what the vow was. Not why they are still keeping it.**

Requires: Trait: Oath-keeper

Nobody has asked them that. Everyone asks the other question.

They tell you, and it is a reasonable vow made for a reasonable reason, and the stone is exactly as heavy as it was before.

You walk with them for a while.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Earth +12 · Karma: Human +3

GREY Try to help break the chain

You try everything, but the chain remains indifferent. The pilgrim watches with tired gratitude. Their goodbye handshake is stronger than you expected.

Effects: XP 3 · Karma: Human +3, Hell -1

Frozen Army hell_frozen_army

The valley below is filled with an army, frozen mid-march — thousands of soldiers preserved in ice, banners still flying. The armor is from no civilization you recognize. They are marching toward something that is no longer there.

They look like they are waiting.

GREY Pay your respects to the fallen

You stand at the valley's edge and bow. Barely perceptible: in the front rank, a soldier's hand tightens slightly on their weapon.

Effects: XP 5 · Karma: Human +3, God +2

BLUE Study the banners and try to identify them

Requires: Learning 2+

Sun bisected by a spear; armor wrong for any hell-native force. These were mortals who marched here deliberately to rescue someone. They were winning; then stopped. You leave with a feeling of grief without closure.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: Human +5, God +3, Hell -2

BLUE Search for a way to end their vigil

Requires: Ritual 3+

You find a binding mark at the standard's base and speak words of release. The ice melts gently, the army dissolves into light, armor clanking on the icy ground. The last soldier turns their head toward you and bows with ancient gratitude.

Effects: XP 15; items: Good Iron Armor · Karma: God +8, Hell -8

BLUE Study the armor — find out who they were

Requires: Armor 2+

You walk the front rank with trained eyes, reading the armor's construction, its repairs, its modifications. The plates are layered for siege conditions, not field skirmishes. The insignia has been filed off — but the filing pattern tells you who filed it and why. These were household guard for someone who did not want to be found.

They were winning. They almost made it.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: Human +4, Hell -2

BLUE Rouse one soldier — ask what happened

Requires: Summoning 3+

You reach into the ice with the words and one figure stirs — not freed, but present. A young soldier, not more than twenty when they marched.

'We were winning,' they say. Voice like ice on stone. 'The gate was opening. And then — he told us to stop.'

'Who?'

The soldier's eyes go distant. 'The one we came for.' They settle back into the ice. The answer costs you more than you expected.

Effects: XP 12 · Karma: Human +5, Hell -3

BLUE Read the formation — understand the battle order

Requires: Logistics 3+

The formation is a textbook advance-and-secure pattern, adapted for unknown terrain. Scouts ahead, heavies in the center, supply line staggered back. Whoever commanded this force was good — methodical, experienced, careful with their people.

The supply wagons are at the back of the column. They stopped mid-resupply. Whatever halted them came as a command, not a defeat.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: Human +3, God +2

BLUE Look at the formation, not the faces.

Requires: Trait: War-hardened

The formation tells you what happened: they were not caught marching. They were caught *forming up*, which means they saw it coming and had time to do the wrong thing about it.

You find the officer by where he is standing. What he is holding is worth taking.

Effects: XP 15; items: Item Random

BLUE Somebody should say something. Nobody has.

Requires: Trait: Mourner

You do not know a single name, so you say the words without them, which is how it is done for the unnamed anyway. It takes a long time. The ice does not change. You did not expect it to.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Water +15, Space +8; gains trait: Mourner · Karma: Human +4, Hungry Ghost -4

GREY Take the ridge path to avoid the valley

At the far end, you glance back at ten thousand frozen soldiers in perfect formation, rays of light glittering on their helmets.

The Pyromancer's Challenge hell_pyromancer_duel

A human mage in scorched red robes blocks the path, orbiting flames circling her like planets. The dueling scar on her cheek is self-inflicted — a mark made deliberately. She examines you with professional interest.

'You move like a magic user. I can always tell. I've been here forty years and no one's given me a real fight. You interested?'

Behind her, the path continues.

BLUE Accept the fire duel

Requires: Fire Magic 1+

Combat: Demon Patrol (normal)

She smiles for the first time and takes a stance. 'Honorable rules. No killing blows. First to yield.' The orbiting flames spin faster.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: Asura +5, Human +3

BLUE Answer fire with wind magic

Requires: Air Magic 2+

You raise a hand and let wind answer her fire. The two forces meet between you — not combat, but dialogue. Fire reaches. Wind redirects. Fire presses. Wind opens.

She holds this for a long moment, then lowers her hands.

'Huh. I've never had someone answer fire with wind before.' She considers. 'That's actually better. You're teaching me something.' She steps aside and demonstrates a technique for sealing fire before she lets you pass.

Effects: XP 12 · Karma: Asura +3, Human +5

BLUE Ask why she has been here for forty years

Requires: Persuasion 2+

The orbiting flames slow. Something in her expression shifts from challenge to something older.

'I came looking for my student,' she says. 'He made bad choices. He ended up here. I found his ghost eventually. Spent ten years helping him move on.' A pause. 'He did, in the end. But I stayed. I thought I owed this place something.' She looks at the path behind her. 'I'm not sure that's true anymore.'

She steps aside without being asked. Her flames continue their orbit, but slower — more contemplative than aggressive.

Effects: XP 8 · Karma: Human +5, God +3, Hell -3

BLUE She has not finished the challenge. You have already accepted.

Requires: Trait: Duelist

The scars on her hands say she has done this often. Yours say something similar, and she reads them at about the same moment you read hers.

It is a good duel. It is stopped, by mutual agreement, one exchange before it would have stopped being one.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Fire +10

GREY Decline and find another way around

She watches you find the path around with the measured disappointment of someone who has been doing this for a long time and has learned not to expect much.

'Fair enough,' she says. The orbiting flames resume their patient circuit. She settles in to wait for the next traveler.

Karma: Human +1

The Demon Marketplace hell_demon_marketplace

A chaotic bazaar has assembled in the middle of the lava fields — dozens of stalls selling weapons, memories, bottled emotions, demon-forged equipment, and items you cannot categorize. The merchants are a mix of demons, damned souls, and creatures that do not appear to belong to any known category.

A sign over the entrance reads: NO FIGHTING. NO UNAUTHORIZED FIRE (the sign is on fire). NO RETURNS.

The noise is extraordinary.

GREY Browse the marketplace stalls

Opens: Ember Merchant

You move through the stalls, shoulder to shoulder with demons and the damned alike. It is, despite everything, a marketplace — and there is something almost comforting about the familiar rhythms of commerce.

Effects: XP 2 · Karma: Human +2, Hungry Ghost +1

BLUE Seek out the best deals with expert knowledge

Requires: Trade 2+

You spend an hour working the stalls with professional efficiency — checking quality, testing weights, haggling at the right moments. You find a stall in the back that others seem to avoid, its proprietor a very old demon sitting behind a display of items none of the other merchants will look at directly.

'Good eye,' the demon says. 'The things nobody wants are often the things someone needs.' The prices are fair. The goods are unusual.

Effects: XP 8; items: Fire Crystal · Karma: Human +3

BLUE Find the restricted goods in the back alleys

Requires: Guile 2+

You find the alley behind the main stalls where the less official commerce happens. A hooded demon with careful eyes offers things the main market won't stock — items with complicated histories, scrolls from restricted collections, objects whose provenance cannot be confirmed.

You leave with a scroll and a sense of mild unease.

Effects: XP 6; items: Scroll Firebolt · Karma: Hungry Ghost +4, Hell +2

BLUE Survey the market systematically — map what's actually here

Requires: Logistics 2+

You work through the stalls in a pattern — quadrant by quadrant, comparing prices, noting quality, identifying which merchants specialize and which are generalists. By the end you have a clear picture of what this market contains and what it's worth.

The most valuable stall turns out to be one you'd have walked past entirely: a narrow booth near the east exit, staffed by a demon with seven arms who handles bulk orders for things you didn't know you needed in quantity.

Effects: XP 8; items: Item Random · Karma: Human +3

GREY Watch the crowds instead of buying

You find a good position and spend an hour simply watching.

Three deals go wrong in interesting ways. Two go surprisingly right — a demon and a damned soul find they both want what the other has, and part looking pleased. A woman in grey robes stands before a stall selling memory-jars, reading the labels, and cries quietly in front of one that says: 'Tuesday, Age 7.'

She doesn't buy it. Neither would you.

Effects: XP 4 · Karma: Human +3

BLUE Every stall here is run by somebody bored.

Requires: Trait: Flirt

They are, and boredom is the only currency you have never been short of.

You do not buy anything at a discount. You are simply given three things over the course of an afternoon, by three different people, each of whom believes they started it.

Effects: items: Item Random; gold small; XP 20

BLUE You walk the whole market and want none of it.

Requires: Trait: Content

This is a strange sensation in a place engineered to produce the opposite, and one of the vendors follows you for a while trying to work out what is wrong with you.

You leave with your purse intact and an unusual amount of goodwill from the one stallholder who understood.

Effects: XP 15; mind: Earth +10, Fire +8

BLUE The crowd noise here is total.

Requires: Trait: Hard of Hearing

You catch about one word in four, and the one in four does not include the part where the vendor names the real price, or the part where somebody behind you says your description out loud.

You find out about the second one later.

Effects: gold -20; mind: Air -8; XP 22

YELLOW Strike up conversation with vendors — gather market intelligence through friendly haggling

Roll: Charm, easy difficulty

If it succeeds:

Vendors talk more than they mean to when someone seems genuinely interested. By the time you've moved through half the market, you know which stalls are fronts, which goods are mislabeled, and where the real bargains are buried.

Effects: XP 8 · Karma: Human +2

If it fails:

One vendor takes your interest as an insult to their pride and raises their prices to spite you. The word spreads faster than you'd like. You pay more for the same goods and leave resolving to be less obvious next time.

Effects: XP 3 · Karma: Hell +1

The Burning Library hell_burning_library

A library is on fire.

Not metaphorically — the entire building is actively burning, shelves collapsing, books falling in cascades of sparks. But at the center, visible through the inferno, an enormous bookshelf stands intact, its contents still whole.

The fire has been burning long enough that the outer walls have almost collapsed. It will reach the center shelf soon.

YELLOW Dash through the flames to save what you can

Roll: Constitution, easy difficulty

If it succeeds:

You cover your head and run. The heat is enormous. You reach the center shelf, grab armfuls without looking, and sprint back as a beam comes down behind you.

Singed, coughing, but standing. In your arms: books that are ancient and intact and unlike anything you have seen before. You have no idea what language they are in. That feels like a problem for later.

Effects: XP 10; items: Scroll Firebolt, Scroll Lesser Heal · Karma: Human +4

If it fails:

The heat drives you back before you reach the center. You grab one book from shelves near the entrance — old, smoke-damaged, but intact — before the entrance collapses.

You stand outside, coughing, clutching a book you saved. The center shelf burns.

Effects: XP 5; items: Scroll Lesser Heal · Karma: Human +2, Animal +2

BLUE Command the flames to clear a path

Requires: Fire Magic 2+

You reach into the fire and speak to it. It takes a moment — the fire here is old and set in its ways — but it responds. A corridor of cooler air opens before you, the flames pulling back on either side.

You walk to the center shelf calmly and take your time selecting. The books feel important in a way you cannot explain. You exit as the building finally collapses behind you in a controlled exhale.

Effects: XP 14; items: Scroll Firebolt, Mana Potion · Karma: Human +5, Asura +3

GREY Shout to see if anyone is still inside

You cup your hands and call into the flames.

Silence. Then: a cough. Then a small demon emerges from behind a burning pillar, clutching a ledger to its chest with both arms, absolutely refusing to put it down despite the circumstances.

You pull it out by the collar. It stands outside looking humiliated — not by the rescue, but by the fact that it needed one.

'The accounts,' it says, still holding the ledger. 'I couldn't leave the accounts.' It presses a key into your hands. 'For an archive in the eastern quarter. Everything there is in order too. In case anyone asks.' It walks away with dignity it has not entirely earned.

Effects: XP 8; items: Demon Key · Karma: Hell -5, Human +8, God +3

BLUE Build a fireproof carry-container from materials at hand

Requires: Smithing 3+

You find fire-hardened bricks from the outer wall, a metal frame, hinges from a collapsed cabinet. The construction takes twenty minutes you don't quite have. But it works — a crude sealed box, clay-and-ash compound holding against the heat. You carry it in, load the best of the center shelf's contents methodically, and exit as the roof comes down behind you. The box is intact. The books inside are dusty but unburned.

Effects: XP 12; items: Scroll Firebolt, Scroll Lesser Heal · Karma: Human +5

BLUE It is a burning building. Leave the burning building.

Requires: Trait: Incurious

You leave the burning building. This turns out to have been the correct structural assessment by a margin of about ninety seconds.

Someone else will mourn the books.

Effects: mind: Space -8; XP 22

GREY Stand and witness the burning

You stand in the heat and watch the library burn.

At a certain point, the center shelf goes. The books go last — their pages lifting in the updraft, briefly bright, then dark. Something is lost. And yet, watching it, you also feel something like release — as though the books were finished being books and have become something else instead.

You are not sure this is a useful thought. But it is the thought you have.

Effects: XP 3 · Karma: Human +2

The Sinner Gang hell_sinner_gang

A group of damned souls has made camp around a fire — not for warmth, none of them need warmth, but for the feeling of it. A former soldier, a tax collector, an artist, a merchant. They've made rules, share what they find, keep watch in shifts. It is, against all odds, working.

One of them looks up as you approach.

'You're alive. Actual living. We don't get many of those.' A pause. 'Sit down. We're not going to hurt you.'

GREY Share a meal and hear their stories

You sit with them and the stories come out — what they did, what they understand now about what they did, what they are still working out.

The soldier burned a village on orders. The tax collector took more than was owed, always. The artist spent a life accepting credit for other people's work. The merchant let a business partner take the fall for a shared crime.

None of them are done yet. But they are thinking clearly about it, which is more than many here manage. You leave feeling, strangely, less alone.

Effects: XP 8 · Karma: Human +5, Hell -3

GREY Trade supplies with them

They have things scavenged from wandering souls — small items, coins, a potion someone dropped. You have things from the living world. You trade fairly, taking what you need, giving what you can spare.

The merchant among them negotiates with professional precision, which makes everyone laugh, including the merchant. 'Habits,' they say. 'Even here.'

Effects: XP 4; items: Health Potion · Karma: Human +3

BLUE Inspire them to give their suffering more purpose

Requires: Persuasion 2+

You talk to them for a long time — about suffering as instruction, about the difference between enduring and understanding, about what it would mean to actively help other souls in the hell realm rather than simply outlasting it.

The words land differently here than they would in the living world. One of them begins to cry. Another says quietly, 'We could actually do something with our time here.'

When you leave, they are still talking. Their camp looks like the beginning of something.

Effects: XP 12 · Karma: Human +6, God +4, Hell -5

BLUE Help them organize more effectively

Requires: Leadership 3+

You spend an hour with them, helping them think through what they're actually trying to do and who is best suited to what. The soldier takes watch. The artist keeps morale. The merchant manages what they find. The tax collector, reluctantly, handles records — 'At least I'm using it for something real this time.'

The structure clicks into place. They look more purposeful than any group has a right to in this realm.

Effects: XP 12 · Karma: Human +5, Hell -4, God +2

BLUE Set up a sustainable rotation so the suffering doesn't compound

Requires: Logistics 3+

You map out their resources: what they have, what they need, what they can acquire, where the choke points are. The pattern of their suffering isn't random — there's a rhythm to it, and rhythms can be managed.

You draw up a rotation that gives each of them genuine rest between the harder stretches. The tax collector calls it 'the first fair system I've ever been part of,' and laughs at themselves for saying it.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: Human +4, Hell -3

GREY Watch from a distance without disturbing them

You stop on the ridge above their camp and watch for a while. The fire. The four figures around it. The quiet conversation.

One of them looks up and sees you. They raise a hand. You raise yours. They return to their conversation.

That is enough, somehow. For both of you.

Effects: XP 2 · Karma: Human +2

BLUE There is a game running at the edge of that fire.

Requires: Trait: Gambler

There is. It is crooked in a way you identify within four throws and decline to mention, since it is crooked in a direction you can work with.

You leave before it becomes impolite to keep winning.

Effects: gold small; XP 15; gains trait: Gambler

BLUE Sit down. These are, regrettably, your people.

Requires: Trait: Drunk

They make room without being asked, which is the thing about the damned — they can spot it.

You are welcome here in a way that is not entirely comfortable to be welcome, and you leave with a name to drop and a headache.

Effects: XP 30; mind: Fire -10, Water +5

BLUE They have a fire and a bottle and no particular plans.

Requires: Trait: Night Drinker

So do you, now. The talk is good and the bottle is worse than the talk, and at some point in the small hours it stops being an evening and starts being a habit that has followed you into another realm.

You will feel this one for a while.

Effects: gains trait: Addiction; mind: Fire -15, Earth -8; XP 30

YELLOW Join them at the fire and tell a story — one that might make the suffering mean something

Roll: Charm, easy difficulty

If it succeeds:

They listen. Really listen — something rare here. By the end, someone is laughing in a way that sounds almost clean. Several of them clap you on the back as you leave.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: Human +4, God +2

If it fails:

'That's a nice story,' says one of them, not unkindly. 'We've heard nicer. But sit down — you look like you've been walking for years.' You're welcome at the fire anyway.

Effects: XP 4 · Karma: Human +2

The Forge Spirit hell_forge_spirit

An abandoned forge still glows with ancient heat — the fire here has not gone out in centuries. A translucent figure works the bellows with practiced rhythm, hammer rising and falling on metal that is not there. She died here, or near here, long enough ago that the distinction no longer matters.

She stops as you approach. Looks at you with the focused attention of someone who has not had company in a very long time.

'Oh. A visitor. Forgive me — I lose track of... everything. What day is it?'

GREY Tell her what you know of the current state of the realm

You tell her what you know — the demon patrols, the lava flows, the frozen north, Yama's lieutenant at the gate. Each piece of information she processes slowly, turning it over.

'Still going, then. The realm.' She resumes the rhythm of the bellows. 'I wasn't sure.'

Then she stops again. 'Thank you. No one has told me anything in... I genuinely don't know how long. You forget there is news to be had.' She works the bellows harder, as though the information has given her energy.

Effects: XP 5 · Karma: Human +4, God +2

BLUE Help her find the peace she is missing

Requires: White Magic 2+

You spend a long time speaking with her — about what she made, who she made it for, what she was working toward when she died. The hammer and bellows slow and finally stop.

'I kept thinking there was one more thing to finish,' she says. 'But it was already finished. I just didn't see it.'

She looks up and goes very still. 'Oh,' she says. 'There it is. I've been looking right at it.' And then she is simply gone — not destroyed, but complete. On the forge floor, her tools have become solid. Real. Apparently hers to leave behind.

Effects: XP 14; items: Fire Crystal · Karma: God +8, Hell -8, Human +5

BLUE Ask to learn her craft techniques

Requires: Smithing 2+

She teaches. Ancient methods — based on relationship with material rather than mastery over it. She shows you how to hear what a metal wants to become before you force it into a shape.

Your hands seem to remember what your mind cannot quite hold. You leave with something that feels less like knowledge and more like patience.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: Human +4, Asura +3

BLUE Examine the binding that keeps her here

Requires: Enchantment 3+

You examine the bindings with careful attention and find that the enchantment keeping her tied to the forge is fraying — not by neglect, but by completion. The forge was her life's work. The binding was always meant to loosen when the work was done.

You don't repair it. You make it more transparent to her instead. She stares at her hands for a long moment.

'Oh,' she says. 'I see.' The hammer stays. She does not.

Effects: XP 14; items: Fire Crystal · Karma: God +7, Hell -6, Human +4

BLUE Work beside her at the forge

Requires: Smithing 2+

You pick up a hammer and begin. Your technique is rougher than hers — she corrects your grip twice without words, just a precise adjustment of your hand. You work side by side for an hour in the rhythm of the forge.

When you leave, she is still at the bellows, but something in her rhythm has changed. A little faster. A little more alive.

Effects: XP 8; items: Good Iron Weapon · Karma: Human +4, Asura +2

GREY Leave the spirit to her work

You bow at the entrance to the forge. She does not look up, but the rhythm of the hammer changes briefly — a different beat, just for a moment — before returning to its ancient pattern.

A greeting, in the only language available.

Effects: XP 2 · Karma: Human +1

The Invitation hell_the_invitation

An ornate envelope rests on a flat rock in the middle of a lava field, as though placed there deliberately. It is sealed with black wax. Your name is written on the outside — not the name you are using in this life, but a name you know with absolute certainty is yours.

The handwriting is beautiful.

Inside: a map, a time, an address, and the words: 'It would please us greatly if you would attend. We have matters of mutual interest to discuss. Come alone.'

GREY Follow the map

The address leads to a formal dining room carved from black obsidian, lit by candles burning with a clean blue flame. A demon of apparent authority waits at the head of a long table — well-dressed, patient, carrying the specific stillness of someone who has planned this meeting carefully.

'We have been observing your journey,' it says. 'With interest. There is a matter we would like to discuss — something that would benefit both of us, if we can reach an agreement.'

The conversation that follows is careful and illuminating. You learn things about the hell realm you did not know. You also decline the offer, politely, when it finally arrives.

'The offer stands,' the demon says as you leave. 'When you change your mind, you'll know how to reach us.' It does not say if.

You notice, on the way out, that there is only one setting at the table. They knew you'd come alone.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: Asura +3, Hungry Ghost +2, Human +2

BLUE Follow the map but arrive early and observe first

Requires: Guile 2+

You find the address an hour before the appointed time and settle in a position with a clear view of the entrance.

Someone else has already arrived — a damned soul, young, with the hollow eyes of someone who has been suffering long enough to consider anything an improvement. They go inside. Through the wall (obsidian is surprisingly thin) you can hear the shape of the conversation without the words.

A deal is being made. The soul wants something specific. The demon is offering it.

You could intervene. You could also let them make their own choice — the soul is old enough to know what they're doing, even here.

You wait until the soul emerges — lighter, in some way you cannot verify — then slip away before your own appointment time.

Effects: XP 8 · Karma: Human +3

BLUE Examine the invitation for hidden enchantments

Requires: Black Magic 2+

You read the letter carefully with trained attention to what is not there.

Three layers of enchantment. The first: a location beacon — someone has already noted that the invitation was opened. The second: a subtle compulsion toward compliance, minor enough to be deniable. The third: something you cannot fully name but that feels, precisely and strangely, like recognition — as though whoever wrote this has seen you before, in a context you cannot access.

You burn the invitation. For a moment you feel watched from a very specific direction. Then nothing.

The name they used for you, you will be thinking about for a while.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: Human +3, Hungry Ghost +2

GREY Set it back on the rock and walk on

You set the envelope back on the rock and continue on your way.

Behind you, the envelope waits. A faint sense of disappointment from a specific direction — calm, professional, patient.

The kind of disappointment that is already adjusting its timeline.

Someday, you think, you will want to know what was in that letter.

Effects: XP 3 · Karma: Human +2

YELLOW Look for signs of who placed this — tracks, timing, intent written in the ash

Roll: Awareness, easy difficulty

If it succeeds:

The ash around the rock is undisturbed except for one set of prints — small, deliberate, placed and then retreated. No ambush position. No disturbance in the lava flow. Whoever left this came alone and didn't wait to watch. The invitation might be genuine.

Effects: XP 8 · Karma: Human +2

If it fails:

A new lava flow has already covered whatever marks were here. The ash tells you nothing. You're left exactly as uncertain as before.

Effects: XP 3

A Sigh of Relief hell_sigh_of_relief

You feel strangely drawn towards a clearing, where among the bleakness a figure stands shining softly. A bodhisattva from the higher realms has come to the Hells to give offerings and teach the suffering shades.

As you come closer you see piles of food, drink, and medicine manifesting from thin air, imps swarming around and swallowing mouthfuls.

BLUE Meditate in the presence of the Bodhisattva

Requires: Yoga 2+

As you settle down and focus, you recognize there is no boundary between you. The teacher smiles and raises their hand to bless you.

A warmth spreads through your body — not the burning heat of this realm, but something gentler. Something remembered.

Effects: XP 12; gains trait: Touched by Grace · Karma: Hell -5, Human +3, God +5

BLUE Listen to the teachings

Requires: Focus 14+

Impermanence, compassion, joy. It seems like you have heard these words before, but long forgotten their meaning.

The bodhisattva speaks without urgency, as though time here is different — and perhaps it is. When the teaching ends, the words continue to resonate somewhere you cannot quite locate.

Effects: XP 10; gains trait: Touched by Grace · Karma: Hell -3, Human +3, God +3

GREY Come and take your fill

For a moment, all your fears and hopes dissolve into the present moment. You are content.

The food tastes like nothing you have eaten in this realm — clean, simple, nourishing. Your wounds close. Your mind clears. Your body remembers what it feels like to be whole.

Effects: XP 8; full restore · Karma: Hell -3, Hungry Ghost +2, Animal +2, Human +2

GREY Rush in and take as much as you can

You shove past the imps and grab armfuls of food and medicine — but as your hands close around them, they dissolve like mist. The clearing shimmers. The bodhisattva regards you with an expression that is not disappointment but something closer to recognition.

The scene vanishes as if it was never there.

Effects: XP 0; gains trait: Covetous · Karma: Hell +5, Hungry Ghost +5

YELLOW Open yourself precisely — ask without words for what your situation most needs

Roll: Awareness, normal difficulty

If it succeeds:

The Bodhisattva's attention focuses on you directly, gently, like sunlight through a small window. Nothing is said — but something specific passes, fitted exactly to the shape of what you carry. You know what it is without being able to say it.

Effects: XP 15; gains trait: Touched by Grace · Karma: Human +5, God +4

If it fails:

The peace reaches you — warmth and light after long cold. But the specific teaching you reached for remains just out of grasp. You receive the general blessing, which is not nothing.

Effects: XP 6 · Karma: Human +3, God +1

A Familiar Face devil_deserter

A red devil sits by the road, stripped of his armor. He looks up at you. 'I'm done with the Guard,' he says simply. 'Done with all of it. I just need somewhere to be.'

GREY Take him with you.

Recruit: Brother Karnak

GREY Not your problem. Walk on.

You leave him by the road. Some distances can't be closed.

BLUE Extract information about the Guard's patrol routes and weak points

Requires: Guile 1+

He's grateful for someone who actually wants to listen. Between complaints, useful details slip out — patrol timings, which commanders take bribes, where the soft spots in the ring are. You leave better informed.

Effects: XP 8 · Karma: Human +2, Asura +1

YELLOW Study him carefully — look past the performance to what's underneath

Roll: Awareness, easy difficulty

If it succeeds:

He's genuine. Exhausted, frightened, and done. The despair in him isn't put on — no devil performs suffering this quietly. You feel something shift in your understanding of this place.

Effects: XP 6 · Karma: Human +3, Hell +1

If it fails:

Hellfire makes everyone's eyes the same — flat and red and unreadable. You can't tell. He might be desperate. He might be a trap. You move on uncertain.

Karma: Hell +1

BLUE You know what showing mercy in hell costs. Acknowledge it.

Requires: Yoga 3+

Recruit: Brother Karnak

He looks at you carefully. The recognition is mutual — you have both thought about the same thing. 'You understand it,' he says. It isn't a question. He stands and picks up his pack.

No cost. Karma: Human +3, God +2

BLUE Offer him something worth serving — not just somewhere to be.

Requires: Leadership 4+

Recruit: Brother Karnak

He listens to what you are doing and why. Something shifts behind his eyes for the first time in a while. 'That I could follow,' he says.

No cost. Karma: Human +2

BLUE You know exactly what he is doing, because you did it.

Requires: Trait: Oath-breaker

You do not tell him it gets easier. You tell him the specific practical things: which roads have checkpoints, what they ask, and how long before anyone stops looking.

He listens like a man taking down an address.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Earth +8

BLUE A vow is a vow. Say so, plainly, and then help anyway.

Requires: Trait: Oath-keeper

You tell him what you think of it. He takes it without arguing, which is worse than arguing.

Then you give him the water anyway, because the two positions turn out not to be in conflict, whatever you had assumed.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Earth +10, Water +5

BLUE He has not finished. Let him finish.

Requires: Trait: Patient

It takes him a long time to get to the actual sentence, and the actual sentence is not the one he opened with.

What he is done with is not the Guard. Once that is out, the rest of the conversation is a different conversation entirely.

Effects: XP 8

YELLOW Be someone worth following — just ask him.

Roll: Charm, easy difficulty

If it succeeds: Recruit: Brother Karnak

He looks at you for a long moment, then stands and rolls his shoulders. 'Alright. Can't be worse than this.'

No cost. Karma: Human +2

If it fails:

He shakes his head. 'No offense. I just need a sign it is worth it this time. Come back if things get interesting.'

Teahouse hell_teahouse_cold

A low building crouches at the edge of the frozen waste, smoke leaking from the roof. Inside, a few silent figures nurse cups of something warm. The barkeeper glances up without expression.

GREY Sit down

Opens: Teahouse

You take a seat. Nobody bothers you.

BLUE Watch how they are making it. Ask for the pot, not the cup.

Requires: Trait: Tea Ritualist

The proprietor looks at you for a moment longer than is comfortable, and then hands over the pot without a word, which in this establishment is an honour roughly equivalent to a title.

You make it properly. Several of the silent figures relocate closer to the fire while you do.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Water +10, Fire +5

BLUE Say nothing for an hour and listen to everyone else.

Requires: Trait: Gossip

An hour buys you: two names worth avoiding, one road that is not as closed as the guard post claims, and the current price of a favour in this district.

Nobody notices you listening. Nobody ever does.

Effects: XP 20; gold small

GREY Move on

You keep walking. The smell of smoke follows you longer than it should.

Teahouse hell_teahouse_fire

A squat building half-buried in ash. The sign is burned off but the smell of tea — strong, smoky, almost pleasant — cuts through the sulphur. The door is open.

GREY Step inside

Opens: Teahouse

The heat inside is almost comfortable compared to outside.

BLUE There is more than tea behind that counter, and you know it.

Requires: Trait: Drunk

There is. It is bad, and there is a lot of it, and the proprietor pours without being asked twice.

The evening goes somewhere. In the morning the party is short some coin and you are short some hours you would like back.

Effects: gold -20; mind: Fire -12, Earth -8; gains trait: Night Drinker; XP 30

BLUE You know what is behind the counter and you know how many nights this makes.

Requires: Trait: Night Drinker

You do know how many nights this makes. That is new — the counting is new — and you order anyway, which is the part that settles the question.

Nobody in the party says anything. Two of them exchange a look.

Effects: gains trait: Drunk; gold -25; mind: Fire -12; XP 30

GREY Move on

You leave the warmth behind.

Mercenary Guild hell_mercenary_guild

A fortified outpost flying a plain black banner. A board outside lists rates for services rendered. Inside, armoured figures sharpen weapons or sleep. They look up when you enter.

GREY Browse their wares

Opens: Mercenary Guild

The quartermaster unlocks a case and waits.

GREY Move on

You leave the mercenaries to their sharpening.

Veterans' Camp hell_veterans_camp

A sparse camp around a fire. The people here are old — old for hell, which means they have survived something most haven't. One of them watches you approach with calculating eyes.

GREY Ask about training

Opens: Veterans' Camp

"We can teach two things. Once each. Make your choices."

BLUE Sit down without being invited. They will not mind.

Requires: Trait: War-hardened

They do not mind. Nobody asks where you served, because the question is not interesting to anyone here — what is interesting is whether you know how to sit at a fire without talking.

You do. By morning you have been told three things about the road ahead that are not on any map.

Effects: XP 15; mind: Water +8

BLUE One of them looks at you and knows.

Requires: Trait: Sole Survivor

She does not say anything about it. She moves along the log to make room, and later, when the fire is low, she says: 'It doesn't get quieter. You just get better at the noise.'

It is not comfort. It is better than comfort, which is accuracy.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Water +15, Space +8

GREY Move on

The veteran returns to staring into the fire.

Sacred Grove hell_sacred_grove

The dappled light streaming through the dense canopy seems like living gold. The Yakshas and Yakshinis come to commune with their followers in this place, marked with colored ropes on the tree trunks and prayer flags hanging from

the branches.

GREY Approach the practitioners

Opens: Sacred Grove

A Yakshini turns and regards you without surprise. Earth magic has a price — she names it.

GREY Leave them to it

You walk on. The light filters through the canopy long after the grove is out of sight.

Temple of the Naga hell_temple_of_the_naga

In every world some beings are born innately attuned to the mindstreams of the Naga. Temples arise where they practice, communing with their reptilian friends and patrons through offerings of saffron milk, fruits and flowers.

GREY Ask about their teachings

Opens: Temple of the Naga

A practitioner rises smoothly and names the spells they can teach. The price is gold, as always.

GREY Move on

You don't disturb the offerings. The scent of flowers follows you.

Garuda Roost hell_garuda_roost

A tall pole with a horned symbol at the top rises from the ground, sacred stones and offerings heaped at its base, colorful ribbons fluttering in the wind. The worshippers say the Garudas come to perch at the top during their long travels.

GREY Speak to the worshippers

Opens: Garuda Roost

One of the worshippers looks up. They teach Air magic here — what you pay is your own business.

GREY Leave an offering and go

You set something at the base of the pole and move on. The ribbons flutter.

BLUE Draw on your knowledge — you've seen this symbol before, or something like it

Requires: Learning 1+

You recognize the horned emblem as a Garuda boundary marker — a sign this place is protected from the worst hell denizens. The worshippers confirm it quietly, impressed you knew. They share a fragment of lore about the great birds who sometimes pass through even here.

Effects: XP 8 · Karma: Asura +2, Human +2

BLUE Greet them the way you greet anything with feathers.

Requires: Trait: Pet-lover

This is, by every account, a serious error of protocol. The garuda are not birds and take a dim view of being addressed as such.

The young one, however, comes down off the pole to see what you are doing, and stays.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Water +8 · Karma: Animal +3

YELLOW Open your senses to whatever power remains in this place

Roll: Awareness, easy difficulty

If it succeeds:

Something vast has perched here recently. You feel the echo of huge wings, a smell of lightning and high altitude. For a moment you see the hell realm from above — tiny, contained, impermanent. Then it is gone.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: Asura +3, God +1

If it fails:

The offerings are old. Whatever came here has moved on. You sense nothing but ash and the cold prayers of the worshippers.

Hidden Gompa hell_hidden_gompa

Practitioners come to this place seeking solitude and peace. The ground itself vibrates with the power of their meditation, mantric syllables appearing spontaneously in the rock.

GREY Knock and ask to enter

Opens: Hidden Gompa

After a long pause, the door opens. A monk gestures you inside. Space magic. What do you need?

GREY Don't disturb them

You walk past without knocking. The syllables in the rock seem to pulse as you go.

BLUE Center yourself and send an inner request — the way the tradition demands

Requires: Yoga 2+

Before you can knock, the door opens. A monk with ancient eyes looks at you for a long moment. 'You know the language. Come in.' The interior is impossibly quiet — the hell realm's noise cut off as if by thick stone. You sit, breathe, and receive something wordless that nevertheless settles into your bones.

Effects: XP 15 · Karma: Human +5, God +3

YELLOW Appeal to the monks — you have come a long way, and you are learning

Roll: Charm, normal difficulty

If it succeeds:

One of the monks regards you with genuine warmth. 'You ask well,' he says. 'That is already something.' He gives you a brief teaching on the nature of suffering as a teacher rather than an enemy. You leave quieter than you arrived.

Effects: XP 12 · Karma: Human +4, God +2

If it fails:

The monk at the door considers you kindly. 'The teaching comes when conditions ripen. Sit outside if you like — the quiet here reaches further than the walls.' You sit for a while. It does.

Effects: XP 4 · Karma: Human +2

Mirror Lake hell_mirror_lake

Mirages flicker over the mercurial surface of the lake. Followers of the Goddess of Illusion gather around, meditating on the fleeting nature of phenomena and exchanging stories of their dreams.

GREY Sit and listen

Opens: Mirror Lake

A practitioner meets your eyes in the reflection before turning around. They can teach Enchantment. The lake makes everything a fair price.

GREY Walk away from the mirage

You step back. The images on the water follow you for a moment, then dissolve.

BLUE Clear your mind completely and look without craving — see what is actually there

Requires: Yoga 1+

The lake's mirages still flicker, but you see through them — not with effort but with stillness. Beneath the illusions the surface is perfectly clear, reflecting something real: a glimpse of a path you had not considered. The Goddess's followers notice your clarity and nod.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: Human +3, God +2

YELLOW Stare into the surface and attempt to see through to what is real

Roll: Awareness, normal difficulty

If it succeeds:

The mirages dissolve. For a moment the lake shows something true — a vision specific to you, something you needed to see. You don't fully understand it yet. But it stays with you.

Effects: XP 12 · Karma: Human +3, God +2

If it fails:

The mirages pull you in rather than yielding. For a disorienting moment you are standing somewhere else entirely — a childhood memory, or perhaps someone else's. You surface confused, the lake placid and unhelpful.

Effects: XP 3 · Karma: Hungry Ghost +1

Crossroads Stupa hell_crossroads_stupa

The wind carries the smell of sacred juniper smoke and sacrificial wine far from this place. As you come closer, you see little heaps of torma and butter lamps, some still burning.

GREY Approach the stupa

Opens: Crossroads Stupa

A practitioner emerges from behind the stupa. Summoning magic — the crossroads is the right place for it. Gold is the price.

GREY Observe from a distance

You watch the butter lamps flicker in the wind. Some things are better left undisturbed.

Circle of the Yoginis hell_yogini_circle

The inward-facing side of this circular stone wall is carved with the bizarre forms of sixty four Yoginis. There is no ceiling, so the witches can land when they come flying from vast space to meet their earthly sisters.

GREY Enter the circle

Opens: Circle of the Yoginis

One of the earthly sisters turns and gestures. No words needed.

GREY Move on

You back away slowly. The air around the circle hums for a long time.

BLUE Perform the correct entry rites — approach the circle as it demands

Requires: Ritual 2+

You move clockwise, make the right offerings at the right points, and step through the gap with the correct orientation. The carved faces seem to relax. The circle activates around you in spiraling light. One Yogini's form peels slightly from the stone and places something cold in your hand — a small charm of compressed power.

Effects: XP 15; items: Space Charm Common · Karma: God +4, Human +3

YELLOW Sit at the center and meditate — open yourself to whatever the circle holds

Roll: Awareness, normal difficulty

If it succeeds:

The sixty-four faces hold your attention without pulling it apart. Something passes through you — not comfortable, but clarifying. The energies here are immense and indifferent, but they don't consume you. You emerge with a clean, bright quality to your awareness.

Effects: XP 12 · Karma: God +3, Human +2

If it fails:

The combined power of sixty-four Yoginis is too much to hold. You lose your center within minutes and have to stumble out, disoriented, the carved faces still spinning. You sit outside until the world steadies.

Effects: XP 4 · Karma: Hell +1

Medicinal Garden hell_medicinal_garden

The air is vibrant with the aroma of medicinal herbs and flowers. The healers cultivating them are happy to share some of their knowledge for the benefit of all suffering beings.

GREY Ask to learn

Opens: Medicinal Garden

A healer looks up from her work and nods. She names her price without ceremony.

GREY Leave them to their work

You leave without disturbing them. The scent of herbs follows you.

BLUE Offer your hands — help with a difficult case in exchange for a share of the harvest

Requires: Medicine 1+

The healers hand you a patient immediately and watch without comment. You work. When you finish, one of them presses a cloth bundle into your hands — a selection of herbs, properly dried and labelled, worth more than anything in the nearest market.

Effects: XP 10; items: Herb Bundle, Healing Herb · Karma: Human +4, God +2

BLUE Ask about the preparations they do not advertise.

Requires: Trait: Bhang Enjoyer

The healer's expression does not change, but she takes you to the far end of the garden and shows you a bed you had walked straight past.

'For pain,' she says, in the tone of someone who has heard every other reason and is offering you the dignity of not giving one.'

Effects: XP 20; supplies: Herbs 4

BLUE Offer what you carry — they will want the parts you do not use.

Requires: Trait: Hunter

Sinew, bone, the small glands that are worth more than the meat. She goes through it with the brisk competence of someone who has done this trade for a century.

You come away with herbs and a standing invitation.

Effects: supplies: Herbs 6; XP 20

YELLOW Carefully harvest some of the rarer specimens growing at the garden's edge

Roll: Finesse, easy difficulty

If it succeeds:

Your hands are steady enough. The roots come free cleanly, the stalks cut at the right angle. You have a handful of something potent that shouldn't grow anywhere near a hell realm.

Effects: XP 8; items: Healing Herb, Herb Bundle · Karma: Human +2

If it fails:

Your grip slips and you damage the root system of something rare. The healers watch without anger but without warmth. 'Those take twelve years to grow here,' one says quietly. You apologize and leave.

Effects: XP 2 · Karma: Human -1

Temple of the Eternal Fire hell_eternal_fire

Priests clad in white robes have been guarding the sacred fire since time immemorial. Many come to pay their respects and seek visions in the dancing flames.

GREY Approach the priests

Opens: Temple of the Eternal Fire

A priest turns from the flame and regards you. He names the spells, and then the prices.

GREY Pay your respects and leave

You bow before the flame and step back out. The fire reflected in your eyes for some time after.

Black Lodge hell_black_lodge

The entrance is half-buried in the earth, marked only with a crooked khatvanga topped with a skull and streaming black ribbons reeking of smoke and poison. As you enter, the darkness overwhelms you - until you notice the glint of a sneering smile.

GREY Ask to learn

Opens: Black Lodge

The smile does not move. A hand gestures to a list scratched into the wall. Spells. Prices. No preamble.

BLUE You already know how to hold something. Say so.

Requires: Trait: Secret-bearer

The doorkeeper asks one question. Your answer is not the right one, but the way you decline to elaborate apparently is.

You are shown further in than most, and what is discussed there stays where it was discussed.

Effects: XP 20; gains trait: Secret-bearer

GREY Back out

You step back into the light. The khatvanga watches you leave.

Town hell_town_weapons

A settlement built from salvaged iron and spite. The biggest building is the armoury. Someone is always selling something in the street, and half of it is sharp.

GREY Enter the town

Opens: Town

You push through the crowd.

GREY Move on

You skirt the settlement and keep moving.

Town hell_town_magic

A settlement where more windows glow than can be explained by candlelight. Strange smells drift from the apothecary. A scholar argues with a demon outside the library.

GREY Enter the town

Opens: Town

You find the market square.

GREY Move on

You leave the scholars to their arguments.

Town hell_town_supplies

A trading post that survives on practicality. The sign reads: FOOD. TOOLS. NO CREDIT. It is the most honest thing you have seen in hell.

GREY Enter the town

Opens: Town

The shopkeeper nods without looking up.

GREY Move on

You keep walking.

Infernal Forge hell_infernal_forge

The heat hits you a hundred paces out. A demon the color of cooled lava stands at an enormous anvil, hammering something that glows white. The sign over the door reads: WEAPONS. ARMOR. NO CREDIT. NO REFUNDS. NO EXCEPTIONS.

The demon doesn't look up.

GREY Browse the forge's stock

Opens: Infernal Forge

The demon nods once. You are allowed to look.

BLUE Ask to be trained in axe techniques

Requires: Axes 1+

Opens: Infernal Forge

The demon sets down the hammer. "You know which end to hold. Good. Cost you extra for the rest."

YELLOW Pocket a blade while the smith has their back turned

Roll: Finesse, normal difficulty

If it succeeds:

A demon at an anvil is completely absorbed in their work. You lift a finished blade from the cooling rack, tuck it under your arm, and walk out at a deliberate pace. The hammering does not stop.

Effects: items: Iron Axe · Karma: Hungry Ghost +5

If it fails: Combat: Demon Sentinel (hard)

The hammering stops. The demon turns around, still holding the hammer. They do not speak. They do not need to.

Karma: Hungry Ghost +3

YELLOW Attempt a joke about blacksmiths and hot work

Roll: Comedy, easy difficulty

If it succeeds:

"So I said to the blacksmith, 'is it hot in here or is it just your hammer?'" The demon sets down their work. Looks at you. Then emits a sound like metal shearing — which, you eventually realize, is laughter. They hand you a fistful of scrap. 'You. I don't hate you.' Highest praise, probably.

Effects: items: Scrap Metal · Karma: Human +2

If it fails:

The demon stares at you for a very long time. Then they pick up the hammer again. "Leave," they say. The word is shaped like a threat.

BLUE There is something in the scrap pile that does not belong there.

Requires: Trait: Collector

There is. It has been in the pile long enough to be the colour of the pile, which is presumably why nobody has taken it.

The smith watches you fish it out and says nothing at all, which you decide to interpret generously.

Effects: items: Item Random; XP 20

GREY Leave

The hammering resumes behind you.

Bone Archer Camp hell_bone_archer_camp

A fortified camp of skeleton warriors — most armed with bows, some with knives. They regard you with hollow eyes. One of them, slightly larger than the rest, has set up a makeshift trading post.

"We trade," it says. "We do not explain ourselves."

GREY Browse the camp's goods

Opens: Bone Archer Camp

The skeleton gestures at the racks of weapons with one bony hand.

BLUE Ask one of the archers to teach you

Requires: Ranged 1+

Opens: Bone Archer Camp

One of the archers tilts its skull at you, considering. Then it nocks an arrow and gestures for you to do the same.

Karma: Hell +1

YELLOW Lift something from the rack while no one is looking

Roll: Finesse, normal difficulty

If it succeeds:

Skeletons don't blink. What they do have is peripheral vision — but yours is better. You slip a bow from the rack while the trader skeleton is occupied. You are forty paces gone before anyone counts the inventory.

Effects: items: Hunting Bow, Throwing Knife · Karma: Hungry Ghost +5

If it fails: Combat: Demon Patrol (hard)

Forty hollow eye sockets turn toward you simultaneously. The trader skeleton says nothing. It simply nocks an arrow. So do the others.

Karma: Hungry Ghost +3

GREY Draw your weapon — bones break

Combat: Demon Patrol (hard)

The skeletons reach for their weapons without urgency. You get the impression they have been waiting for someone to try this.

Karma: Hell +5

BLUE Talk to them about the bows. Only about the bows.

Requires: Trait: Hunter

Skeletons, it emerges, have opinions about draw weight.

An hour of genuinely technical conversation later, one of them presses something into your hand — not a gift exactly, more a professional courtesy between people who both know what a bad string does in cold.

Effects: XP 20; items: Item Random

GREY Leave

The skeleton archers watch you go, silent.

Mercy Ward hell_mercy_ward

A tent, remarkably clean. Inside, a figure in grey robes tends to the wounded — souls who staggered in from the wastes, demons nursing old injuries. Nobody asks questions. Nobody explains.

"I patch what I can," says the medic, without turning around. "I charge what I must. Sit down if you're bleeding."

GREY Buy supplies and spells

Opens: Mercy Ward

The medic points at the supply shelves.

Karma: Human +1

BLUE Ask to rest and recover

Requires: Charm 10+

The medic studies your face, then nods. "An hour. Then I need the cot." You sleep deeply. When you wake, your wounds feel lighter.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: Human +3, God +1

GREY Leave a donation for those who can't pay

Cost: Gold (small)

The medic pauses. Looks at the coins. Looks at you. "I'll make sure it goes to the ones who need it most." They say nothing else. In this place, that is enough.

Effects: XP 5 · Karma: God +5

YELLOW Crack a very quiet joke to lighten the mood

Roll: Comedy, trivial difficulty

If it succeeds:

It is a small joke. Barely a joke, really — more of an observation about the absurdity of hell having a triage system. The medic glances up. The corners of their mouth move — not quite a smile, but not not a smile. "I'll put that in the notes," they say. Their prices are slightly more negotiable afterward.

Effects: XP 3 · Karma: Human +3

If it fails:

The medic looks at you with the eyes of someone who has been stitching wounds for three hundred years in a place that specializes in creating them. They return to work. You feel, correctly, that you have misjudged the room.

BLUE You do not need to explain the pain to this one.

Requires: Trait: Chronic Pain

The grey-robed figure listens to about six words and then stops you.

'Yes,' she says. 'The kind that is always there.' What she gives you does not cure it, because it cannot be cured, and it is the first thing in a long time that has actually helped.

Effects: XP 15; full restore

BLUE Let them work. You have been through worse than a ward.

Requires: Trait: Scarred

She works quickly, because you are not making it difficult, and talks while she does — mostly about other people's wounds, which is her way of not asking about yours.

You leave better mended than you went in.

Effects: full restore; XP 20

GREY Leave

The medic returns to work without watching you go.

Brimstone Lab hell_brimstone_lab

The structure looks like it's held together by habit and sulfur fumes. A figure peers at you through thick goggles, stirring something that smells like it wants to be left alone.

"Seventeen explosions," they announce, before you can speak. "All educational. You need something that burns, you've come to the right address."

GREY Buy alchemical supplies

Opens: Brimstone Lab

The alchemist sweeps a collection of vials to one side to make room for the transaction.

BLUE Ask about alchemy techniques

Requires: Alchemy 1+

Opens: Brimstone Lab

"You know the basics. Good. The advanced work is where it gets interesting — and occasionally fatal."

Karma: Asura +1

YELLOW Pocket a few vials while the alchemist monologues

Roll: Finesse, easy difficulty

If it succeeds:

The alchemist's lecture on the eighteenth explosion provides excellent cover. Three vials heavier, you edge toward the exit. They are still talking.

Effects: items: Fire Bomb, Smoke Bomb, Antidote · Karma: Hungry Ghost +5

If it fails:

Your elbow catches a rack of unstable compounds. The subsequent blast leaves you singed, briefly confused, and completely empty-handed. The alchemist writes something in their notes without looking up. "Eighteen explosions," they say. "Seventeen of which were educational."

Effects: XP 2 · Karma: Hungry Ghost +2

YELLOW Ask how they feel about the eighteenth explosion with full sincerity

Roll: Comedy, trivial difficulty

If it succeeds:

You lean on the counter and deliver the line with complete deadpan: "Seventeen educational explosions is experience. Eighteen is a philosophy." The alchemist freezes. Then cackles. Then nearly knocks over the thing that smells like it wants to be left alone. "Take this," they say, pressing a vial into your hands, "and don't come back. I mean that as a compliment."

Effects: XP 4; items: Health Potion · Karma: Human +3

If it fails:

"That is not funny," the alchemist says. "Explosions are not funny. Explosions are science. I have been seriously injured seventeen times and I will not have it trivialized." They point at the door. You go.

GREY Leave

Something bubbles aggressively as you go.

Warden's Pit hell_wardens_pit

A fortified post around a deep pit, guards drilling in formation on the parade ground. The warden — a scarred devil in heavy armor — watches them from the parapet.

"Outsiders," she says, not looking at you. "You want something. They always do."

GREY Ask to buy gear

Opens: Warden's Pit

She jerks her chin toward the supply depot.

Karma: Hell +1

BLUE Request combat training

Requires: Spears 1+

Opens: Warden's Pit

She looks you over slowly. "You know how to hold a spear. The rest is discipline. Discipline costs coin."

Karma: Hell +2

YELLOW Slip into the supply depot while everyone is drilling

Roll: Finesse, normal difficulty

If it succeeds:

The drilling formations create a predictable rhythm. You match it — moving only when boots hit the ground, stopping when they stop. The supply depot yields a spear and some armor before the rotation changes. You are back outside before anyone notices the count is off.

Effects: items: Wooden Spear, Leather Vest · Karma: Hungry Ghost +5

If it fails: Combat: Demon Patrol (hard)

The warden's voice carries across the entire pit: "I SAW THAT." She has not moved from the parapet. She does not need to. Karma: Hell +4

GREY Challenge the warden's authority — by force

Combat: Demon Patrol (hard)

The warden doesn't raise her voice. She just raises one finger. The drilling stops. The soldiers turn. "Show me what you've got," she says.

Karma: Hell +6

GREY Leave

The drilling continues. You are not relevant to it.

Waystation of Ash hell_waystation

A fortified waystation rises from the volcanic plain, its walls scorched black by centuries of eruptions. Smoke vents line the roof, and a battered sign reads 'ALL TRADES WELCOME — NO SOULS ACCEPTED AS PAYMENT.' Inside, merchants, healers, and weapon-smiths carve out a livelihood amid the suffering.

The Garland hell_angulimala_pursuit

The road ahead is clear except for one figure, standing still. Behind him: several bodies. He watches you approach with the calm attention of someone who has made his peace with violence.

Angulimāla. You know the name even here. He does not move to block you. He just watches — to see what you will do.

GREY Give him a wide berth. Some problems aren't yours to solve.

He watches you go. You feel the weight of his attention until the road curves out of sight.

BLUE Walk toward him — not around him. Calmly.

Requires: Yoga 5+

Recruit: Angulimāla

He watches you walk toward him. The calm does not waver — you are not afraid of him, and it shows in every step. Something shifts behind his eyes. He has met this once before, in a different life, a different road, and it ended the same way it ended him.

"You're not afraid," he says. It is not a compliment. It is recognition.

He turns and falls into step beside you.

No cost. Effects: gains trait: Merciful · Karma: God +3, Human +2

BLUE Acknowledge what you see — not what he's done with it, but the skill itself.

Requires: Martial Arts 4+

Recruit: Angulimāla

He tilts his head slightly. Most people flinch or reach for a weapon. You are looking at the bodies the way a craftsman looks at joinery — reading method, not grieving consequence.

"You know the difference," he says.

You do. So does he. That turns out to be enough.

No cost. Karma: Human +2

YELLOW His stillness isn't threat — read what it actually is, and act on it.

Roll: Awareness, normal difficulty

If it succeeds: Recruit: Angulimāla

You see it — the absolute composure of someone who is tired. Not of violence. Of the point of it.

"You're done," you say. Not a question.

A long silence. Then: "I need somewhere that isn't this."

You offer that. He follows.

No cost. Effects: gains trait: Clear-eyed · Karma: Human +3, God +2

If it fails: Combat: Demon Elite (hard)

Your movement reads wrong — a reach, a hesitation. He has spent a long time watching for exactly that. He moves before you finish the thought.

Karma: Hell +3

Still Water hell_water_lily

At the edge of a frozen river in the cold hell wastes, a blue-skinned woman stands alone. She is looking down at the ice. The water beneath it is visible, dark and still.

She does not move when you approach. She has been here a while.

GREY Leave her to her silence. Not every stillness wants company.

You walk on. The frozen river does not change. Neither does she.

BLUE Place your hand on the ice. Commune through it.

Requires: Water Magic 4+

Recruit: Water Lily

The cold travels up your arm. You let it. Something underneath the surface stirs — not the water, but her attention.

She looks at your hand on the ice, then at you. "You're not afraid of it," she says.

"No."

She steps back from the river's edge for the first time in a long while. "Where are you going?"

No cost. Karma: Human +3, God +2

BLUE Sit beside her. Say nothing. Wait.

Requires: Yoga 5+

Recruit: Water Lily

You sit. You do not speak. The cold hell wind moves across the ice.

After a long time — long enough that most people would have given up — she turns and looks at you properly for the first time.

"You stayed."

"Yes."

She does not ask why. She seems to already understand. When you stand to leave, she stands with you.

No cost. Karma: God +3, Human +2

YELLOW Say something to her — something real, not reassurance.

Roll: Charm, normal difficulty

If it succeeds: Recruit: Water Lily

What you say is simple. Honest. Not an offer to fix anything — just acknowledgment of what she is looking at and why. She is quiet for a moment. Then: "You didn't try to talk me out of it."

"No."

She turns from the river. "I'll come with you."

No cost. Karma: Human +3

If it fails:

She looks at you briefly, then back at the ice. The words weren't wrong, exactly — they just weren't right. She doesn't respond. The river holds her attention more completely than you do.

Old Habit hell_serji_watching

A red devil stands apart from a pit fight, watching. He is the biggest person in the vicinity by a significant margin and the only one not involved. Arms crossed. Expression unreadable.

The fighters below are working hard. He looks like he stopped caring about the outcome some time ago but cannot quite bring himself to walk away.

GREY Walk past. Some people need to find their own door.

He doesn't look at you. The fight continues below. You leave him to his watching.

BLUE Stand beside him and watch. Let him see you understand what you're looking at.

Requires: Unarmed 4+

Recruit: Serji

You stand beside him. You watch the same fight. After a while, he speaks without looking at you.

"He's winning because the other one is afraid of his left hand. Doesn't know that himself yet."

"I see it," you say.

He looks at you sideways. A long pause. "You training anyone?"

"I could use someone who knows what they're looking at."

No cost. Karma: Human +2

BLUE Tell him what you're doing. Make it worth leaving this for.

Requires: Leadership 5+

Recruit: Serji

He listens without interrupting. When you finish, the pit fight has ended below — neither of you noticed.

"The gym stopped meaning anything when I got to the top of it," he says. "What you're describing hasn't got a top."

He uncrosses his arms. "Alright."

No cost. Karma: Human +3, God +1

YELLOW Ask him why he still watches, if he's done with it.

Roll: Charm, normal difficulty

If it succeeds: Recruit: Serji

He's quiet for a long moment. Then: "Habit. No other reason."

"That's the saddest thing I've heard today."

Something in his face shifts — surprise, maybe, that anyone would say that. Then something closer to a laugh.

"Yeah," he says. "Probably is." He turns from the pit. "You going somewhere?"

No cost. Karma: Human +3

If it fails:

He looks at you once, the way you look at a bad technique — briefly, to catalogue what's wrong. Then back to the fight. He doesn't answer.

The Best Seat hell_tejasimha_fire

A building is burning. Not collapsing, not yet — fully, magnificently on fire, the kind that takes your breath away from ten meters off.

A red devil is standing inside it. He is laughing. Not the laughter of someone losing their mind — hearty, genuine, appreciative. He is watching it the way you watch a great performance.

GREY Back away from the lunatic in the burning building.

The laughter follows you down the road. The building eventually collapses. You're not sure what happened to him. Given everything, probably fine.

BLUE Step into the fire. Stand beside him. See what he's seeing.

Requires: Fire Magic 4+

Recruit: Tejasimha

The heat is extraordinary. You let it move around you rather than fighting it. He notices immediately — turns to look at you with something like delight.

"You're not burning," he says.

"Neither are you."

He grins. "I never do. Not on the inside." He gestures at the fire around you. "Beautiful, isn't it?"

You stand together in it for a while before he follows you out.

No cost. Karma: Hell +1, Human +2

BLUE Call something genuinely funny into the burning building.

Requires: Comedy 4+

Recruit: Tejasimha

The laugh that comes back from inside the fire is different from before — surprised, real.

His head appears at a burning window. "Who said that?"

"Me."

He stares at you through the smoke and flame for a moment. Then: "Wait there. I'm coming out."

No cost. Karma: Human +3

YELLOW Hold your ground in the heat until he notices. Don't flinch.

Roll: Focus, normal difficulty

If it succeeds: Recruit: Tejasimha

You plant your feet and stay. The heat is punishing. You don't move.

His laughter slows. He turns. For the first time, he is actually looking at you — the person standing in a firestorm out of stubbornness or something he can't name yet.

"You're interesting," he says. "Come here."

No cost. Karma: Human +2

If it fails:

The heat wins. You step back, eyes watering. The laughter inside the building doesn't pause. He didn't see you — or if he did, what he saw wasn't enough.

The Thirteenth Name hell_sineater_encounter

Something is wrong with the stretch of road ahead. Not visibly — the landmarks are where they should be. But the space between them feels occupied in a way that has nothing to do with sight.

The sensation of being read passes over you like cold water. Something vast and hungry has noticed you are here. It has twelve names already. It is considering a thirteenth.

GREY Back away. Slowly. Entities like this respect nothing, but they respect distance.

The presence recedes as you put ground between you. Whatever it is, it does not follow — not yet. The road normalizes behind you. You take a different route.

BLUE Greet it correctly — by speaking to what it is, not what it looks like.

Requires: Black Magic 5+

Recruit: Sineater Thirteen

You name its nature — not a name but a category, the oldest classification for entities born from shattering. The presence goes very still.

Then, something shifts. The hunger is still there, but turned sideways. Curious.

"You know what I am," it says. The voice comes from nowhere in particular.

"Yes."

"No one has said that before without running afterward."

A form coalesces at the edge of sight — something like a person, the way that lightning is something like light. "I will walk with you for a while," it says. "I want to see what you do with that knowledge."

No cost. Karma: God +2, Human +2

BLUE Offer it something other than a soul to absorb — a perspective from outside the hunger.

Requires: Space Magic 4+

Recruit: Sineater Thirteen

You open yourself to the emptiness rather than filling it — show it the space between things, where hunger has no object. For a moment the presence is genuinely disoriented.

Then fascinated.

"That is not a thing I have encountered," it says slowly. "Twelve names and none of them knew that."

The form that solidifies is almost gentle. "Show me more of that."

No cost. Karma: God +3

YELLOW Let it read you — and don't come apart while it does.

Roll: Focus, difficult difficulty

If it succeeds: Recruit: Sineater Thirteen

The scrutiny is total. Every surface of yourself is turned over and examined. Most people fragment under that kind of attention — become something easier to absorb.

You don't.

A long pause. "You stayed yourself," it says, almost puzzled.

"Yes."

"Interesting. I should like to understand how." The form that takes shape beside you is curious rather than hungry — for now. "Lead on."

No cost. Karma: God +3, Human +2

If it fails:

The scrutiny is too complete. For a moment you are not entirely sure which thoughts are yours. You stumble back, gasping. The presence withdraws, satisfied with the inspection if not the meal. You are whole — mostly. The road ahead feels different for a while.

Effects: XP -20 · Karma: Hell +2

Two Invoices hell_dvijihva_chase

A blue devil is moving through the junction ahead with the practiced urgency of someone who has been in this exact situation before. He checks both approaches at every turn, tracks two separate routes in his head simultaneously, and is doing it with an air of irritated professionalism.

You can hear the reason why from both directions. Two sets of footsteps. Two sets of clients who have recently compared notes.

GREY Not your problem. Clear the junction before the clients arrive.

You get out of the way. A few junctions later, you hear a brief commotion behind you. Then silence. Whether that means he escaped or didn't, you genuinely can't tell.

BLUE Help him play both clients — you take one side, he takes the other.

Requires: Guile 4+

Recruit: Dvijihva

You split without discussing it — instinct meeting instinct. Ten minutes later, both clients have been sent in wrong directions, each convinced the other one was dealt with.

He looks at you afterward with genuine appreciation. "You understood the problem immediately."

"So did you, apparently. Twice."

A dry laugh. "Occupational hazard. You're looking for a sorcerer?"

No cost. Karma: Hungry Ghost +2, Human +1

BLUE Cast something that stops both pursuers in their tracks — show him what real craft looks like.

Requires: Sorcery 4+

Recruit: Dvijihva

The effect is clean and leaves no trace. Both sets of footsteps stop. He watches the working from the junction, and what crosses his face isn't gratitude — it's professional assessment.

"That's a good working," he says. "Who trained you?"

The conversation that follows lasts until the junction is well behind you. He is still talking when you realize he has simply joined your party.

No cost. Karma: Human +2

YELLOW Spot which client is closer and warn him with enough precision to be useful.

Roll: Awareness, easy difficulty

If it succeeds: Recruit: Dvijihva

"Left side, thirty seconds. The right one turned at the last junction."

He pivots immediately, adjusts his route, and slips through a gap you would not have noticed yourself. Two minutes later he is beside you, walking casually.

"Good eyes," he says. "I owe you one. Or would, except — " He tilts his head. "Actually, where are you headed?"

No cost. Karma: Human +2

If it fails:

You call the wrong direction. He goes that way and nearly walks into one of his pursuers. The resulting scramble is chaotic and you lose sight of him in the confusion. He probably survived — he had the look of someone who has done this before — but he is not inclined to stop and chat.

Post-Clarity hell_coolhead_aftermath

A black devil sits in the wreckage of what was recently a building. He is writing in a notebook. The walls around him are scorched. There is a crater behind him of impressive diameter.

He looks up as you approach, expression neutral. He does not seem distressed. He seems, if anything, very calm — the particular calm of someone who has been through the seal-breaking and come out the other side of it.

GREY Keep moving. Whatever happened here is between him and the building.

He watches you go, then returns to his notes. The crater will be there long after both of you have moved on.

BLUE Look at what he's writing. Recognize what he's actually documenting.

Requires: Learning 4+

Recruit: Coolhead Hotblood

The notes are behavioral — not damage assessment but internal process, the phenomenology of the retort breaking. He is treating himself as a specimen.

"You're cataloguing it," you say.

"If I don't, who will?" He glances at the crater. "This is the third time. The interval is getting shorter. I should understand the mechanism."

You talk for a while about mechanisms. By the end, he is walking with you.

No cost. Karma: Human +3

BLUE Offer a different kind of stillness — not suppression, but actual peace.

Requires: Yoga 3+

Recruit: Coolhead Hotblood

You settle beside him and demonstrate what you mean — not blocking the feeling but letting it move through without accumulating. He watches with the careful attention of someone encountering an unfamiliar technique.

"I've been treating it like a pressure problem," he says slowly. "Structural."

"It isn't."

"No." He closes the notebook. "Show me that again, and I'll come with you."

No cost. Karma: God +2, Human +3

YELLOW Ask how it felt. Without judgment — you are genuinely curious.

Roll: Charm, easy difficulty

If it succeeds: Recruit: Coolhead Hotblood

He blinks. Most people, apparently, do not ask that.

"Clarifying," he says, after a moment. Then, more slowly: "Like setting down something I'd been carrying so long I'd forgotten its weight."

He looks at the crater again. "The building was empty. I made sure."

"I didn't ask."

"No." He stands, brushing ash from his robe. "You want a sorcerer who's done suppressing things?"

No cost. Karma: Human +3

If it fails:

He looks at you with the polite wariness of someone who has heard that question before and found it a prelude to a lecture. He answers briefly and returns to his notes. The conversation does not develop.

First Impression hell_princess_spiderface

A black devil stands in the middle of a street. The ash around her has footprints leading away — running, by the depth and spacing of them. She is watching after the person who left.

She is not upset. She has the look of someone who is simply used to it. Her face is the reason. She knows this.

GREY Take a different route. You don't need to add to her morning.

You go around. She doesn't see you do it. This, at least, you spare her.

BLUE Approach with a healer's attention — look past the surface to what's actually there.

Requires: White Magic 3+

Recruit: Princess Spiderface

You walk up to her directly. Healers learn early not to flinch — injury looks like injury, whatever form it takes.

She turns. Waits for the reaction.

You simply say: "Are you alright?"

A long silence. "People don't usually — " She stops. Starts again. "No. I mean, yes. I'm fine. I just —"

"Do you want company?" you ask.

She looks at you for a long time. Then: "Yes. Actually."

No cost. Karma: Human +4, God +2

BLUE Greet her the way you'd greet a spirit — speak to what's behind the surface.

Requires: Space Magic 3+

Recruit: Princess Spiderface

Space magic teaches you that what you see and what is there are not always the same thing. You address the presence behind the face — the one that names spirits by name and asks how they've been.

Something brightens in her eyes. "You can tell."

"Yes."

"Most people can't. Or won't." She glances at the retreating footprints. "Their loss, honestly. The spirits I know are very good company." She turns. "Are you going somewhere?"

No cost. Karma: God +3, Human +2

YELLOW Hold her gaze and say something true to the person behind the face.

Roll: Charm, normal difficulty

If it succeeds: Recruit: Princess Spiderface

You don't flinch. You don't make a point of not flinching. You just look at her the way you'd look at anyone, and say something that belongs to the conversation rather than to her face.

She exhales — a small, controlled sound. "That was nice," she says, quietly. "That was really very nice." A pause. "I'm Princess Spiderface. People run, usually, so I don't get to do introductions much. Where are you headed?"

No cost. Karma: Human +4

If it fails:

You hold her gaze, but something in what you say catches wrong — too careful, too deliberate. She can tell you're working at it. She smiles, but it is the practiced smile of someone who has been given effort instead of ease.

"Thank you for trying," she says. "That's more than most." She turns back to the empty street.

Karma: Human +1

Security Theater hell_samvibrahmi_fortress

A roadside ruin has been transformed. Tripwires — visible only if you know what to look for. Sight-lines from every approach accounted for. A small figure inside is crouched over what appears to be a very precise map, muttering assessments of approach vectors.

He looks up when he realizes you've reached the interior of his perimeter without triggering a single countermeasure. His expression cycles through surprise, calculation, and something that might be professional offense.

GREY Announce yourself calmly and give him time to collect himself.

He accepts this with dignity and proceeds to document your entry vector in significant detail. You exchange brief pleasantries and move on. He returns to his map.

BLUE Walk him through exactly how you got past every single one of his defenses.

Requires: Comedy 4+

Recruit: Samvibrahmi

You do it with affection — the way you'd point out a brilliant mistake to someone you respected. By the third countermeasure you breached without noticing, his expression has moved from offense to pained hilarity.

By the seventh, he is laughing despite himself.

"It's the cabbage cart problem," he says finally. "You plan for every threat you can imagine, and then—"

"The one you didn't imagine."

"Yes." He folds the map. "Traveling with you would be very bad for my threat assessments. I'll do it."

No cost. Karma: Human +3

BLUE Identify the one gap in his defenses he hasn't thought of yet.

Requires: Guile 5+

Recruit: Samvibrahmi

You point to a spot on his map. "From there. At this elevation, in rain. You've assumed flat-light approach vectors."

He stares at the spot. His eye twitches once.

"That's — " He stops. "I have been working on this for three weeks."

"I know."

Another pause. "Do you want a job? I mean — I assume you have a job. Can I have a job? The perimeter here is clearly inadequate."

No cost. Karma: Human +2

YELLOW Invite him to redirect all this preparation into something that actually makes sense.

Roll: Charm, normal difficulty

If it succeeds: Recruit: Samvibrahmi

"You've put all this work into defending a ruin that no one was going to attack anyway," you say. "Travel with me and I can promise you: the threats will be real."

He looks at you. Then at his map. Then at you again.

"The threats will be real," he repeats slowly, as though tasting the words.

"Genuinely dangerous. Multiple approaches. Poor visibility. Everything you've been preparing for."

He rolls up the map with the energy of a man who has finally been understood.

No cost. Karma: Human +2

If it fails:

He considers your offer carefully, then shakes his head. "The threats out there are speculative. The threat models in here are documented." He taps his map. "I will join you when I have finished mapping all approaches to this ruin."

You look at the ruin. It has approximately forty approach vectors. You will not wait.

The Warden's Strongroom hell_warden_strongroom

A door of blue iron set into the ice, and behind it a room the cold has kept exactly as it was left: a desk, a ledger, a rack of seals on hooks.

One hook is labelled and empty. The rest hold the authority to open every lock in the cold hells, and nobody has been in to count them for a very long time.

GREY Take a warden's seal from the rack

Cold blue iron, heavier than it looks, stamped with a sigil that makes your thumb ache where it rests. Whatever this opens, it opens with authority.

Effects: XP 12 · Karma: Hungry Ghost +2

BLUE Read the ledger before you touch anything

Requires: Learning 3+

Every seal is signed out against a prisoner's name and a sentence length. The empty hook belongs to a seal signed out four hundred years ago against a sentence of ninety days, never returned. Somebody is still in a box out there on a warrant that expired before this ice formed.

You take a seal, and you take the ledger page too, because a name will matter more than a key.

Effects: XP 22; gold 60 · Karma: Human +4, Hell -3

GREY Take everything that is not nailed down

Seals, desk fittings, the good inkwell, and a strongbox that has clearly not been opened since the last audit.

Effects: XP 10; gold 170; items: Item Random · Karma: Hungry Ghost +5

GREY Take nothing from a warden

You close the blue iron door behind you. The rack of seals stays on its hooks, and every lock in the cold hells stays shut.

Effects: XP 4 · Karma: Human +2

The Frozen Prisoner hell_frozen_prisoner

A pillar of clear ice with a man inside it, upright, eyes open. He is alive in the way things are alive here — aware, unable to move, and entirely unable to stop being aware.

A locked iron collar shows at his throat. His lips move. It takes a while to work out that he is counting.

GREY Use the warden's seal on the collar

Only after: Flag is set

The seal touches the collar and the ice goes out of the pillar all at once, like a held breath. He falls forward into your arms — thin, freezing, four hundred years into a ninety-day sentence — and the first thing he does, before anything else, is finish the number he was on.

Then he stops counting. You get the impression that took more effort than standing up.

Effects: XP 40 · Karma: God +8, Human +6, Hell -8

YELLOW Break the pillar open by force

Roll: Strength, difficult difficulty

If it succeeds:

It takes an hour of hammering and the ice comes away in plates. The collar stays locked — you cannot do anything about the collar — but he can walk, and he goes, wearing it, which he seems to consider an enormous improvement.

Effects: XP 20 · Karma: Human +5, God +3

If it fails:

The ice is not ordinary ice. You succeed only in making a great deal of noise and taking the skin off two sets of knuckles, and his eyes track every failed swing.

Effects: XP 5; HP loss (light, random) · Karma: Human +2

BLUE Melt him out slowly

Requires: Fire Magic 4+

Fast heat would kill him. You spend most of a day bringing the pillar up by degrees, and he comes out of it able to speak, which he could not have done any other way. He tells you his name and the number he had reached. Both are worth writing down.

Effects: XP 30; items: Item Random · Karma: God +6, Human +5, Hell -4

GREY There is nothing you can do here

You walk on. Behind you, at the edge of hearing, the counting continues.

Effects: XP 3; mind: Water -12 · Karma: Hell +3, Animal +2

Blisterfang hell_blisterfang

The red devil sprawled across three chairs outside a slag-side drinking house is enormous, cheerful, and entirely unbothered by the four separate people currently glaring at him from across the yard.

"Blisterfang," he agrees, when you say the name. "Everyone's looking for me this season. It's flattering, honestly."

GREY Tell him the ember merchant wants paying

"He does," Blisterfang says. "He absolutely does." He does not reach for a purse. He does, however, stop sprawling, which from a devil that size is a whole sentence.

You have found him. Getting the money out of him is going to be a separate piece of work.

Effects: XP 12 · Karma: Human +2

GREY Take the payment off him

Combat: Red Devil Warband (hard)

"Ah," he says, delighted, getting up. "One of *those* collectors." The four people glaring from across the yard suddenly become extremely interested in the wall.

After victory:

He goes down laughing and pays up from a purse that turns out to have been on his belt the entire time.

Karma: Asura +4, Hell +3

BLUE Ask what the debt was actually for

Requires: Awareness 14+

It is not a debt. It is a settlement — the merchant's brazier burned a district and Blisterfang paid the compensation out of his own pocket at the time, and the merchant has spent forty years re-describing this as a loan to anyone who will listen. Blisterfang has never once corrected the story. "Let him have it," he says. "He needs it more than I need to be right." He gives you the original settlement papers to prove it, and does not ask you to use them.

Effects: XP 26; items: Item Random · Karma: Human +5, God +3

BLUE Buy him a drink and get it out of him sideways

Requires: Guile 3+ · Cost: Gold (small)

Three rounds in, Blisterfang is explaining his entire financial position unprompted, including where the money is and why he has not handed it over: he simply forgets, constantly, and has done for decades. He is enormously relieved to be reminded and pays on the spot, in coin, counted out twice because he loses his place.

Effects: XP 20; gold 120 · Karma: Human +3, Asura +2

The Ember Merchant's Books hell_ember_merchant_debt

The ember merchant keeps his stall at the edge of the slag fields and his ledger under the counter, and he wants to know — before you have finished saying hello — whether you have found Blisterfang yet.

GREY Hand over what you collected

Only after: Flag is set

He counts it three times and his hands shake on the second count. Then he writes the entry closed, turns the ledger around, and shows you the line — forty years of a single unresolved figure, ruled off at last.

He pays your fee without being asked and gives you the good coal on top of it.

Effects: XP 30; gold 100; items: Item Random · Karma: Human +4, Hell +2

GREY Show him the settlement papers

Only after: Flag is set

He reads them standing up and does not say anything for a long time. Then he sits down on his own stock.

"I knew," he says. "I have known for forty years." What he wanted was not the money; it was for the debt to stay open, because a debt is a thread to a person and he has nothing else left. You stay a while. When you go, the ledger line is ruled off, and he did it himself.

Effects: XP 40; gold 60 · Karma: God +8, Human +8, Hungry Ghost -5

GREY Just here to trade**Opens: Ember Merchant**

He is a good merchant when he is not talking about Blisterfang, which is roughly a third of the time.

BLUE Negotiate your fee up front

Requires: Trade 3+

You point out that a forty-year-old debt has a collection value considerably below its face value, and that you are the only person who has ever offered to go and get it. He grumbles and pays an advance, which is the first money that ledger has generated in four decades.

Effects: XP 14; gold 70 · Karma: Human +2, Hungry Ghost +2

Something in the Drift hell_scroll_in_the_drift

A corner of oiled cloth shows above the snow at the base of a wind-scoured ridge — the kind of thing that has been buried and uncovered a dozen times by the same wind and will be buried again by evening.

Something is wrapped in it.

GREY Dig it out

A scroll case, sealed, dry inside. The scroll within is a sequence of protective mantras copied in a careful old hand, and the cold has not touched a single character of it.

Effects: XP 14 · Karma: Human +2

BLUE Read the mantras before wrapping them back up

Requires: Ritual 3+

They are cold-protection mantras, and they are a good set — the third one in particular is a variant you have not met, and you copy it into your own book before resealing the case. Whoever lost this lost something they will not survive the season without.

Effects: XP 24; learns a spell (White Magic) · Karma: Human +3, God +2

BLUE Read the ground — where did it come from?

Requires: Awareness 13+

The cloth did not blow here. It was dropped by someone moving north-east along the ridge line at a stumble, and there is a second set of prints behind the first, keeping pace and not closing. Somebody was being followed and shed weight to move faster.

You take the scroll, and you take the bearing.

Effects: XP 20; items: Item Random · Karma: Human +4

GREY Leave it to the drift

By evening the wind has covered the corner of cloth again, as it has a dozen times before.

The Hermit in the Cold hell_cold_hermit

He has dug himself into the lee of a boulder and built a wall of packed snow, and he is sitting in the shelter of it doing the only thing left to do, which is recite from memory and get it wrong.

He does not look up. "Third repetition," he says. "I lose it at the third repetition. I have lost it at the third repetition for eleven days."

GREY Give him the scroll

Only after: Flag is set

He takes the case without understanding what it is, and then understands, and stops.

He reads the third repetition off the page, out loud, correctly, for the first time in eleven days — and the cold goes out of the hollow. Not metaphorically: the snow wall starts dripping. He keeps reading. You leave him at the seventh repetition with his eyes shut and his shelter melting around him.

Effects: XP 40 · Karma: God +8, Human +6

BLUE Recite the third repetition for him from memory

Requires: Yoga 4+

You do not have his scroll but you have the shape of the thing, and mantras are not private property. You give him the third repetition. He takes it up, gets it, carries on — and by the fifth he has remembered the rest himself, the way you remember a road once someone names the first turning.

Effects: XP 30; mind: Space +20; gains trait: Steady Practice · Karma: God +10, Human +4

GREY Build his wall up properly and share your fire

Cost: Food (small)

You cannot give him the words but you can give him another few days to find them. The wall goes up to head height, the fire is banked to last, and he thanks you without once breaking the recitation, which keeps going wrong in the same place.

Effects: XP 14; gains trait: Merciful · Karma: Human +5, God +2

GREY **Leave him to it**

"Third repetition," he says behind you, starting again. "Third repetition."

Effects: XP 3; mind: Space -10 · Karma: Animal +2

20. Hungry Ghost (Pretaloka)

The realm of insatiable craving, decay and clinging to what is gone.

Pretaloka is divided into fetid swamps crawling with the newly dead, ancient graveyards haunted by desiccated skeletons, and the charnel grounds where vetalas hold court in palaces that are not quite real. The theme is scarcity: hunger amid plenty, things that can never be enough. Its births are the undead, the starving and the spirit nobility. There is a great variety of skeletons: bone, silver, copper, golden, iron, turquoise.

At a glance: **14** births · **23** companions · **150** events · **23** enemy types · **19** places.

20.1 The land and its regions

The realm of insatiable craving, divided into fetid swamps crawling with the newly dead, ancient graveyards haunted by desiccated skeletons, and the charnel grounds where vetalas hold court in palaces that are not quite real.

The notes under each region are design comments for the writer; the player never sees them.

Fetid Swamps `fetid_swamps`

Left third of the map, full height. Start zone.

Vertical Divider `vertical_divider`

Vertical wall separating swamp from the right half. Pass biased to lower area so the player must travel south before crossing.

Charnel Grounds `charnel_grounds`

Top-right section. Final zone — reached by going UP through the horizontal wall from the graveyard.

Horizontal Divider `horizontal_divider`

Horizontal wall within the right section. Pass biased to the right so the player must explore the graveyard before finding it.

Dry Graveyards `dry_graveyards`

Bottom-right section. First zone entered after the vertical wall pass.

Fixed landmarks

Portal

Leads to the Animal realm. Opens only once the realm's boss is defeated.

The Insatiable King

Boss in Charnel Grounds; event: The Insatiable King

Swamp Warden

Pass Guardian in Vertical Divider; event: Swamp Warden

Bone Gate Keeper

Pass Guardian in Horizontal Divider; event: Bone Gate Keeper

Settlement names used on the map

Yidaklung, Roshel, Dribkhar, Tshogthang, Nyomyul, Kugong, Semdzong, Rotrak, Driblung, Nyomkhar, Kshudhapura, Trishnakshetra, Pretanagar, Shavanagar, Smashanapura

20.2 Births of this realm

Rolang, Preserved, Skeleton, Dralha, Gyelpo, Dré, Vetala, Shaza, Yidag, Silver Skeleton, Copper Skeleton, Golden Skeleton, Iron Skeleton, Turquoise Skeleton. Full entries are in chapter 25; companions are in chapter 27.

20.3 Places: shops, guilds and teahouses

Each of these has a name and a short description shown when the party arrives.

General merchant

Bone Merchant hg_bone_merchant

A skeleton trader squats among the dry graves, its jaw clicking as it counts coins with bony fingers. The wares are crude but functional — carved from the bones of those who no longer need them.

Wandering Preta hg_wandering_preta

A gaunt, distended figure with a neck like a needle and a belly like a drum. It clutches its wares with desperate hands, willing to trade food for almost anything — though it can never eat enough to be satisfied.

The Smuggler's Alcove hg_black_market

A low tunnel behind a false wall, lit by a single floating ember. The figure inside won't show its face. It trades in things that shouldn't have made it into the hungry ghost realm — quality ironwork, foreign medicines, a few items with the smell of other worlds still on them. Prices reflect the difficulty of getting anything here at all.

Spell trainer

Charnel Sorcerer hg_chnel_sorcerer

A vetala perches atop a crumbling funerary monument, its stolen body draped in rotting silk. It trades in dark knowledge — curses, poisons, and the thin art of pulling life from the dying.

Trains: Black Magic, Water Magic

The Bone Library hg_spell_shop

A sorcerer-ghost has assembled a collection of sutras and grimoires, most of them water-stained or singed at the edges, all of them legible to those with the patience to study. It charges for access by the session — a small candle's worth of time per spell — and answers no questions that aren't paid for.

Trains: White Magic, Black Magic, Sorcery, Ritual

Teahouse

The Last Cup hg_teahouse

A lantern glows faintly above a low doorway carved into a burial mound. Inside, a quiet figure brews tea from dried flowers that grow only on graves. The dead do not drink, but the living are welcome to rest.

Town

Crossbones Armory hg_town_weapons

A squat stone building marked with crossed femurs above the door. The smith inside is alive — barely — and forges weapons from scavenged iron and whatever the gravediggers bring in.

Trains: Swords, Axes, Maces, Armor

Whispering Shrine hg_town_magic

Faded prayer flags hang from a cracked shrine where the boundary between the living and dead has worn thin. The priests here teach what they remember of the old arts — healing and hexing in equal measure.

Trains: White Magic, Black Magic, Water Magic, Earth Magic

Gravedigger's Supply hg_town_supplies

A practical establishment run by those who tend to the dead for a living. The shelves are well stocked — people always need supplies in a land where nothing grows.

Mercenary guild

Undertakers' Lodge hg_mercenary_guild

A fortified charnel house where the realm's hired fighters gather between jobs. They call themselves undertakers — they put things in the ground, one way or another.

Veteran camp

The Old Guard hg_veterans_camp

A ring of tents around a guttering fire, where warriors who have survived the hungry ghost realm long enough gather to share what they know. Their eyes have the hollow look of those who have seen too much decay.

Alchemist

The Dré Herbalist hg_alchemist

A dré ghost crouches behind a folding table heaped with dried herbs, stoppered gourds, and bundles of something that smells like incense and rot. Its robes are stuffed so full of plant matter that it looks like a walking thicket. It speaks in a dry rasp and seems to genuinely enjoy its trade.

Trains: Alchemy, Medicine

Spell guild

Black Lodge hg_black_lodge

A mound of bones marks the entrance, a khatvanga hung with a skull and black silk. Inside, something moves that may not be fully alive. It knows what you want.

Circle of the Yoginis hg_circle_of_yoginis

Sixty-four forms carved into standing bones, forming a ring on the charnel ground. The earth inside is worn smooth by countless ritual footprints. The witches still come.

Domain spell trainer

Crossroads Stupa hg_crossroads_stupa

At the intersection of the ancient paths, a stupa rises from layers of offerings — skulls, prayer flags, bones wrapped in cloth. The practitioners here call back what has been lost.

Hidden Gompa hg_hidden_gompa

A small monastery sits undisturbed between the burial grounds, its walls marked with painted eyes. The monks here practice for the benefit of all beings caught between lives.

Mirror Lake hg_mirror_lake

The surface of the lake reflects not the sky but something else — other realms, other moments. Practitioners sit at its edge, learning to bend what is seen.

Sacred Grove hg_sacred_grove

A stand of ancient trees whose roots grow through charnel earth. Offerings of food hang from the branches — the hungry ghosts can smell them but cannot eat. Practitioners here speak to both the living and the dead.

Temple of the Naga hg_temple_of_the_naga

A low temple built around a black-water pool. The nagas who dwell in such pools are guardians of the dead. Their human followers leave milk offerings at the water's edge and learn what the serpents are willing to teach.

20.4 Bestiary

Enemy types met in this realm. The note under a name is a design comment for the writer and never shown to the player.

Rolang Shambler hg_rolang_shambler any · frontline

Rolang Drowned hg_rolang_drowned swamp · frontline, skirmisher

Rolang Ancient hg_rolang_ancient any · support, caster

The rare preserved rolang - alchemical or yogic arts kept the body intact. Rot caster and support.

Swamp Leech hg_swamp_leech swamp · support

Attaches to a target and drains HP/stamina per turn until removed. Needs attach behavior in combat AI.

Centipede hg_centipede any · skirmisher

Carrion Worm hg_carrion_worm any · frontline

Slow bloated tank. Explodes on death dealing rot/disease damage in an area. Needs explodes_on_death behavior in combat AI.

Skeleton Warrior hg_skeleton_warrior any · frontline

Skeleton Archer hg_skeleton_archer any · ranged

Skeleton Mage hg_skeleton_mage any · caster

Skelepuppy hg_skelepuppy any · skirmisher

Bone Horror hg_bone_horror any · frontline

Heavy construct assembled from many skeletons. Reassembles once after death, returning at 50% HP after one turn. Needs 'reassemble' perk implementation.

Harpy hg_harpy any · skirmisher, ranged

Vetala Blooddrinker hg_vetala_blooddrinker any · frontline, skirmisher

Vetala Sorcerer hg_vetala_sorcerer any · caster

Vetala Elder hg_vetala_elder any · support, caster

Vulture hg_vulture any · skirmisher

Prioritizes low-HP or downed targets. Needs scavenger targeting behavior in combat AI.

Carrion Dog hg_carrion_dog any · skirmisher

Vampire Bat hg_vampire_bat any · skirmisher

Life drain on hit; in mixed encounters, healing feeds the paired vetala. Needs life_steal behavior in combat AI.

Lost Preta hg_lost_preta any · frontline, caster

Dissolving consciousnesses barely present in the physical world. Analogous to hell's tormented shade. Appear in all three zones.

Charnel Wraith hg_chnel_wraith charnel_grounds · caster, support

Stronger incorporeal from the charnel grounds — more focused and more dangerous than a lost preta.

Skeleton King hg_skeleton_king dry_graveyards · boss

The Insatiable King hg_insatiable_king charnel_grounds · boss

The Insatiable King (Sated) hg_insatiable_king_weakened charnel_grounds · boss

20.5 Quests

No quests have been written for this realm yet.

20.6 Event catalogue (150 events)

Every event written for this realm, in the order they are stored. **GREY** choices are always available, **BLUE** choices need a party member with a skill, attribute or trait, **YELLOW** choices are rolls. The small grey lines are reference labels, not game text.

The Starving Spirit hg_starving_preta

An emaciated figure blocks the path — belly swollen like a gourd, throat thin as a reed. Its hands are skeletal claws reaching toward you. The voice that comes out is barely a whisper.

"Please. Anything. I haven't eaten in — I can't remember how long. Please."

GREY Share your rations

Cost: Items (Rations)

The food dissolves the moment it touches its lips, transformed to ash by the curse it carries. But it weeps, grateful for the gesture. "You... tried. That's more than most."

Effects: XP 6 · Karma: God +4, Human +3

BLUE Examine its condition carefully

Requires: Medicine 2+

You recognize the curse of the hungry ghost — every craving fed only deepens the hunger. You describe this to the creature gently, guiding it to eat slowly, deliberately. It seems to find some fragile relief in understanding its own condition.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: God +5, Human +2

BLUE Teach it about the nature of craving

Requires: Yoga 3+

"There is no meal that ends hunger. There is no object that ends want. The relief you seek cannot be found in a bowl." The preta goes still. Its eyes, desperate a moment ago, grow strangely clear. It doesn't answer. But something in its posture changes.

Effects: XP 14 · Karma: God +5, Human +4

GREY Turn your eyes away and walk past

The whisper fades behind you. You tell yourself it's not your problem. The realm of hungry ghosts is full of such creatures. You can't save them all.

Karma: Hungry Ghost +3

BLUE Give it something. It will not be enough and give it anyway.

Requires: Trait: Generous

It is not enough. Nothing would be — the throat is a needle and the belly is a room.

But it stops, for a moment, being a thing that is starving and becomes a thing that is being fed, and it looks at you differently for the length of that moment.

Effects: XP 14; supplies: Food -3; mind: Water +12 · Karma: Hungry Ghost -6, Human +4

BLUE Work out exactly how little will satisfy it.

Requires: Trait: Scrimper

The answer is: nothing will, so the correct expenditure is the smallest amount that buys passage.

You are right. You are right in a way that sits badly on the walk afterwards, and the party does not discuss it.

Effects: mind: Earth -8; XP 30 · Karma: Hungry Ghost +4

GREY Cut it down — put it out of its misery

Combat: Lost Preta (easy)

Karma: Hell +4, Hungry Ghost +2

Bone Merchant hg_bone_merchant_event

A skeleton in a tattered merchant's robe sits behind a blanket of wares laid on the dry earth — wrapped bundles, clay jars, glinting objects of uncertain purpose. It clicks its jaw merrily as you approach.

"Ah! Customers! Or at least, beings capable of carrying things away! Welcome, welcome — the overhead is low and the bones are FREE."

GREY Browse the wares

Opens: Bone Merchant

Karma: Human +1

BLUE Negotiate the prices down

Requires: Trade 2+

You counter its opening price with calm authority, citing comparable goods in the living world. The skeleton clacks its teeth together in what might be admiration. "You know your market. Fine — take it for less."

Effects: XP 5 · Karma: Human +2

YELLOW Wait for its attention to wander and pocket something

Roll: Finesse, easy difficulty

If it succeeds:

The skeleton turns to argue with a passing rolang. Your hand moves before you've quite decided to move it. By the time it looks back, you're innocently studying the sky.

Effects: items: Item Random · Karma: Hungry Ghost +5

If it fails: Combat: Skeleton Warrior (normal)

The skeleton's eye sockets swivel with unsettling precision. "I may be dead, but I am not BLIND." It produces a weapon from somewhere in its robes.

Karma: Hungry Ghost +3

YELLOW Tell a skeleton joke

Roll: Comedy, easy difficulty

If it succeeds:

"...and the skeleton said, 'I just don't have the guts for it!'" The merchant clacks its jaw so hard a tooth falls out. "HA! Oh — oh, that's GOOD. I haven't laughed like that since — well, since I had muscles to laugh with. Here, take this. Consider it payment for services rendered."

Effects: XP 5; items: Item Random · Karma: Human +3

If it fails:

The merchant stares at you with hollow sockets. "Was that... a joke? Was it supposed to be funny?" Uncomfortable silence. You browse its wares.

The Restless Grave hg_restless_grave

The earth shifts. A hand pushes through the soil — five fingers, then a second hand. Something is clawing its way up from below. The ground heaves.

YELLOW Grab its hands and pull it free

Roll: Awareness, easy difficulty

If it succeeds: Recruit: a random companion from this zone

You haul it clear of the earth — a confused rolang, blinking in the grey light. It looks at its hands, then at you. Something surfaces in its eyes. Not a full mind, but enough. It stays close to your heel like a dog that's found someone.

No cost. Karma: Human +3, Animal +2

If it fails: Combat: Bog Zombie (normal)

It comes up snarling — whatever consciousness it had is buried under panic and hunger. It goes straight for you.

BLUE Force the earth open with brute strength

Requires: Strength 15+

Recruit: a random companion from this zone

You get both hands under the soil and heave. The earth gives. The rolang sits up, dazed and blinking. It looks at you for a long moment, then slowly nods. It will follow you.

No cost. Karma: Human +3

BLUE Perform last rites — put whatever's down there to rest

Requires: Ritual 3+

You press your palm to the churning soil and recite the words. The hands slow, relax, and slip back into the earth. The ground settles. The air is lighter.

Effects: XP 12 · Karma: God +6

GREY Walk away

A low groan follows you from beneath the trembling ground. It fades as you move on. This realm is full of things trying to surface.

Karma: Animal +2

The Fetid Crossing hg_swamp_crossing

A wide stretch of black, stinking water blocks the path. Shapes move beneath the surface — too large to be debris, too slow to be fish. The only bridge is half-rotted wood on crumbling stone. It might hold. Might.

YELLOW Cross the bridge quickly

Roll: Finesse, normal difficulty

If it succeeds:

You move fast and light, skipping over the worst boards. The bridge shudders but holds. On the far bank, you look back — a plank falls into the water the moment your foot leaves it.

Effects: XP 5

If it fails: Combat: Swamp Vermin (normal)

The board snaps. You go in. The water is cold and thick as tar — and something in it is already moving toward you.

BLUE Wade through — constitution over caution

Requires: Constitution 14+

You take the damage. The water burns where it touches skin, and something bumps against your leg in the darkness. You push through on will alone and drag yourself up the far bank, filthy and hurting. But through.

Effects: XP 4

BLUE Look for another way around

Requires: Awareness 13+

There — a line of flat stones barely visible below the surface, an old ford hidden by the murk. You pick your way across with dry boots.

Effects: XP 7

BLUE Black water to the chest, and you are not built for this.

Requires: Trait: Frail

You are not. You make it across and you make it across badly, and you spend the next day with something in your lungs that should not be in them.

The party slows for you, which you would rather they did not.

Effects: HP loss (light, random); mind: Earth -8; XP 22

BLUE Take the rope across first. You are the one who can.

Requires: Trait: Strong

You go in with the line and the current is exactly as bad as it looks and you stand in it anyway while everyone else comes over hand by hand.

Your legs are unhappy for a day. Nobody else gets wet above the waist.

Effects: XP 15

GREY Swim across

Combat: Bog Zombie (normal)

Within three strokes something grabs your ankle.

The Dead Monk hg_wandering_monk

A skeleton in saffron robes sits in perfect lotus position on a flat stone. Prayer beads still wrapped around its bony fingers. Intact, somehow — no rot, no damage, as if it simply sat down and stopped one day.

As you approach, its jaw opens: "I have been waiting. Not for you specifically. Just... waiting."

BLUE Sit and meditate together

Requires: Yoga 3+

You sit across from it in the grey dust. For a long time, neither of you speaks. Then the skeleton begins, in a voice like wind through empty rooms, to talk about impermanence — not as tragedy, but as relief. You listen. When you open your eyes, hours have passed and you feel lighter than you have in some time.

Effects: XP 20 · Karma: God +8

GREY Request a teaching — offer payment

Cost: Gold (moderate)

It accepts the coin without looking at it and begins. The teaching is brief, precise, and aimed exactly at something you've been struggling with. You aren't sure how it knew.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: God +4

GREY Ask about the hungry ghost realm

"This realm is the shape of want," it says. "Every being here is caught in the moment they decided their craving was more important than everything else. They are still in that moment. They will be until they aren't." It resumes its stillness.

Effects: XP 5 · Karma: Human +2

YELLOW Take the prayer beads while it's distracted

Roll: Finesse, normal difficulty

If it succeeds:

Your hand moves. The beads slide free. The skeleton sits perfectly still. Maybe it didn't notice. Maybe it chose not to.

Effects: items: Prayer Beads · Karma: Hungry Ghost +4, God -3

If it fails:

"Well," the skeleton says softly, without opening its eyes, "what can I expect from beings in this realm if not demented hijinks like that?" It sounds more tired than angry. You retreat with your dignity in tatters.

Karma: God -4, Hungry Ghost +3

Hungry Crowd hg_preta_pack

A pack of pretas surrounds you — a dozen, maybe more — moaning and reaching with skeletal hands. Their eyes are cavernous and desperate. They don't attack. They beg. The sound is almost worse than violence.

GREY Share your supplies

Cost: Items (Rations)

The food vanishes in their hands — the curse takes it before it reaches their mouths. But the act itself seems to do something. The desperate reaching slows. They let you pass.

Effects: XP 6 · Karma: God +5, Human +3

YELLOW Drive them back with presence and force of will

Roll: Strength, normal difficulty

If it succeeds:

You spread your arms wide and roar. For a moment, the part of them that remembers fear overrides the hunger. They scatter into the grey mist.

Effects: XP 4 · Karma: Hell +3

If it fails: Combat: Rolang Mob (normal)

The hunger is stronger than the fear. They surge forward.

Karma: Hell +4

BLUE Lead them toward a water source

Requires: Persuasion 3+

You speak calmly and point the way — there's a trickle of clean water half a mile east, something most denizens here cannot find or would not think to look for. They turn. Whether the water helps is uncertain. But they turn.

Effects: XP 12 · Karma: God +5, Human +3

GREY Fight your way through**Combat: Rolang Mob (normal)**

Karma: Hell +4, Asura +2

The Charnel Grounds

 hg_chnel_ground_entrance

Smoke rises from ritual pyres. Human bones are arranged in geometric patterns on the ground — too deliberate to be accidental, not quite like anything you recognize. A vetala perches on a skull-pile, watching you with amused curiosity.

"Another living one. How delightful. We don't get many."

GREY Ask for passage through

"Passage costs breath," it says. "Not much. Just a little. You have plenty to spare." There's a brief cold sensation, as if something has been lifted from you. You feel slightly less alive than you did. The vetala waves you through with its too-long fingers.

Karma: Human +2

GREY Challenge the vetala**Combat: Vetala Scout (normal)**

Karma: Human +2, Asura +3

BLUE Demonstrate your dark workings

Requires: Black Magic 3+

You show it something that makes its eyes go wide with professional appreciation. "Oh, you ARE interesting," it says. "Someone actually worth talking to." It grants passage and, before you leave, whispers the shape of a spell you hadn't known before.

Effects: XP 15 · Karma: Human +3

BLUE You cannot help it. You simply cannot help it.

Requires: Trait: Fastidious

It is not fear, which would at least be respectable. It is that everything here is *touching* everything else, and you spend the whole passage moving in a way the vetala find frankly hilarious.

They let you through specifically to see how far you will get.

Effects: XP 14; mind: Earth -8

BLUE Offer to trade stories

Requires: Charm 15+

Vetalas prize novelty above most things, and living stories are rarest of all. You sit together on the skull-pile for an hour, trading tales. It laughs often. When you leave, it waves with something approaching fondness.

Effects: XP 12 · Karma: Human +4, God +2

Grave Robbers hg_grave_robbers

Two skeletons are prying open a stone sarcophagus with iron bars. They freeze when they see you — a guilty, comedic tableau. One slowly puts the crowbar behind its back.

GREY Help them open it — split the loot

Three sets of hands make short work of the lid. Inside: some aged valuables, a corroded weapon, a few coins. You divide the take by unspoken agreement.

Effects: items: Item Random; gold small · Karma: Hungry Ghost +4

GREY Stop them — drive them off

Combat: Skeleton Warrior Pair (normal)

Karma: Asura +3

BLUE Demand a cut for your silence

Requires: Charm 14+

You plant yourself between them and the tomb and fold your arms. They exchange a glance — or the skeleton equivalent — and reluctantly extend a share. Good bones know when they're outmatched.

Effects: items: Item Random · Karma: Asura +3

YELLOW Find a skeleton patrol and report them

Roll: Awareness, easy difficulty

If it succeeds:

You locate a patrol two streets over and lead them back. The grave robbers are hauled away clacking in protest. The patrol sergeant presses a coin into your hand — the King's reward for civic virtue.

Effects: XP 8; gold small · Karma: Human +4

If it fails: Combat: Skeleton Warrior Pair (normal)

The grave robbers see you look around for a patrol, decide their odds are better now, and attack.

The Last Cup hg_teahouse_event

In an impossible pocket of warmth among the grey wastes, a skeletal figure in fine robes serves tea to the dead. The smell is real — jasmine and wood smoke, somehow surviving in this realm. Dead patrons sit quietly at low tables. A hand-painted sign above the door reads: ALL ARE WELCOME. PAYMENT EXPECTED.

GREY Enter and rest

Opens: The Last Cup

Karma: Human +2

GREY Ask about the other patrons

The teamster pours without looking up. "The one by the window was a judge. That one a merchant. The two arguing in the corner have been arguing about a land dispute for two hundred years. The tea helps. Not much, but some."

Effects: XP 4 · Karma: Human +2

YELLOW Perform for the patrons

Roll: Performance, normal difficulty

If it succeeds:

The dead crowd goes quiet as you begin. Then something stirs in them — the memory of being moved by something beautiful. Coins appear on tables. The teamster nods at you with something like approval.

Effects: XP 10; gold small · Karma: Human +4

If it fails:

Silence. Then an awkward clicking of bones. The teamster sets a cup of tea gently in front of you. "Sit," they say. "Drink. We all have bad days."

BLUE There is a right way to take a last cup.

Requires: Trait: Tea Ritualist

There is, and you do it — the whole form, in a bone teahouse at the edge of the grey.

The skeleton proprietor watches every movement. When you finish it turns the cup over, which you understand at once to mean that the house will not be serving anyone else today.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Water +12

BLUE Offer to help serve

Requires: Grace 3+

You spend an hour moving through the tables, refilling cups with the careful attention the work demands. The teamster watches you from across the room. At the end, it sets before you a full meal and refuses payment. "Well done," is all it says.

Effects: XP 8 · Karma: Human +4, God +2

The Dead Caravan hg_undead_caravan

A line of skeletons carrying bundles marches along a dusty road. Pack animals made of bone and binding-wire bear crates of indeterminate goods. A skeleton with an extravagant feathered hat rides at the front on a skeletal horse.

"Traders of the dead! We go between the cities of this realm and ask no questions of the living. Care to travel with us for a stretch?"

GREY Travel with them awhile

Safe company across a bleak stretch of road. The caravan guards watch the wasteland for threats. The feathered hat bobs ahead. You part ways at a crossroads.

Effects: XP 4 · Karma: Human +2

GREY Browse the caravan's goods

Opens: Bone Merchant

Karma: Human +1

BLUE Offer your services as a guard

Requires: Strength 14+

Combat: Rolang Mob (normal)

The hat bobs appreciatively. "A living fighter! Excellent — rolang packs have been troublesome this season." Three miles on, the packs appear. You earn your pay.

Effects: XP 10; gold moderate · Karma: Human +3

GREY Ambush the caravan

Combat: Skeleton Warband (hard)

The feathered hat turns. The guards reach for weapons. The trading life has made them careful.

Karma: Hell +5, Hungry Ghost +4

The Wailing Well hg_wailing_well

A stone well stands alone in a dead field. No village, no path to it — it was simply placed here and has been here a long time. Wailing rises from its depths. Not wind. Voices, dozens of them, calling from somewhere far below. Something glints at the bottom.

YELLOW Lower yourself down on a rope

Roll: Finesse, normal difficulty

If it succeeds:

Hand over hand in the dark, the voices growing louder. Your feet touch the bottom — wet stone, a narrow chamber. And there: a cache, sealed in oilcloth. Someone threw it in a long time ago.

Effects: XP 6; gold moderate; items: Item Random

If it fails:

The rope slips at the worst moment. You take the fall hard on cold stone and have to drag yourself back up, bruised and empty-handed.

BLUE Be very still and listen to the voices

Requires: Awareness 15+

You close your eyes and let the wailing wash over you. Under it — patterns, repetitions. These aren't screams of pain. They're warnings. Specific ones, about specific places in this realm. You listen until you have what you need.

Effects: XP 18 · Karma: Human +2

GREY Throw an offering into the depths

Cost: Gold (small)

Coins fall into the dark. The wailing pauses — as if something has been surprised. Then, slowly, it stills. The field is quiet for the first time in what feels like a long age.

Effects: XP 4 · Karma: God +5

BLUE Seal it with earth magic

Requires: Earth Magic 3+

You bring stone up from below and cap the well properly. The voices stop with finality. Something is over.

Effects: XP 12 · Karma: God +5, Human +3

BLUE Sing along with the wailing

Requires: Comedy 3+

You add your voice to theirs — not mocking, but joining. For a moment the dissonance is jarring. Then something shifts. The voices find a new shape around yours, a resolution they hadn't been able to reach alone. One by one, they stop. The field is quiet.

Effects: XP 16 · Karma: God +5, Human +4

The Riddler hg_vetala_riddler

A vetala hangs upside-down from a dead tree by its knees, grinning. Its arms are folded. It seems completely comfortable.

"Answer my riddle, traveler, and I'll let you pass with a gift. Fail, and I take something of yours."

YELLOW Accept the challenge

Roll: Awareness, normal difficulty

If it succeeds:

"What is it — a shoal of silver fish jumps up and down in a blue net?" You think. Then: "The stars in the night sky." The vetala blinks, rights itself, and drops to the ground. "Hm. Correct. I haven't heard that from someone in decades." It tosses you something valuable.

Effects: XP 12; items: Item Random · Karma: Human +3

If it fails:

You guess wrong. The vetala drops to the ground with a long, satisfied smile. "Mine, I think." Your coin purse is lighter when you walk away.

Karma: Hungry Ghost +3

GREY Refuse and fight

Combat: Vetala Scout (normal)

Karma: Asura +3

BLUE Counter with your own riddle

Requires: Learning 3+

You pose a riddle back at it. The vetala's grin falters. It answers wrong. You collect the reward twice over — once for accepting the challenge, once for winning it.

Effects: XP 15; items: Item Random, Item Random · Karma: Human +3

BLUE A riddle. Obviously you are going to try the riddle.

Requires: Trait: Curious

You are, and the vetala can tell, and it is so pleased to have a genuine participant that it gives you the second riddle for free.

You get one of the two. It considers this a good afternoon's work for both of you.

Effects: XP 8

BLUE It said the riddle. You heard the riddle.

Requires: Trait: Forgetful

You heard the riddle and it has gone, entirely, in the time it took to start thinking about it.

The vetala repeats it once, with visible enjoyment, and then declines to repeat it again.

Effects: mind: Space -10; XP 22

YELLOW Try to steal its treasure without engaging the riddle at all

Roll: Guile, difficult difficulty

If it succeeds:

While the vetala is busy posing dramatically, you've already located the cache behind the tree roots and lifted it. You wave cheerfully as you leave. The vetala is still explaining the rules.

Effects: XP 10; items: Item Random · Karma: Hungry Ghost +3

If it fails: Combat: Vetala Pack (hard)

The vetala's smile disappears. It drops to the ground and three more drop from the branches. "Let's try a different game."

The Burial Mound hg_burial_mound

An ancient mound rises from the swamp, its entrance marked with faded symbols carved into standing stones. Cold air breathes from the opening — not the damp cold of the swamp, but the dry cold of sealed places.

GREY Enter without preparation

Combat: Rotting Sentinel (normal)

Something ancient is waiting in the dark.

Effects: items: Item Random; gold small · Karma: Asura +2

BLUE Study the carved symbols before entering

Requires: Learning 3+

The symbols are warnings — and instructions. You understand what is inside, what it guards, and how to approach it without waking the worst of it. You go in, find what you came for, and leave intact.

Effects: XP 10; items: Item Random; gold moderate

BLUE Perform a ritual for the entombed

Requires: Ritual 3+

You don't take anything. You leave offerings instead — a little food, some incense, a prayer for the dead. The cold air stills. Somewhere inside, something ancient settles into proper rest.

Effects: XP 12 · Karma: God +7

BLUE Call the spirit within to your side

Requires: Ritual 3+

Recruit: Temba

The offering is correct. The incantation is correct. A shape emerges from the mound's dark — a dralha, a warrior-chieftain, still bearing the weapons of a kingdom that has not existed in centuries. It looks at you with eyes that have not looked at anything for a very long time.

No cost. Karma: God +4

BLUE Seal the entrance

Requires: Earth Magic 2+

You bring the entrance stones down. Whatever is inside stays there.

Effects: XP 5 · Karma: Human +2

The Corpse Flower hg_corpse_flower

An enormous flower blooms in the swamp, its petals the color of bruised flesh. Its scent is overpowering — sweetly wrong, like incense covering something that should not be sweetened. Dead insects litter the ground around it in concentric rings.

BLUE Harvest it for reagents

Requires: Alchemy 2+

You cut carefully, taking the useful parts without triggering the aromatic glands. The reagents are worth having — the flower's strange chemistry has properties you've never seen elsewhere.

Effects: XP 8; items: Item Random

YELLOW Walk past without being drawn in

Roll: Constitution, normal difficulty

If it succeeds:

The smell hooks something in you and pulls. You keep moving. It takes more will than you expected.

Effects: XP 4

If it fails: Combat: Swamp Vermin (normal)

The scent overwhelms you — you stumble, and the stumbling draws things from the mire.

BLUE Study it from a safe distance

Requires: Medicine 3+

Medicinal — in the right doses. The same compound that overwhelms at close range becomes a useful palliative in small quantities. You harvest a bundle carefully.

Effects: XP 10; items: Herb Bundle

GREY Burn it

The smell, briefly, is terrible. Then it's gone. Whatever the flower was attracting, it won't attract anymore.

Effects: XP 3 · Karma: Human +2

BLUE Meditate on it — find the beauty in the strange

Requires: Yoga 3+

Disgust is a judgment. You sit with the smell and the wrongness until they stop being wrong and start being simply what they are. The flower is a flower. It does what it does. Something in you loosens.

Effects: XP 14 · Karma: Human +3, God +3

The Herald hg_skeleton_king_herald

A copper skeleton in ceremonial armor — turquoise beads strung between its ribs, feathers wired to its shoulder plates — plants itself in the middle of the road. Its voice is enormous for its frame.

"His Ruby-like Majesty, the Skeleton King of the Setting Sun, demands tribute from all who traverse his domain. Pay, serve, or be added to the collection."

GREY Pay the tribute

Cost: Gold (moderate)

The herald accepts the gold with practiced dignity. "For your patient compliance, receive a sparkle of the King's unceasing glow." It touches your brow with a copper finger. Something warm passes through you — and for the next few encounters, your words carry unusual weight.

Effects: XP 3 · Karma: Human +2

GREY Refuse and draw your weapon

Combat: Skeleton Elite (hard)

Karma: Asura +4

BLUE Claim diplomatic immunity

Requires: Persuasion 3+

You produce a very official-looking nothing and speak with great certainty. The herald stares at the empty air where your credentials should be. "...very well. I shall note your passage as diplomatic in nature." You walk past with a straight face.

Effects: XP 8 · Karma: Human +3

BLUE Offer military service instead of tribute

Requires: Swords 3+

Combat: Rolang Mob (normal)

"A fighting force! The King can always use those." It leads you to a trouble spot — rolang incursion, needs clearing. You earn safe passage and the patrol's grudging respect.

Effects: XP 10; gold moderate · Karma: Human +2, Asura +2

BLUE Offer a hymn of praise in lieu of gold

Requires: Performance 3+

"I am a poor traveler, but I will offer my only treasure — my voice." The herald goes still as you begin. By the second verse, it has lowered its halberd. By the third, it has produced a small donation from its own coin pouch. "His Majesty would approve," it says. "Pass freely."

Effects: XP 10; gold small · Karma: Human +4, God +2

The Mother hg_desperate_mother

A rolang woman crouches in the grey dust, clutching a bundle to her chest, rocking back and forth. The bundle is empty — just rags shaped by a mother's hands. She doesn't seem to know. Her eyes are elsewhere, in a time this realm cannot reach.

"Have you seen my child? I just need to feed them. Just once more."

GREY Sit with her gently — offer what comfort you can

She doesn't fully notice you. But your presence seems to register somewhere, some warmth in the grey. She rocks more slowly.

Effects: XP 5 · Karma: God +4, Human +3

BLUE Guide her gently toward understanding her condition

Requires: Yoga 3+

You speak softly about attachment, about the nature of what she holds. She listens with the partial attention of someone dreaming. A long pause. She looks at the bundle. "There's nothing here, is there." It isn't a question. She sets it down. Her hands are empty.

Effects: XP 14 · Karma: God +6, Human +3

YELLOW Tell her plainly that her child is gone

Roll: Charm, difficult difficulty

If it succeeds:

You choose your words with great care. She goes still. Looks at you. Looks at the bundle. "I know," she says, very quietly. After a long moment: "I know." She rocks more slowly. She seems, in some way, relieved.

Effects: XP 12 · Karma: God +4, Human +3

If it fails: Combat: Swamp Wraith (hard)

The words come out wrong. Something in her breaks in the wrong direction. The grief becomes rage and the rage becomes something else entirely.

Karma: Hell +2

GREY Leave quietly

You back away without disturbing her. She doesn't notice you leave. She was somewhere else already.

Karma: Animal +2

YELLOW Try to wake her from the dream entirely

Yoga 3+; Roll: Charm, difficult difficulty

If it succeeds:

"If there is no child, how can there be a mother?" She looks at you with sudden, piercing clarity. Her eyes sharpen. Then, very slowly, the clarity passes into something like peace. Her form grows transparent. She smiles — genuinely — and fades. She is not here anymore.

Effects: XP 25 · Karma: God +10

If it fails:

She looks through you and resumes rocking, babbling softly to the empty rags. The dream is too strong.

Effects: XP 4 · Karma: God +2

Undertakers' Lodge hg_mercenary_lodge

A squat building of stacked bones, its door marked with crossed shovels. Inside, undead mercenaries sit sharpening weapons and arguing about pay rates with the vigor of the professionally disgruntled. A notice board covers one wall, bristling with jobs and wanted notices.

GREY Enter and look for work

Opens: Undertakers' Lodge

Karma: Human +1

GREY Check the notice board

Wanted: rolang herders to redirect a mob from the eastern fields. Reward posted by the Skeleton King's chamberlain. Two other notices offer bounties on a rogue dré that's been impersonating officials. The third is just a skeleton complaining about a debt.

Effects: XP 4 · Karma: Human +1

YELLOW Challenge a mercenary to a practice spar

Roll: Strength, normal difficulty

If it succeeds:

You hold your own — better than hold your own. The watching mercenaries go quiet in a way that means something. The sparring partner extends a hand. "Not bad for a warmie. We'll call it a draw."

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: Asura +2, Human +3

If it fails:

You lose solidly. The mercenary is professional about it. "Not bad. Keep practicing. Costs you a round though." You pay for drinks you cannot drink.

BLUE Demonstrate unarmed technique — get their attention

Requires: Unarmed 3+

You find a cleared space and run through a form — not showing off, just working. The lodge goes quiet in the particular way it gets when something unexpected is happening.

A mercenary with no visible weapons walks over and watches carefully. "Who trained you?" You talk for an hour. She introduces you to three people who turn out to be worth knowing.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: Asura +2, Human +3

BLUE Offer your fighting services — take a contract

Requires: Might 3+

Combat: Rolang Mob (normal)

The lodge master hands you a contract without ceremony. "Rolang infestation, two miles east. Standard terms." You go.

Effects: XP 10; gold moderate · Karma: Human +2

YELLOW Try to entertain the mercenaries — loosen them up

Roll: Charm, easy difficulty

If it succeeds: Recruit: a random companion from this zone

It takes a few minutes of material to break through the professional sullenness. Then one skeleton starts laughing. Then another. By the end, the lodge is rowdy and welcoming. One of the mercenaries pulls you aside afterward. "That was good. I could use a change of scene. You taking on crew?"

No cost. Karma: Human +4

If it fails:

"Do you think it's a circus, stranger? Do your business or leave before I lose patience." The lodge master points at the door. You can still browse, but everything is priced 25% higher.

The Poison Bog hg_poison_bog

Green mist clings to the surface of a bubbling swamp, hanging low and still. The water hisses faintly where it touches exposed stone. The smell is thick enough to feel.

YELLOW Move fast and hold your breath

Roll: Constitution, normal difficulty

If it succeeds:

You cross at a run, holding your breath until your lungs burn. On the far bank you spit twice and keep moving.

Effects: XP 4

If it fails:

The mist gets into you. By the time you reach the other side your hands are shaking and your vision has gone green at the edges.

BLUE Look for a path above the mist line

Requires: Awareness 14+

A raised ridge of firmer ground runs along the bog's western edge — not obvious, but there. You cross clean.

Effects: XP 7

BLUE Neutralize the bog with alchemy

Requires: Alchemy 3+

You scatter reagents into the water upstream. The reaction takes ten minutes and smells worse before it smells better. But the mist clears, and the exposed bog yields unusual materials.

Effects: XP 14; items: Item Random

BLUE Disperse the mist with air magic

Requires: Air Magic 3+

You push a wind through the bog. The mist tears and scatters. A clean path opens.

Effects: XP 10

BLUE Green mist. You have kept worse down than this.

Requires: Trait: Iron Stomach

Everyone else is retching before the halfway point and you are not, which means you are the one still capable of pulling people forward.

It is not a heroic contribution. It is the whole crossing, as it turns out.

Effects: XP 15

BLUE Seal your joints against the mist before crossing

Requires: Armor 3+

You know exactly where the mist gets in — the seams, the collar gap, the wrist joints. You seal them all before you step off solid ground. The crossing is still unpleasant but the mist finds no purchase. You arrive on the far bank clean.

Effects: XP 8

Crossbone Town hg_town_event

A settlement of the dead — bone-walled buildings, skeleton merchants, ghostly lanterns in permanent vigil. It functions. That's the remarkable thing. Guards at the gate eye you without hostility. "Weapons peace inside the walls. Break it and we break you, warmie."

GREY Visit the armorer

Opens: Crossbones Armory

Karma: Human +1

GREY Visit the local shrine

Opens: Whispering Shrine

Karma: Human +1

GREY Buy supplies

Opens: Gravedigger's Supply

Karma: Human +1

GREY Look for odd jobs

You spend a few hours moving crates for a bone merchant, delivering a message for a skeleton official who turns out to be three levels underground, and locating a mislaid femur for a very upset skeleton. You are paid in coin and the particular satisfaction of a task well done.

Effects: XP 5; gold small · Karma: Human +2

BLUE Sing in the marketplace

Requires: Performance 3+

The dead gather slowly at first, then in numbers. They stand very still in the way that means they are listening hard. When you finish, coins appear on the ground before you — more than you expected. A skeleton merchant nearby leans over:

"Come back. You're good for business."

Effects: XP 6; gold small · Karma: Human +4, God +2

YELLOW Set up at the shrine and teach about impermanence

Yoga 3+

If it succeeds:

The locals circle slowly, then stop. A crowd of skulls tips attentively as you speak. These beings know more about impermanence than most — and something in your framing reaches them. Offerings appear when you finish: food, a small pouch of coin, a health potion pressed into your hands by a skeleton with no face left to show its expression.

Effects: XP 10; gold small; items: Health Potion · Karma: God +6, Human +3

If it fails:

Nobody likes an uninvited preacher. The locals glance at you, then go back to their business. A skeleton child — or at least, a small skeleton — throws a pebble at you. You pack up.

The Ancient Battlefield hg_ancient_battlefield

Weapons jut from the earth like iron flowers — spears, swords, shafts of arrows, all corroded past use but too numerous to count. The ground is more bone than dirt. Some of the fallen still twitch between the weapons, trapped between death and something worse, unable to move on.

GREY Search the field for salvageable equipment

Combat: Bone Pack (normal)

You find something worth taking — and something finds you.

Effects: items: Item Random · Karma: Hungry Ghost +3

BLUE Consecrate the field and put the fallen to rest

Requires: White Magic 2+

You walk the length of the field, speaking the words, touching each fallen fighter with blessing. The twitching slows. Stills. The field goes quiet for the first time since before either of your lifetimes.

Effects: XP 15 · Karma: God +7, Human +3

BLUE Raise some of the fallen to fight beside you

Requires: Black Magic 3+

The words come up from somewhere old. Three fighters rise — ragged, half-formed, but battle-ready. They follow behind you with the patience of the dead, ready for the next fight.

Effects: XP 8 · Karma: Asura +4

BLUE Train among the fallen

Requires: Martial Arts 3+

The field is a library of killing techniques if you know how to read it. You practice forms between the weapons for two hours, learning from the preserved evidence of old fighters.

Effects: XP 12 · Karma: Asura +2

BLUE Meditate among the dead

Requires: Yoga 3+

"The ocean of samsara is itself a battlefield. I vow to end the battle — first inside, and eventually everywhere." The field is very quiet. The twitching figures slow. You sit with them until you feel the weight of the vow settle into something real.

Effects: XP 14 · Karma: God +7

BLUE You can read what happened here from where you are standing.

Requires: Trait: War-hardened

A line held, then folded from the left. The reserve went in late and went in wrong. Everything after that was arithmetic.

You walk the field explaining it to nobody in particular, and the party is very quiet, and at the end of it you are more of a veteran than you were that morning.

Effects: gains trait: War-hardened; XP 15

BLUE Something in that jumble is not corroded.

Requires: Trait: Sharp-eyed

Nothing here should have survived. One thing has, under a shield that fell the right way up, and it is in the condition it was in on the day.

Effects: items: Item Random; XP 15

BLUE Survey the fallen armor — read who these were

Requires: Armor 3+

You walk the field reading armor the way others read books — construction methods, battle damage, repairs, the wear patterns of years of use. Three factions, at minimum, all fighting each other. The oldest armor is local; the other two came from somewhere else.

One piece near the center shows signs of combat on all sides simultaneously. Whoever wore it died surrounded — held their ground far longer than the math suggested was possible.

Effects: XP 12 · Karma: Human +4, God +2

The Trickster hg_vetala_trickster

"Thank the gods, another living soul! This place is absolutely horrible! I've been lost for days — do you know the way to the eastern road?"

The smile is wrong. Too many teeth. Held a fraction too long.

BLUE Call it out directly

Requires: Awareness 15+

"You're a vetala." A pause. Then it laughs — genuine, delighted, not the performance from before. "Oh, finally. You have no idea how boring this is when no one notices." It drops the pretense entirely and offers you a trade. Something real, as a reward for paying attention.

Effects: XP 12; items: Item Random · Karma: Human +3

GREY Help the poor lost traveler

Combat: Vetala Pack (hard)

It leads you cheerfully around a corner, down a path, through a narrow gap — and straight into three of its friends. The smile is back. "I DID say thank the gods."

GREY Challenge it directly — no games

Combat: Vetala Scout (normal)

Karma: Asura +3

YELLOW Play along — and out-trick it

Roll: Guile, normal difficulty

If it succeeds:

You match its performance beat for beat, leading it along a route that ends with its own ambush companions confused and its stash located and emptied. It stares at you. "I... you..." A long pause. "I respect that enormously."

Effects: XP 14 · Karma: Human +2

If it fails: Combat: Vetala Pack (hard)

Your counter-play is good but not quite good enough. The smile widens into something real and dangerous.

BLUE Turn the whole thing into a bit

Requires: Comedy 3+

You compliment it extensively on its meatsuit. You ask about the tailor. You admire the not-quite-living-flesh color — very fashionable this season. You wonder aloud if it ever gets the seams adjusted.

The vetala laughs until it has to sit down. When it recovers, it presses a ring into your hand. "That's the funniest thing I've been subjected to in forty years. You're terrible. Here."

Effects: XP 12; items: Item Random · Karma: Human +4

The Drowned Temple hg_drowned_temple

Half-sunken in the black swamp, a temple's upper spire still rises above the waterline. Faded murals of bodhisattvas peer out from beneath the surface, their serene faces distorted by the water. From inside comes a sound that should not survive in this realm: the turning of a prayer wheel, still spinning after all this time.

YELLOW Swim inside

Roll: Constitution, normal difficulty

If it succeeds:

You find a chamber still half above water. The prayer wheel turns in a current you cannot feel. The murals inside are extraordinary — preserved perfectly by the dark water. You study them until you understand something new.

Effects: XP 10; items: Spell Random White · Karma: Human +3

If it fails: Combat: Bog Zombie (hard)

In the tight darkness under the water, something cold wraps around your arm.

GREY Pray from the bank — don't enter

You kneel in the grey mud and offer what you have. The prayer wheel turns inside its sunken room. Somehow, in this realm, the gesture feels heard.

Effects: XP 4 · Karma: Human +2

BLUE Part the waters and enter dry

Requires: Water Magic 3+

The water pulls back. The temple mouth opens before you, still and reverent. Inside, the murals are perfect — the water preserved them. The offerings are intact. You spend a proper hour within, taking what is offered and leaving what is owed.

Effects: XP 16; gold moderate; items: Item Random · Karma: Human +4, God +3

BLUE Salvage building materials from the accessible sections

Requires: Smithing 2+

The upper stonework is solid — old construction, well-made. You extract what you can carry without disturbing the structure below the waterline.

Effects: XP 5; items: Item Random · Karma: Animal +2

Bone Patrol hg_skeleton_patrol

Four skeletons in mismatched armor march in tight formation down a grey road. Their sergeant — distinguishable only by a dented helmet someone has polished to a painful shine — holds up a bony hand. "Halt. State your business in the King's domain."

GREY State your business honestly

"Traveler. Moving through." The sergeant looks you up and down. Nods. "Move through, then. Stay on the road." The patrol resumes its march.

Effects: XP 2 · Karma: Human +2

YELLOW Claim to be a royal emissary

Roll: Charm, easy difficulty

If it succeeds:

You speak with sufficient authority and sufficient vagueness. The sergeant salutes. "Very well. The King's emissaries have right of passage." You are escorted, somewhat against your will, all the way to the next waypoint.

Effects: XP 8 · Karma: Human +2

If it fails: Combat: Skeleton Patrol (normal)

The sergeant's empty sockets narrow. "We have no record of any emissary today. Seize them."

Karma: Asura +2

BLUE Show your trader's credentials

Requires: Trade 3+

Merchants of standing move freely in the Skeleton King's domain. The sergeant examines your credentials with unexpected care, nods, and waves you on. "Nearest market town is north. The road is clear today."

Effects: XP 5 · Karma: Human +2

YELLOW "Who truly knows their business in this world of dreams?"

Yoga 3+; Roll: Charm, normal difficulty

If it succeeds:

The sergeant goes still. The others exchange glances. A long pause. "Go on your way, yogi." They step aside.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: Human +4

If it fails: Combat: Skeleton Patrol (normal)

"Don't try messing with my head, stranger."

Karma: Asura +2

GREY Attack the patrol

Combat: Skeleton Patrol (normal)

Karma: Asura +4

Forgotten Shrine hg_forgotten_shrine

A small roadside shrine, half-buried in grey dust. The offering bowl is empty. The carved face of the deity has worn smooth — you cannot tell who it once depicted. It could be anyone. It could be no one.

GREY Leave an offering

Cost: Gold (small)

You place coins in the bowl and press your palms together. Whoever this was, someone carved this stone and set it here. That deserves acknowledgment.

Effects: XP 4 · Karma: God +5

BLUE Restore the shrine properly

Requires: Smithing 2+

You re-level the base, clear the dust from the carvings, and shore up the crumbling back. You can't recover the face, but the structure stands again with purpose. Someone will see it.

Effects: XP 14 · Karma: God +8, Human +2

BLUE Meditate before it

Requires: Yoga 3+

You settle into stillness and the shrine's history comes in fragments. Among them: a vision of the bodhisattva once depicted here — the one whose name means Womb of the Earth, who comes to this bleak realm to patiently teach and feed the ever-hungry dead. The face that has worn away is still present somehow.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: God +4, Human +3

BLUE Half-buried is not the same as finished.

Requires: Trait: Pilgrim

You dig it out. It takes an hour and ruins a pair of gloves and reveals that the offering bowl is not empty — it was buried full, which means somebody left in a hurry and meant to come back.

Effects: XP 20; gold small · Karma: God +3, Human +2

GREY Take the offering bowl — it's well-made

Finely carved stone, old work. It fits in your pack. The shrine looks wrong without it.

Effects: items: Item Random · Karma: Hungry Ghost +4

The Horde

 hg_rolang_horde

The ground trembles. Over the ridge, a mass of rolangs shuffles forward — dozens, maybe hundreds. Not aggressive, just moving. A tide of the mindless dead flowing toward something far away, unfortunately seemingly unaware of a village lying directly in their path.

GREY Get out of the way and let them pass

You press yourself against a rock wall and wait. The tide takes ten minutes to pass. The village on the far side of the hill has no idea what's coming.

Effects: XP 3 · Karma: Animal +2

BLUE Herd them away from the village

Requires: Leadership 3+

You work the edges of the horde, using presence and sound to nudge the direction of hundreds of shuffling dead. It takes an hour and every ounce of focus you have. But the horde turns, flowing away from the village and into empty wasteland.

Effects: XP 20 · Karma: Human +5, God +4

GREY Stand your ground**Combat: Rolang Mob (hard)**

Karma: Asura +3

BLUE Guide the horde with your spear — use reach to steer them

Requires: Spears 3+

You work the edges of the horde with your spear horizontal, using reach and presence to deflect the outermost rolangs. The mindless dead respond to obstacle and pressure — they don't fight back, they just redirect. Your leverage at the flank shifts the whole column gradually, like guiding a slow river.

It takes two hours and the spear gets heavy. But the horde turns, and the village is no longer in its path.

Effects: XP 16 · Karma: Human +4, God +3

BLUE Follow them — see where they're going

Requires: Awareness 13+

You trail them at a distance. Hours pass. They converge on a vast pit, an old mass grave, and begin to circle it in an endless loop. Something in the earth is pulling them home. You watch for a long time, learning more about this realm than you wanted to know.

Effects: XP 18

The Alchemist hg_alchemist_camp

A dré — a bodiless ghost inhabiting a suit of robes stuffed with dried herbs — floats above a bubbling cauldron. Jars of questionable substances line makeshift shelves carved from bone. It turns as you approach.

"Customer or ingredient?" it asks cheerfully.

GREY Browse what it has for sale

Opens: The Dré Herbalist

Karma: Human +1

BLUE Offer to help with the brewing

Requires: Alchemy 3+

The dré is delighted to have a competent hand. You work together for an hour over the cauldron, and what emerges is something neither of you could have made alone.

Effects: XP 12; items: Item Random · Karma: Human +2

BLUE Ask what's in the cauldron

Requires: Medicine 2+

The ingredients are unusual — some things that work differently in this realm than in the living world. The dré explains patiently, and you come away with a recipe that shouldn't work but does.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: Human +2

GREY Knock the cauldron over

Combat: Charnel Wraith (normal)

The cauldron hits the ground with a sound like a scream. The dré's cheerful demeanor evaporates instantly.

Karma: Asura +4

The Bone Pit hg_bone_arena_event

A circular pit ringed with skull-topped posts. Skeletons sit in the stands, clicking their jaws in anticipation. A skeleton announcer with an elaborate wig of woven hair calls out over the crowd: "Fresh meat! Who wants to test the newcomer?"

GREY Step into the pit

Combat: Skeleton Warrior (normal)

The crowd clacks with approval.

Effects: XP 10; gold moderate · Karma: Asura +2

YELLOW Bet on a fight instead

Roll: Luck, normal difficulty · Cost: Gold (moderate)

If it succeeds:

The underdog wins in a way no one predicted. You collect double.

Effects: gold moderate

If it fails:

The favorite wins. Of course it does.

Karma: Hungry Ghost +2

BLUE Demand to fight the champion directly

Requires: Strength 15+

Combat: Skeleton Elite (hard)

The announcer's wig falls off from excitement. The crowd goes silent.

Effects: XP 18; gold large; items: Item Random · Karma: Asura +3

YELLOW Work the crowd as an entertainer instead

Roll: Performance, normal difficulty

If it succeeds:

You become the entertainment. The skeletons appreciate variety. Tips rain down from the stands — mostly coins, occasionally something that used to be a coin.

Effects: XP 8; gold small · Karma: Human +3

If it fails:

Booing. A rib bone bounces off your head. The announcer wags a finger: "Not what they came for, friend."

BLUE There is money moving in those tiers.

Requires: Trait: Gambler

There is, and the odds are being set by someone who has not watched the third fighter closely enough.

You have. You bet accordingly and collect with a straight face.

Effects: gold small; XP 15

BLUE You are not going to sit in the tiers.

Requires: Trait: Duelist

You were never going to sit in the tiers. You are over the rail before the current bout has finished and the crowd's noise changes shape.

It is close. You win it, barely, and the barely is what they will remember.

Effects: XP 30; gold small; HP loss (light, random)

BLUE Propose an archery contest as an alternative spectacle

Requires: Ranged 3+

The announcer considers with a long click of its jaw. 'Unusual. We have never done that.' A pause. 'We will try it.'

Targets are assembled from spare ribs and skulls with remarkable speed. The contest draws a crowd intrigued by novelty.

You hit every target cleanly. The skeletons are not sure if they like this more or less than combat — but they are watching.

The gold reflects the attendance.

Effects: XP 10; gold moderate · Karma: Human +3, Asura +1

Ghost Lights hg_ghost_light

Pale blue flames dance above the swamp surface, drifting slowly deeper into the mire. They're beautiful, and clearly a trap. Yet they seem to be leading somewhere specific, with unusual purpose.

YELLOW Follow them carefully

Roll: Awareness, normal difficulty

If it succeeds:

The lights lead you on a winding path through the mire and stop above a half-sunken object — a cache, wrapped in oilcloth, wedged between the roots of a dead tree.

Effects: XP 6; gold moderate; items: Item Random

If it fails:

The lights lead you off solid ground. You sink to your waist in mire before managing to haul yourself free, filthy, somewhat injured, and deeply unimpressed.

GREY Ignore them and walk on

You watch them drift away into the dark. Wise, probably.

BLUE Speak to them through fire

Requires: Fire Magic 2+

The lights pause, then pulse in response. They're souls, not traps — trapped here by the same forces that trap all things in this realm. They show you a safe path through the mire in gratitude for being seen.

Effects: XP 10; items: Item Random · Karma: God +4, Human +2

BLUE Extinguish the lights — free them

Requires: Water Magic 2+

You reach out with the spell and the lights go out one by one. Not dramatically — gently, like candles at the end of a long evening. Whatever they were, they are done now.

Effects: XP 12 · Karma: God +5

The Old Guard hg_veterans_camp_event

A fortified camp — real fortifications, not the improvised sort. These undead soldiers maintain discipline, run drills, keep watch rotations. A grizzled skeleton missing half its ribcage sits by the fire cleaning a weapon it will probably never use again.

"We remember what we were. That's more than most here can say."

GREY Enter the camp

Opens: The Old Guard

Karma: Human +1

BLUE Ask for a sparring session

Requires: Swords 3+; Axes 3+; Maces 3+

They train you the way they trained soldiers — without ceremony, without encouragement, with complete focus. You come out of it tired and considerably more capable.

Effects: XP 14 · Karma: Asura +2, Human +2

GREY Share news from the living world

They gather around you. You tell them about roads and cities and the way the light looks in the morning. They listen with the complete attention of beings who have been starved of new information for a very long time.

Effects: XP 5 · Karma: Human +4

YELLOW Challenge their best fighter

Roll: Strength, normal difficulty

If it succeeds:

You win. Narrowly. The grizzled skeleton nods once — the highest praise available in this camp — and hands you a weapon from its own collection.

Effects: XP 16; items: Item Random · Karma: Asura +3, Human +2

If it fails:

You lose solidly. The camp watches in respectful silence. The grizzled skeleton helps you up. "Come back when you're ready."

Effects: XP 5 · Karma: Human +3

BLUE Assert field command — suggest a redeployment

Requires: Leadership 3+

You study the camp's layout and defensive positioning before saying anything. Then you lay out a redeployment — one that accounts for the patterns you've observed in this realm, the cover the terrain offers, the direction of the usual threats. The grizzled skeleton is quiet for a long time.

'Show me on the map.'

You work together for an hour. Their defensive position improves considerably. They give you something from the supply cache in recognition — not payment, but acknowledgment.

Effects: XP 16; items: Item Random · Karma: Asura +2, Human +4

The River of Tears hg_crying_river

A river of black water flows silently through the wasteland. The surface ripples with faces — the crying dead, trapped in the current. A ferryman waits on the bank, pole in hand. He is enormous. He is silent. He has been waiting here for a very long time.

GREY Pay for passage

Cost: Gold (small)

The ferryman accepts without looking at you and poles across in silence. The faces in the water follow your progress with eyes that remember hope.

YELLOW Swim across — save the gold

Roll: Constitution, normal difficulty

If it succeeds:

The current is strong and the water thick. You make it across with teeth clenched and nothing left.

Effects: XP 4

If it fails:

The faces pull at you, curious or desperate. You go under twice before the current spits you out downstream, bruised and shaking.

BLUE Speak to the faces in the water

Requires: Black Magic 3+

You reach into the current with dark working and the faces turn toward you, speaking in voices like water over stone. They tell you things about this realm that aren't written anywhere. The lore is old and the weight of it stays with you.

Effects: XP 16; gains trait: Grief-struck · Karma: God +4

BLUE You have heard this note before, from the inside.

Requires: Trait: Melancholic

The faces are not saying anything. That is what everyone gets wrong — they assume the sound is speech.

It is not. You know exactly what it is, and you sit on the bank with it for a while, and the ferryman waits without complaint, because he has seen this before too.

Effects: XP 15; mind: Water +8

BLUE Offer to help pole the raft

Requires: Might 3+

The ferryman looks at you for the first time — properly looks, as if assessing something. Then steps aside and hands you the pole. You work in silence side by side. When you reach the far bank, he nods once. You have the sense this will be remembered.

Effects: XP 8 · Karma: Human +4, God +2

The Sorcerer's Court hg_gyelpo_court

A ruined palace, still grand in its decay. A gyelpo — a dead sorcerer of terrible power — holds court here, attended by bound spirits drifting in slow orbits. He turns as you enter without being told you'd arrived.

"I ruled then and I rule now. What makes you think I'd stop for something as trivial as dying?"

GREY Pay your respects formally

The gyelpo is pleased by the form, if not the visitor. He waves a hand and the bound spirits clear a path. "You may pass. Tell no one what you saw here."

Karma: Human +2

BLUE Request a formal audience

Requires: Charm 14+

He grants it. The negotiation takes time — he thinks in decades, not minutes — but eventually yields something valuable. A name, a technique, a piece of knowledge that should not have survived him.

Effects: XP 16; items: Spell Random · Karma: Human +3

GREY Challenge his authority

Combat: Corpse Sorcerer (hard)

The bound spirits stop their orbiting and turn inward.

Karma: Asura +4

BLUE The court notices you before you have said anything.

Requires: Trait: Attractive

It does, and the gyelpo — dead some centuries and still vain about his hall — decides that you improve the room.

You are seated well above where a traveller is seated, which is useful, and watched throughout, which is not.

Effects: XP 15

BLUE Offer him magical knowledge in exchange

Requires: Focus 15+

He leans forward for the first time. What you offer genuinely interests him — not for its power but because it is new, and almost nothing is new to him anymore. He gives back more than you gave.

Effects: XP 18; items: Spell Random · Karma: Human +3

The Fungal Grove hg_fungal_grove

Enormous mushrooms grow from the bodies of the dead, some taller than trees. The air is thick with spores. There is a sound underneath the silence — soft, irregular, buzzing — and when you listen closely you seem to hear melodies within it. Call and response, echoing somewhere in the mycelium.

BLUE Harvest the mushrooms carefully

Requires: Alchemy 2+

Unusual reagents — things with properties you haven't seen in living-world fungi. This place grows something new.

Effects: XP 8; items: Item Random · Karma: Human +2

BLUE Stop and listen properly

Requires: Awareness 14+

You sit very still and let the sound find you. The fungi are sharing memories of the dead they grow from — and their own nature as something new, a collective being beyond ego and egolessness, not just the dead and not just the fungus, but an amalgam that has grown past both. Something in this troubles the assumptions you arrived with.

Effects: XP 20 · Karma: God +6

YELLOW Move through quickly, hold your breath

Roll: Constitution, easy difficulty

If it succeeds:

You make it through without breathing more than necessary. The buzzing fades behind you.

If it fails:

The spores get in. The world becomes very interesting for a while.

Karma: Animal +2

GREY Burn a path through

The mushrooms burn poorly and smell terrible. You get through. The melodies stop.

Effects: XP 3 · Karma: Hell +3

The Dead King's Warband hg_dralha_warband

A dralha — an undead warrior-king — rides at the head of a column of skeleton soldiers. Banners of a forgotten kingdom snap in the memory of a wind that doesn't blow anymore. The dralha raises a gauntleted fist and the column halts.

"You. You have the look of a fighter."

GREY Accept a commission

Combat: Rolang Mob (normal)

"Against the rolang horde to the east. Standard terms." It pays.

Effects: XP 10; gold moderate · Karma: Asura +3

BLUE Decline — without giving offense

Requires: Charm 13+

"Different roads," you say. The dralha studies you for a moment, then lowers its fist. "Fair enough. Ride on."

Effects: XP 4 · Karma: Human +3

GREY Challenge the dralha itself

Combat: Skeleton Elite (very_hard)

The column watches in absolute silence. This is going to be talked about.

Effects: XP 25; items: Item Random · Karma: Asura +4

BLUE Offer tactical intelligence instead of service

Requires: Learning 3+

You share what you know about the terrain ahead and the rolang movements you've observed. The dralha listens with the attention of someone who has fought a thousand battles and knows useful information when it hears it.

Effects: XP 12 · Karma: Human +3

BLUE Speak to it as a peer commander

Requires: Leadership 3+

You don't ask permission and you don't defer — you address it the way one field commander addresses another, with the specific confidence of someone who has made the same decisions under worse conditions.

The dralha reads this immediately. Its posture shifts — not submission, but respect.

"Where are you headed?" You tell it. "The southern route is safer. We cleared it two days ago." It turns the column without further words.

You have, without planning to, just exchanged tactical intelligence with an undead warlord. Both parties leave better informed.

Effects: XP 14 · Karma: Human +4, Asura +2

BLUE Fall in with the column — present yourself as infantry

Requires: Spears 3+

Combat: Rolang Mob (easy)

You fall in with the column, spear at the correct angle, march at the correct pace. The column incorporates you without ceremony. The brief engagement at the far side of the patrol route goes quickly with the warband behind you.

Effects: XP 10; gold moderate · Karma: Asura +3, Human +1

The Whispering Bones hg_whispering_bones

Scattered bones on the ground begin to whisper as you pass. Each one holds a fragment of memory — a name, a regret, a last wish. The whispers grow louder the longer you stay.

GREY Sit and listen to all of them

You sit for a long time. The stories come in fragments — none complete, all real. You learn the names of people no one else remembers.

Effects: XP 8 · Karma: God +5

BLUE Perform a bone-gathering ceremony

Requires: Ritual 3+

The ceremony takes an hour. You arrange the bones with care, speak the names as you collect them, give the fragments the dignity they were denied. The whispering quiets into something that might be gratitude.

Effects: XP 14 · Karma: God +6

YELLOW Block out the sound and push through

Roll: Focus, easy difficulty

If it succeeds:

You hold the silence inside yourself and walk through the noise. It doesn't touch you.

If it fails:

The whispers find the gaps in your concentration and settle in. Something heavy lingers in your mind.

BLUE Speak their names aloud — give them voice

Requires: Black Magic 3+

As you speak each name, something answers. The bones whisper back differently — with direction, with purpose. There is something hidden nearby that they want you to find.

Effects: XP 12; items: Item Random; gold small · Karma: God +3

YELLOW Call them back — all of them at once

Black Magic 3+; Roll: Focus, normal difficulty

If it succeeds: Recruit: Iron Oath

The bones rise and coalesce — dozens of fragments assembling into something massive. It looks at you with eyes made of hollow sockets and memory. Then, slowly, it kneels.

No cost. Karma: Asura +3

If it fails: Combat: Bone Horror (hard)

The bones rise. But whatever you called, it is not taking orders.

Karma: Hell +3

The Charnel Sorcerer hg_chnel_sorcerer_event

In a cave hung with bones and dried entrails, a vetala sorcerer works rituals by the light of candles made from human fat. It turns at your footstep with an expression of genuine pleasure.

"I don't get many visitors. Most find the décor off-putting. Can't imagine why."

GREY Browse what it has to offer

Opens: Charnel Sorcerer

Karma: Human +1

BLUE Ask about the advanced workings

Requires: Black Magic 3+

It tells you things that are not in the books. Things about what persists after death, what can be moved and where, what the dead remember that the living cannot access. You come away changed.

Effects: XP 16 · Karma: Asura +2

BLUE Trade spell components

Requires: Alchemy 3+

You lay out your reagents. It picks through them with practiced fingers, setting things aside, weighing others. What you receive in exchange is stranger and more potent.

Effects: XP 8; items: Item Random, Item Random

GREY Disrupt the ritual — shut this down

Combat: Corpse Sorcerer (very_hard)

The vetala's pleasant expression disappears. What's underneath is considerably less friendly.

Effects: XP 20 · Karma: Asura +4

The Lost Caravan hg_lost_caravan

Overtaken carts and scattered goods. The caravan guards are dead — properly so. Something attacked them recently. Tracks lead into the swamp. The goods are still here, undisturbed by the local dead.

GREY Take what you can carry

You work quickly, taking the most valuable things. The dead guards don't object.

Effects: items: Item Random; gold moderate · Karma: Hungry Ghost +4

BLUE Search for survivors

Requires: Medicine 2+

There — breathing, barely, under an overturned crate. The wound is serious but survivable if treated now. You work fast.

Effects: XP 14 · Karma: God +5, Human +4

BLUE Track whatever did this

Requires: Awareness 13+

Combat: Carrion Flock (normal)

The tracks are fresh. You follow them into the swamp and find the attackers still circling their kill.

Effects: XP 10; items: Item Random; gold small · Karma: Asura +2

BLUE Bury the dead properly

Requires: Ritual 3+

You leave the goods untouched and dig. It takes time. When you finish, the site looks less like a disaster and more like a grave. You say what should be said.

Effects: XP 12 · Karma: God +6

The Mirror Pool hg_mirror_pool

A pool of perfectly still, perfectly clear water in the middle of the wasteland. Impossible here. It shows not your reflection but something else — a past life, a death, something that might be a future.

GREY Look into the pool

The vision comes without asking for it. You see the realms ordered by what you've built — the highest first, the lowest last. No numbers. Just the weight of things.

Effects: XP 8

YELLOW Drink from it

Roll: Constitution, normal difficulty

If it succeeds:

The water tastes like memory. Something sharpens in you.

Effects: XP 6; gains trait: Haunted

If it fails:

The visions come faster than you can process them. You sit by the pool for a long time before you can stand again.

BLUE Meditate beside it

Requires: Yoga 3+

You sit with the visions rather than fighting them. The pool shows you the cycle — not as horror, but as mechanism. Something in the understanding frees a knot you didn't know was there.

Effects: XP 20; gains trait: Clear-eyed · Karma: God +7

BLUE Of course you are going to look.

Requires: Trait: Vain

You look. It shows you accurately, which is the cruelty of it — not distorted, not aged, simply seen from outside for the first time.

You are quiet for some hours afterwards and decline to say why.

Effects: XP 18; mind: Earth -12

GREY Shatter the surface

You throw a stone. The vision breaks into ripples. Something lifts. Something else wonders if you were ready to stop looking.

Effects: XP 4 · Karma: Human +3, Hungry Ghost -2

The Hunters hg_shaza_ambush

A shaza pack has been tracking you — body-snatching predators that crave living flesh above all else. You spot them circling at the same moment they realize you've noticed. The circling tightens.

GREY Stand and fight

Combat: Undead Convergence (normal)

Karma: Asura +2

BLUE Lure them into a kill zone

Requires: Guile 3+

Combat: Undead Convergence (easy)

You choose your ground carefully, then let them come to you on your terms.

Effects: XP 6 · Karma: Asura +2

YELLOW Get above them — high ground

Roll: Finesse, difficult difficulty

If it succeeds:

You scramble up a bone-pile before they close the distance. From up here you're outside their preferred engagement range. They mill about below, and eventually give up.

Effects: XP 6

If it fails: Combat: Undead Convergence (hard)

Not fast enough. They hit you from behind as you climb.

YELLOW Play dead

Roll: Guile, normal difficulty

If it succeeds:

You go down convincingly and stay down. They sniff around you, confused. Their hunger is for living flesh — and yours, for the moment, doesn't smell like it. They drift on.

Effects: XP 8; gains trait: Harrowed

If it fails: Combat: Undead Convergence (hard)

They're not fooled. And they go for you first because you're already on the ground.

BLUE Confuse them with a quick act of ventriloquism

Requires: Comedy 3+

You produce a small doll from your pack and throw your voice into it, sending the shaza into baffled circles trying to locate the sound. While they mill in confusion, you walk briskly in the other direction.

Effects: XP 12 · Karma: Human +3

BLUE Pick off the hunters as they close — surgical precision

Requires: Daggers 3+

You wait for the lead shaza to enter knife range, drop it cleanly, and move through the pack targeting vital points. The rest of them scatter when they realize what's happening — they hunt in groups because they have to, and a group suddenly three smaller is no longer a group with confidence.

You walk on. The survivors do not follow.

Effects: XP 14 · Karma: Asura +3

BLUE You heard them a while ago. You have been waiting.

Requires: Trait: War-hardened

You picked it up two hundred paces back — not a sound, a shape of silence in the wrong place — and you have spent the walk since arranging where everyone is standing.

When it comes, it comes into a formation rather than a column.

Effects: XP 15

BLUE Keep them at range — shoot them down before they close

Requires: Ranged 3+

You back up to maintain distance and start shooting — not panicked, but methodical, picking the ones moving to flank first. The shaza are confident close-in hunters and terrible at range. You stay outside their distance and well within yours.

They figure this out on the third volley and decide you are not worth the cost.

Effects: XP 12 · Karma: Asura +2

The Singing Skull hg_singing_skull

A skull sits atop a cairn of stones, humming a melody. When you approach, its jaw opens wider: "Oh! A listener! I used to be a bard, you know. Died mid-song. Very embarrassing. Would you like to hear how it ends?"

GREY Listen to the song

It's actually beautiful. The skull has had a long time to get the ending right. Something about the melody lingers with you long after you leave.

Effects: XP 6 · Karma: Human +4

YELLOW Sing along

Roll: Performance, normal difficulty

If it succeeds:

You find the harmony. The skull stops mid-phrase and stares. "Oh," it says softly. "Oh, that's exactly it. That's exactly what was missing." The duet locks together and the song completes. Something resonates.

Effects: XP 14 · Karma: Human +4, God +2

If it fails:

Off-key. The skull is politely disappointed but thanks you for trying. "Not everyone has it. That's what makes it special."

Effects: XP 3 · Karma: Human +2

GREY Ask how it died

"Mid-performance. Big crowd. I was just getting to the good bit." A pause. "I've had time to work out whether it was tragic or funny. I've decided it was both."

Effects: XP 4 · Karma: Human +3

BLUE It has a song. Trade it one.

Requires: Trait: Storyteller

You give it something long with a good middle, and it listens the whole way through without humming over you, which for a skull on a cairn is close to reverence.

What it gives back is not a song. It is directions, sung, and they are accurate.

Effects: XP 20

BLUE Offer to carry it to an audience

Requires: Comedy 3+

The skull goes very still. Then: "You're serious." Then: "YES." It settles into your pack with enormous dignity, humming quietly. Its commentary on your journey turns out to be worth hearing.

Effects: XP 10; items: Item Random · Karma: Human +5

The Mass Grave hg_mass_grave

The ground sinks under your feet. You realize you're standing on a mass burial site — hundreds, maybe thousands of dead from some forgotten catastrophe. The earth pulses with dark energy.

GREY Leave immediately

Some places don't want to be investigated. You respect that.

YELLOW Investigate carefully

Roll: Awareness, normal difficulty

If it succeeds:

You move slowly, reading the ground. There — a corner of something preserved, protected by the sheer density of death around it. Burial goods from someone important.

Effects: XP 8; gold moderate; items: Item Random

If it fails: Combat: Rolang Mob (normal)

Your foot goes through the soil into something that moves. Then several things move.

BLUE Consecrate the site

Requires: White Magic 3+

The undertaking takes everything you have. The pulse of dark energy fights you for an hour before it yields. When it's done, the ground is quiet for the first time since the catastrophe that filled it. This will matter to someone, somewhere, even if you never know who.

Effects: XP 30; gains trait: Merciful · Karma: God +10, Human +4

BLUE You are already carrying one. What is a thousand more.

Requires: Trait: Grief-struck

It is not the same, and you know it is not the same, and you kneel anyway because the difference is not the point. Something in the ground eases. Not much. The amount you would expect one person's attention to be worth.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Water +10 · Karma: Hungry Ghost -6

BLUE Channel the dark energy

Requires: Black Magic 3+

You open yourself to it and let it move through you. It is vast and old and full of a specific kind of knowledge. What you learn cannot be unlearned.

Effects: XP 18; items: Spell Random Black; gains trait: Blood-handed · Karma: Hungry Ghost +5

The Skeleton King of the Setting Sun hg_skeleton_king

A city of bone — towers of fused ribcages, walls of skulls, gates of pelvis and shoulder blade. On a throne of vertebrae sits the Skeleton King, crowned with a circlet of hammered copper. His eye sockets burn with cold intelligence. Rings of copper, gold, and ruby decorate his fingers and exposed ribs.

"All the dead pass through my kingdom eventually."

GREY Kneel and request an audience**Combat: Rolang Mob (normal)**

He's amused. "Clear the infestation to the east and you may pass freely." Simple enough.

Effects: XP 12; gold moderate · Karma: Human +2

BLUE Challenge his authority — formally

Requires: Strength 16+; Charm 14+

Combat: Skeleton King Duel (boss)

He rises from his throne for the first time in years. The court goes absolutely still. "Then let us see." The battle ends when he reaches ten percent — he stops it himself. "Enough. You have proven your right."

Effects: XP 40; items: Item Random · Karma: Asura +4

BLUE Offer him magical knowledge

Requires: Focus 16+

He listens with unexpected patience. What you offer is genuinely rare. He gives back something equally rare.

Effects: XP 20; items: Spell Random · Karma: Human +3

GREY Bow and take your leave

No shame in discretion. He watches you go with what might be respect.

Effects: XP 4 · Karma: Human +2

BLUE Offer a song of praise in lieu of tribute

Requires: Performance 3+

"I am a poor traveler. But I will offer my only treasure — my voice." He leans back. The court goes still. You sing. When it's over, he reaches into his robes and extends a trinket and a small purse. "An unusual currency. But acceptable."

Effects: XP 14; gold small; items: Item Random · Karma: Human +4

BLUE Offer a puja in his honor

Requires: Ritual 3+

You set up the offering with care — the correct order, the correct words, nothing improvised. The Skeleton King watches every detail. When you finish, something in his bearing has shifted. He teaches you something from his own practice.

Effects: XP 16; items: Spell Random · Karma: Human +3, God +3

The Elder of the Charnel Grounds hg_vetala_elder

Deep in the charnel grounds, where the bone-fires burn highest, you find her — a vetala so old her skin has turned to parchment, her eyes like oil lamps. She sits on a throne of piled corpses, surrounded by offerings brought by lesser vetalas.

"I have eaten the memories of ten thousand dead. Ask me anything. And remember — everything has a price."

BLUE Ask about the nature of death

Requires: Awareness 13+

"Death is a trick of perception. There was never a separate, singular body that lived and then died. The minuscule creatures in your gut have not noticed any change." She pauses. "There was never a separate person. Nobody was born and nobody died."

Effects: XP 18 · Karma: God +7

BLUE Ask about the nature of the world

Requires: Learning 3+

"All worlds are the same. They arise out of the potential of the void, driven by the expectations of sentient beings. Here, you see a world of thirst. A Buddha sees a garden ripe with possibility."

Effects: XP 18 · Karma: God +6

BLUE Ask about liberation

Requires: Yoga 3+

She is quiet for a long time. Then: "Who will be liberated? From where? To where?" Another pause. "Keep dreaming, child. As long as you want."

Effects: XP 18 · Karma: God +7

GREY Ask for power

She smiles for the first time. "Now that is the honest question." She names a price: something permanent, something significant, and something that will follow you across lives. Whether the exchange is worth it is entirely up to you.

Karma: Hungry Ghost +8

BLUE Offer her a memory from the living world

Requires: Charm 15+

She goes still as you speak. Something behind the oil-lamp eyes flickers — surprise, perhaps, or something that was once longing. "I have not tasted a living memory in centuries." She gives you something in return that only she could give.

Effects: XP 20; items: Spell Random Black · Karma: God +4

GREY Strike while her attention is elsewhere**Combat: Vetala Elder Court (very_hard)**

She does not look up. "I wondered when you'd try that." The court rises.

Effects: XP 30; gold large; items: Item Random · Karma: Hell +5, Asura +4

The Golden Sage hg_golden_skeleton_sage

A skeleton of gleaming gold sits beneath a withered bodhi tree, radiating calm. Other skeletons give it a wide berth — not from fear, but from reverence. It does not speak first. It waits.

"You carry the weight of many lives. Would you like to set some of it down?"

BLUE Accept teaching

Requires: Yoga 3+

The teaching is brief and exact. It goes directly to something you have been carrying and shows you how you've been carrying it wrong.

Effects: XP 22; gains trait: Touched by Grace · Karma: God +8

GREY Ask about the golden skeletons

"Compassion doesn't disappear when the body does. It goes somewhere." It gestures at itself. "Here, apparently."

Effects: XP 6 · Karma: Human +3

GREY Ask for healing

It places a hand on you without ceremony. The damage recedes. The exhaustion behind it recedes too, which is rarer.

Effects: XP 4 · Karma: Human +3

BLUE Ask to learn healing magic

Requires: Awareness 14+

It teaches without preamble. What it shows you is not complex — simplicity is the whole point of it.

Effects: XP 14; items: Spell Random White · Karma: God +4

The Turquoise Dancers hg_turquoise_dancers

A troupe of turquoise skeletons in rainbow skirts and flower headdresses dances in a circle, rattling and clacking in joyful rhythm. They notice you and beckon.

"Dance with us! What is the use of worrying here?"

YELLOW Join the dance

Roll: Finesse, easy difficulty

If it succeeds:

You find the rhythm and it carries you. When the song ends, a turquoise hand presses something into yours — a trinket worn smooth by dancing fingers.

Effects: XP 14; items: Item Random · Karma: Human +5

If it fails:

You trip over your own feet. The dancers catch you, clacking with laughter. They dance around your embarrassment until it becomes part of the performance.

Effects: XP 14 · Karma: Human +4

BLUE Play music for them

Requires: Performance 3+

The dance transforms around your music. Skeleton audience members appear from nowhere, clacking appreciatively. Coins rain down.

Effects: XP 16; gold small · Karma: Human +5

GREY Ask why they dance

The nearest dancer stops and looks at you with an expression that somehow works without a face. "Why don't you?"

Effects: XP 4 · Karma: Human +3

GREY Decline politely

They wave goodbye with genuine warmth. The music follows you for a while.

Karma: Animal +1, Human +2

BLUE They are enjoying themselves. Join in.

Requires: Trait: Celebrant

You are terrible at it. This turns out to be entirely beside the point — the troupe's delight is not in the standard of the dancing but in the fact of somebody dancing.

You come away with flowers in your hair and, for some hours, the inability to be gloomy about the hungry ghost realm.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Air +15, Fire +10

BLUE Join them fully — dance and make them laugh

Requires: Comedy 2+

You throw yourself in completely — dancing, mugging, making art of your own clumsiness. The troupe loves every second of it. When you finally stop, breathless, they press a trinket into your hands with both skeletal fists.

Effects: XP 18; items: Item Random · Karma: Human +6

The Iron Challenger hg_iron_skeleton_duel

An iron skeleton stands at a crossroads, sword driven into the ground before it. A sign reads: DEFEAT ME AND PASS. LOSE AND SERVE. It has clearly been here a very long time. The paint on the sign is old. The skeleton is patient.

GREY Accept the duel

Combat: Skeleton Elite (normal)

It pulls the sword from the ground and takes its stance.

Effects: XP 12; items: Item Random · Karma: Asura +2

BLUE Find the logical flaw in its oath

Requires: Learning 3+

You point out the ambiguity in the oath's wording — technically, the requirement is already fulfilled by the act of being challenged. The skeleton freezes mid-reach for its sword. You can hear it processing. You walk past at a measured pace.

Effects: XP 14 · Karma: Human +4

YELLOW Persuade it that the oath no longer serves

Roll: Persuasion, normal difficulty

If it succeeds:

You speak to it about the nature of oaths — not their letter but their purpose. What was it protecting? Is the thing it was protecting still here? The iron skeleton stands for a long time. Then it lowers its sword. Something releases in its posture.

Effects: XP 16 · Karma: Human +5

If it fails: Combat: Skeleton Elite (hard)

"My oath is not a matter for debate." It draws.

Karma: Asura +2

BLUE Offer to take its place

Requires: Charm 15+

"I'll stand here. You've done enough." The iron skeleton goes very still. Then, slowly, it pulls the sword from the ground and holds it out to you. Its posture as it walks away is the lightest you've seen anything move in this realm.

Effects: XP 20; items: Item Random · Karma: God +6

BLUE Fight unarmed — use joint locks and throws

Requires: Unarmed 3+

Combat: Skeleton Elite (easy)

You cross your arms over your chest and bow, empty-handed. The iron skeleton looks at you for a long moment. Then it accepts the terms. What follows is not a sword fight.

Effects: XP 14; items: Item Random · Karma: Asura +3, Human +2

BLUE Smash its sword arm — end the fight before it starts

Requires: Maces 3+

Combat: Skeleton Elite (easy)

Your first move is not a block — it's a strike at the wrist holding the sword. Iron on iron. The skeleton stumbles back, sword arm compromised. The duel continues, but on your terms now.

Effects: XP 14 · Karma: Asura +3

BLUE A sword in the ground at a crossroads is a sentence with one ending.

Requires: Trait: Duelist

You draw before it has finished standing up, which it takes as the courtesy it was intended to be.

The iron skeleton is better than you in three respects and worse in one, and the one is enough.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Fire +10

BLUE Fight at reach — keep it off its blade advantage

Requires: Spears 3+

Combat: Skeleton Elite (easy)

The iron skeleton has a short sword. You have a spear. The reach disparity matters more than the skill gap. You manage distance and let it exhaust itself against your range.

Effects: XP 12 · Karma: Asura +2

The Copper Mirror hg_copper_mirror

A copper skeleton sits polishing an enormous mirror of burnished copper. The mirror shows not reflections but truths — the viewer sees themselves as they truly are.

"Most can't bear it," the skeleton says, without looking up. "Can you?"

YELLOW Look into the mirror

Roll: Awareness, difficult difficulty

If it succeeds:

You look. What you see is not flattering and not damning — it is accurate. You stand with it until the accuracy becomes useful.

Effects: XP 16 · Karma: God +6

If it fails:

You look. What you see is too much. You look away after a moment, unsettled in a way that takes time to settle back.

GREY Ask the skeleton about itself

"I was a judge. In life, I showed people their crimes. In death, I show them themselves. It is the same work." It resumes polishing.

Effects: XP 4 · Karma: Human +3

GREY Smash the mirror

Combat: Skeleton Warrior (normal)

The skeleton sets down its cloth. The mirror reforms before the fight is over.

Karma: Hungry Ghost +4, Hell +3

GREY Sit and polish it together

You work in companionable silence. The mirror grows brighter. The skeleton nods when you finish.

Effects: XP 6 · Karma: God +4

BLUE Ask what he is polishing it for.

Requires: Trait: Clear-eyed

Nobody asks that. Everybody asks what it shows.

He stops polishing. 'For the King,' he says, and then, after a pause that goes on rather too long, 'He has not asked for it in some time.'

Effects: XP 15

BLUE Study the enchantment behind the mirror

Requires: Enchantment 3+

The enchantment is elegant — a truth-compulsion layered over a reflection spell, calibrated not to lie but not to flatter either. It shows what is, precisely and without context.

You study the structure for a while. The skeleton watches you study it.

'Most people just look in,' it says.

'Most people aren't trying to understand it.'

The skeleton polishes in silence. 'You just did both,' it says. 'You looked in when you read it.'

Effects: XP 14 · Karma: God +5, Human +2

The Feeding Ground hg_preta_feeding_ground

A hollow where pretas gather around a spring of water that turns to pus in their mouths, fruit trees whose apples become ash when touched. The pretas wail and claw at sustenance that perpetually escapes them. It is one of the worst things you have ever seen.

GREY Share your own food

Cost: Items (Rations)

It works, briefly. Your food is not cursed, and for a moment they eat — actually eat. The crying slows. It doesn't last. But for a moment it was real.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: God +5, Human +3

BLUE Bless the spring with white magic

Requires: White Magic 3+

The water runs clear. The pretas drink with expressions that have no analog in the living world. It reverts after an hour. But for that hour it is something.

Effects: XP 18 · Karma: God +8

BLUE Study the mechanics of the curse

Requires: Learning 3+

You understand it now — how the curse works, where it originates, why the simple solutions fail. What to do with this understanding is a separate and harder question.

Effects: XP 12 · Karma: Human +4

GREY Move on

You can't help everyone. You keep moving. The sound follows you for a while before the wind takes it.

Karma: Animal +3

The Bone Bridge hg_bone_bridge

A bridge of interlocking bones spans a chasm of howling darkness. Halfway across, a figure blocks the way — a massive bone horror, assembled from dozens of skeletons, looming in perfect silence. It does not speak. It does not need to.

GREY **Fight it head-on**

Combat: Bone Horror (hard)

Karma: Asura +2

BLUE **Look for the binding spell**

Requires: Awareness 15+

Combat: Bone Horror (easy)

There — the keystone bone, the one the spell anchors to. If that goes, the rest follows.

Effects: XP 8

YELLOW **Collapse the bridge behind you and leap**

Roll: Finesse, difficult difficulty

If it succeeds:

You trigger the collapse and run. The bridge drops away beneath you and you catch the far edge with both hands, hauling yourself over as the horror falls into the dark below.

Effects: XP 12

If it fails: Combat: Bone Horror (hard)

You both go over. You catch the edge. It does not.

BLUE **It is made of people and it is over a hole that howls.**

Requires: Trait: Timid

It is, and you cannot, and the party has to spend an hour finding a way that does not involve it.

The hour costs supplies. Nobody says anything about it, which somehow does not help.

Effects: supplies: Food -4; mind: Air -12; XP 22

BLUE **Somebody crosses first or nobody crosses.**

Requires: Trait: Brave

You go. The bridge says things while you are on it, in several voices, and you keep walking through all of them.

On the far side you find you have to sit down for a moment before waving the others over.

Effects: XP 12; mind: Air +8

BLUE **Sing to the people inside it**

Requires: Performance 3+

You sing something simple, something that belonged to someone once. The horror shudders. The assembled bones tremble against each other. One by one, the fragments that were people hear something they recognize. The thing steps aside, shaking. You cross in silence.

Effects: XP 20 · Karma: God +8

The Pack hg_grave_hound_pack

A pack of grave hounds — skeletal dogs with eyes of green flame — circles you. They're not attacking. They're sniffing. Curious. One tilts its skull and whines.

GREY **Offer food**

Cost: Items (Rations)

They eat with the focused joy of dogs everywhere. One stays close to your heel afterward, green eyes glowing up at you.

Effects: XP 5 · Karma: Human +4

YELLOW Stare them down

Roll: Strength, easy difficulty

If it succeeds:

You hold your ground and meet the eyes of the largest one. It blinks first. The pack loses interest and drifts away.

If it fails: Combat: Grave Hound Pack (normal)

They take the challenge seriously.

BLUE Speak to them calmly

Requires: Charm 12+

Something in your tone reaches the part of them that was once a dog. They settle. The one that whined leads you, with clear purpose, to a hollow in the ground.

Effects: XP 8; items: Item Random · Karma: Human +3

YELLOW Attempt to bind one as a familiar

Summoning 3+; Roll: Focus, easy difficulty

If it succeeds:

The binding takes. One hound sits and tilts its skull at you with what you decide to read as acceptance.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: Hungry Ghost +2

If it fails:

The binding fails. The hound in question is offended and snaps at you. The pack loses interest and trots away.

BLUE Find the one the others keep glancing at.

Requires: Trait: Hunter

Third from the left, smaller than the rest, standing slightly apart.

Everything the pack does routes through her. You do not have to fight seven grave hounds; you have to convince one, in front of six witnesses.

Effects: XP 20

BLUE Drop the alpha at distance — scatter the pack

Requires: Ranged 3+

You identify the pack leader — the one the others keep watching — and put a shot between its shoulder blades at range.

Clean drop. The pack scatters immediately, the hierarchy dissolved in one shot. No further engagement required.

Somewhere behind you, a green flame flickers once and goes out.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: Asura +2

The Unfinished Rites hg_last_rites

A half-completed funeral pyre. The body hasn't been burned — the rites were interrupted. A dré circles the pyre, keening. Without proper rites, neither body nor spirit can move on.

BLUE Complete the rites

Requires: Ritual 3+

The ceremony takes time and every word must be right. When the pyre catches, the dré's keening softens and then stops. It drifts upward and is gone.

Effects: XP 16; gains trait: Mourner · Karma: God +8

BLUE Pray for the dead — what you can offer

Requires: Yoga 1+

You cannot complete the rites, but you can witness. You sit and pray for a while. The dré calms, marginally. It is not enough but it is something.

Effects: XP 5 · Karma: God +3

YELLOW Take the funeral offerings

Thievery 2+; Roll: Finesse, normal difficulty

If it succeeds:

You work quickly and quietly. The dré doesn't notice.

Effects: gold small; items: Item Random; gains trait: Covetous · Karma: Hungry Ghost +5

If it fails: Combat: Charnel Wraith (normal)

The dré notices. Its keening changes pitch.

Karma: Hell +3

BLUE Build a proper pyre from what's available

Requires: Smithing 3+

The existing pyre was assembled wrong — too loose, wrong timber arrangement, no heat concentration. You break it down and rebuild it properly in forty minutes, using the scavenged materials as they should be used.

The dré watches you work in silence. When you light it, the fire catches cleanly and burns hot. Not the same as the proper rites — the spirit knows the difference — but the dré settles at the fire's edge with something that is almost quiet.

Effects: XP 12; gains trait: Mourner · Karma: God +5, Human +3

BLUE Somebody started this and did not finish it. Finish it.

Requires: Trait: Mourner

You know the order. You have done this often enough that your hands know the order, which is the part nobody warns you about.

When the pyre takes, the thing that has been waiting at the edge of the clearing goes wherever such things go, without any fuss at all.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Water +15 · Karma: Hungry Ghost -8, Human +5

GREY Ask the dré what happened

It takes a long time to understand the dré — its grief interrupts its speech constantly. Eventually you piece it together: the ritual was interrupted by a fight, the practitioners fled, and no one came back. It tells you where the practitioners went.

Effects: XP 6 · Karma: Human +2

The Needle-Throat hg_yidag_encounter

A yidag — the truest form of the hungry ghost, belly swollen to bursting, throat thin as a needle — blocks the road. Not threateningly. It simply can't move. It wheezes:

"Please. Anything. Even a drop."

GREY Give it water

The water evaporates the moment it touches its throat. It weeps. You tried.

Effects: XP 4 · Karma: God +3

BLUE Use white magic to ease its suffering

Requires: White Magic 3+

You temporarily widen its throat — just enough. It drinks for the first time in centuries, slowly, with its eyes closed. When it opens them, they're wet in a way that has nothing to do with the water.

Effects: XP 18 · Karma: God +8

GREY Ask how it came to this

A story of accumulated small greeds, none of them spectacular. It builds a picture of a life structured entirely around taking without giving — not evil, just narrow, for a very long time. The warning in the story is precise.

Effects: XP 6 · Karma: Human +2

BLUE You know what it is to want and not take.

Requires: Trait: Ascetic

You sit down in front of it, which nobody does, and you do not offer it anything, which everybody does and which has never once worked.

What you offer instead is the observation that the wanting does not have to be obeyed. It is not cured. It is, for the first time in a very long while, spoken to.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Fire +15 · Karma: Hungry Ghost -8, Human +5

YELLOW Help it let go

Roll: Charm, normal difficulty

If it succeeds:

"There is nothing to drink here. There has never been anything to drink here. You can stop." It looks at you for a long time. Then, very slowly, it loosens its grip on existing. It dissolves, quietly.

Effects: XP 14 · Karma: God +6

If it fails: Combat: Lost Preta (normal)

The suggestion that it could stop triggers something desperate. It attacks.

The Smuggler's Tunnel hg_smuggler_tunnel

A narrow tunnel entrance hidden behind a collapsed wall. Scratch marks on the stone suggest frequent use. From inside: voices, the clink of coin, the smell of something cooking.

GREY Enter cautiously

Opens: The Smuggler's Alcove

Karma: Hungry Ghost +1

YELLOW Announce yourself openly

Roll: Charm, easy difficulty

If it succeeds: Opens: The Smuggler's Alcove

A pause. Then: "Come in, then. Leave your paranoia at the door." Better prices for a customer who didn't sneak.

Karma: Human +2

If it fails: Combat: Skeleton Warband (normal)

"A spy." They don't wait to find out.

BLUE Present yourself as a potential partner

Requires: Thievery 2+

Opens: The Smuggler's Alcove

You know the right words. They let you into the back room.

Karma: Hungry Ghost +3

BLUE Those scratches are not damage. They are a message.

Requires: Trait: Secret-bearer

They are a message, in the sense that anything kept from most people is a message to the rest.

You read it: a count, a direction, and a warning about the third turning. All three prove accurate.

Effects: XP 20

BLUE Report them to the bone patrol

Requires: Persuasion 3+

You find the nearest patrol and bring them back. The tunnel is raided. The Skeleton King's forces are grudgingly grateful.

Effects: XP 8; gold moderate · Karma: Human +4

The Lantern Procession hg_spirit_lanterns

A line of ghostly lanterns floats through the darkness, each carried by an invisible hand. They move with purpose — a funeral procession of pure spirit, honoring someone important who died long ago. The procession repeats every night, endlessly.

GREY Walk alongside respectfully

You fall into step with the procession. The light is warm despite the cold. Something solemn and beautiful moves through you with it.

Effects: XP 6 · Karma: God +4

BLUE Join the procession — carry a lantern

Requires: Ritual 2+

A lantern drifts into your hands. As you carry it, visions come — fragments of the honored dead's life, their work, their love for whatever is being mourned here. The procession ends at a marker stone. The lanterns settle. A long peace.

Effects: XP 16 · Karma: God +6

YELLOW Try to end the eternal repetition

White Magic 3+; Roll: Focus, difficult difficulty

If it succeeds:

You reach into the pattern of it and find where the loop closes. You open it. The lanterns flicker, then go still. The procession ends — truly ends. The darkness is darker for a moment, then easier.

Effects: XP 24 · Karma: God +8

If it fails:

The pattern resists you. The procession blurs and stutters for a moment, then resumes its course as if nothing happened.

Effects: XP 4 · Karma: Human +2

YELLOW Take one of the lanterns

Roll: Finesse, normal difficulty

If it succeeds:

The lantern comes away in your hands, warm and surprisingly heavy.

Effects: items: Item Random · Karma: Hungry Ghost +4

If it fails: Combat: Charnel Wraith (normal)

The invisible hand does not let go. What was carrying the lantern turns its attention to you.

BLUE It is the middle of the night and you are wide awake.

Requires: Trait: Night Owl

Everyone else is asleep or nearly. You are at your best, and you fall in at the back of the procession and walk with it for a mile before it notices you.

When it notices, it does not object. It makes room.

Effects: XP 12; mind: Space +10

BLUE You were awake before the light reached the camp.

Requires: Trait: Light Sleeper

You always are. It means you see the procession from its first lantern to its last, which nobody else in the party does, and you count them.

The number matters later.

Effects: XP 15

BLUE Study the enchantment — understand what drives the loop

Requires: Enchantment 3+

The enchantment is a grief-loop — a mourning spell that has outlasted its caster by centuries, still running because no one cancelled it. The procession is real; the love in it is real. It just doesn't know it's allowed to stop.

You cannot dissolve it with enchantment alone, but now you understand its structure. The next person who walks beside these lanterns might be able to give it the permission it's been missing.

Effects: XP 14 · Karma: God +6, Human +2

The Gravedigger hg_gravedigger

A living man — actually alive — digs graves in the realm of the dead. He's been here so long he's forgotten how he arrived. He looks up as you approach without stopping his work.

"Someone's got to do it. The dead keep coming and the holes don't dig themselves."

GREY Help him dig

You work side by side in companionable quiet. At the end of it, he shares what he has — some food, some stories, a practical warmth that is rare in this realm.

Effects: XP 6 · Karma: Human +4

GREY Ask how to leave this realm

"Couldn't tell you. Been trying myself." He leans on his shovel. "What I can tell you is: don't eat anything they offer. Don't go near the river after dark. And the Skeleton King's patrols are mostly reasonable, as long as you're doing something they can categorize."

Effects: XP 6 · Karma: Human +2

BLUE Offer to help him find his way home

Requires: Charm 13+

He stops digging. Considers it for a long moment. "Who'd dig the graves?" He goes back to work. But something about him looks lighter after the question was asked.

Effects: XP 4 · Karma: Human +4, God +3

BLUE He is alive. Ask him how he is, before anything else.

Requires: Trait: Warm-hearted

Nobody has asked him that. He gets asked what he is doing here, and how he got here, and whether he can be bought.

He leans on the spade for a while before answering, and the answer takes most of an hour and is worth the hour.

Effects: XP 15; mind: Water +10

BLUE Offer to trade — he's had interesting finds

Requires: Trade 2+

He digs through a sack he keeps by the graveside. Things accumulate around graves. He has more than you'd expect, and most of it is in good condition.

Effects: XP 6; items: Item Random · Karma: Human +2

The Bone Library hg_bone_library

Shelves of bone hold scrolls of dried skin. A bespectacled silver skeleton moves between them, filing and organizing with tireless precision. It turns at your approach.

"Knowledge doesn't decay. My work today may help somebody in a thousand years. What can I do for you?"

BLUE Research a subject

Requires: Learning 3+

The librarian pulls scrolls without hesitation, knowing exactly where everything is. What you find goes beyond what you expected to find.

Effects: XP 16 · Karma: Human +2

GREY Ask about the realm's history

The librarian settles into it with obvious pleasure. The history of the hungry ghost realm is longer than you expected and stranger. You come away with the sense that this place has its own logic, older than any of the beings currently living in it.

Effects: XP 8 · Karma: Human +2

GREY Offer a book from the living world

The librarian takes it with both hands, holding it carefully away from the bone shelves as if it might be infectious in the best possible way. "I have nothing like this. Nothing written after the living left." It opens the rare section.

Effects: XP 10; items: Spell Random · Karma: God +4, Human +3

YELLOW Steal a rare scroll

Roll: Finesse, difficult difficulty

If it succeeds:

You find what you want and leave with it. The librarian doesn't notice.

Effects: items: Spell Random · Karma: Hungry Ghost +4

If it fails:

The librarian looks at you. Then at the scroll. Then at you again — not angry, just deeply, genuinely sad. You put it back.

Karma: God -4

BLUE You are not leaving a library. Be reasonable.

Requires: Trait: Curious

The silver skeleton adjusts its spectacles and produces, from somewhere, a second chair.

What you find in four hours is not what you were looking for and is considerably better: a name, an obligation, and where the obligation was last recorded.

Effects: XP 8

BLUE Do not read them. Index them.

Requires: Trait: Sharp Memory

You go through the shelf-marks rather than the scrolls, which the librarian watches with mounting professional respect.

By evening you hold the shape of the whole collection, and the shape has a gap in it exactly where something was removed.

Effects: XP 12

BLUE Ask if they'd teach you a few things

Requires: Persuasion 2+

Opens: The Bone Library

"Well, I suppose. Why not." It pulls a selection of relevant scrolls and begins.

Karma: Human +2

The Hermit of the Mire hg_swamp_hermit

Deep in the swamp, a rolang sits on a rock, fishing in toxic water with a line made of hair. It's the most peaceful undead you've ever seen. It has achieved something rare here — contentment.

GREY Sit and fish together

You sit in silence for a long time. Nothing bites. It doesn't seem to matter to either of you.

Effects: XP 6 · Karma: Human +4

BLUE Ask its secret

Requires: Awareness 13+

It doesn't look up from the water. "I stopped wanting." A long pause. "That's it. That's all there is."

Effects: XP 18 · Karma: God +6

GREY Offer what you're carrying

It shakes its head gently. "I have everything I need." It gestures at the toxic water, the dead fish, the grey sky. It means it.

Karma: God +2

GREY Disturb its peace — just to see

You consider it. Then the thought seems so ridiculous — there is so little peace in this realm and so much to disturb — that you simply leave. The faintest hint of hell clings to the idea.

Karma: Hell +2

The Wandering Preta hg_wandering_preta_event

A preta merchant dragging an enormous sack materializes from the grey. Despite being a hungry ghost, this one has channeled its craving into commerce with evident satisfaction.

"I can't eat, I can't drink, I can't sleep — but I CAN make a profit! Browse my wares?"

GREY Browse the wares

Opens: Wandering Preta

Karma: Human +1

GREY Ask what merchant life is like as a preta

"The margins are incredible since I no longer need to eat into them." A pause. "That's a joke. I can still make jokes." It delivers a ten-minute monologue on the economics of not needing to sleep, eat, or maintain any quality of life while operating a commercial enterprise.

Effects: XP 5 · Karma: Human +3

GREY Offer it some of your food

It stares at the food for a long time. Then at you. "Nobody has done that in... a long time." It waves you away. "Take ten percent off whatever you buy. Consider it a professional courtesy."

Karma: God +3

YELLOW Rob it

Roll: Finesse, easy difficulty

If it succeeds:

Fast hands, fast feet. You're gone before it counts its stock.

Effects: items: Item Random; gold small · Karma: Hungry Ghost +5

If it fails: Combat: Rolang Mob (normal)

It screams loud enough to be heard across the wasteland. Apparently it has regulars.

Karma: Hungry Ghost +3

BLUE Make a joke about hunger for money

Requires: Comedy 3+

A wheeze that might be laughter. "Oh, that one's good. That one's actually good." It waves you toward the sack. "Take what you want. I'll give you the suffering-colleague discount."

Karma: Human +3

The Charnel Ground Meditation hg_death_meditation

A flat stone among the bones, worn smooth by sitting. This is a practice site — you can feel it in the quality of the stillness around it. Confronting death directly. Not abstractly.

BLUE Meditate on death fully

Requires: Yoga 3+

You sit and let the smell and the reality and the inevitability be present without distance. It is not pleasant and it is not supposed to be. When you rise, something has been processed that had been waiting to be processed for some time.

Effects: XP 24; gains trait: Enlightened Insight · Karma: God +9

BLUE Sit for a moment

Requires: Yoga 1+

A few minutes on the stone. The reality of the place presses in. You let it. Something small shifts.

Effects: XP 8; gains trait: Composed · Karma: God +4

BLUE Study the bones academically

Requires: Medicine 2+

The collection here is unusual — varied, old, well-preserved by the dry air. You learn something about anatomy and something else, harder to name, about impermanence.

Effects: XP 8 · Karma: Human +2

BLUE You have sat in places like this before.

Requires: Trait: Ash-marked

The stone is worn smooth in the shape of people who have done exactly this, and you fit the shape.

What comes up is not fear, because that was dealt with some time ago. What comes up is the ordinary and much harder question of what to do tomorrow.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Space +15, Water +10

GREY Leave a prayer flag

You tie it to a bone and leave it fluttering. A small mark that someone was here and paid attention.

Karma: God +3

The Toll hg_toll_bridge

Two massive skeletons in heavy armor flank a stone bridge. A sign lists prices that escalate from the merely unreasonable to the openly delusional. The skeletons seem bored.

GREY Pay the toll

Cost: Gold (moderate)

They accept the coins without enthusiasm and step aside. Professional.

YELLOW Haggle

Trade 2+; Roll: Charm, easy difficulty

If it succeeds:

You work down through the price list methodically. They concede ground slowly, then all at once.

Effects: XP 5

If it fails:

They hold the line. The price goes up.

YELLOW Make them laugh

Comedy 2+; Roll: Charm, easy difficulty

If it succeeds:

You hit something genuinely funny. One skeleton laughs so hard it falls apart at the waist, and is still clicking on the ground when you walk past.

Effects: XP 6 · Karma: Human +3

If it fails:

"Heard that one. Pay up."

BLUE Read the sign properly. Signs like this always have a clause.

Requires: Trait: Debtor

There is a clause. There is always a clause, and you have spent enough of your life on the wrong side of one to find it inside a minute.

The toll applies to the living. Two of your party, on a technicality that the skeletons accept with visible irritation, are not paying it.

Effects: XP 20; gold small

BLUE Point out the economic flaws in the toll structure

Requires: Logistics 2+

You explain, briefly and with specific examples, why their pricing model is destroying long-term traffic revenue and creating a structural deficit. The skeletons stand very still for a long time. You walk past during this.

Effects: XP 8 · Karma: Human +3

The Border hg_realm_exit

The air changes. Ahead, the grey wasteland of the hungry ghost realm gives way to something else. A boundary marker — a stone carved with the Wheel of Life — stands at the transition point. Behind you, the realm of craving. Ahead, the unknown.

GREY Cross without looking back

You step through. The grey lifts.

Effects: XP 8

BLUE Look back one last time

Requires: Awareness 14+

You turn. The realm reveals itself — not as horror, not as punishment, but as consequence. Everything here follows from something. The craving was always going somewhere. It came here. That clarity stays with you as you cross.

Effects: XP 18 · Karma: God +6

GREY Leave an offering at the boundary stone

For those still inside. You leave what you can spare and cross.

Effects: XP 6 · Karma: God +4

BLUE Dedicate all merit gained here to the beings still suffering

Requires: Yoga 3+

You stand at the boundary and give it all away — every good thing earned in this realm, offered outward to those who couldn't earn it for themselves. The gesture costs you nothing you can measure. What it does is harder to name.

Effects: XP 30 · Karma: God +12

The Eye in the Dark hg_mehr

Something catches the thin light of the charnel grounds and throws it back — gold, steady, unblinking. Not an insect. Not a torch. An eye. Set in the face of a preserved woman standing knee-deep in black water, watching you with the patience of someone who has been here a long time.

GREY Call out to her

She answers. Dry, measured, without warmth or hostility. She answers your questions the way a stone does if you press your ear to it. She is not interested in traveling. You are not sufficiently interesting.

Effects: XP 5

BLUE Light a ritual flame — the old greeting of the Sun priesthood

Requires: Fire Magic 3+

Recruit: Mehr

The flame catches her attention in a way nothing else would. She straightens. Her golden eye moves before the other one does. 'Where did you learn that form?' She is already wading toward you before you finish answering.

No cost. Karma: God +3

BLUE Ask about the prophecy — you have enough to read what she was reading

Requires: Space Magic 3+

Recruit: Mehr

Her good eye narrows. The gold one does not move. 'That is the first intelligent question anyone has asked me in a very long time.' A pause. 'Come. Walk with me while I explain what it actually said.'

No cost. Karma: Human +2

YELLOW Speak to her as an equal — not with reverence, not with wariness

Roll: Charm, normal difficulty

If it succeeds: Recruit: Mehr

She studies you for a long moment. 'You have the manner of someone who has survived things,' she says. 'I find that more persuasive than credentials.' She wades toward you.

No cost. Karma: Human +3

If it fails:

She looks at you the way she must have looked at the court before they threw her in the tar pit. 'I have heard every manner of introduction,' she says. 'Go.'

The Gathering hg_choki

At the edge of a bog with no wind and no movement, a girl sits watching the water. She does not look up. She has been here long enough that moss has grown around where she sits. She is holding a bundle of forest plants that dried to nothing long ago.

GREY Leave her to the water

The bog is silent as you walk away. You don't hear her move.

Effects: XP 3 · Karma: Animal +1

BLUE Touch the water beside her — let it speak for you

Requires: Water Magic 3+

Recruit: Chöki

The water stirs slightly under your hand. She watches it. 'It was like that,' she says. 'One moment there was nothing. Then —' She trails off. Then: 'You are going somewhere. Can I come?'

No cost. Karma: Human +2, God +3

BLUE Ask her what she was gathering when the flood came

Requires: Logistics 3+

Recruit: Chöki

She finally looks up. Something in the question — the specificity of it, the acknowledgment of what she was doing when she left — gets through where comfort never would. She tells you everything she was carrying. She asks if you need a guide.

No cost. Karma: Human +4

YELLOW Sit beside her without speaking — wait for her to acknowledge you

Roll: Awareness, normal difficulty

If it succeeds: Recruit: Chöki

The silence stretches to an hour. Then two. Then she says: 'You're still here.' After another long while: 'Most people leave.' She looks at you sideways. 'Where are you going?'

No cost. Karma: Human +3, Animal +2

If it fails:

She doesn't acknowledge you. The waiting becomes its own kind of grief. You eventually stand and go.

The Unfinished Argument hg_nangwa

In the collapsed shell of what was once a library — shelves of ash, scrolls of smoke — a barely-visible figure moves between the ruins. It is picking up nothing, reading nothing, but its lips are moving. Occasionally it stops, gestures at empty air, shakes its head, and starts again from the beginning.

GREY Watch him for a while, then leave

He doesn't notice you leave. The argument continues.

Effects: XP 4

BLUE Complete his sentence — you can see where the argument is going

Requires: Learning 3+

Recruit: Nangwa

He stops. Turns toward you with the most attention he has given anything in centuries. He seems to become slightly more present in the physical world as he focuses. 'Walk with me,' he says. 'I think better when I walk. Tell me if I have this right.'

No cost. Karma: Human +3

BLUE Reach toward him through space — make contact with the part of him that is still here

Requires: Space Magic 3+

Recruit: Nangwa

For a moment, genuine contact. He startles. Looks at his hands as if seeing them for the first time in a while. 'Oh,' he says. 'I have been quite far away.' He looks at you with new attention. 'Would you stay nearby? I find I concentrate better when someone is present.'

No cost. Karma: God +2

YELLOW Follow the argument — interrupt at the right moment

Roll: Focus, normal difficulty

If it succeeds: Recruit: Nangwa

You catch the flaw and name it. He stops mid-gesture. 'Say that again.' You do. He is silent for a full minute. Then: 'I hadn't considered that approach.' A longer silence. 'Come with me while I think it through. I need a sounding board.'

No cost. Karma: Human +2

If it fails:

Your interjection breaks his concentration entirely. He dissipates for a moment, then reforms, looking confused and irritated. You have cost him hours of work.

The Crossroads Question hg_prashan

A vetala perches on a crumbling milestone, its mismatched layers of stolen cloth draped over a body it wears like a borrowed coat. It turns its head at your approach with the particular alertness of someone who has been waiting for exactly this. 'Ah,' it says. 'A traveler. I have a question for you.'

GREY Refuse to engage

'As you like. You will be back. They always come back when they have had time to think of an answer.' It settles in to wait.

Effects: XP 4

BLUE Ask it a better question instead of answering

Requires: Learning 3+

Recruit: Prashan

It goes very still. This has not happened before — or not for a very long time. 'You—' It stops. 'Where did you—' Stops again. Slowly, a smile spreads across a face not quite designed for it. 'All right. This is excellent. You will come with me. I insist.'

No cost. Karma: Human +5

BLUE Tell it a joke instead of answering

Requires: Comedy 3+

Recruit: Prashan

It blinks. Then, despite itself, makes a sound. Then another. 'That is — oh, that is terrible. That is genuinely terrible.' Its head is listing sideways with laughter. 'Come, I'll show you something better. I promise.'

No cost. Karma: Human +3

YELLOW Answer the riddle

Roll: Awareness, normal difficulty

If it succeeds: Recruit: Prashan

It tilts its head. Then further. Then further still, nearly upside down. 'Hmm.' A long pause. 'That is either a very good answer or a very bad one, and I cannot immediately tell which.' It straightens. 'I need to follow this further. Come with me.'

No cost. Karma: Human +2

If it fails:

'No. That is the obvious answer. Everyone says that.' It gestures dismissively. 'Go away. Come back when you have thought more carefully.'

The Round hg_nyingje

Among the ruins of a catacomb, a silver skeleton moves methodically from form to form — rolangs, dré, the occasional barely-present ghost. It is tending them. Binding wounds that will not heal, offering a hand to things that won't take it, reciting something under its breath to creatures that cannot hear. It does not seem to need an audience.

GREY Leave without disturbing her

She doesn't look up as you go. The recitation continues.

Effects: XP 6 · Karma: God +3, Human +2

BLUE Help her with her round — tend alongside her

Requires: White Magic 3+

Recruit: Nyingje

You work in silence for a while. She watches your technique without comment. Then: 'You have been taught properly.' A pause. 'By whom?' By the time you finish answering, you are both walking. You realize later you agreed to travel together without either of you saying so directly.

No cost. Karma: God +5, Human +3

BLUE Sit in meditation nearby — make yourself a point of stillness in this place

Requires: Yoga 3+

Recruit: Nyingje

She completes her round and comes back to where you are sitting. Waits. When you open your eyes, she is very close. 'You practice,' she says. It is not a question. A pause. 'I will walk with you for a while.'

No cost. Karma: God +4

YELLOW Ask her directly: will you travel with us?

Roll: Charm, difficult difficulty

If it succeeds: Recruit: Nyingje

She pauses in her work. Studies you with empty eye sockets that somehow convey careful attention. 'You are going further than here,' she says. 'There will be beings who need tending there too.' She finishes with her current patient, then stands. 'I will come.'

No cost. Karma: God +4, Human +2

If it fails:

'I am needed here.' She returns to her work without hostility. It is simply true.

The Auspicious Count hg_khedrup

On a flat rock carved with auspicious symbols, a preserved rolang sits in full meditation posture, counting beads with extraordinary precision. His lips move with sub-vocalized counts. Beside him, a pile of tally marks in the stone suggests he has been at this particular session for a very long time. He has the focused look of a man who is almost sure his formula is right.

GREY Leave him to his counting

The counting continues. The tally marks accumulate.

Effects: XP 3

BLUE Point out a flaw in his formula — you can see where the multiplier breaks down

Requires: Ritual 3+

Recruit: Khedrup

His hand stops on the beads. He looks up for the first time. 'Show me.' You do. He studies it. Studies you. Then: 'I may need to revise my methodology. I would welcome a second opinion — going forward.'

No cost. Karma: Human +2

BLUE Examine his preserved state — make a technical observation

Requires: Alchemy 3+

Recruit: Khedrup

'Copper oxide as the fixative?' He looks up sharply. 'How did you—' He examines his own hand, then back at you. 'What else can you tell?' The conversation goes on for some time. By the end he is standing. 'I should like to continue this. If you're traveling, I'll accompany you as far as convenient.'

No cost.

YELLOW Wait for him to complete his count — do not interrupt

Roll: Focus, normal difficulty

If it succeeds: Recruit: Khedrup

Three hours. Four. He reaches the end of his calculation, opens his eyes, and finds you there. 'You waited.' A pause. 'Most don't.' He consults his tallies. 'This is inconvenient. I will need to adjust for your presence in the calculation. Sit down. What is your birth star?'

No cost. Karma: Human +2

If it fails:

You shift at the wrong moment. He loses count, closes his eyes, and begins again from the beginning without acknowledging you.

The Formula hg_rasabhava

In a low-ceilinged catacomb chamber, a preserved zombie works steadily at a cluttered bench. Phials, powders, a bellows made of preserved lung. The formula on the stone tablet before him is enormously complex. He is at the part he always reaches before noticing something is wrong and starting over. He has not looked up.

GREY Leave him to it

He doesn't notice you leave. He's found something to check.

Effects: XP 4

BLUE Identify the phase where the formula breaks down

Requires: Alchemy 3+

Recruit: Rasabhava

'The stabilization phase — your catalyst ratio shifts at temperature.' He goes absolutely still. 'Say that again.' You do. He checks it three times. 'I have been wrong for forty-three years.' He closes his eyes. Opens them. 'I believe I need a different sort of problem. Will you have me?'

No cost. Karma: Human +2

BLUE Ask what he is trying to preserve and whether it can be summoned instead

Requires: Summoning 3+

Recruit: Rasabhava

He looks up for the first time. 'You're suggesting — instead of physical fixation, a binding of—' He sets down his tools. 'That would require a collaborator.' A pause. He looks at you properly. 'Come in. Close the door. I want to try something.'

No cost.

YELLOW Read the formula over his shoulder — try to spot what keeps going wrong

Roll: Awareness, easy difficulty

If it succeeds: Recruit: Rasabhava

You see it — a small error in the stabilization phase, invisible in isolation but fatal in combination. 'There,' you say. He looks. Silence. 'That can't be right. I've checked it six—' He checks it again. 'Oh.' The smallest, most deflated sound. Then: 'Are you traveling? I may want to get out of this room.'

No cost. Karma: Human +1

If it fails:

You can follow the general outline but the specifics are beyond you. He doesn't look up.

The Contained Curse hg_durvasa

In a hollow beneath a collapsed stupa, a gyelpo sits within a circle of his own making — binding signs carved into the stone, faintly active. He is maintaining a careful stillness. Whatever is bound is inside him. He watches you approach with eyes that are doing a great deal of work to remain calm.

GREY Leave him to it — this is his problem

You feel his eyes on your back as you leave. The sigils continue to glow.

Karma: Hell +2

BLUE Diffuse the bound energy through the air — disperse it gradually

Requires: Air Magic 3+

Recruit: Durvasa

It takes time. It takes all the steadiness you have. Gradually the sigils stop glowing. He slumps, then straightens. He looks at his hands, then at you. 'You have done this before,' he says. 'No,' you say. He considers this. 'Hm. I owe you a debt. How are you traveling?'

No cost. Karma: Human +6

BLUE Perform a proper reversal — unmake the binding through ceremony

Requires: Ritual 3+

Recruit: Durvasa

The curse unwrites itself, step by step. He exhales for the first time in what sounds like a very long time. 'Thorough,' he says. 'Methodical. I appreciate methodical.' He stands slowly. 'Whoever taught you that taught you well. I find myself without current employment. Are you taking work?'

No cost. Karma: Human +3

YELLOW Try to read the binding — understand what you are dealing with

Roll: Focus, normal difficulty

If it succeeds: Recruit: Durvasa

A death-curse, reflected and internalized. He has been holding it in containment since it returned to him. 'How long?' you ask. He answers. You do not ask again. You sit across from him and begin talking through options. By the time the sigils fade, you are colleagues.

No cost. Karma: Human +2

If it fails:

You can see something is deeply wrong but not what. He watches you fail to understand with the patience of someone who has been sitting very still for a very long time.

The Contract Web hg_gomchen

In a monastery that has somehow persisted in the charnel grounds — crumbling but still standing, its prayer flags bleached to grey — a gyelpo meditates in the central hall. Carved into every surface around him: contracts. Obligation clauses.

Reciprocal bindings. The accumulated leverage of a long political career, frozen in stone. He sits in the center of it with his eyes slightly open.

GREY **Leave him to his contracts**

The hall is silent except for the slow erosion of stone.

Karma: Hell +1

BLUE **Dissolve the primary binding — force the keystone obligation apart**

Requires: Sorcery 3+

Recruit: Gomchen

The stone cracks. The inscription flakes. He exhales slowly. 'I felt that.' The rest of the web loosens by degrees. He opens his eyes fully. 'You have just made me more dangerous. I hope you know what you are doing.' He stands, after effort. 'I owe you a debt. I prefer to pay them personally.'

No cost. Karma: Human +3

BLUE **Read the obligations back to him — enumerate the full cost of what he is holding**

Requires: Black Magic 3+

Recruit: Gomchen

You read them back slowly. Each one. He is very still. When you finish, the hall is quiet. 'I know,' he says. 'Say it again. Slower.' You do. When you finish the second time, something changes in his face. 'I have been very foolish,' he says quietly. 'Will you walk with me? I need to think outside these walls.'

No cost. Karma: Human +4

BLUE **Offer to hold one of them. You are good for it.**

Requires: Trait: Oath-keeper

You take one obligation off the web — the smallest, and even the smallest is heavier than it looks — and the gomchen watches you accept it with an expression that has not been used in a long time.

You will keep it. That was never in question, which is precisely why it could be offered.

Effects: gains trait: Oath-keeper; XP 20; mind: Earth +15

YELLOW **Study the contract web — try to find the obligation everything else depends on**

Roll: Awareness, difficult difficulty

If it succeeds: Recruit: Gomchen

You find it — a debt of precedence, buried under thirty layers of mutual obligation. You point to it without speaking. His eyes focus for the first time. 'You see it,' he says. 'No one has seen it.' A long pause. 'Then you are someone worth traveling with. Come.'

No cost. Karma: Human +2

If it fails:

The web is too complex. Everything connects to everything else. He watches you fail to find the thread without expression.

Bog Hermit hg_bog_hermit

A gaunt figure crouches in the reed beds, sorting through bundles of grey-green herbs with practiced hands. It is alive — or near enough to count. It looks up without alarm.

"You find herbs growing in the shade," it says by way of greeting, as if this explains everything. It holds up a sprig of something. "Helps with the rot. Mostly."

GREY **Ask what the herbs are for**

"Keep the living alive. Slow the dead down. Somewhere in between there's a tea that tastes almost good." It hands you a bundle without ceremony. You take it.

Effects: items: Herb Bundle; XP 4 · Karma: Human +2

BLUE Discuss the pharmacopoeia of the dead realm

Requires: Medicine 2+

You name what you recognise. The hermit corrects you once, with precision, then settles into a real conversation — the first, you suspect, it has had in some time. You leave knowing more than you arrived with.

Effects: XP 14 · Karma: Human +3

BLUE Sit with it a while — you have nowhere better to be

Requires: Yoga 1+

You sit. The hermit works. The bog makes its sounds. After a long silence it says: "Most people run through here." Another silence. "Thank you for not running."

Effects: XP 8 · Karma: God +4, Human +2

GREY Ask if it trades

"I trade in knowledge, mostly. I already have everything else I need." It gestures at the grey sky, the toxic water, the rustling reeds. It seems to mean it. You move on.

Corpse Merchant hg_corpse_merchant

A broad figure in a waxed coat stands over a cart heaped with cloth-wrapped bundles, sealed jars, and objects you decline to examine closely. Its face is partially masked. It does not smell good, but it has clearly made peace with this.

"Everything recovered in good condition," it says. "Relative condition. Relative good."

GREY Browse the goods

Opens: Bone Merchant

Karma: Human +1

GREY Ask where the goods come from

"The dead leave things behind. I collect them. Consider it a service." A pause. "To commerce. Also arguably to the dead. They weren't using it."

Effects: XP 3

BLUE Haggle — this is salvage, not retail

Requires: Trade 3+

You explain the theory of salvage pricing. The merchant listens with professional attention and adjusts its margins. "Fair. You know the trade." The discount is modest but genuine.

Effects: XP 6; gold 20 · Karma: Human +1

YELLOW Pocket something while it looks away

Roll: Finesse, normal difficulty

If it succeeds:

The merchant turns to re-tie a bundle. In the gap, your hand moves. You're three paces gone before it straightens up. It doesn't seem to notice — or doesn't care. Possibly both.

Effects: items: Item Random · Karma: Hungry Ghost +4

If it fails: Combat: Demon Patrol (normal)

The merchant doesn't turn around. "I can smell the living," it says. "I can smell them reaching." It produces a heavy implement from the cart.

Karma: Hungry Ghost +3

The Wailing hg_preta_wail

A chorus of voices rises from just beneath the waterline — hungry ghosts calling out in a language that is not quite sound. The words, if words they are, convey only need.

GREY Press on, ignoring the calls

Nothing reaches you. The voices fade behind you.

YELLOW Listen carefully — try to understand

Roll: Awareness, easy difficulty

If it succeeds:

One voice becomes distinct. A name. Something that mattered, once, somewhere.

Effects: XP 30; buff: Awareness +2

If it fails:

The need fills your mind for a moment. Hollow.

Effects: HP loss (light, all)

BLUE Chant a mantra of compassion for them

Requires: Yoga 3+

The voices quiet, one by one. It doesn't solve anything. It might help anyway.

Effects: XP 32 · Karma: Human +2, Hungry Ghost -2

Will-o'-Wisp hg_will_o_wisp

A faint light dances ahead, moving just fast enough to stay out of reach. It has no face — just a glow, and an implied direction.

GREY Let it drift away

You watch it go. It doesn't look back.

YELLOW Follow it

Roll: Finesse, easy difficulty

If it succeeds:

It leads you to a dry patch of ground, then vanishes. Something is buried just beneath the surface.

Effects: XP 12; items: Water Charm Common

If it fails:

You step wrong. Bog, not ground. You pull yourself out soaked.

Effects: HP loss (light, all)

BLUE Recognize it as a trapped spirit

Requires: Air Magic 3+; Space Magic 3+

You know this pattern. A soul caught between awareness and dissolution. You speak the syllable that releases it. It brightens, briefly, then goes out.

Effects: XP 35; buff: Awareness +2 · Karma: Human +3, Hungry Ghost +2

Swamp Spirit hg_swamp_spirit

A translucent figure stands ankle-deep in still water across a narrow channel. It watches you with the expression of someone who has forgotten where they were going.

GREY Wave and continue

It raises a hand in response. You don't look back.

YELLOW Speak to it gently — ask if it needs help

Roll: Charm, trivial difficulty

If it succeeds:

It doesn't answer in words, but something shifts. It presses a cold hand briefly to your forehead, then walks away into the mist.

Effects: buff: Strength +2, Constitution +2, Finesse +2, Focus +2, Awareness +2, Luck +2 · Karma: Human +2

If it fails:

It stares at you for a long moment, then sinks slowly into the water. You're not sure what you said wrong.

BLUE Offer guidance toward liberation

Requires: Yoga 3+

You know the practice for this. It takes most of an hour. The spirit becomes more present, then less, then gone — in the right direction.

Effects: XP 45 · Karma: Human +3, Hungry Ghost +2

Bone Raft hg_bone_raft

A crude raft of lashed femurs floats slowly past on the current. Something wrapped in waxed cloth sits in the middle. It's addressed to someone.

GREY Let it drift by

Whoever it's for, it's not you.

YELLOW Grab it before it floats out of reach

Roll: Finesse, trivial difficulty

If it succeeds:

You snag it. The cloth is still dry inside.

Effects: XP 8; gold small; items: Health Potion

If it fails:

You lean too far. You get wet. The raft keeps going.

Effects: HP loss (light, all)

BLUE Notice the name on the address — read it before it's gone

Requires: Awareness 14+

You can't retrieve it. But you read the name. It means something, even if you're not sure what yet.

Effects: XP 28

Weeping Shrine hg_weeping_shrine

A small shrine on a mud-island, half-sunk. Water seeps continuously from the cracks in the stone — it has been weeping so long the ground beneath is stained dark.

GREY Make an offering and move on

The shrine accepts. The weeping continues.

Effects: XP 15 · Karma: Human +1

YELLOW Meditate on what the shrine mourns

Roll: Awareness, easy difficulty

If it succeeds:

The grief becomes specific. A name, a cause, an old loss. Understanding doesn't fix it, but understanding tends to be useful.

Effects: XP 32; buff: Awareness +3

If it fails:

Grief doesn't always explain itself. You sit with it anyway.

Effects: XP 5 · Karma: Human +1

BLUE It is half-sunk and it is still a shrine.

Requires: Trait: Pilgrim

You wade out to it. This is unpleasant and takes some time and the party makes remarks.

What you find on the far side, above the waterline, is a carved instruction — brief, practical, and clearly meant for whoever cared enough to get that close.

Effects: XP 20; items: Item Random · Karma: God +3, Human +2

BLUE Perform a proper purification ceremony

Requires: Ritual 3+

The weeping slows, then stops — for the first time in however long. The shrine feels lighter. So do you.

Effects: XP 28; full restore · Karma: Human +3

Sacrifice Post hg_sacrifice_post

A wooden post driven into the mud, hung with trinkets, cloth strips, dried flowers. The offerings are from multiple eras — some ancient, some recent. Whatever this appeases, it is still being appeased.

GREY Add something small to the post

Cost: Gold (tiny)

It costs you almost nothing.

Effects: XP 8 · Karma: Human +1, God +1

YELLOW Try to identify what this protects against

Roll: Awareness, easy difficulty

If it succeeds:

You piece it together from the nature of the offerings. The swamp has teeth, and this is how the locals have been keeping them dull.

Effects: XP 22; buff: Dodge +10

If it fails:

Folk magic doesn't always leave notes. You make a small offering anyway.

Effects: XP 4 · Karma: Human +1

BLUE Take several of the more potent-looking charms

Requires: Black Magic 3+

They're not yours to take, but they're functional.

Effects: XP 8; items: Black Charm Common, Water Charm Common · Karma: Hungry Ghost +3, Human -2

Funeral Rites hg_funeral_rites

A skeleton sits beside a crumbling grave, methodically arranging offerings — flowers long since turned to dust, fruit that is only the shape of fruit. It works without hurry, with complete attention.

GREY Don't disturb it

Some things should be left alone. You pass at a respectful distance.

YELLOW Watch what it is arranging — try to understand

Roll: Awareness, easy difficulty

If it succeeds:

You recognize the pattern. Old funeral rites, obscure but correct. Someone taught this skeleton well.

Effects: XP 35; buff: Awareness +2

If it fails:

You shift your weight. A branch snaps. The skeleton freezes. You hold your breath. Then it continues, ignoring you entirely.

BLUE Kneel and help perform the rites correctly

Requires: Yoga 3+; Ritual 3+

It turns to look at you when you kneel. A long pause. Then it extends a handful of dust-flowers toward you, and together you finish the ceremony.

Effects: XP 40; full restore; gains trait: Mourner · Karma: Human +3, Hungry Ghost +2

Memory Echo hg_memory_echo

A shimmer in the graveyard air, like heat haze — but it's cold here. For a moment you see a family at a meal. Vivid, fully real. Then gone, leaving only the smell of food that isn't there.

GREY Blink and move on

Some things are just residue of lives. You don't need to understand every one.

YELLOW Hold the vision — try to understand who they were

Roll: Awareness, easy difficulty

If it succeeds:

A life becomes briefly comprehensible. The attachment, the warmth, and what happened to it.

Effects: XP 40; buff: Spellpower +3

If it fails:

The hunger in the image reaches you before the meaning does. You feel it in your chest for an hour.

Effects: HP loss (light, all)

BLUE Study the echo's magical structure

Requires: Black Magic 3+

A well-preserved echo. Whoever imprinted it was powerful in life, and thoroughly unresolved.

Effects: XP 20; buff: Focus +2, Awareness +2 · Karma: Hungry Ghost +1

Skeleton Musician hg_skeleton_musician

A skeleton sits on a gravestone, playing a two-stringed instrument with surprising skill. The music is slow and strange and not entirely unpleasant. It stops when it notices you.

GREY Nod respectfully and pass

It watches you go. When you're far enough away, the music resumes.

YELLOW Play along, or try to match the melody

Roll: Charm, trivial difficulty

If it succeeds:

It tilts its head at you, then picks up the tempo. You manage to follow. For a few minutes, in a graveyard in the hungry ghost realm, something like music happens.

Effects: XP 22; buff: Charm +2 · Karma: Human +3

If it fails:

Your contribution is not musically interesting. The skeleton watches you politely until you stop.

BLUE Sing for the musician

Requires: Performance 3+

It tilts its head at you, then picks up the tempo to match your voice. For a few minutes, in a graveyard in the hungry ghost realm, something like music happens.

Effects: XP 22; buff: Charm +2 · Karma: Human +3

BLUE It is playing a form. Give it words.

Requires: Trait: Poet

You put words to what it is playing, roughly and out of metre, and it stops dead for the length of a breath before picking the line back up underneath your voice.

You get through four verses. It has not had a singer in a very long time.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Air +12, Fire +8

BLUE Tell a joke

Requires: Comedy 3+

It makes no sound. But the jaw moves, and the ribcage shakes, and the instrument ends up upright and the musician hunched over it in a posture that can only be described as helpless.

Effects: XP 18; items: Air Charm Common · Karma: Human +2

Dust Storm hg_dust_storm

A wall of bone-dry grit sweeps across the graveyard with no warning. There's nowhere to shelter. You're going to take this one.

GREY Push through

You bow your head and walk. It gets in everywhere.

Effects: HP loss (light, all); buff: Constitution -2

YELLOW Brace against it — or dodge the worst of it

Roll: Constitution, easy difficulty

If it succeeds:

You turn your back, cover your face, wait it out. It passes.

If it fails:

It's worse than you thought.

Effects: HP loss (light, all); buff: Constitution -2

BLUE Raise a wind-break with earth magic

Requires: Earth Magic 3+

A low ridge of packed earth takes the worst of it. You emerge into clear air already reforming your thoughts about dry graveyards.

Effects: XP 10; buff: Constitution +2

The Dancing Dead hg_dancing_dead

A ring of corpses dances in perfect silence around an empty throne. Their movements are stiff but coordinated, as if memory persists where intention does not. They do not appear to notice you.

GREY Slip past the outer edge carefully

Whatever they are celebrating, or mourning, continues without you.

YELLOW Join the ring — dance with them

Roll: Finesse, easy difficulty

If it succeeds:

Your body finds the rhythm. For a moment you are part of something very old and very strange. When the dance ends, you are on the other side of the ring.

Effects: XP 18; buff: Finesse +2, Luck +2 · Karma: Hungry Ghost +2

If it fails:

You misstep. The ring shifts. They look at you all at once. Then, somehow worse, they resume — leaving you outside it.

BLUE Let them have it. Watch properly.

Requires: Trait: Celebrant

They are dancing around an absence and they are doing it in total silence and they have clearly been doing it a long time.

You watch it through rather than past, which nobody has done, and at the end one of them bows to you specifically.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Water +10 · Karma: Hungry Ghost -4

BLUE Recognize the ceremony and complete your part

Requires: Ritual 3+; Performance 3+

This is a specific ceremony. You've seen fragments of it. You take the empty throne, perform your part. When you rise, the dance resolves — the figures slow, then still, with something like satisfaction.

Effects: XP 45 · Karma: Human +2, Hungry Ghost +2

Spirit Fires hg_spirit_fire

Three fires burn without fuel at the edge of the charnel grounds. One is pale blue, one is deep green, one is a colour that doesn't have a name. None of them give off heat.

GREY Walk around them

They seem to watch you go — or seem to.

YELLOW Approach and study them

Roll: Awareness, easy difficulty

If it succeeds:

Each one is a distinct consciousness, in the earliest stage of what might become a ghost or might become something else. You learn something from how they burn.

Effects: XP 20; buff: Spellpower +3, Focus +2

If it fails:

The nameless-coloured one flares. The heat is not physical. You step back.

Effects: HP loss (light, all)

BLUE Understand their elemental nature

Requires: Fire Magic 3+; Sorcery 3+

Three elements, one process. You spend time with each one, and each one teaches you something.

Effects: XP 35; items: Fire Charm Common

Charnel Feast hg_chnel_feast

A long table laid out in the open, covered in a feast that looks perfect and smells wrong. Seated pretas reach for food endlessly — it passes through without satisfying anything. The table is infinite. The hunger is infinite. Neither notices you standing at the edge.

GREY Turn away quickly

The right call.

YELLOW Eat anyway — you're hungry, and it looks real enough

Roll: Constitution, normal difficulty

If it succeeds:

It's real enough. Strange but real. It sits wrong for an hour, then doesn't.

Effects: full restore; supplies: Food 2; gains trait: Haunted

If it fails:

You understand, briefly and completely, what it is like to need something and have it provide nothing at all.

Effects: HP loss (moderate, all); buff: Constitution -3

BLUE Sit with the nature of what you're seeing

Requires: Yoga 3+

You observe the feast without hunger. The pretas slow, one by one, and watch you — the strange creature at the edge of the table who is not reaching. Something about this interests them.

Effects: XP 55; buff: Focus +3; gains trait: Clear-eyed · Karma: Human +3, Hungry Ghost -3

BLUE You have been hungrier than this on purpose.

Requires: Trait: Ascetic

You look at the table the way you look at any table, which is to say briefly.

Whatever laid it was counting on the wanting, and there is not enough of that in you to work with. The hall loses interest and the food stops being convincing halfway down the table.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Fire +15

BLUE You can tell from here that the lamb is done properly.

Requires: Trait: Gourmand

You can. That is the trouble — it is not a general temptation, it is a specific and extremely well-observed one, and something went to the effort of knowing what you would want.

You eat one mouthful before the party gets you away from the table. One is enough to be unwell for a day.

Effects: HP loss (light, random); mind: Fire -12; XP 30

BLUE Pocket the gold candleholders — they look real

Requires: Thievery 3+

They are real. Everything solid about this table is real.

Effects: XP 8; gold moderate · Karma: Hungry Ghost +3, Human -2

A Sigh of Relief hg_sigh_of_relief

A small cairn with a folded cloth on top. Written in a careful hand: "You are not as lost as you feel."

GREY Read it. Move on.

You are not as lost as you feel.

Effects: XP 8; full restore; gains trait: Touched by Grace · Karma: Human +1

Black Lodge hg_black_lodge

A mound of bones marks the entrance, a khatvanga hung with a skull and streaming black silk. As you enter, the darkness swallows sound. Something in the corner shifts — it may not be fully alive. A slow turn. A waiting smile.

GREY Ask to learn

Opens: Black Lodge

The movement stills. A bony hand gestures to a list scratched into the wall. Spells. Prices. No explanation offered.

BLUE Say nothing at the door. That is the password.

Requires: Trait: Secret-bearer

It is. You are inside before you have decided whether you wanted to be, and what is discussed there is not written down anywhere, including here.

Effects: XP 20

GREY Back out

You step back into the pale light. The khatvanga watches you leave.

Circle of the Yoginis hg_yogini_circle

Sixty-four forms carved into standing bones form a perfect ring on the charnel ground. The earth inside is worn smooth by countless ritual footprints. A low humming comes from the center — women's voices, or something passing for them.

GREY Enter the circle

Opens: Circle of the Yoginis

One of the sisters turns. No words — a gesture toward the center of the ring. What do you need?

GREY Move on

You back away slowly. The humming follows you longer than it should.

Crossroads Stupa hg_crossroads_stupa

At the intersection of the ancient paths, a stupa rises from layers of offerings — skulls, prayer flags, bones wrapped in cloth. Juniper smoke and the smell of old offerings drift on the wind. A practitioner crouches behind the stupa, neither fully alive nor fully dead.

GREY Approach the stupa

Opens: Crossroads Stupa

The figure looks up. The crossroads is the right place for calling back what is lost. The price is gold.

GREY Observe from a distance

You watch the butter lamps flicker in the wind, then walk on. Some things are better left undisturbed.

Hidden Gompa hg_hidden_gompa

A small monastery sits undisturbed between the burial grounds, its walls marked with painted eyes that seem to follow you. The monks here practice for the benefit of all beings caught between lives. The ground vibrates faintly with their prayers.

GREY Knock and ask to enter

Opens: Hidden Gompa

After a long pause, the door opens. A monk gestures you inside and names what can be taught here — and the price.

GREY Don't disturb them

You walk past without knocking. The painted eyes seem to close behind you.

Mirror Lake hg_mirror_lake

The surface of the lake is perfectly still, reflecting not the sky above but something else — other realms, other moments, faces that do not look back when you stare. Practitioners sit at its edge, meditating on what the water reveals.

GREY Sit and listen

Opens: Mirror Lake

A practitioner meets your eyes in the reflection before turning around. They can teach what the lake teaches. The water makes everything a fair price.

GREY Walk away from the mirage

You step back from the water's edge. The reflection holds your shape a moment longer, then dissolves.

Sacred Grove hg_sacred_grove

A stand of ancient trees whose roots grow through charnel earth. The branches are hung with offerings of food — the hungry ghosts who press at the edge of the grove can smell them but cannot eat. Practitioners move among the roots, speaking to both the living and the dead.

GREY Approach the practitioners

Opens: Sacred Grove

One of the practitioners turns. She names what can be taught here, and then the price. Gold is gold in every realm.

GREY Leave them to it

You walk on. The smell of offerings follows you through the trees.

Temple of the Naga hg_temple_of_the_naga

A low temple built around a black-water pool. The nagas who dwell in such pools are guardians of the dead, and their human followers leave milk offerings at the water's edge. A practitioner sits cross-legged on the stone, eyes closed, lips moving.

GREY Ask about their teachings

Opens: Temple of the Naga

The practitioner opens her eyes. She names the spells the nagas have permitted to be taught here, and the price. It is not cheap.

GREY Move on

You leave the offerings undisturbed. The pool surface ripples once as you go.

Mercenary Guild hg_mercenary_guild

A walled compound marked with the crossed-bone sigil of the guild. Skeletal warriors and half-dead fighters linger between contracts, sharpening weapons they barely need to use anymore.

GREY Enter the guild

Opens: Undertakers' Lodge

The guildmaster looks you over without interest. Weapons, armor, contracts — name what you need.

GREY Move on

You leave the compound to its dead-eyed inhabitants.

Wandering Preta hg_peddlar_graveyard

A preta wanders between the grave markers, its distended belly dragging, desperate hands clutching bundles of goods. It will trade anything for food — though it can never eat enough to be satisfied.

GREY Trade with the preta

Opens: Wandering Preta

The preta's needle-thin neck cranes toward you, eyes fixed on your pack. It lays its goods on a grave marker and waits.

GREY Move on

You give the preta a wide berth. It watches you go with hollow, hungry eyes.

Wandering Preta hg_peddlar_swamp

A preta rises from the mist at the water's edge, its needle-thin neck craning as it senses your approach. Desperate hands clutch wares salvaged from the swamp floor. It will trade anything for food.

GREY Trade with the preta

Opens: Wandering Preta

The preta spreads its goods on a half-submerged log and regards you with hollow, hopeful eyes.

GREY Move on

You leave it to the mist. Its eyes follow you until the fog closes in.

Charnel Teahouse hg_teahouse_chnel

A lantern glows faintly above a low doorway carved into a wall of stacked bone. Inside, a quiet figure brews tea from dried flowers that grow only on graves. The dead do not drink, but the living are welcome.

GREY Step inside

Opens: The Last Cup

The figure pours without looking up. You can rest here — if you can afford it.

GREY Move on

You leave the lantern light behind. The scent of grave-flowers follows you a while.

Graveyard Teahouse hg_teahouse_graveyard

A small dwelling built into the side of an old burial mound, its entrance marked with a hanging lantern and a painted sign no longer legible. Someone has been serving tea here for a very long time.

GREY Step inside

Opens: The Last Cup

The host gestures to a low table. The tea is bitter and dark. You can rest here — if you can afford it.

GREY Move on

You leave the mound behind. The lantern swings in a wind you can't feel.

Swamp Teahouse hg_teahouse_swamp

A teahouse built on stilts above the swamp water, its light the only warmth for miles. A rope bridge leads to the door. Someone is already watching you from the window.

GREY **Cross the bridge**

Opens: The Last Cup

The host sets a cup on the table before you sit. You can rest here — if you can afford it.

GREY **Move on**

You leave the light behind. The swamp closes around you.

Town hg_town_magic

A settlement where more windows glow than can be explained by candlelight. Strange smells drift from the apothecary. A practitioner argues with a vetala outside the library, and neither seems to have the better of it.

GREY **Enter the town**

Opens: Whispering Shrine

You find the market square. The odd merchants eye you with professional interest.

GREY **Move on**

You leave the scholars to their arguments. The strange lights fade behind you.

Town hg_town_supplies

A trading post built among the graves, supplies scavenged from the dead and traded among the half-living. The market is quiet but well-stocked — necessity makes practical merchants of everyone here.

GREY **Enter the town**

Opens: Gravedigger's Supply

You push through to the market. Traders call out their wares in dry, patient voices.

GREY **Move on**

You skirt the settlement and keep moving.

Town hg_town_weapons

A fortified compound where warriors trade blades and bones. The biggest building is an armory. Someone is always sharpening something, and the sound of whetstones never stops.

GREY **Enter the town**

Opens: Crossbones Armory

You push through the gate. The armorer looks up from their work.

GREY **Move on**

You skirt the compound and keep moving.

Veterans' Camp hg_veterans_camp

A camp of battle-scarred fighters who never left the ghost realm. Their fire has been burning since they arrived — they stopped counting how long ago. They still trade in the tools of their old trade.

GREY Approach the camp

Opens: The Old Guard

A veteran looks up from the fire. Old fighters make fair merchants — they know what things are worth.

GREY Move on

You leave the veterans to their fire. It will still be burning when you pass this way again.

Shadow Market hg_shadow_market

A market that appears only between the grave stones, visible only to those who know how to look. The stalls are draped in dark cloth and the merchants keep their faces in shadow. Everything here was obtained quietly.

GREY Browse the stalls

Opens: The Smuggler's Alcove

A shadowed hand gestures you deeper into the market. No questions asked, no names given.

GREY Move on

You step back. The market seems to thin and vanish between blinks.

Shadow Peddler hg_shadow_peddler

A hunched figure steps from behind a grave marker, face obscured beneath a ragged hood. Its voice is barely a whisper but its goods are real enough — things it has acquired in ways it declines to explain.

GREY See what it has

Opens: Wandering Preta

The figure spreads its goods on the grave stone between you. It wants food more than gold.

GREY Keep moving

You walk past without stopping. The figure watches you go, then is gone.

The Insatiable King hg_boss_insatiable_king

He sits on a throne of fused bone before the Realm Gate, a mountain of a preta — belly vast as a granary, throat thin as a needle. A thousand offering bowls lie scattered around him, every one licked clean and none of them enough.

"More," he says, and the word carries the weight of centuries. "Everything that passes this gate feeds me first. Wealth. Blood. Memory. What have you brought the King of Hunger?"

GREY Give him nothing — draw your weapon

Combat: Insatiable King (boss)

Karma: Hell +3, Asura +5

GREY Lay out a feast from your own stores before the fight

Cost: Food Percent (50)

Combat: Insatiable King Weakened (normal)

He devours everything in moments — and for one heartbeat his eyes close, almost peaceful. When they open, the hunger is back, but slower. Heavier. He rises to fight without his court.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: Human +5, Hungry Ghost -3

BLUE Speak the sutra of the open hand — hunger ends where giving begins

Requires: White Magic 4+

Combat: Insatiable King Weakened (normal)

The words land like rain on a fire that has burned for ten thousand years. His courtiers dissolve, wailing. The King alone remains, diminished, weeping — and still he attacks, because he no longer knows how to do anything else.

Effects: XP 12 · Karma: God +5, Human +3

BLUE Sit with him. Ask what he was, before the hunger

Requires: Yoga 6+

The question stops him like a blade. Slowly, haltingly, he remembers: a rich man who buried grain while his village starved, who died counting. You sit with the memory until he can hold it himself.

When he finally weeps, the tears are ordinary and human. The throne of bone crumbles. Where the King sat there is only an old man's shadow, bowing once before it fades. The gate stands open.

Effects: XP 30 · Karma: God +10, Human +5, Hungry Ghost -10

Swamp Warden hg_swamp_warden

The only dry crossing through the wall of thorn and mire is watched. A rolang ancient stands waist-deep in the black water, preserved by centuries of swamp tannin, carrion worms moving beneath its skin like slow thoughts.

It raises one dripping arm and points — not at you, but at the toll stone beside the path, hollowed like a begging bowl.

GREY Cut it down and force the crossing

Combat: Rotting Sentinel (hard)

Karma: Hell +3, Asura +2

GREY Fill the toll stone with food and pass

Cost: Food (moderate)

The worms boil out of the warden's body to swarm the offering. While the ancient stands hollowed and swaying, you walk the causeway unopposed.

Effects: XP 6 · Karma: Hungry Ghost +3, Human +2

BLUE Perform the rites that should have been spoken over this corpse

Requires: Ritual 3+

You speak the old words and the warden goes very still. The worms leave it, one by one, sliding into the water. What remains is only a dead man, finally allowed to be dead, toppling softly into the reeds. The crossing is yours.

Effects: XP 15 · Karma: God +5, Human +3, Hungry Ghost -3

YELLOW Wade through the deep mire, out of its reach

Roll: Constitution, difficult difficulty

If it succeeds:

Chest-deep in rot, leeches at your ankles, you haul yourselves through the mire and up the far bank, shaking but past.

Effects: XP 8 · Karma: Animal +3

If it fails: Combat: Rotting Sentinel (hard)

The mud holds you fast — and the warden comes wading.

Karma: Hungry Ghost +2

Bone Gate Keeper hg_bone_gate_keeper

The pass through the ossuary wall runs beneath an arch of ten thousand fused skulls. Before it stands a skeleton formation in ancient parade order — warriors, archers, and at their center a bone horror wearing the rusted regalia of a gate captain.

Its jaw grinds open: "State. Your. Dead."

GREY Break the formation

Combat: Skeleton Elite (hard)

Karma: Hell +3, Asura +3

GREY Name your dead, honestly, one by one

You speak the names — companions lost, enemies slain, the lives that ended so you could stand here. The captain's skull tilts with each one, counting. When you finish, the formation parts with a sound like dry applause.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: Human +3, God +2, Hungry Ghost +2

BLUE Command them in the tongue of the dead

Requires: Black Magic 4+

Your word of command cracks across the pass like a whip. The formation snaps to attention — and holds it, rigid, as you walk through their ranks. The captain's eye sockets track you the whole way.

Effects: XP 12 · Karma: Hungry Ghost +4, Hell +2

BLUE Return the salute and inspect the honor guard

Requires: Leadership 3+

Combat: Bone Horror (normal)

You walk the line like a visiting general. Halfway down the rank, the captain decides you are worth testing — but formation discipline binds most of its troops to their posts.

Effects: XP 8 · Karma: Asura +4, Human +2

Zombie Horde hg_zombie_horde

They come out of the reeds in ones and twos and then in dozens — bog zombies, waterlogged and patient, drawn by whatever it is the living give off that the dead can smell.

There is no line to hold. There is only the direction with fewest of them in it.

GREY Cut a path through

Combat: Zombie Pack (hard)

Karma: Asura +3, Hungry Ghost +2

YELLOW Go low into the reeds and let them pass over you

Roll: Constitution, difficult difficulty

If it succeeds:

Face-down in black water breathing through a reed while a hundred waterlogged feet go past inches from your ribs. It takes forty minutes. Nobody coughs. That is the whole achievement and it is enormous.

Effects: XP 14; mind: Water -10 · Karma: Animal +3

If it fails: Combat: Zombie Pack (hard)

Somebody's lungs give out. A head turns. Then all of them turn.

Karma: Hungry Ghost +2

BLUE Set the marsh gas alight behind you

Requires: Fire Magic 3+

There is more methane over this bog than anyone should stand in. You touch it off from the far side and the whole flat goes up in a low blue sheet. The horde does not so much burn as simply stop, mid-step, and keep standing there while the fire takes them. You are well clear. You watch longer than you meant to.

Effects: XP 18 · Karma: Asura +3, Hell +2

BLUE Sever what is holding them upright

Requires: White Magic 4+

Rolang are not animate by their own will — something keeps them walking, and it is thin here. You speak the release across the whole flat at once and the horde goes down in a long ragged wave, like a field of wheat. In the silence afterwards the swamp sounds almost ordinary.

Effects: XP 24; mind: Water +15 · Karma: God +8, Human +3

Zombie Toll hg_swamp_toll

The causeway is the only dry ground for a mile, and four bog zombies stand across it in a row. They are not shambling. They are *waiting* — arranged, deliberate, with the stillness of a posted guard.

One of them holds out a swollen hand, palm up. It has been taught to do this.

GREY Break the line

Combat: Bog Zombie (normal)

Karma: Asura +3

GREY Put something in the hand

Cost: Gold (small moderate)

The fingers close. The four of them step aside in unison and resume waiting, facing the way you came. Somewhere in this swamp is whoever trained them, and you find you would rather not meet them.

Effects: XP 6 · Karma: Hungry Ghost +3

BLUE Follow the training back to whoever set this up

Requires: Awareness 14+

The zombies are facing the causeway, but their heels are aligned to a stand of dead willow forty paces off. There is a rolang in it, very old, very still, running a toll booth in a swamp with four corpses and infinite patience. You negotiate directly. It turns out to be reasonable, and lonely, and it waives the fee for conversation.

Effects: XP 18; gold 40 · Karma: Human +4, Hungry Ghost +2

BLUE Four zombies and a causeway. Do the arithmetic out loud.

Requires: Trait: Scrimper

You establish, at length, that the causeway is not theirs, that no work has been done to maintain it, and that the toll has no basis of any kind.

The zombies are not equipped for this argument. Two of them wander off during it.

Effects: XP 20

BLUE Pay with something that is not money

Requires: Guile 3+

You press a flat river stone into the swollen palm with great ceremony. The fingers close on it. Whatever instruction these four are running does not include an assay step. They step aside. You cross the causeway feeling both clever and slightly cheap.

Effects: XP 12 · Karma: Hungry Ghost +4, Animal +2

Rotting Bridge hg_rotting_bridge

The bridge is the only crossing for miles and it has been rotting for longer than that. Half the planks are gone; the rest are the colour of old cheese. Beneath it, the channel runs deep and black and busy.

Someone has scratched a warning into the post. The scratching is also rotten.

YELLOW Cross one at a time, testing every board

Roll: Finesse, normal difficulty

If it succeeds:

Four crossings, four held breaths, one plank that goes into the water without you. Everyone across.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: Human +2

If it fails: Combat: Swamp Vermin (normal)

The board does not creak first. One moment there is a bridge and the next there is black water and a great deal of movement in it.

Effects: HP loss (light, random) · Karma: Hungry Ghost +2

BLUE Rebuild the span properly before anyone sets foot on it

Requires: Smithing 3+

You cut and set new stringers, deck it in salvaged planks, and lash the whole thing to the surviving piles. It takes four hours and a quantity of scrap. When you finish, it is the only sound structure you have seen in this realm — and it will still be here for whoever comes next, which is a strange thing to care about in a place like this.

Effects: XP 20; supplies: Scrap -6 · Karma: Human +6, God +3

BLUE Find where the channel shallows and ford it

Requires: Logistics 3+

Bridges exist where the crossing is hard. Two hundred paces upstream the channel spreads over a gravel bar and is thigh-deep and boring. You get wet to the hip and nothing tries to eat anyone.

Effects: XP 12 · Karma: Animal +3, Human +2

GREY Not worth it — go the long way

Most of a day added to the journey and every member of the party privately relieved.

Effects: XP 3 · Karma: Human +2

Lost Traveler hg_lost_traveler_swamp

He is sitting on his pack in six inches of water, and he is alive — properly alive, breathing, shivering, sunburnt on one side of his face from a sun that does not shine here.

"I've been walking in a circle," he says, with the terrible calm of someone who worked this out some time ago. "I keep finding my own footprints. I've stopped following them."

GREY Take him with you as far as the next dry ground

He talks for the first hour and then stops, and the silence afterwards is better. At the treeline he shakes everyone's hand formally, one at a time, and walks off south. You do not find out whether he makes it.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: Human +5, God +2

GREY Give him food and directions

Cost: Food (small)

He eats too fast and apologises for it. The directions he repeats back to you three times, getting them right on the third.

Effects: XP 6 · Karma: Human +4

BLUE Ask how a living man got into the realm of the dead

Requires: Awareness 13+

He does not know, and the not-knowing is the whole horror of it. But in the telling he mentions a doorway in a hillside, a smell of jasmine, and a woman who asked him to carry something. You write down everything he says. Some of it will matter later.

Effects: XP 16; items: Item Random · Karma: Human +3, God +2

BLUE He is not lost. He is somewhere he does not want to be.

Requires: Trait: Homesick

Lost is a thing you can fix with directions. This is the other thing, and you recognise it because you are carrying a version of it yourself.

You do not give him directions. You sit in the water next to him for a while, and then you both get up.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Water +10

BLUE Break whatever is turning him in a circle

Requires: Space Magic 3+

The loop is real and it is thin — a fold in the swamp about a mile across that returns everything to its own footprints. You cut it. The change is not visible; it is simply that the horizon means something now. He starts crying, which he seems as surprised by as you are.

Effects: XP 22; mind: Space +20 · Karma: God +6, Human +5

Sunken Village hg_sunken_village

Roof-ridges break the water in rows. A whole village went under here and did not go anywhere else — the water simply arrived and stayed, and the village kept its shape beneath it.

In the shallows at the edge, a cooking pot sits on its stones, upright, full of black water.

GREY Leave it under the water

The roof-ridges are still visible a long way down the road, whenever you look back.

GREY Work the shallow houses

Waist-deep through what used to be doorways. Cookware, tools, a strongbox nobody had time for.

Effects: XP 10; gold 80; supplies: Scrap 8 · Karma: Hungry Ghost +3

YELLOW Dive the headman's house at the centre

Roll: Constitution, difficult difficulty

If it succeeds:

Three dives. The third one gets the box out of the rafters where somebody put it when the water was already at the door.

Effects: XP 16; gold 180; items: Item Random · Karma: Hungry Ghost +3, Animal +2

If it fails: Combat: Bog Zombie (normal)

Something in the rafters is not a rafter, and it has been waiting in the dark of that room for a very long time.

Karma: Hungry Ghost +2

BLUE Say the water-rites over the whole village

Requires: Ritual 3+

You stand in the shallows and name the village — you do not know its name, so you name it by what it was: a place where people cooked and argued and slept. The water does not change. But when you go through the houses afterwards nothing objects, and in the headman's rafters you find what was hidden there, and it comes away easily.

Effects: XP 22; gold 140; items: Item Random · Karma: God +6, Human +3

Flooded Crypt hg_flooded_crypt

Stone steps go down into standing water. Whatever this was built to hold has been below the waterline for centuries, and the swamp has been patiently filling it the entire time.

The first two feet of the stair are slick with something that is not algae.

GREY Some doors stay shut

You go back up into the grey daylight, which is not much, but is more than what is down there.

YELLOW Wade in with torches

Roll: Constitution, difficult difficulty

If it succeeds:

Chest-deep, torch held over your head, through three chambers of grave-goods that nobody has been able to reach since the water came. Cold beyond describing. Worth it.

Effects: XP 18; gold 160; items: Item Random · Karma: Hungry Ghost +3

If it fails: Combat: Rotting Sentinel (hard)

The torch goes out in the second chamber. In the dark, something that has been standing in this water for four hundred years turns to face the sound of you.

Karma: Hungry Ghost +2

BLUE Part the water and walk in dry

Requires: Water Magic 4+

You push the water back down the stair and hold it there, and walk into a crypt that has not been dry since its builders sealed it. The sentinel in the third chamber is standing exactly where it was posted. It does not attack. It looks at the dry floor for a long moment and then, apparently satisfied that its watch is finally over, sits down and stops.

Effects: XP 26; gold 200; items: Item Random · Karma: God +5, Human +3

BLUE Read the seals on the doorway before opening anything

Requires: Learning 3+

The seals are not protective. They are a *containment*, and the water is part of it — whoever flooded this crypt did it on purpose and did it well. You take what is in the entry chamber, which is generous, and you leave the inner door alone, which is wisdom.

Effects: XP 20; gold 100; items: Item Random · Karma: Human +4, God +2

Cursed Well hg_cursed_well

A well, in a swamp — which is absurd, because there is water everywhere. Somebody dug down through all this wet ground looking for something cleaner, and found something else.

The rope is still on the winch. It is taut. Something is hanging on the other end of it.

GREY Leave the winch alone

The rope stays taut behind you for as long as you can see the well.

GREY Turn the winch and see what comes up

Combat: Swamp Wraith (normal)

It comes up easily. It comes up much too easily, in fact, for the weight that was on the rope.

Karma: Hungry Ghost +3

BLUE Cut the rope and let whatever it is go back down

Requires: Black Magic 2+

You can feel it up the rope like a pulse — patient, attentive, entirely aware that someone has come. You cut the rope near the winch and the tension goes out of it, and something a long way down makes a sound of what is unmistakably disappointment. Then nothing. You fill the shaft with stones for an hour to be certain.

Effects: XP 16 · Karma: God +4, Human +3

BLUE Purify the shaft

Requires: White Magic 3+

You work the rite down the shaft in stages, and what is on the rope comes apart quietly on the way up — not destroyed, released, the way a knot is released. What finally reaches the top is a bucket. In the bucket is clean water, the first you have seen in this realm, and it tastes of nothing at all, which is extraordinary.

Effects: XP 24; full restore; mind: Water +20 · Karma: God +8

Preta Feast hg_preta_feast_swamp

They have laid a table in the marsh. A real table, on real trestles, in eight inches of standing water — and on it, a banquet: rice, fruit, roast meat, all of it steaming.

The pretas are seated around it. None of them is eating. They are all just looking at it, and have been for a long time.

GREY Walk on past the table

Nobody at the table looks up as you go. The food is still steaming when you lose sight of it.

Effects: XP 4; mind: Water -8 · Karma: Animal +2

GREY Sit down and eat

It is real, and it is good, and it is the best meal you have had in weeks. Every preta at the table watches every mouthful.

Nobody stops you. Nobody says anything. You finish because stopping halfway would somehow be worse.

Effects: XP 8; supplies: Food 10; mind: Water -20, Fire +10 · Karma: Hungry Ghost +6

BLUE Take a bowl and feed the nearest one by hand

Requires: Medicine 3+

The throat is the width of a straw and the swallowing has to be taught — small, slow, wait, again. It takes twenty minutes to get four mouthfuls into her. She keeps them down. The others watch this happen with an attention that is difficult to be the subject of. When you leave, three of them have moved their chairs closer to hers.

Effects: XP 22; mind: Water +20 · Karma: God +8, Human +4

BLUE Look at what is actually on the table first.

Requires: Trait: Sworn Vegetarian

You look, and having looked you decline, and the declining is easy in a way it has not been easy for years.

The pretas cannot make you want it. They have nothing else to offer and drift off to find someone who can be worked with.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Fire +10, Earth +8

BLUE Ask why nobody is eating

Requires: Yoga 3+

"Because it will end," says the one at the head of the table, without looking away from the rice. "While we do not begin, it is still whole." You sit with that for a while. Then you point out, gently, that the food is going cold, and that this is also an ending, and that it is happening whether or not anyone begins. There is a very long silence. Then somebody picks up a spoon.

Effects: XP 26; mind: Water +25, Space +15 · Karma: God +10, Human +4

Medicinal Garden hg_medicinal_garden

Something is growing here on purpose. Beds of herbs in ordered rows, staked and labelled, tended in a place where nothing should tend anything — and the labels are in a careful hand, in a language you half-recognise.

A preserved one straightens up from the weeding and regards you without alarm. "Patients or customers?"

GREY Customers

Opens: The Dré Herbalist

She lays out what is dried and ready, and prices it fairly.

GREY Neither — apologise for the intrusion

"Mm," she says, and goes back to the weeding. "Mind the third bed."

BLUE Offer your hands for the afternoon

Requires: Medicine 3+

She sets you thinning the third bed and does not explain why it matters until you have done it correctly, at which point she explains at length and with real pleasure. Nothing grows well in this realm; everything here grows because she made it. You leave with your kit restocked and an open invitation.

Effects: XP 18; supplies: Herbs 14, Reagents 6 · Karma: Human +5, God +3

BLUE Ask for the thing that helps rather than the thing that cures.

Requires: Trait: Chronic Pain

The gardener stops what she is doing. It is, apparently, a much rarer request than the other one and a considerably easier one to fulfil.

What she gives you will not fix anything. It makes tomorrow's walking possible, which is the whole of what you asked for.

Effects: supplies: Herbs 5; XP 15

BLUE Ask about the beds she has not mentioned.

Requires: Trait: Bhang Enjoyer

She has not mentioned them because most people do not ask, and most people who do ask are not asking about medicine. She establishes which you are with one question, and appears satisfied with the answer.

Effects: supplies: Herbs 4; XP 20

BLUE Ask how anything grows in the realm of hunger

Requires: Earth Magic 3+

"It doesn't," she says. "I feed it." She shows you the trench at the garden's edge, where she has been composting her own substance — a little at a time, for a very long time, into the soil. She is markedly less than she was when she started. She considers this an entirely reasonable arrangement and will not be argued with.

Effects: XP 24; supplies: Herbs 8; mind: Earth +20, Water -10 · Karma: God +6, Human +4

Grave Hound hg_graveyard_dog

It is standing on a grave mound with its head down and its green eyes fixed on you, and it has not decided yet. A grave hound alone is a guard; a grave hound in a pack is a problem. This one is alone.

Behind it, the mound has been dug at. Not by the hound.

GREY Put it down**Combat: Grave Hound (normal)**

Karma: Animal +3, Asura +2

GREY Throw it food and go around

Cost: Food (small)

It takes the meat back onto the mound and eats there, watching you the whole time, guarding even while it chews.

Effects: XP 6 · Karma: Animal +3, Human +2

BLUE Look at what dug the mound

Requires: Awareness 13+

Tool marks, not claws — somebody came for this grave with a spade and left in a hurry. The hound is not guarding the grave from you; it is guarding it from whoever is coming back. You reset the turf and stack stones over it while the hound watches, and when you finish it lies down. It is still lying there when you look back.

Effects: XP 16 · Karma: Human +4, Animal +4

BLUE It is a dog. You are going to do this whatever anyone says.

Requires: Trait: Pet-lover

It is a dog in the way that a burnt-out house is a house, and you go toward it anyway with your hand out, and the party makes noises.

It lets you. It has apparently been standing on that grave for a very long time and nobody has offered it anything since.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Water +10 · Karma: Animal +4

BLUE Speak to it the way you would to a working dog

Requires: Summoning 2+

Low voice, no eye contact, hand held out flat and still. Whatever it is now, it was a dog once, and something in the shape of the address gets through. It comes down off the mound and walks you a quarter mile to the graveyard's edge, and turns back at the boundary of what it considers its ground.

Effects: XP 14; items: Item Random · Karma: Animal +5, Human +2

Skeleton Army hg_skeleton_army

They are drawn up in ranks across the whole width of the dry valley, and they are not moving. Rank on rank of skeleton infantry in the armour of an army that lost — you can tell it lost, because it is all still here.

They are facing an enemy that is no longer present. They have been facing it for a very long time.

GREY Go around the flank, quietly

Two hours of picking along the valley wall while ten thousand skulls face resolutely the other way. Not one of them turns.

Effects: XP 8 · Karma: Human +2

GREY Walk straight through the ranks

Combat: Skeleton Warband (hard)

You are six ranks deep when the nearest one registers that something has entered the formation, and the correction ripples outward.

Karma: Asura +3, Hungry Ghost +2

BLUE Give the order to stand down

Requires: Leadership 5+

You walk to the front, face the ranks, and dismiss them — properly, with the form and the cadence, the way it is done at the end of a campaign. It takes a moment. Then ten thousand skeletons ground their arms in one enormous rattling crash and the formation simply ceases to be a formation. Some of them sit down. Most of them come apart. What is left is a valley full of bones and a great deal of abandoned equipment.

Effects: XP 30; gold 220; items: Item Random; supplies: Scrap 20 · Karma: God +8, Human +5

BLUE Ranks do not attack what walks through them like it belongs.

Requires: Trait: Composed

You walk down the middle at an even pace with your hands where they can be seen, and you do not speed up at any point, including the point at which the second rank turns its head.

They close behind you. Nothing else happens.

Effects: gains trait: Composed; XP 12; mind: Water +10

BLUE Work out what they are still facing

Requires: Learning 4+

The line is anchored on high ground at both ends and refused on the left — a textbook defensive deployment against cavalry that would have come from the north. There is no north army. There has not been for centuries. But there is a supply train behind the line, unlooted, because nobody has ever gotten past the ranks to it.

Effects: XP 20; gold 160; supplies: Food 12, Scrap 10 · Karma: Human +3, Hungry Ghost +2

Ancient Crypt hg_ancient_crypt

The crypt door is stone, and it is ajar — about a hand's width, which is both an invitation and a warning depending on which side of it opened.

Dry air comes out. It smells of dust and cold iron and nothing organic at all.

GREY Pull the door to and walk away

The stone grinds shut. It takes both hands and most of your weight, and it feels like the right thing to have done.

GREY Go in

Combat: Skeleton Warrior Pair (normal)

Two of them are standing just inside the door, one to each side, in the dark. They have been standing there since the door was last closed.

After victory:

Past the door-guards, the crypt is undisturbed and generously furnished.

Karma: Hungry Ghost +3

BLUE Listen at the gap before you open it

Requires: Awareness 14+

Nothing breathes in there, but something *shifts* — twice, at an interval, the way a person shifts weight when they have been standing a long time. Two of them, flanking the door. You open it wide instead of squeezing through, and take them from outside with the light behind you, which turns a bad fight into a short one.

Effects: XP 18; gold 160; items: Item Random · Karma: Human +3, Hungry Ghost +2

BLUE Read the door before touching it

Requires: Ritual 3+

The inscription is a service contract. The two inside are not guardians in any hostile sense — they are staff, on a term of duty that expired four hundred years ago because the family that hired them stopped existing. You go in and tell them so. There is a pause you would describe as stunned. Then they hand over the keys, formally, and lie down in the alcoves they were meant to occupy in the first place.

Effects: XP 26; gold 180; items: Item Random · Karma: God +6, Human +4

Crumbling Mausoleum hg_crumbling_mausoleum

It was grand once and it is coming apart now — the roof half in, one wall bowed outward, the whole structure held up mostly by the habit of standing. Inside, the sarcophagi are visible through the gaps.

Something moves in there when the wind does. It may only be the wind.

GREY It will fall on someone. Not you.

You give it a wide berth. Behind you, a stone comes off the parapet and lands where nobody is standing.

YELLOW Get in, get what is reachable, get out

Roll: Finesse, difficult difficulty

If it succeeds:

In through the gap in the bowed wall, two sarcophagi levered open, out before the dust settles. The roof comes down about ten minutes later. Nobody was under it.

Effects: XP 16; gold 150; items: Item Random · Karma: Hungry Ghost +3

If it fails:

The lid you are levering is load-bearing, which is not a sentence anyone wants to discover from underneath. You get out. Most of the building does not.

Effects: XP 5; HP loss (moderate, random); wound: Broken Rib · Karma: Hungry Ghost +2

BLUE Prop the wall before anyone goes in

Requires: Smithing 3+

Two hours of bracing with timber cut from grave-markers, which is grim but effective. With the wall held you can work the whole interior properly instead of snatching at what is nearest, and there is a great deal more in the back than there was in the front.

Effects: XP 22; gold 240; items: Item Random; supplies: Scrap -4 · Karma: Human +4, Hungry Ghost +2

BLUE Read the family names and give them their rites

Requires: White Magic 3+

Eleven names, four generations, one family line that ended here. You say each name aloud in the ruin of their house. Nothing dramatic happens. But the movement in the back of the mausoleum stops, and stays stopped, and when you leave the grave-goods are simply objects rather than the other thing they had been.

Effects: XP 24; gold 120; items: Item Random · Karma: God +7, Human +3

The Forgotten King hg_forgotten_king

The tomb is the largest thing in the graveyard and every inscription on it has been chiselled out — thoroughly, deliberately, by people who wanted this specific man erased and had the time to do it properly.

Inside, on a throne, he is still sitting. He turns his head as you enter. "Do you know my name?"

GREY "No."

"No," he agrees. "Nobody does. That was the sentence." He sits back. He does not attack, does not threaten, does not ask for anything. After a while it becomes clear the audience is simply over, and you leave him in the dark he has been sitting in for eight hundred years.

Effects: XP 10; mind: Space -10 · Karma: Human +3

GREY Whatever he was, he is a corpse on a chair now

Combat: Skeleton Elite (hard)

He rises with the enormous unhurried dignity of a man who has been waiting a long time for something to happen.

Karma: Asura +3, Hungry Ghost +3

BLUE Reconstruct the name from what the chisels missed

Requires: Learning 5+

They were thorough on the walls and careless underneath — the mason's setting-out marks are still there, cut deep and never intended to be read. You work it letter by letter and then say it out loud.

The effect is not gratitude. He goes very still, and then he begins, quietly and with great precision, to come apart, because being named was the only thing still holding the shape together. What is left on the throne is a crown and a considerable quantity of dust.

Effects: XP 30; gold 200; items: Item Random · Karma: God +6, Human +4

BLUE Sit down on the step and keep him company a while

Requires: Yoga 4+

You do not ask him anything and you do not tell him anything. You sit on the tomb step for a couple of hours in the company of a man whose entire punishment was to be alone with himself indefinitely. Eventually he says, "Thank you," in a voice that has clearly not been used for that before. He is still there when you go. But he is sitting differently.

Effects: XP 26; mind: Space +20, Water +15 · Karma: God +9, Human +4

Dusty Library hg_dusty_library

A reading room, intact, under a collapsed roof that fell in such a way as to shelter rather than crush it. Shelves of scroll-cases, a desk, a chair pushed back as though someone stood up mid-sentence.

On the desk, a document is still weighted flat, half-copied, the ink long dry.

GREY Leave the room as you found it

You put the weight back on the corner of the document on your way out, which is a small courtesy to nobody in particular.

GREY Take whatever looks valuable

Scroll-cases of good bronze, a silver inkwell, and three documents that look important enough to sell to somebody.

Effects: XP 8; gold 90; items: Item Random · Karma: Hungry Ghost +3

BLUE Read the half-copied document

Requires: Learning 4+

It is a commentary on a sutra you know, and the copyist was arguing with it in the margins — sharp, funny, occasionally wrong, entirely alive. The hand stops mid-word. You finish the sentence yourself, in your own hand, underneath, because it is obvious how it was going to end and it seems a shame to leave it hanging.

Effects: XP 22; learns a spell; mind: Space +15 · Karma: Human +5, God +3

BLUE A collapsed roof over wet paper. Move on.

Requires: Trait: Incurious

You move on. The roof comes down the rest of the way about an hour later, which you hear from some distance and do not go back to investigate.

Effects: mind: Space -5; XP 22

BLUE Work out what the collection was **for**

Requires: Ritual 3+

It is not a general library. Every text is on one subject, approached from every possible angle over what must have been decades: how to die correctly. Somebody in this realm spent a lifetime studying the thing they were about to fail at. The final shelf is practical instructions, and they are good ones.

Effects: XP 24; items: Item Random; Ritual +1 · Karma: God +5, Human +3

Bone Collector hg_bone_collector

He works the graveyard with a handcart and a system, and he is extremely particular: he takes only certain bones, only from certain graves, and he is keeping a tally on a wax tablet.

"Femurs," he says, before you can ask. "Matched pairs. You would be amazed how hard that is."

GREY Leave him to it

The handcart creaks away between the mounds. He is whistling.

GREY Ask what he is building

"A bridge," he says, with the patience of a man who gets asked a lot. "Over the chasm on the north road. Been at it eleven years." He shows you the plans. They are competent. He is entirely serious.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: Human +3

BLUE Help him find matched pairs

Requires: Medicine 3+

You know what he does not: matched femurs are far easier to find if you stop opening random graves and start reading the markers for age at death. Inside an hour you have found him six pairs, which is better than his last two months. He is so pleased he gives you his spare tools and a genuinely useful map of the graveyard's dry routes.

Effects: XP 18; items: Item Random; supplies: Scrap 6 · Karma: Human +5, Hungry Ghost +2

BLUE Ask whether the dead consented to being a bridge

Requires: Yoga 3+

He stops the cart. It is clear nobody has ever put it to him and equally clear he has put it to himself, many times, at night. "They're not using them," he says, and then, after a while: "I ask. Every one. If it feels wrong I put it back." He shows you the reject pile. It is much larger than the cart.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Earth +15 · Karma: God +4, Human +4

Ancestor Spirit hg_ancestor_spirit

The shrine is small and very old and somebody has been maintaining it — swept, the offering-bowl clean, fresh dust patterns raked around the base. Above it hangs a presence rather than a shape.

"You are not of my line," it says. It does not sound disappointed. It sounds like it is checking.

GREY Bow and continue

"Go well," it says, and the presence settles back into the raked dust.

Effects: XP 4 · Karma: Human +2

GREY Leave something in the bowl anyway

Cost: Gold (small)

"Not of my line," it observes again, differently this time. The offering is accepted. Something eases in the air around the shrine that had been held for a long time.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: God +4, Human +3

BLUE Ask who has been sweeping the shrine

Requires: Awareness 13+

Silence. Then: "I do." An ancestor spirit with no descendants left, maintaining its own shrine, raking its own dust, keeping up the observances for a family that ended. It has not admitted this out loud before. You spend an hour helping with the raking and it talks the entire time, about people eight hundred years dead, and you listen.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Water +15 · Karma: God +6, Human +5

BLUE Somebody has been maintaining this. Take a turn.

Requires: Trait: Mourner

The offerings are recent and the cloth has been changed within the month, which means somebody is walking a long way to do this and will not always be able to.

You do what they have been doing, and you leave the shrine better stocked than you found it.

Effects: XP 30; supplies: Food -2 · Karma: Human +4, Hungry Ghost -4

BLUE Offer to carry the line

Requires: Ritual 4+

There is a rite for this — adoption across the line of death, so a family that has run out of living can be continued by someone willing to take the observance on. It is not a small thing to accept. You do it properly, with the responses, and the presence at the shrine becomes something with a stake in whether you live.

It gives you what it has: its name, its protection, and the contents of a grave nobody else knows about.

Effects: XP 28; gold 180; items: Item Random; gains trait: Devout · Karma: God +10, Human +5

Bone Shrine hg_bone_shrine

Skulls set into a cairn in a spiral, each one facing outward, each one with a small offering wedged into the eye socket — a coin, a bead, a folded scrap.

It is either a place of great devotion or a place of great warning, and the two are not always different.

GREY Pass without touching anything

Every socket you pass is looking somewhere else. That is the intended effect and it works.

GREY Add your own offering to an empty socket

Cost: Gold (small)

There is exactly one empty socket, at the centre of the spiral, and it takes your coin as though it had been waiting for that specific denomination. The air over the cairn goes briefly warm.

Effects: XP 12; buff: Armor +4 · Karma: God +5

YELLOW Empty the sockets

Roll: Finesse, difficult difficulty

If it succeeds:

Forty-odd offerings, some of them very old and one of them gold. You are three miles away before you stop feeling watched, and you never entirely stop.

Effects: XP 12; gold 190 · Karma: Hungry Ghost +8, Hell +3

If it fails: Combat: Bone Pack (normal)

The spiral is a ward and the offerings are what holds it closed. The third socket you empty opens it.

Karma: Hungry Ghost +4

BLUE Read the spiral

Requires: Ritual 3+

It is a containment, wound outward, and the offerings are the seal — each one a small debt paid on behalf of whatever is under the cairn. It has been maintained by passing strangers for centuries without any of them knowing what they were maintaining. You pay your share, tighten the two sockets that had gone loose, and leave it in better repair than you found it.

Effects: XP 22 · Karma: God +7, Human +3

Grave Goods hg_grave_goods

A grave has opened itself — the earth has subsided rather than been dug, and the contents are simply lying there in the depression, exposed to the grey daylight.

Someone was buried well. Bronze, worked cloth, a sword still in a scabbard, all of it a hand's reach away and nobody's.

GREY Take it

It is good gear and it is on the surface and there is no argument to be had with a hole in the ground. You take it and you do not linger.

Effects: XP 8; gold 120; items: Item Random; gains trait: Covetous · Karma: Hungry Ghost +4

GREY Push the earth back over it

An hour with your hands and a broken marker for a spade. When you have finished you cannot tell there was ever a subsidence, which is the point.

Effects: XP 10; gains trait: Merciful · Karma: God +5, Human +3

BLUE Ask the occupant

Requires: Black Magic 3+

She is still in there and she is entirely lucid and she has been listening to people discuss her possessions for two hundred years without once being consulted. Being asked improves her mood immeasurably. She grants you the sword, declines to part with the cloth, and asks — as her condition — that you push the earth back afterwards, which you do.

Effects: XP 22; items: Item Random; gold 60 · Karma: Human +5, God +3

BLUE **It is in the open. That makes it nobody's.**

Requires: Trait: Greedy

You have the reasoning worked out before your hand arrives, which is the sign of a well-practised reasoning.

The goods are real, valuable, and will be missed by something that is still nearby.

Effects: gold moderate; mind: Earth -10; XP 18 · Karma: Hungry Ghost +5

BLUE **Work out why the ground gave way**

Requires: Earth Magic 3+

There is a void under this whole section of the graveyard — something hollowed it out from below, recently, and this grave is simply the first to notice. You mark the extent of it, which takes an afternoon, and the map you make of where not to walk is worth more than the grave goods. You take those too, since the occupant is about to have a much worse problem.

Effects: XP 20; gold 110; items: Item Random · Karma: Human +3, Hungry Ghost +2

Weary Pilgrim hg_weary_pilgrim

A skeleton in a pilgrim's robe sits at the roadside with its staff across its knees, facing the direction it was going. Prayer-flags, long since bleached white, are tied to the staff head.

"Is it much further?" it asks. It does not say to where.

GREY **"Not much further."**

"Good," it says, and gets up, and sets off in the direction it was facing at a pace that suggests it believes you. You watch it go. You have no idea whether you told it the truth.

Effects: XP 8 · Karma: Human +3, God +2

GREY **Sit down beside it for a while**

Neither of you says anything for a long time. It is restful in a way very little in this realm is. When you stand up to go it lifts the staff an inch off its knees in farewell.

Effects: XP 10; mind: Earth +12 · Karma: Human +4

BLUE **Ask where the pilgrimage was going**

Requires: Charm 13+

It cannot remember the destination, only the walking, and it is not distressed by this — it stopped needing the destination somewhere around the fourth century. "The road was the observance," it says. "I just liked to have somewhere to point it."

It gives you its spare flags, which it has been carrying for no reason it can name.

Effects: XP 16; items: Item Random · Karma: God +5, Human +3

BLUE **You know this particular tiredness.**

Requires: Trait: Pilgrim

It is not the walking. It is never the walking — it is the arithmetic of how much road is left against how much of you there is.

You sit down at the roadside with it and do not offer any encouragement, which is what it needed and what nobody else has managed.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Earth +10 · Karma: Human +3

BLUE **Walk with it as far as you are going**

Requires: Yoga 3+

Six miles of shared road, in step, in silence, with a dead pilgrim who has been walking since before your language existed.

Around the fourth mile you stop being someone accompanying it and start simply being on a pilgrimage, and the difference is not subtle. At the crossroads it goes one way and you go the other and both of you are, briefly, going somewhere.

Effects: XP 24; mind: Earth +20, Space +15 · Karma: God +8, Human +3

The Ossuary hg_ossuary_bargain

Bones stacked to the vaulted ceiling, sorted by type, in a building constructed entirely for that purpose. At a counter near the door, a skeleton in a clerk's visor is doing sums in a ledger.

"Buying, selling, or storing?" it asks. "We do all three. Storage is where the money is."

GREY Buying

Opens: Bone Merchant

The clerk produces a second ledger and a surprisingly good selection.

GREY Just looking

"Everyone says that," the clerk says, and goes back to the sums.

BLUE Look at the ledger

Requires: Trade 4+

The storage business is running at a loss and has been for eighty years — the clerk has been discounting long-term contracts against a currency that stopped existing. You show it the error. It goes very quiet, recalculates two centuries of accounts in about four minutes, and then, being fundamentally honest, insists on paying you a consultant's fee out of the correction.

Effects: XP 20; gold 200 · Karma: Human +5

BLUE Read all of it before agreeing to any of it.

Requires: Trait: Oath-keeper

You read all of it. You are not agreeing to something you have not read; you have never been able to, and it has cost you opportunities.

This time it costs the ossuary keeper an hour and you the clause on the fourth page, which was going to be the expensive one.

Effects: XP 20

BLUE Ask who is paying for all this storage

Requires: Awareness 14+

The contracts are prepaid, in perpetuity, by the deceased themselves — every skeleton in this building is a client who arranged its own indefinite safekeeping rather than risk being scattered. It is not a warehouse. It is a very long-term hotel, and the clerk is the concierge, and it takes the duty extremely seriously.

Effects: XP 18; items: Item Random · Karma: Human +4, Hungry Ghost +2

Vetala Court hg_vetala_court

They have taken over what was once a hall and turned it into something between a salon and a slaughterhouse. Perhaps thirty vetala, beautifully dressed, holding a conversation of extraordinary wit across a floor that has not been cleaned in living memory.

The talk stops. Thirty faces turn with the same expression: delight.

GREY You are not going to talk your way out of thirty

Combat: Vetala Elder Court (very_hard)

Karma: Asura +4, Hell +2

GREY Bow, apologise for interrupting, and back out

The courtesy is so unexpected that it works. Somebody laughs; somebody else says "oh, let it go"; the conversation resumes behind you as though you had been a draught from an open door.

Effects: XP 8 · Karma: Human +3

BLUE Take a seat and hold your own

Requires: Charm 15+

The rule of the court, you work out fast, is that dullness is the only capital offence. You are interesting for two hours — genuinely, exhaustingly interesting — and at the end of it a vetala in green raises her glass and says, "We shall not eat this one," and the matter is settled by acclamation. They send you off with gifts and directions and an open invitation you will never use.

Effects: XP 26; gold 160; items: Item Random · Karma: Human +5, Hungry Ghost +3

BLUE Observe the forms of a vetala court exactly

Requires: Black Magic 4+

There is a protocol for a living guest and almost nobody alive has ever known it. You give the greeting, present the required token, and take the low seat without being told to. The effect is roughly that of a peasant walking into a royal audience and getting every bow right. They are charmed, scandalised, and obliged — the forms bind both ways, and now they cannot touch you.

Effects: XP 28; learns a spell (Black Magic) · Karma: Hungry Ghost +4, Human +3

Vetala's Offer hg_vetala_bargain

It is sitting on a wall, swinging its heels, and it has clearly been waiting for someone specifically your size.

"A trade," it says. "Your body for a day and a night. I have errands. You get everything I know — and I know a great deal — and I give it back exactly as I found it. I have never once failed to give it back."

GREY Refuse

"Worth asking," it says, unoffended, and goes back to swinging its heels. "Someone always says yes eventually."

Effects: XP 5 · Karma: Human +3

GREY Accept the bargain

You wake a day and a night later exactly where you lay down, with everything where you left it and a head full of somebody else's knowledge — genuinely useful, precisely as promised. Your hands smell faintly of smoke. Nobody in the party will tell you what they saw you doing, and you decide, on balance, not to press.

Effects: XP 24; learns a spell (Black Magic); mind: Space -20; gains trait: Oath-breaker · Karma: Hungry Ghost +6, Hell +2

BLUE Accept — but negotiate the terms first

Requires: Persuasion 5+

Four hours of hard bargaining. You get: a witness, a fixed return time, a prohibition on violence while wearing you, and the knowledge transferred up front. It agrees to all of it, with increasing respect, and then keeps every clause to the letter — because a vetala that breaks terms in front of a witness stops being able to make bargains, and bargains are what it eats.

Effects: XP 30; learns a spell (Black Magic); gold 120 · Karma: Human +5, Hungry Ghost +3

BLUE You know what it is going to ask for, because you have given it before.

Requires: Trait: Oath-breaker

It wants a promise. It does not much care what the promise is about — the value is in the breaking, later, when it can be collected on.

You recognise the shape because you have been on the other side of it, and you decline in terms it finds genuinely disappointing.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Earth +10

BLUE Ask what happened to the ones who said yes

Requires: Awareness 15+

"Returned. Every one." True, and not the answer. You keep asking, and eventually get the rest: returned, yes — but a body worn by a vetala for a day and a night is a body that has been *somewhere*, and the ones who said yes have all, without exception, come back a little easier to persuade the second time. It admits this freely. It considers it a feature.

Effects: XP 22; mind: Space +15 · Karma: Human +4, God +3

Illusory Palace hg_illusory_palace

A palace stands where there was nothing an hour ago: lit windows, music, the smell of food, a door standing open onto warm light.

Everything in this realm is grey and cold and starving. This is none of those things, which tells you everything you need to know and does not make it one bit easier to walk past.

GREY Walk past without looking in the windows

It takes more out of the party than the last three fights combined. Half a mile on, the music stops abruptly, mid-phrase.

Effects: XP 12; mind: Fire -10 · Karma: God +4, Human +3

GREY Go in**Combat: Vetala With Minions (hard)**

The warmth lasts about as long as it takes for the door to close. Then the hall is a charnel pit with a very good acoustic, and the hosts are already seated.

Karma: Hungry Ghost +4

BLUE Take the illusion apart from outside

Requires: Space Magic 4+

It is an excellent working — layered, self-repairing, with the smell built in, which is the part most illusionists skip. You unpick it from the outside like a knitted seam. Underneath is a pit with fourteen vetala in it looking extremely startled and, for the moment, extremely visible.

Effects: XP 26; gold 140; items: Item Random · Karma: Human +4, God +3

BLUE A palace was not here an hour ago.

Requires: Trait: Suspicious

A palace was not here an hour ago, and you say so, repeatedly, until the party stops arguing about it.

You make camp at a distance and watch. At some point in the small hours the lit windows go out one row at a time, which settles the matter.

Effects: XP 15; mind: Air +8

BLUE It is a warm building with the door open.

Requires: Trait: Trusting

It is. You are three rooms in and being handed something warm before anyone else has crossed the threshold.

What saves you is that you are genuinely, transparently pleased to be there, and whatever runs the palace finds it has nothing to work with. It lets you go, baffled.

Effects: XP 15; mind: Water +8

BLUE Go in, take nothing, eat nothing, leave

Requires: Yoga 5+

You walk the whole length of the hall through the music and the light and the smell of roast lamb, decline everything offered with perfect courtesy, and go out the far door. The hosts cannot touch a guest who accepts no hospitality; that is the entire rule the illusion is built to exploit, and you have simply not broken it. Behind you somebody throws a plate.

Effects: XP 30; mind: Fire +25, Space +20 · Karma: God +10, Human +3

Glittering Trove hg_illusory_treasure

A hoard, unattended, in the open: coin and plate and gemwork heaped against the base of a bone-wall, glittering in a realm that does not glitter.

There are no tracks around it. There is no reason for it to be here. It is, objectively, the single most suspicious object any of you has ever seen.

GREY Obviously not

You keep walking. The party discusses it for the next hour in the tone of people reassuring themselves.

Effects: XP 6 · Karma: Human +3

GREY Grab an armful and run

Combat: Hungry Wraith (hard)

The moment your hands close on it the hoard is a hand's-breadth of gravel and something that has been lying underneath it for a long time is sitting up.

Effects: gains trait: Covetous · Karma: Hungry Ghost +5

BLUE Test it from a safe distance first

Requires: Awareness 14+

You throw a stone into it. The stone does not clink; it lands with the soft sound of gravel. Everything above the third layer is glamour over grit — but the bottom layer, interestingly, is real, and the thing guarding it is asleep. You take the real part slowly and leave the glitter for the next fool.

Effects: XP 20; gold 150; items: Item Random · Karma: Human +3, Hungry Ghost +2

BLUE You have already started walking toward it.

Requires: Trait: Covetous

You have. Someone catches your arm and you shake it off, and the arm-catcher lets you go because there is a limit to how much you can save a person from themselves.

What you come back with is worthless and you carry it for two days before admitting that.

Effects: mind: Air -12, Earth -8; XP 22

BLUE Look at the light on it. Light does not do that.

Requires: Trait: Clear-eyed

Light does not do that. It takes about four seconds once you are looking at the right thing, and the right thing is never the treasure.

You can see where whatever laid it is waiting, too, which is more useful than the hoard would have been.

Effects: XP 15

BLUE Use the bait against whatever set it

Requires: Guile 4+

You rig the hoard — a tripline, a deadfall of bone-wall masonry, and a very convincing set of fresh footprints leading up to it. Then you wait uphill. What comes to collect the next victim collects a quarter ton of wall instead. Its own hoard, it turns out, is somewhere much better hidden and now unguarded.

Effects: XP 26; gold 240; items: Item Random · Karma: Asura +4, Hungry Ghost +2

The Feasting Hall hg_feasting_hall_trap

Long tables, laid for a hundred, in a hall with the roof still on. Food on every platter. Every chair occupied by something that was a guest once and has not left the table since.

At the head, one chair is empty, and a place is set at it. The setting is clean. It has been kept clean.

GREY Back out the way you came

Nothing at the tables moves. The empty chair stays empty. You are extremely aware of the clean place-setting for a long time afterwards.

Effects: XP 8 · Karma: Human +3

GREY Sit in the empty chair

Combat: Vetala Noble (hard)

A hundred heads turn as one. The host has been waiting a very long time for the last guest to arrive, and you have just accepted the invitation.

Karma: Hungry Ghost +5

BLUE Work out what the seating means

Requires: Learning 4+

The guests are arranged by precedence and the empty chair is not the host's — it is the *guest of honour's*, and it is set for someone who never came. This entire hall has been holding a place at a party for a person who declined the invitation, for four hundred years, out of spite. You do not sit down. You do steal the silver, which is superb, and nothing at the tables has any protocol for that.

Effects: XP 24; gold 200; items: Item Random · Karma: Human +4, Hungry Ghost +2

BLUE Dismiss the guests

Requires: White Magic 4+

You go to the head of the table, take the clean place-setting, and clear it — which is, in the grammar of the hall, the host announcing that the last guest is not coming and the meal is over. A hundred bound guests are released from a dinner party at once. Several of them weep. Most simply come apart with an air of enormous relief.

Effects: XP 30; gold 150; mind: Water +20 · Karma: God +10, Human +4

Uninvited Guest hg_body_possession

One of your party stops walking. Turns around. Smiles.

It is not their smile. The face is doing something faces do not do, and when it speaks the voice is right and the cadence is entirely wrong: "Oh, this is a *good* one. Strong legs. Do you know how long I've been on foot?"

GREY Beat it out

Combat: Charnel Wraith (normal)

It abandons the body the instant real damage starts — vetala are pragmatists — and comes out fighting in its own shape, furious about the inconvenience.

Effects: HP loss (light, random); gains trait: Harrowed · Karma: Asura +3

GREY Negotiate for its departure

Cost: Gold (moderate)

It wants passage, not the body specifically — it is simply tired of walking. You pay it off. It leaves without argument and with genuine thanks, and your companion drops to their knees swearing in a language nobody knew they spoke.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: Hungry Ghost +3, Human +2

BLUE Put it out properly

Requires: White Magic 3+

The rite is short and extremely unpleasant for everyone in the room. It comes out backwards, complaining bitterly about professional courtesy, and is gone before it hits the ground. Your companion is fine. Your companion is going to want to talk about this later.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Space -10 · Karma: God +6, Human +3

BLUE Whatever is in there is in one of yours. Do not let go.

Requires: Trait: Grudge-bearer

You do not let go. This is the one circumstance in which the thing that is wrong with you is exactly the thing required.

It tries several exits. You are still holding the arm at the end of it, and the face that comes back is the right one.

Effects: XP 22; mind: Water -8

BLUE It is in there. Ask it things while it is

Requires: Black Magic 4+

A possessing spirit is, briefly, a captive audience — it cannot leave without giving up the body, and it does not want to give up the body. You spend a fascinating and deeply unethical twenty minutes interrogating it about the charnel grounds, the courts, and who exactly rules here. Then you let it out. Your companion is going to want to talk about this too, and rather more loudly.

Effects: XP 26; gold 80; items: Item Random; mind: Space -15 · Karma: Hungry Ghost +4, Human -2

Corpse Sorcerer hg_sorcerer_of_corpses

He is working on a body laid out on a stone bench, and the work is precise — thread, needle, small silver instruments, a diagram weighted at the corners.

"Don't jog the table," he says without looking up. "I have been at this since the moon was somewhere else."

GREY Do not jog the table. Leave.

The needle goes in and out. He does not notice you go.

GREY Whatever he is making, stop him making it

Combat: Corpse Sorcerer (hard)

Karma: God +3, Asura +3

BLUE Offer to hold the retractors

Requires: Medicine 4+

He accepts instantly and without surprise, which tells you how long it has been since he had help. Four hours of surgery on a corpse, conducted with total professional courtesy in a place that smells the way this place smells. What he is building turns out to be a body for a friend who lost theirs. He pays you in reagents and technique.

Effects: XP 24; supplies: Reagents 12; items: Item Random; Medicine +1 · Karma: Human +4, Hungry Ghost +3

BLUE Read the diagram he is working from

Requires: Black Magic 4+

It is a binding, and it is beautiful work, and it is also — you check twice — inverted at the third node, which means when he finishes, the thing on the table will not be bound to him. It will be bound to nobody, and it will be very strong. You point at the node. There is a long silence while he traces it himself. Then he sits down heavily on the floor and says a word you have not heard before.

Effects: XP 28; learns a spell (Black Magic); gold 100 · Karma: God +4, Human +4

Bone Tower hg_bone_tower

Nine storeys of fused bone, tapering, with a stair spiralling up the outside and no rail. It serves no obvious purpose. Nothing lives in it. It simply goes up.

At the base, cut into the lowest course, one word in an old script: HIGHER.

GREY Leave it standing

It is visible from a very long way off, in every direction, for the rest of the day.

YELLOW Climb it

Roll: Finesse, difficult difficulty

If it succeeds:

Nine storeys of no rail. At the top there is a flat platform, a stone bench, and a view of the entire charnel grounds — every fire, every court, every road — laid out like a map somebody drew for you. You sit on the bench for an hour and learn more about this realm than in all the walking that got you here.

Effects: XP 22; items: Item Random; mind: Air +20 · Karma: Human +3, God +3

If it fails:

Somewhere around the sixth storey the wind gets under the party and everyone's nerve goes at once. Coming down is worse than going up. Somebody is sick over the side from a great height.

Effects: XP 6; HP loss (light, random); mind: Air -12 · Karma: Animal +2

BLUE Work out what it is for

Requires: Learning 4+

It is a practice structure. The bench at the top faces west; the whole thing is oriented for a specific meditation done at a specific hour, and the climb without a rail is not an obstacle but the first part of the exercise. Somebody built a nine-storey teaching aid out of bones and then, presumably, used it.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Space +15 · Karma: God +4, Human +2

BLUE Climb it and do what it was built for

Requires: Yoga 5+

Up without a rail, sit facing west, and do the thing the structure is asking for — which becomes obvious the moment you are seated, because the whole tower has been shaped to make one particular state of mind the easiest thing available. Whoever built this was extremely good. You come down at dusk not entirely the same.

Effects: XP 32; mind: Space +30, Air +20 · Karma: God +10

Royal Messenger hg_king_messenger

A skeleton in the Skeleton King's copper livery reins in a bone horse beside you, unrolls a scroll, and reads without preamble:

"To the living party currently trespassing in the charnel grounds: the King of the Setting Sun requires your attendance. Or your absence. He is flexible. He requires you to choose, in writing, today."

GREY Sign the attendance

The messenger countersigns, stamps it, gives you the counterfoil, and departs at speed. You are now, formally, expected somewhere. It is oddly steady to have an appointment.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: Human +3

GREY Sign the absence

"Sensible," says the messenger, entirely off the record, and stamps it. "Between us: the ones who attend are usually still there." It gives you a route that avoids the bone city and will not accept payment for the favour.

Effects: XP 12 · Karma: Human +3, Hungry Ghost +2

GREY Refuse to sign anything

Combat: Skeleton Patrol (normal)

The messenger sighs, rolls the scroll, and raises one hand. The escort you had not noticed comes out of the bone-scrub on three sides.

Karma: Asura +3

BLUE A messenger has been everywhere. Keep him talking.

Requires: Trait: Gossip

He has orders and a schedule and neither of them survive twenty minutes of being asked, with evident interest, about places he has recently been.

By the time he remembers the schedule you know the state of three roads and one court.

Effects: XP 20

BLUE Amend the document before signing

Requires: Trade 4+

You add two clauses in the margin: attendance at a time of your choosing, and safe conduct both ways. The messenger reads them, reads them again, and gets down off the horse to do so properly. Nobody has ever amended one of these. It counter-signs — because the document does not actually forbid it — and rides off looking like a functionary who is going to have an interesting conversation with its superior.

Effects: XP 22; gold 80 · Karma: Human +5, Asura +2

Corpse Oracle hg_corpse_oracle

A body has been arranged on a platform with its mouth propped open, and a queue of the dead is waiting patiently for their turn to lean in and listen. The corpse itself is quite ordinary and thoroughly deceased.

"It says true things," explains the vetala managing the queue. "Not helpful things. True ones."

GREY Join no queues today

The line shuffles forward by one. Somebody at the front leans in, listens, and walks away looking much worse.

GREY Take your turn and listen

You lean over the open mouth. What you hear is one sentence, in your own voice, about something you did before you came to this realm. It is entirely accurate. It is not advice and there is nothing to be done about it. You give up your place in the queue.

Effects: XP 14; mind: Water -15, Space +10 · Karma: Human +3

BLUE Frame a question the truth can actually answer

Requires: Learning 4+

An oracle that only says true things is useless if you ask it what you should do. You ask it something checkable instead — where the horizontal pass lies, what holds the bone bridge together, who the King's messenger reports to. Three answers, all verifiable, all worth having. The vetala managing the queue watches you do this and takes notes.

Effects: XP 24; items: Item Random · Karma: Human +5

BLUE It is an oracle. Write down every word.

Requires: Trait: Superstitious

You take it down complete, including the parts that are clearly the mechanism rather than the message.

One line of it will turn out to matter enormously, and you will not know which until it does, which is precisely the arrangement you have always found bearable.

Effects: XP 22; mind: Air -5

BLUE Sort the prophecy from the plumbing.

Requires: Trait: Clear-eyed

Half of it is the propped jaw and the wind. A quarter is what any dead mouth says. The remaining quarter is specific, and specific is the only part that can be wrong, which is what makes it worth having.

Effects: XP 15

BLUE Close the mouth

Requires: Ritual 4+

Nobody in the queue has thought to ask whether the corpse consented to being an amenity. You perform the closing, and the truth-telling stops, and there is a small ugly moment where the queue considers being angry with you. Then the vetala at the head of it says, "Well. It never said anything good anyway," and the crowd disperses, and the body is allowed to be a body.

Effects: XP 26; mind: Water +15 · Karma: God +8, Human +3

Charnel Hermit hg_chnel_hermit

She has built a hut against the wall of the burning ground and lives in it, alive, by choice, among the smoke and the offerings and the vetala. She is boiling something over a small fire.

"Sit," she says. "You'll want to hear this before you go further in. Most don't. Then most don't come out."

GREY You have somewhere to be

"Mm," she says, and stirs the pot. She does not seem surprised, which is worse than if she had argued.

Effects: XP 3 · Karma: Animal +2

GREY Sit down and hear it

An hour of extremely practical advice about the charnel grounds: which fires to walk upwind of, what the courts consider an insult, why you never accept food, and how to tell an illusion by the smell. It is the single most useful hour of your time in this realm.

Effects: XP 18; supplies: Food 6 · Karma: Human +5, God +2

BLUE Ask why a living woman lives in a burning ground

Requires: Awareness 14+

"Because it is the only honest place I have ever lived." She has been here nineteen years. She came to do the corpse-ground meditation for a season and found she had no further use for anywhere else. She is not mad, and she is not enlightened, and she is entirely at ease, which in this realm is the rarest thing you have seen.

Effects: XP 22; mind: Earth +20, Water +15 · Karma: God +6, Human +3

BLUE Ask to sit with her. You will not need it explained.

Requires: Trait: Steady Practice

She looks at you for slightly too long and then moves over on the mat.

No instruction is given. None is needed and both of you know it, and the afternoon goes by in a burning ground in complete silence and is one of the better afternoons.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Space +12

BLUE Ask to sit the corpse-ground practice with her

Requires: Yoga 4+

She takes you out among the bodies at the hour when the fires are low and sits you down facing one, and gives you no instruction whatsoever, because there is none. It goes on for a long time. Twice you want to leave. Around the third hour the thing the practice is for happens, briefly, and then you are just a person sitting near a corpse in the cold, which turns out to be the same thing.

Effects: XP 30; mind: Water +25, Space +25; gains trait: Ash-marked · Karma: God +10

Vetala Arena hg_vetala_arena

A pit, ringed by tiered seating cut from bone, and it is full — several hundred vetala in their finery, watching two of their own tear at each other on the sand below for entertainment.

The crowd notices you at the entrance tunnel. A chant starts. It is not a friendly chant, but it is unmistakably an invitation.

GREY Go down onto the sand

Combat: Vetala Pack (hard)

The crowd noise when a living thing steps onto the sand is something you will hear in your sleep.

After victory:

The pit falls silent, then erupts. You are showered with coin, jewellery, and at least one severed hand thrown in enthusiasm.

Karma: Asura +5, Hungry Ghost +3

GREY Back out of the tunnel

The chant follows you up the tunnel and turns to booing, which is somehow more humiliating than being chased.

Effects: XP 4 · Karma: Human +2

BLUE Find the bookmaker instead of the sand

Requires: Trade 4+

There is always a bookmaker. His odds are set for a crowd that bets on style rather than outcome, which means the outcome is badly mispriced, which means an afternoon's careful work at the rail is worth more than any purse from the sand. You leave rich and entirely uninjured, which nobody in this building considers a victory except you.

Effects: XP 22; gold 300 · Karma: Hungry Ghost +4, Human +2

BLUE Get the two on the sand to stop

Requires: Persuasion 5+

You go down and get between them, which is insane, and then talk — not to the fighters, who are past hearing, but to the crowd, about how much more interesting it would be if they *didn't*. It takes everything you have. The crowd, which above all fears being bored, decides that this is the novel thing and stops the fight itself. The two on the sand look at each other, baffled, and are led away by friends.

Effects: XP 32; gold 120 · Karma: God +8, Human +5

Preta Feast hg_preta_feast_charnel

The offerings left for the dead are heaped at the edge of the burning ground — rice, cakes, fruit, poured milk — and the pretas are around them in a ring, on their knees, faces inches from the food.

None of it goes in. Their throats will not pass it. They stay anyway, because being near it is the closest thing available.

GREY Leave them their proximity

You go quietly. It is the second-worst thing you have seen in this realm and you are aware you will not remember which was first.

Effects: XP 5; mind: Water -10 · Karma: Animal +2

GREY Burn the food — smoke, they can take

It is the oldest solution and the reason the offerings get burnt in the first place: a preta cannot swallow rice but it can take the smoke. You build the fire properly and feed everything into it. The ring closes around the smoke and breathes, and for a while the sound they make is not the sound they were making.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Water +15 · Karma: God +8, Human +4

BLUE Do it as the rite prescribes, with the words

Requires: Ritual 4+

Burnt offering with the dedication spoken over it is a different order of thing from a bonfire — the words are what turn smoke into food. You perform the whole sequence. The ring of pretas eats, properly, for the first time in however long, and one of them thanks you in a language that died before the offerings were stacked.

Effects: XP 30; mind: Water +25 · Karma: God +12, Human +4

BLUE Teach them to make the smoke themselves

Requires: Yoga 4+

Feeding them once is an afternoon's work. You spend three days instead, teaching the ring to build and dedicate the fire without you — which is harder, because they have to stop clinging to the heap long enough to learn. Two of them get it. Those two will teach the others. You leave a functioning arrangement behind rather than a full stomach, which is the difference between charity and something better.

Effects: XP 34; mind: Water +20, Space +15 · Karma: God +14, Human +5

A Glint in the Dark hg_recruit_mehr

Something catches the light at the bottom of a tar seep — a single gold glint, deep down in the black.

It blinks.

"Yes," says a voice from under the tar, quite calmly. "I can see you too. Only the one eye, mind. Would you mind terribly?"

BLUE Get her out

Requires: Strength 14+

Recruit: Mehr

It takes both arms and most of an hour and she comes out of the tar in one long appalling motion, tall and black-lacquered and entirely composed. She thanks you, wipes the good eye clear, and says: "You are going to want to hear the last prophecy. Nobody ever does. It was the accurate one."

No cost. Effects: XP 24 · Karma: Human +5, God +3

BLUE Ask her for the failed prophecy first

Requires: Ritual 3+

Recruit: Mehr

She recites it from under the tar, in the dark, unhurried. It is not a failed prophecy. It is a correct one that arrived at a court that had already decided, and the court's response is why she is in a tar pit.

When you pull her out afterwards, she has already decided you are worth attaching to.

No cost. Effects: XP 28; items: Item Random · Karma: God +5, Human +4

GREY Offer to pay her out

Recruit: Mehr

"A commercial arrangement. Very sensible." She takes the coin with a tar-black hand and does not mention that she would have come for nothing.

Effects: XP 6 · Karma: Human +2

GREY Leave the tar seep alone

"Quite all right," the voice says, receding. "It is not an urgent situation. It has not been urgent for some time."

Effects: XP 3 · Karma: Animal +2

At the Water's Edge hg_recruit_choki

A dré stands at the edge of a still pool with her feet in the shallows, facing the water. She has been standing there long enough that reeds have grown around her ankles.

"It came down the valley in the afternoon," she says, to nobody. "There was no sound. That's the part I keep coming back to. There should have been a sound."

BLUE Let her finish the whole account

Requires: Yoga 3+

Recruit: Chöki

It takes two hours and she has clearly never got to the end of it before — she stops three times and each time you wait, and each time she starts again slightly further on. When she reaches the part where she went into the river herself, she stops for a long while.

Then she says, "That's all of it," with enormous surprise, and steps out of the reeds for the first time in however long.

No cost. Effects: XP 28 · Karma: God +6, Human +5

BLUE Show her what the water is actually doing

Requires: Water Magic 4+

Recruit: Chöki

You put your hand in the pool and let her feel it the way you feel it: not a thing that took her village, just water, doing what water does, without intent and without memory of having done it. It is not comfort. It is accuracy, and she has been waiting for accuracy.

"Oh," she says. And then, after a while: "Where are you going?"

No cost. Effects: XP 26 · Karma: God +5, Human +4

GREY Ask her to come along and offer to pay**Recruit: Chöki**

She looks at the coin without much interest, and then at you. "You want me to come." That part seems to land. She comes.

Effects: XP 6 · Karma: Human +2

GREY Leave her to the water

"There should have been a sound," she says again, behind you.

Effects: XP 4; mind: Water -12 · Karma: Animal +2

Mid-Sentence hg_recruit_nangwa

The library is three walls and a floor of wet scroll-pulp. In the middle of it a dré is pacing a tight circle, talking rapidly, gesturing at a diagram that is not there.

"—and therefore, if the third term holds, which it does, which I have shown, then—" He stops. Frowns. Starts again. "—and therefore, if the third term holds—"

BLUE Supply the conclusion

Requires: Learning 4+

Recruit: Nangwa

You listen through two full cycles, work out where he is going, and say the next line out loud.

He stops dead. Turns around. Looks at you as though you have appeared out of nothing, which from his perspective you have. "Yes," he says. "Yes — that's it — and then the corollary—" and he is off again, but forward this time, and he does not stop for an hour, and at the end of it he is somebody who has finished a thought and needs a new one.

No cost. Effects: XP 30; items: Item Random · Karma: Human +6, God +3

BLUE Look at what is holding him in the loop

Requires: Space Magic 4+

Recruit: Nangwa

He is not haunting the library. He is caught in about four seconds of it, running them over and over, and the loop is thin enough to see the seam. You cut it. He arrives in the present mid-gesture, extremely disoriented and — once he works out how long it has been — extremely embarrassed.

"Right," he says. "Well. I shall need to see what's been published."

No cost. Effects: XP 28 · Karma: God +5, Human +4

GREY Interrupt and make him an offer

Recruit: Nangwa

The interruption works where nothing else has. He accepts the terms distractedly, still gesturing at the diagram, and follows you out still talking.

Effects: XP 6 · Karma: Human +2

GREY Salvage what survived the water

Three scroll-cases from a high shelf, dry inside. He does not notice you take them. He does not notice you at all.

Effects: XP 8; items: Item Random · Karma: Hungry Ghost +3

The Question at the Crossroads hg_recruit_prashan

The vetala at the crossroads does not block the road. He simply says, as you pass:

"What is it that you carry everywhere, cannot put down, did not choose, and will lose entirely at the moment you most need it?"

Then he waits, with the air of someone who has waited a very long time and expects to wait longer.

BLUE Answer it

Requires: Learning 4+

Recruit: Prashan

"Your name," you say.

The silence goes on for some time. "...That is not the answer I have," he says at last. "It is better than the answer I have."

He gets up off the milestone he has been sitting on for four centuries, dusts himself off, and falls in beside you without being invited. "I shall need considerably more material. You appear to be going somewhere interesting."

No cost. Effects: XP 30 · Karma: Human +6, God +2

BLUE Ask him one he cannot answer

Requires: Awareness 15+

Recruit: Prashan

"What are you going to do," you ask, "if someone answers it?"

He opens his mouth. Closes it. You watch four hundred years of a very good defensive position collapse in about six seconds. "I had not," he says slowly, "considered that as a live possibility." He is, it turns out, delighted rather than wounded — which is what makes him worth having.

No cost. Effects: XP 28 · Karma: Human +5, Asura +2

GREY Skip the riddle; offer him employment

Recruit: Prashan

"A commercial answer. Disappointing but valid." He pockets the coin and comes, and asks the riddle again three miles later in case you have improved.

Effects: XP 6 · Karma: Human +2

GREY Walk on past

"Take your time," he calls after you. "I have some."

Effects: XP 4 · Karma: Animal +2

The One Who Stayed hg_recruit_nyingje

A silver skeleton is working its way along a row of pretas laid out on mats, doing for each one whatever can be done — water it cannot swallow, a cloth on a forehead that feels nothing, a hand held.

It does not look up. "There are forty-one today. Yesterday there were thirty-nine. I am not gaining."

BLUE Take the other end of the row

Requires: Medicine 3+

Recruit: Nyingje

You work the row from the far end and meet in the middle after four hours. Neither of you says anything useful in that time. At the end it straightens up, looks at the mats, and then at you.

"I vowed to remain until every being here found its way out," it says. "I have been assuming that meant standing still." It picks up its bowl and comes with you, and does not look back at the forty-one, which costs it something.

No cost. Effects: XP 30 · Karma: God +8, Human +5

BLUE Ask what the vow actually said

Requires: Yoga 4+

Recruit: Nyingje

It recites the vow. You point out — carefully, because this is somebody's life's work — that it says *until every being finds its way out*, not *until every being here is comfortable*, and that one of those is a task that can be advanced by leaving this row of mats.

The silence is long. "I have been reading it wrong for eight hundred years," it says, without any bitterness at all. "Well. Shall we go?"

No cost. Effects: XP 32 · Karma: God +10, Human +4

GREY Offer to fund the work if it comes with you

Recruit: Nyingje

It accepts the coin on behalf of the forty-one, arranges for their care with a neighbouring dré, and comes. The arrangement is meticulous. It takes most of the afternoon.

Effects: XP 6 · Karma: Human +2

GREY Leave what supplies you can spare

Cost: Food (moderate)

It accepts without fuss and immediately begins distributing. "Forty-one," it says. "That is better than it was an hour ago."

Effects: XP 12 · Karma: God +6, Human +3

The Auspicious Rock hg_recruit_khedrup

A preserved one sits cross-legged on a flat rock, reciting at speed, with a tally-board propped beside him and a set of tables weighted down under a stone.

He holds up one finger without breaking the recitation — *wait* — finishes a count, marks the board, and only then looks up. "Auspicious day," he explains. "Triple merit. I am not going to waste it being sociable."

BLUE Check his arithmetic

Requires: Learning 4+

Recruit: Khedrup

The tables are internally consistent and beautifully kept and rest on one bad assumption made four hundred years ago, which he has been compounding ever since. You show him. He recalculates. It takes eleven minutes and the colour, such as it is, goes out of him.

"So the entire ledger," he says.

"The entire ledger."

He sits with it. Then he picks up the tally-board, considers throwing it, and puts it in his bag instead. "I should like to see how other people are doing this," he says.

No cost. Effects: XP 30 · Karma: God +5, Human +5

BLUE Sit down and recite with him

Requires: Ritual 4+

Recruit: Khedrup

You do not argue with the system. You just sit down and do the practice properly beside him for three hours, at the pace it is meant to be done at, which is about a fifth of his.

He speeds up for the first hour out of competitiveness. In the second he slows down. In the third he stops counting altogether, and afterwards he sits very still for a while and does not mark the board.

"That was slower," he says eventually. "Why was that better?"

No cost. Effects: XP 32 · Karma: God +8, Human +3

GREY Point out that travel accrues merit too, and pay him**Recruit: Khedrup**

He checks the tables. Pilgrimage does in fact carry a multiplier. He accepts on those grounds and only those grounds, and brings the tally-board.

Effects: XP 6 · Karma: Human +2

GREY Leave him to the triple merit

The recitation resumes before you are out of earshot, at the same impossible pace.

Effects: XP 4 · Karma: Animal +2

The Preservation Lab hg_recruit_rasabhava

A workshop cut into the rock: benches, glassware, a cold-vault, everything labelled in a small exact hand. On the central bench a vessel of clear liquid sits exactly where it was set down, beside a notebook open to a finished page.

The preserved one on the stool beside it inclines his head. "Mixed it the night before. You will notice the date."

BLUE Read the notebook properly

Requires: Alchemy 4+

Recruit: Rasabhava

The formula is correct. You check it three times because you do not believe a formula for eternal preservation can be correct, and it is. He watches you check it, entirely composed, and you understand that he has been waiting a very long time for somebody who could tell whether it was right.

"It works," you say.

"It works," he agrees. "By eleven hours." And then, after a moment: "I should like to be somewhere else now."

No cost. Effects: XP 30; items: Item Random; supplies: Reagents 10 · Karma: Human +5, God +3

BLUE Say the only useful thing there is to say about the timing

Requires: Yoga 4+

Recruit: Rasabhava

"You would have been preserved," you say. "You would not have been finished."

He considers this for a long time — he is a careful man and does not accept propositions quickly. "An unfalsifiable consolation," he says at last. "But not, I think, a false one." He caps the vessel, labels it with the date and the word UNTESTED, and leaves it on the bench for whoever comes next.

No cost. Effects: XP 32 · Karma: God +8, Human +4

GREY Offer him a laboratory that moves**Recruit: Rasabhava**

"A travelling practice." He is packing before you finish the sentence. The glassware is wrapped in eleven minutes; he has clearly rehearsed this.

Effects: XP 6 · Karma: Human +2

GREY Ask whether you might have the vessel

"Take it. It is no use to me at this end." He watches it go with the mildest possible expression.

Effects: XP 10; items: Item Random; supplies: Reagents 8 · Karma: Hungry Ghost +2

The Returned Invoice hg_recruit_durvasa

The gyelpo is pinned in the air about a foot above the ground, arms out, held there by something that is visibly still working — a curse coming back the way it went, and arriving continuously.

"Contract work," he says, through his teeth, with considerable dignity. "Final commission. The client's target had a *practice*. Would you consider — this is embarrassing — would you consider stabilising the field?"

BLUE Take the pressure off the field

Requires: Air Magic 4+

Recruit: Durvasa

The curse is not attacking him; it is *returning*, endlessly, along a channel that never closed. You cannot break it. You can widen it until the flow is survivable, which takes about twenty minutes of extremely careful work.

He comes down onto his feet, straightens his robes, and says: "That is still happening, you understand. It will be happening in a hundred years." Then, with real courtesy: "Where are we going?"

No cost. Effects: XP 30 · Karma: Human +5, Hungry Ghost +2

BLUE Close the channel properly

Requires: Ritual 4+

Recruit: Durvasa

A returned curse runs on an open contract. You do not fight it — you settle it: name the commission, name the client, mark the invoice paid, and close the instrument with the correct forms. It takes an hour and a great deal of chalk.

He lands hard, on his knees, silent for the first time. "Nobody," he says eventually, "has ever thought to *pay it off*."

No cost. Effects: XP 34; items: Item Random · Karma: God +6, Human +5

GREY Cut him down and put him on retainer

Recruit: Durvasa

He accepts the retainer with the professionalism of a man who has never in his life worked without one, and remains, technically, still being cursed.

Effects: XP 6 · Karma: Human +2

GREY He is a professional curse-caster. Leave him hanging.

"Fair," he calls after you, entirely without rancour. "Genuinely — that is fair."

Effects: XP 6 · Karma: God +3, Hell +2

Amid the Contracts hg_recruit_gomchen

A gyelpo sits in perfect meditation posture in the middle of a room knee-deep in paper. Contracts, deeds, letters of appointment — thousands of them, all bearing his seal, all still legally in force.

He opens one eye. "I am told this is the practice now. Sitting in it." He does not sound convinced. He does sound like a man who has been trying for a long time.

BLUE Read what he actually signed

Requires: Learning 4+

Recruit: Gomchen

You read for two hours. The contracts are not corrupt — that is the thing. Every one is defensible, procedurally sound, and in the interest of the institution. He never once did anything indefensible. He simply did ten thousand defensible things and ended up here.

You tell him so. It is not absolution and he does not take it as any. But he stops sitting in the paper as though it were a punishment and starts going through it as though it were a problem.

No cost. Effects: XP 30 · Karma: Human +6, God +3

BLUE Release him from the instruments

Requires: Ritual 5+

Recruit: Gomchen

Every document bearing his seal is a binding he is still party to, and there are, at a rough count, eleven thousand of them. You cannot read them all. You can dissolve the seal itself, which voids the lot at once, and takes most of a day and everything you have.

The paper goes to ash in a single soft rush. He sits in the middle of it with his eyes shut. "A master of ten thousand sutras," he says. "And what got me out was somebody else's paperwork."

No cost. Effects: XP 34 · Karma: God +8, Human +4

GREY Offer him a position with no paperwork whatsoever**Recruit: Gomchen**

The phrase "no paperwork whatsoever" does more work than the coin. He is on his feet before you have finished the offer.

Effects: XP 6 · Karma: Human +2

GREY Leave him to the practice

He closes the eye again. The paper does not move.

Effects: XP 4 · Karma: Animal +2

21. Animal (Tiryakloka)

The realm of instinct, appetite and territory.

Tiryakloka is the realm of primal instinct and predation. The vast ocean depths hold naga courts older than memory and makara that swallow ships whole. Inland, the ancient forest is territory, contested, marked, fought over, while the open meadows are the world's great stage, where khadga charge and bhramara darken the sun. The birds live everywhere, but the high places belong to them alone. The realm mixes fighting and negotiation, and each birth has its own way of naming things (Appendix C).

At a glance: **18** births · **52** companions · **86** events · **43** enemy types · **30** places.

21.1 The land and its regions

The realm of primal instinct and predation. The vast ocean depths hold naga courts older than memory and makara that swallow ships whole. Inland, the ancient forest is territory — contested, marked, fought over — while the open meadows are the world's great stage, where khadga charge and bhramara darken the sun. The birds live everywhere, but the high places belong to them alone.

The notes under each region are design comments for the writer; the player never sees them.

Ocean ocean

Bottom section. Entry zone — player arrives from the Hungry Ghost Realm. Vast coastal shelf and open ocean: deep water channels, coral reef flats, rocky islets, sandy shallows. The naga rule here and they remember everything.

Coastal Wall coastal_wall

Horizontal wall separating the ocean from the inland zones. A coral barrier ridge — impassable except at tidal passes where the reef breaks. The karka hold these choke-points.

Forest forest

Upper-left section. Dense canopy — dark, layered, territorial. The forest floor is never quiet. Every fallen log is a claim, every fruiting tree a war. The portal to the Human Realm is hidden in the oldest part, near the northwestern corner.

Ridge ridge

Vertical wall between forest and meadow. A ridgeline of tumbled boulders, thorn scrub, and dry ravines. Hard to cross but not impossible — the passes tend to be where the old game trails are.

Meadow meadow

Upper-right section. Open sky-brushed plains, termite cathedrals, migration routes, watering holes. Exposure is the currency here — the khadga charge, the yaksha mark territory, the bhramara darken the midday sun. More dangerous than the forest because there is nowhere to hide.

Fixed landmarks

The Naga's Greeting

Scene in Ocean; event: The Naga's Greeting

Reef Warden

Pass Guardian in Coastal Wall; event: Reef Warden

Ridge Predator

Pass Guardian in Ridge; event: Ridge Predator

The King of Beasts

Boss in Forest; event: The King of Beasts

Portal

Leads to the Human realm.

Settlement names used on the map

Vanakhar, Jalathang, Simhakhar, Mrigapura, Nagalung, Vyaghrakhar, Aranyagram, Pakshiyul, Matsyathang, Tshokhar, Byathang, Nyaling, Klungri, Vanarapura, Gajayul

21.2 Births of this realm

Naga, Yaksha, Bhramara, Karka, Matsya, Makara, Dura, Khadga, Patanga, Rakshasa, Varaha, Marjara, Gana, Mriga, Vanara, Shyena, Kapota, Uluka. Full entries are in chapter 25; companions are in chapter 27.

21.3 Places: shops, guilds and teahouses

Each of these has a name and a short description shown when the party arrives.

Teahouse

Forest Teahouse animal_forest_teahouse

A platform structure high in the canopy, reachable by rope bridges from three directions. The vanara who run it have been doing so since before any of them can remember. The tea is brewed from forest herbs you don't recognize and tastes like rain, bark, and something that is not quite spice.

Meadow Teahouse animal_meadow_teahouse

A circular tent-structure at a major watering hole, serving travelers and migrants and the occasional khadga who has learned to sit still long enough to drink something warm. The yaksha proprietor brews from the seasonal grass-flowers and charges exactly what the market will bear.

Tide Shelter animal_ocean_teahouse

A structure built into a sea cliff, half-submerged at high tide and bone-dry at low. A fire burns in a sealed alcove. The keeper is a broad and unhurried makara current who settled down forty years ago and has been pouring the same tea blend since. Nobody asks the recipe.

Veteran camp

Forest Training Camp animal_forest_training_camp

A gana training ground deep in the canopy — worn wooden practice posts, rope courses strung between trees, the smell of exertion and leaf-litter. The instructors are scarred veterans who have survived things that don't have names yet.

Meadow Training Camp animal_meadow_training_camp

An open-air training ground where the wind comes from every direction at once. The dura instructors here believe that there is no better teacher than exposure, and schedule sparring sessions during the hour before the bhramara cloud arrives.

Reef Training Camp animal_ocean_training_camp

A karka war-school built into the coral. Sessions alternate between fighting in the shallows and fighting in open water, on the grounds that you will never get to choose. The instructors communicate primarily by demonstration.

Mercenary guild

Mercenary Guild animal_mercenary_guild

Animals who have figured out that their skills have cash value and have the good sense to organize. Better equipment than you might expect. The guild master keeps the contracts brief and the payment terms clear.

Town

Town animal_town_weapons

A market where different territories agree, briefly, to exchange. Dura shell-wright craftsmanship, vanara jugaad improvisation, marjara-claw handles on daggers sold by gana traders who got them somewhere no one is explaining. The weapons here are practical and tell stories.

Town animal_town_magic

A settlement that has drawn its share of hedge-mages, ritual practitioners, and wandering herbalists. The apothecary smells of bark, fungal spores, and something resinous that's been burning for days.

Town animal_town_supplies

A clearing settlement where four game trails meet. Sounder matrons and herb-walkers tend most of the stalls. Food preserved in bark and clay, medicines extracted from things most travelers walk past without recognizing, tools for the deep wild. It is honest trade in a place that doesn't demand credentials.

Spell guild

Sacred Grove animal_sacred_grove

The oldest trees in the realm gather here as if in council. Bark-sigils accumulate on the trunks over centuries — offerings pressed into the wood, prayers absorbed by the roots. The Yakshas and Yakshinis who maintain this grove are older than the realm's current configuration.

Temple of the Naga animal_temple_of_the_naga

An old structure where those born with naga-affinity come to train under the great serpents' direct guidance. The water here has properties that don't exist anywhere else in the realm. Offerings of saffron milk and river-flowers are accepted at the outer shrine.

Garuda Roost animal_garuda_roost

A great landing pole rises above the canopy, hung with wind-bells and sky-prayer flags. The Garudas who use it leave residual power in the ground below. Practitioners of air and space magic come here to feel the difference between flight and fall.

Hidden Gompa animal_hidden_gompa

A monastery that exists only insofar as the practice of its inhabitants sustains it. The walls are older than memory and the silence deeper than the forest. The practitioners here have been undisturbed for long enough that the ground itself has opinions.

Mirror Lake animal_mirror_lake

The surface shows things that aren't there — or rather, things that are there but not yet. Followers of the Goddess of Illusion use this as a training ground: if you can hold your mind still enough to see clearly in a place that specializes in confusion, you can do it anywhere.

Medicinal Garden animal_medicinal_garden

A cultivated clearing tended by practitioners who have studied the relationship between plant, body, and suffering for generations. The herbs here grow things that have no equivalent elsewhere. Knowledge is shared freely; materials cost what they cost.

Temple of the Eternal Fire animal_eternal_fire

White-robed priests have tended this fire since before the realm's current configuration. The animals who come here for vision-seeking say the fire speaks differently than any other source of light — more direct, less patient.

Black Lodge animal_black_lodge

Half-buried, marked with a khatvanga hung with black ribbons and bone-charms. The practitioners here study predation as a spiritual technology — what it means to take life, what it transfers. The animal realm is uncommonly honest about the subject.

Crossroads Stupa animal_crossroads_stupa

Where four major migration routes intersect, a stupa marks the conjunction. Tormas and butter lamps heap at its base, some kept burning by passing devotees, some long guttered out. The practitioners here specialize in working with beings rather than forces.

The Ancient Banyan animal_ancient_banyan

A banyan so old it has become its own forest — hundreds of aerial roots, each descended root a new trunk, the whole organism covering ground that would take an hour to walk around. The beings who live inside its aerial forest do not remember when they arrived.

Birds' Congress animal_birds_congress

A high cliff where every species of bird in the realm sends at least one representative, continuously, by some rotation that appears to involve song but which scholars cannot fully decode. What looks like a congress is also, apparently, a school.

Trains: Air Magic, Ranged, Yoga

Bone Forest animal_bone_forest

A forest of pale calcified trees — not dead but transformed, turned to mineral over geological time. The predators who come here to meditate among the skeletal forms have access to a school of thought that treats death not as an ending but as a material.

Naga Palace animal_naga_palace

The seat of a naga court that remembers when this ocean was fresh water. Trading access: the naga have long memories and are interested in what traveling parties have seen. Their price for advanced teaching is always information — specific, verifiable, and something they don't already know.

Trains: Water Magic, Enchantment, Yoga

Termite Cathedral animal_termite_cathedral

A structure ten meters high, built over centuries by beings each the size of a thumbnail, with architectural precision that confounds engineers. The collective intelligence that designed and maintains it doesn't communicate in any language known to surface beings, but it does teach — by implication and exposure.

Trains: Earth Magic, Summoning, Logistics

Yogini circle

Yogini Circle animal_yogini_circle

Sixty-four Yoginis carved in relief on an inward-facing ring of stone, no ceiling, no door. The practitioners who gather here are a rougher assembly than the hidden gumpa — interested in results more than elegance, and willing to discuss the dangerous schools.

General merchant

Pearl Merchant animal_pearl_merchant

Pearls, polished shell, sea-glass, and a few things older than her trade.

Forest Merchant animal_forest_merchant

A varaha trader working a circuit he holds entirely in his head. Everything he owns is on his back.

Plains Merchant animal_meadow_merchant

An enormous cart drawn by a harnessed khadga, worked by a yaksha who has run this route for decades.

Blacksmith

Shell-Wright's Stall animal_shell_wright

A karka craftsman working in moulted shell, chitin, and salvaged metal.

Trains: Smithing, Armor

Healer

Healer's Camp animal_healer_camp

A canvas clinic strung between four trees, run by a grey-muzzled gana who does not hurry.

Trains: Medicine

21.4 Bestiary

Enemy types met in this realm. The note under a name is a design comment for the writer and never shown to the player.

Naga Warrior animal_naga_warrior ocean · frontline

Naga Sorcerer animal_naga_sorcerer ocean · caster

Karka Guardian animal_karka_guardian ocean · frontline

Karka Crusher animal_karka_crusher ocean · frontline

Matsya Hunter animal_matsya_hunter ocean · skirmisher

Matsya Shoal animal_matsya_shoal ocean · frontline

Weak individually; pack bonus applies when 3+ present in encounter

Makara Titan animal_makara_titan ocean · frontline

Makara Currentmaster animal_makara_current ocean · caster, support

Yaksha Guardian animal_yaksha_guardian meadow · frontline

Yaksha Shaman animal_yaksha_shaman meadow · caster

Dura Soldier animal_dura_soldier meadow · frontline

Dura Burrower animal_dura_burrower meadow · skirmisher

Burrows underground and erupts adjacent to its target for a melee strike.

Khadga Blade animal_khadga_blade meadow · frontline

Natural mantis blades; very high crit chance from high finesse + unarmed crit perks

Khadga Ambusher animal_khadga_ambusher meadow · skirmisher

Arrives from concealment; guile perks grant blend_in/cheap_shot; first-strike opening

Bhramara Soldier animal_bhramara_soldier meadow · frontline

Bhramara Drone animal_bhramara_drone meadow · support

Support caster that calls reinforcements; weak alone but dangerous when it completes a summon

Patanga Ascetic animal_patanga_ascetic meadow · support, caster

Patanga Flame Seeker animal_patanga_seeker meadow · frontline

Moves unpredictably before striking — impossible to anticipate.

Rakshasa Hunter animal_rakshasa_hunter forest · frontline

The Young One animal_rakshasa_young forest · skirmisher

Not yet named. Rakshasa are named at their first successful hunt; before that they are simply 'the young one'. Dangerous, and aware it has something to prove.

Rakshasa Maneater animal_rakshasa_maneater forest · frontline

Boss-tier lone predator; singles out the weakest and most isolated party member.

Varaha Charger animal_varaha_charger forest · frontline

Tusk charge; maces perk concussive_force gives knockback on crits

Varaha Elder animal_varaha_elder forest · support

Sounder tactician; heals allies via medicine perks; raises aggression when sounder-mates are wounded

Marjara Stalker animal_marjara_stalker forest · skirmisher

Flanking predator; grace perks give evasion while repositioning; attacks from unexpected angles

Marjara Ambusher animal_marjara_ambusher forest · skirmisher

Drops from canopy; guile perks give first-strike advantage; retreats after opening hit

Mriga Stag animal_mriga_stag forest · frontline

Rutting-season buck; charges anything that does not concede the ground. Antlers count as unarmed.

Mriga Sentinel animal_mriga_sentinel forest · skirmisher

Watches the edge and calls the alarm. Hard to hit, hard to corner, and never fights alone by choice.

Mriga Herd animal_mriga_herd forest · frontline

Individually harmless. A stampede is not a fight, it is weather.

Gana Pack Runner animal_gana_runner forest · frontline

Pack hunter; grows sharper and harder to hit as more of the pack closes in.

Gana Runt animal_gana_runt forest · skirmisher

Last of the litter and last to the kill. Harries the edges and runs from anything that turns.

Gana Stalker animal_gana_stalker forest · skirmisher

Works the flanks while the pack holds the front. Goes for the straggler, never the strongest.

Gana Hunter animal_gana_hunter forest · skirmisher

A full-grown wolf that has done this many times. Closes only when the throat is already open.

Gana Alpha animal_gana_alpha forest · frontline

Not the fastest and not the strongest. The one the pack has already tested every alternative to.

Gana Elder animal_gana_elder forest · support

Sings the hunt rather than joining it. What the pack hears from her, it does.

Gana Howler animal_gana_howler forest · support

Pack support; enchantment perks buff allies and weaken party members

Vanara Skirmisher animal_vanara_skirmisher forest · ranged

Throws rocks and alchemical bombs; taunt forces party member to attack it; TODO: confuse special attack

Vanara Elder animal_vanara_elder forest · support

Troop director; leadership perks give formation bonuses to nearby vanara

Shyena Stoooper animal_shyena_stoooper sky · skirmisher

Aerial dive attacker; flying tag; martial_arts perks give first-strike on initial dive

Shyena Sky Lord animal_shyena_lord sky · frontline

Territorial boss; might perks give enrage-style bonuses when below 50% HP

Kapota Messenger animal_kapota_messenger sky · support

Fast support; disrupts party formation; grace perks make it very hard to pin down

Kapota Flock animal_kapota_flock sky · frontline

Flying mob; individually weak but overwhelming in numbers; grace perks give evasion bonus

Uluka Nightwatcher animal_uluka_nightwatcher sky · ranged, caster

Fires black magic from range in darkness; high awareness gives initiative advantage

Uluka Ill Omen animal_uluka_omen sky · caster

Ill omen debuffer; performance perks like heckle_the_will and stage_fright lower party morale/stats

21.5 Quests

No quests have been written for this realm yet.

21.6 Event catalogue (86 events)

Every event written for this realm, in the order they are stored. **GREY** choices are always available, **BLUE** choices need a party member with a skill, attribute or trait, **YELLOW** choices are rolls. The small grey lines are reference labels, not game

text.

Sacred Grove animal_sacred_grove

Yaksha-marked trees and colored ropes wound around ancient root systems indicate the boundaries of this place. The grove has been tended so long it breathes on its own — the leaves move when nothing else does. Yaksha and Yakshini commune with followers here in the old way: no temples, no intermediaries, just the practitioners and the inhabited earth beneath their feet.

GREY Approach the practitioners

Opens: Sacred Grove

A Yakshini turns and regards you without surprise. Earth magic has a price — she names it.

GREY Leave them to their work

You walk on. The light here filters differently than the rest of the forest — warmer, somehow, as though the sun is paying attention.

Temple of the Naga animal_temple_of_the_naga

Offerings of saffron-milk and wild flowers line the path to the shrine — fresh, which means someone was here recently. The naga temple here is older than the settlements that surround it, and the naga who receive worship here are older still. Their presence is felt as a weight in the air, like the moment before rain.

GREY Ask about their teachings

Opens: Temple of the Naga

A practitioner rises smoothly and names the spells they can teach. The price is gold. The naga do not haggle.

GREY Move on without disturbing the offerings

You don't touch the flowers. The scent of saffron and something older follows you for a while.

Garuda Roost animal_garuda_roost

A horned pole rises from the high ground — above the canopy where it can be seen from the air, or from a cliff edge visible to anything that flies. The garudas pass through this realm regularly on their circuits between worlds. Followers of all species gather here to wait, to offer, and sometimes to receive teachings when the great birds land. Shyena and kapota are among the most devoted.

GREY Speak to the worshippers

Opens: Garuda Roost

One of the worshippers looks up. They teach Air magic here. The price is negotiable, but only within reason.

GREY Leave an offering and go

You set something at the base of the pole and move on. The ribbons flutter.

Hidden Gompa animal_hidden_gompa

A structure of woven branches and packed earth, half-reclaimed by the forest. Inside, mantric syllables are audible — not quite human in their cadence, adjusted over years of practice to harmonize with birdsong and the sounds of the forest. Monks who withdrew from the human realm into the animal realm for solitude. They have been here a long time. The animals have grown accustomed to them.

GREY **Knock and ask to enter**

Opens: Hidden Gompa

After a pause, the door opens. A monk gestures you inside. Space magic. What do you need?

GREY **Don't disturb them**

You walk past quietly. The mantras continue without interruption.

Medicinal Garden animal_medicinal_garden

A clearing carved from the forest floor, every inch cultivated with medicinal plants. Some healers here were born in these forests; others retreated from human settlements to practice more freely. The knowledge is older than any of them — root-knowledge, bark-knowledge, the deep grammar of the healing forest. The teachers share it openly, for a fee.

GREY **Ask to learn**

Opens: Medicinal Garden

A healer looks up from her work and nods. She names her price without ceremony.

GREY **Leave them to their work**

You leave without disturbing them. The scent of growing things follows you for some time.

Black Lodge animal_black_lodge

The entrance is low, partially hidden by undergrowth. You would miss it if you were not looking. Inside: incense so thick it stings, a khatvanga propped against the wall streaming black ribbons. The practitioner here works alone, without students, without oversight — the animal realm affords the privacy that the human realm did not. They turn when you enter, without surprise.

GREY **Ask to learn**

Opens: Black Lodge

A hand gestures to a list scratched into the bark of the wall. Spells. Prices. No preamble.

GREY **Back out**

You step back into the daylight. The khatvanga watches you leave.

Circle of the Yoginis animal_yogini_circle

A ring of standing stones in a forest clearing or on a meadow hill — no ceiling, built that way intentionally so the witches can land when they fly in from the sky. The sixty-four forms are inscribed on the inner face of each stone in a script that predates the current tradition of inscription. Practitioners who come here have traveled a long way to reach this circle.

GREY **Enter the circle**

Opens: Yogini Circle

One of the practitioners turns and gestures. No words needed.

GREY **Move on**

You back away slowly. The air around the circle hums for a long time after.

Mirror Lake animal_mirror_lake

A lake so still it seems to reflect a different sky — no wind reaches it, or the water ignores the wind. Enchantment practitioners gather at the shore to meditate on appearance and reality. In a realm where a deer's world and a wolf's world overlap in the same territory and neither sees what the other sees, the question has obvious urgency.

GREY Sit and listen

Opens: Mirror Lake

A practitioner meets your eyes in the reflection before turning around. They can teach Enchantment. The lake makes everything seem like a fair price.

GREY Walk away from the still water

You step back. The image on the water holds for a moment longer than it should, then dissolves.

Crossroads Stupa animal_crossroads_stupa

Where the old game trails intersect, someone built a stupa centuries ago. The mortar between the stones includes offerings pressed in during construction — seeds, feathers, a cracked egg. Butter lamps burn at the base. The place smells of juniper smoke and something that has been burning for a very long time.

GREY Approach the stupa

Opens: Crossroads Stupa

A practitioner emerges from behind the stupa. Summoning magic — the crossroads is the right place for it. Gold is the price.

GREY Observe from a distance

You watch the butter lamps in the wind. Some things are better left undisturbed.

Temple of the Eternal Fire animal_eternal_fire

The fire burns at the entrance to a cave, or near a volcanic vent, or at the base of an ancient tree struck by lightning and somehow still alive — wherever the ground produces heat that can be consecrated. The priests who tend it wear white and speak rarely. Creatures of many species come to pay respects. The fire does not discriminate.

GREY Approach the priests

Opens: Temple of the Eternal Fire

A priest turns from the flame and regards you. He names the spells, and then the prices.

GREY Pay your respects and leave

You bow before the flame and step back. The fire reflected in your eyes for some time after.

Tide Shelter animal_ocean_teahouse

A structure built into a sea cliff, half-submerged at high tide and bone-dry at low. A fire burns in a sealed alcove. Along the benches: naga, karka, and silhouettes you don't immediately place. The keeper is a broad and unhurried makara current who settled down forty years ago and has been pouring the same tea blend since. Nobody asks the recipe.

GREY Sit down

Opens: Tide Shelter

You take a seat. The current sets down a cup without asking.

GREY Move on

You keep going. The smell of salt and smoke follows you out of the cliff.

Forest Teahouse animal_forest_teahouse

A platform structure high in the canopy, reachable by rope bridges from three directions. The vanara who run it have been doing so since before any of them can remember. The tea is brewed from forest herbs you don't recognize and tastes like

rain, bark, and something that is not quite spice. It is very good.

GREY Sit down

Opens: Forest Teahouse

You take a platform seat. A vanara sets down cups without ceremony.

BLUE A teahouse a hundred feet up. Do this properly.

Requires: Trait: Tea Ritualist

You do the whole form on a swaying platform in the canopy, which is objectively ridiculous and which the proprietor watches with total seriousness.

At the end she brings out the other pot — the one that does not get offered — and does the form back at you.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Water +12

BLUE You are up before the canopy is light. So is she.

Requires: Trait: Early Riser

The proprietor is doing the first firing of the day when you come up the rope ladder, and there is a particular understanding between people who are awake at that hour by choice.

You get the first pot. The first pot is not the same as the others and she does not explain why.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Fire +8

GREY Move on

The smell of forest tea follows you along the rope bridge.

Watering Hole Teahouse animal_meadow_teahouse

A low structure at the edge of the great watering hole, where the land slopes gently down to the water. The truce of thirst holds here — every creature in the meadow observes it, because the keeper enforces it, and the keeper has been here longer than any of them. Inside: food, drink, and improbable peace.

GREY Sit down

Opens: Meadow Teahouse

You take a table. Nobody challenges you. This is the truce.

BLUE Everything that lives here comes to this water eventually.

Requires: Trait: Gossip

Everything does, and everything talks, and a watering hole in the dry season is the single most informative place on the plain.

You leave knowing which route the migration will take, which is worth more than the tea cost.

Effects: XP 20; gold small

GREY Move on

You walk past the watering hole without stopping. The smell of water and cooking carries far on open ground.

Mercenary Guild animal_ocean_mercenary_guild

A fortified reef structure flying a plain banner — the same universal mercenary symbol, translated into something that can survive salt water. Inside, armed figures clean weapons or sleep. The work available in the ocean is different from the work available on land, and the going rate reflects the depth.

GREY Browse their services

Opens: Mercenary Guild

The quartermaster produces a list. Rates, availability, terms.

GREY Move on

You leave the mercenaries to their maintenance.

Mercenary Guild animal_forest_mercenary_guild

A fortified outpost at the forest edge, flying a plain black banner between two old trees. The figures inside are armoured in hide and shell-plate — practical for the terrain. They look up when you enter with the universal expression of people who do this professionally.

GREY Browse their services

Opens: Mercenary Guild

The quartermaster opens a case and waits.

GREY Move on

You leave the mercenaries to their sharpening.

Mercenary Guild animal_meadow_mercenary_guild

A stockaded compound at a crossroads of migration routes, flying the universal mercenary banner on a pole tall enough to be seen from a distance. Inside, armoured figures play dice and argue rates. The work in the open meadow is the most visible and the most dangerous, and the prices reflect that.

GREY Browse their services

Opens: Mercenary Guild

The quartermaster nods and produces a list. Standard rates. Meadow surcharge.

GREY Move on

You skirt the compound and keep moving.

Naga Training Grounds animal_ocean_training_camp

A reef plateau where naga warriors train daily — the drills are ancient and precise. They accept outsiders who show genuine commitment. The water here slows everything and makes every technique twice as demanding, which is the point.

GREY Ask about training

Opens: Reef Training Camp

A senior naga warrior looks you over once. 'Two sessions. Choose carefully.'

GREY Move on

The drills continue without you.

Tracker's Training Ground animal_forest_training_camp

A clearing used by those who hunt without being hunted — trackers, scouts, the nimble-fingered and the quick-footed. The vanara here share techniques that have been refined over many generations in this specific forest. Some of it translates; all of it is worth knowing.

GREY Ask about training

Opens: Forest Training Camp

A vanara elder with patient eyes names two skills. 'Which two? Choose once.'

GREY Move on

You leave the clearing. The forest returns to its own lesson.

Open-Field Training Ground animal_meadow_training_camp

A camp at the edge of the open plain where fighters train in the exposed, unforgiving style demanded by meadow combat — no cover, long sight lines, everything decided by strength and endurance. The yaksha veterans who run it have a simple philosophy: you learn to take a hit, and then you learn to give one back harder.

GREY Ask about training

Opens: Meadow Training Camp

'We can teach two things. Once each. Make your choices.'

GREY Move on

The veteran returns to drilling her students.

Town animal_ocean_town_weapons

A trading post built into a sea cliff and expanded outward on platform structures above the tideline. Karka shell-wrights and naga-forged spear merchants dominate the market. The clang of metalwork reaches out into open water. Most things for sale here were made to puncture something.

GREY Enter the market

Opens: Town

You push through to the main stalls.

GREY Move on

You skirt the settlement along the reef.

Town animal_ocean_town_magic

A settlement built around a thermal vent, where the rising current brings strange minerals and stranger ideas. Water mages and naga sorcerers work from alcoves along the main tunnel. The air smells of sulfur and concentration. Someone is always arguing about the nature of current.

GREY Enter the settlement

Opens: Town

You find the practitioners' quarter.

GREY Move on

You leave the argument unresolved.

Town animal_ocean_town_supplies

A market platform on stilts above the tidal flat. Everything needed to survive the reef and deep water — preserved food, medicine, rope, breathing equipment. The sign reads: WHAT YOU NEED. NO QUESTIONS. The price is printed underneath, which saves time.

GREY Enter the market

Opens: Town

The shopkeeper nods without looking up.

GREY Move on

You keep going.

Town animal_forest_town_weapons

A market at the forest's edge where different territories agree, briefly, to exchange. Dura shell-wright craftsmanship, vanara jugaad improvisation, marjara-claw handles on daggers sold by gana traders who got them somewhere no one is explaining. The weapons here are practical and tell stories.

GREY Enter the market**Opens: Town**

You push through the stalls.

GREY Move on

You skirt the settlement and continue into the trees.

Town animal_forest_town_magic

A forest settlement where the mycelium network runs under every building and the practitioners who use it for communication have built a small trade in that adjacency. Alchemy, earth magic, summoning — the disciplines that grow from understanding what is underground. The shelves smell of soil and something fermented.

GREY Enter the settlement**Opens: Town**

You find the practitioners' stalls.

GREY Move on

You leave the forest scholars to their arguments.

Town animal_forest_town_supplies

A clearing settlement where four game trails meet. Sounder matrons and herb-walkers tend most of the stalls. Food preserved in bark and clay, medicines extracted from things most travelers walk past without recognizing, tools for the deep forest. It is honest trade in a place that doesn't demand credentials.

GREY Enter the market**Opens: Town**

The matron at the nearest stall sizes you up and names a fair price.

GREY Move on

You keep walking. The smell of drying herbs follows you down the trail.

Town animal_meadow_town_weapons

An armorer's compound at a crossroads of migration routes, built low and solid to survive the open-ground seasons. Dura shell-wright work alongside yaksha-enchanted blades and khadga-horn handles. The merchants here have traveled to get here and priced accordingly. Everything for sale is worth carrying a long way.

GREY Enter the compound**Opens: Town**

You find the weapons hall.

GREY Move on

You continue across the open ground.

Town animal_meadow_town_magic

A settlement gathered around a yaksha standing stone, which functions as both landmark and practice anchor. Enchantment, earth magic, white healing — the disciplines that thrive in open country where the sky is visible and the earth is close. The practitioners here are travelers themselves, stopping as they always stop.

GREY Enter the settlement**Opens: Town**

You find the practitioners' quarter around the standing stone.

GREY Move on

You leave the stone to its practitioners.

Town animal_meadow_town_supplies

A trading post at the great watering hole, where the migration routes converge and every creature passes through eventually. The merchants here have learned not to ask where anyone is going. Essential goods for the long traversal: food for crossing open ground, medicine for what open ground does to you, equipment for what you find at the end of it.

GREY Enter the market**Opens: Town**

The shopkeeper glances up briefly and goes back to counting stock.

GREY Move on

You keep moving. The watering hole glitters to your left.

The Naga Palace naga_palace

A coral arch rises from the reef, inscribed with naga glyphs marking territorial sovereignty. Two naga warriors flank the entrance but do not move to stop you. Beyond the arch, chambers of living coral lit by bioluminescent algae descend into the deep. Water magic and enchantment traditions have been practiced here without interruption since before the reef was reef.

GREY Ask to study here**Opens: Naga Palace**

A court official receives you with formal courtesy. They have everything the ocean's magic traditions offer. The price is calibrated to what you can pay, which means they already know.

BLUE Observe the court protocol and withdraw respectfully

Requires: Grace 2+

You bow in the naga manner — low, without breaking eye contact — and withdraw. The court watches. A minor official nods very slightly.

You have not been insulted. In naga terms, this is an achievement.

Effects: XP 15; gains trait: Beauty-struck · Karma: Animal +2

BLUE You have been ambushed by this before.

Requires: Trait: Beauty-struck

The arch alone would have done it. You stand in front of it for some time with the specific helplessness of somebody who knows exactly what is happening to them and cannot speed it up.

The naga are used to this. One of them waits with you.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Space +10, Fire +8

GREY Withdraw without seeking entry

You turn and leave the arch behind. The two warriors watch you go without expression.

The Ancient Banyan ancient_banyan

No one told you the tree existed, but you found it anyway. The banyan's aerial roots form a labyrinth; its canopy covers a quarter mile in every direction. The Vanara Elder sits in the first great fork, weaving something from spider silk and what you eventually realize is solidified starlight.

The tree has the attention of something older than itself. Earth magic and summoning traditions have always known about this place.

GREY Approach the Elder and ask to study

Opens: The Ancient Banyan

The Elder looks down from the fork with unhurried eyes. She names a price for her teaching. It is not small.

BLUE Sit beneath the roots in silence

Requires: Yoga 2+

You sit with your back against a root as wide as a wall and close your eyes. The tree breathes. You breathe. After a time — you cannot say how long — something shifts: a sense of patience that is not your own, accumulated over centuries, seeping in through the bark.

Effects: XP 25; gains trait: Beauty-struck · Karma: Animal +3, Human +2

GREY Walk away from the ancient tree

You leave the labyrinth of roots behind. The canopy covers you until you are out of the grove, and then the light returns all at once.

Termite Cathedral termite_cathedral

The mound rises fifteen feet, engineered with an architect's precision for temperature and airflow. Carved archways mark the entrance in a script older than any living tradition. Inside, something hums at a frequency felt in the chest rather than heard by the ear. Yaksha practitioners and bhramara allies have used this place as a center of earth-consciousness work for as long as the mound has stood.

GREY Seek instruction

Opens: Termite Cathedral

A yaksha practitioner emerges from the main chamber. Earth magic, summoning, and the basics of alchemy — the cathedral has all three. She names the prices plainly.

GREY Leave an offering at the base of the mound

You set your offering at the carved archway and stand back. The hum shifts frequency very slightly — just once. You take that as acknowledgement.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: Animal +2

BLUE **Fifteen feet of engineering and nobody drew the plans.**

Requires: Trait: Curious

You spend the afternoon working out the ventilation, which is the part that should not be possible, and by evening you have it: the mound breathes on a temperature differential and the whole structure is a lung.

You will be thinking about this for weeks.

Effects: XP 8

GREY **Move on**

The hum follows you for longer than the mound is visible.

Conference of the Birds birds_congress

The great assembly tree rises alone on a ridge where forest meets meadow — visible from both territories, which is why it was chosen. Every bird of the realm comes here when the season is right. Kapota and shyena roost three branches apart in a truce older than memory.

A kapota elder calls the session to order with a chant that names every species present. You recognize the structure: a congress, a parliament. They are looking for something. They are, in the old story, always looking for the Simurgh. And, in the old story, they are the Simurgh — but they haven't arrived at that part yet.

GREY **Attend the congress and learn from the teachings**

Opens: Birds' Congress

A kapota messenger escorts you to an observer's perch. Air magic, space magic, and the white traditions of the sky practitioners — all available. The price is a story you haven't told anyone else.

BLUE **Listen to the full session without speaking**

Requires: Awareness 14+

You sit at the base of the tree for the full congress — hours, perhaps longer. The birds speak in twenty overlapping languages and you understand almost none of it.

But near the end, when the elder names the purpose of the journey, you understand that part. Not the words — the shape of it. The search that finds itself.

Effects: XP 30; gains trait: Bird Lover · Karma: Animal +3, Human +3, God +2

BLUE **You can name most of the delegations from here.**

Requires: Trait: Bird Lover

You can, and you do, quietly, and the naming turns out to be the credential — the congress has been addressed by a great many people who did not know a shyena from a garuda.

You are given a place at the lower branches, which is further in than visitors go.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Air +12 · Karma: Animal +4

GREY **Leave the birds to their congress**

You descend from the ridge. The chant continues behind you, diminishing into the wind.

The Bone Forest bone_forest

The bones are organized, not scattered. Skulls face east, spines curve north, limb bones arranged radially from the center as though following a diagram. Something has been doing this for a very long time. In the center of the clearing, a practitioner in dark robes performs a slow ritual over a fresh death — a khadga, enormous, at peace.

They don't look up when you approach.

'Looking for death lessons,' they say. 'Or life ones. They're the same here.'

GREY Ask to learn

Opens: Bone Forest

The practitioner rises, unhurried. Black magic and summoning — the traditions that work with what remains. They name the spells and the prices without ceremony.

BLUE Help with the ritual

Requires: Yoga 2+

You take your position across the body from the practitioner and mirror their movements as best you can. The ritual has its own grammar; you improvise where you don't know the words.

The khadga's presence, enormous even in death, seems to hold still for a moment. Then it passes, as presences do.

Effects: XP 20; gains trait: Mourner · Karma: Animal +3

BLUE The skulls face east. Somebody decided that.

Requires: Trait: Mourner

Somebody decided it, and kept deciding it, for what must be generations — the arrangement is maintained, not merely made.

You find the current keeper by looking for who has been walking here recently, and they are glad to be found.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Water +10 · Karma: Animal +3, Human +2

GREY Leave respectfully

You bow toward the center of the bone arrangement and leave without disturbing anything. The practitioner has already returned to their work.

The Great Stag animal_sigh_of_relief

In a forest clearing — or on an open hillside, or at the edge of the reef where the light reaches — you find a great stag standing alone. His rack is hung with orchids. Around him, smaller creatures have gathered: a rabbit, two kapota pigeons, a young vanara sitting cross-legged. The stag is lowering his head, letting them feed from the flowers and mosses growing between his antlers.

No one has asked him to do this. He simply knows it is time.

BLUE Meditate in the presence of this

Requires: Yoga 2+

You settle into stillness. The stag's attention moves over you once, and then returns to the gathered creatures. That moment of attention is enough — something clear passes through you and keeps going.

You remember that generosity is not sacrifice. It is just knowing it is time.

Effects: XP 15; gains trait: Touched by Grace · Karma: Animal -3, Human +3, God +5

GREY Leave some of your food for those gathered

You set down what you can spare and step back. The vanara reaches it first, then shares without being asked.

The stag watches. He has seen this before — the chain of giving. It always surprises him a little.

Effects: XP 10; gains trait: Generous · Karma: Animal +2, Human +3

GREY Watch from the treeline

You stay at the edge of the clearing and watch until the stag lifts his head and the gathered creatures drift away. Then the clearing is just a clearing again.

You carry the image of it for a long time.

Effects: XP 8 · Karma: Animal +1

GREY Approach and take from what is being offered

You walk into the clearing. The gathered creatures scatter. The stag raises his head and looks at you with amber eyes.

He does not move. He does not attack. He simply regards you until you leave.

You feel, for a long time afterward, that you have been recognized.

Effects: gains trait: Covetous · Karma: Animal +3, Hungry Ghost +5

Crossroads Shrine animal_crossroads_shrine

Where three animal trails cross, someone built a cairn of stones. Prayer flags, thread, feathers pressed flat between layers of bark, bones arranged with obvious care — offerings that don't specify any particular tradition but cover their bases. A single butter lamp burns in a notch in the topmost stone.

GREY Leave an offering

You add something of yours to the cairn. The butter lamp flickers once in still air.

Effects: XP 8 · Karma: Animal +2

BLUE Sit for a moment and breathe

Requires: Yoga 2+

You sit at the base of the cairn. At a crossroads, all directions are valid — this is what makes them sacred. For a moment you remember all of them.

Effects: XP 12 · Karma: Animal +2, Human +1

BLUE Somebody built this where the animals cross, not where people do.

Requires: Trait: Pilgrim

That is the whole point of it and almost nobody notices. The cairn faces the trails, the offerings are the kind an animal would take, and the person who built it was making an argument.

You add to it in the same spirit.

Effects: XP 20 · Karma: Animal +5, Human +2

GREY Pass without disturbing anything

You leave the lamp to its burning.

The Naga's Greeting animal_ocean_naga_greeting

A naga rises from the reef ahead — long, scaled, regarding you with amber eyes that haven't blinked. She circles once, slowly, then stops with her coils wound loosely around a pillar of coral.

'You are not of this water,' she says. It is not quite a question.

She is assessing you. This happens every time something new arrives in the ocean realm. She does not find it alarming — only relevant.

GREY Introduce yourself and explain your purpose

You speak plainly. She listens without interrupting, which is the naga equivalent of a warm welcome.

When you finish, she unwinds from the coral pillar and gestures toward the open water. 'The western currents carry the faster trade. The eastern ones are watched.' She does not explain by whom.

You have been received.

Effects: XP 10

YELLOW Stand your ground without speaking

Roll: Constitution, 12 difficulty

If it succeeds:

You hold her gaze without flinching. She is silent for a long moment.

'Ah,' she says finally, and uncoils. She seems, somehow, pleased. 'The quiet ones always know where they're going.'

Effects: XP 15

If it fails:

You hold it as long as you can, which is not as long as you thought.

The eyes are wrong in a way that takes a moment to locate — there is no lid, and no blink, and nothing behind them that recognises the courtesy you are attempting. When you look away she does not comment on it, which is worse.

'Mm,' she says, and coils back. The audience is over, and you have been placed somewhere in her ordering of things.

Effects: mind: Air -10

GREY Offer a gift

She examines the gift with the patience of someone for whom time is elastic. Then she accepts it.

In return, she describes three things: where the food is, where the danger is, and where the old temple lies. You did not ask about the temple. She offers it anyway, as though it were simply the correct exchange.

Effects: XP 20 · Karma: Animal +2

Reef Warden animal_karka_reef_warden

The pass through the coral barrier is narrow and long. Halfway through, a karka fills it completely — shell the width of the passage, claws braced against the coral walls, eyes fixed on you.

She is not sleeping. She has been watching since you entered the corridor.

The thermal vent behind her produces a faint heat that rises through the passage. This is her vent. This is her pass. These things are not in question.

YELLOW Attempt to negotiate passage

Roll: Charm, 14 difficulty

If it succeeds:

You speak to her in terms she respects — this is her territory, you acknowledge it; you need to pass, you explain why; you will not return unless invited.

Her eyes do not change. But after a long pause, she steps aside — just enough. The passage is tight. She watches every inch of it.

Effects: XP 20

If it fails:

You make the argument. It is a decent argument, and she listens to all of it with her claws folded.

'No,' she says, when you have finished. She does not explain, and it becomes clear she does not consider an explanation to be part of the transaction. The reef is hers. You are not from the reef.

You go the long way, and it costs you most of a day.

Effects: mind: Earth -8

GREY Offer gold as a crossing toll

She looks at the gold. She looks at you. She reaches out one claw and takes it with surprising delicacy.

Then she moves aside. The passage is yours. She adds the gold to a pile you hadn't noticed — there is a system here, practiced over years. You are not the first to find this more efficient than the alternative.

Effects: XP 10

GREY **Fight your way through**

Combat: Animal Karka Vent (hard)

She braces. Her claws score the coral walls. Whatever comes next, she will not move from this vent.

GREY **Retreat and find another route**

You back out of the passage the way you came. There are other passes — you will find them.

Behind you, the karka returns to her vigil without comment. This happens, too.

Ridge Predator animal_ridge_predator

The pass through the thorn ridge narrows to a ledge barely wide enough to walk single file. At its midpoint, something large sits very still.

A marjara — a leopard of immense size, pale as the rock, watching you from exactly the spot the path must cross. His tail moves once, slowly. He does not rise.

He is neither blocking nor permitting. He is simply here, as he has been here many times before, watching what comes through.

BLUE **Make the formal greeting between predator-kin**

Requires: Yoga 2+

You lower your gaze, expose your throat briefly, and then meet his eyes again without aggression — the grammar of predator recognition. It takes composure you didn't know you had.

He considers this for a long moment. Then he stands, turns, and walks to the edge of the ledge, leaving the path clear. He watches you cross without looking away.

Effects: XP 25

YELLOW **Proceed slowly, making no threatening gesture**

Roll: Finesse, 13 difficulty

If it succeeds:

You walk forward with the deliberate calm of something that does not consider itself prey. Each step measured. Gaze steady.

He watches the whole crossing. When you reach the other side, he blinks once — slowly — and looks away. You have been assessed and found unremarkable. In predator terms, this is the best outcome.

Effects: XP 15

If it fails:

Halfway across, someone's foot finds the one loose stone on the ridge.

It is a small sound. It is enough. He is up and moving before the stone has finished falling, and the crossing becomes a run, and the run becomes a scramble down the scree on the far side with a good deal less dignity than anyone intended.

He does not follow past the ridgeline. He does not need to — he has made his point, and you are bleeding from the places the scree found.

Effects: HP loss (light, all); mind: Air -10

GREY **Set down some food and step back**

You set a portion of food on the rock and retreat two steps. He looks at the offering, looks at you, and then — with the total lack of embarrassment of something that does not require gratitude — takes it.

The path is yours.

Effects: XP 10

BLUE He is enormous and beautiful and you want to say hello.

Requires: Trait: Pet-lover

You want to. Everything in you wants to, and the part of you that knows better is losing the argument until somebody takes your elbow.

You cross without incident and spend the rest of the day defending the impulse, badly.

Effects: XP 30; mind: Water +5, Air -5

GREY Challenge him

Combat: Animal Marjara Lone (hard)

He rises from the rock in one fluid motion. His ears flatten. He has done this before.

The King of Beasts animal_boss_simha_king

The oldest part of the forest is where he sits — where the trees are so wide you could sleep in their roots and the canopy blocks all direct sun. The simha king does not rise when you approach.

He is the largest lion you have ever imagined possible. His mane is the color of old wood. He is already ancient in legends that are themselves old. The portal to the Human Realm shimmers behind him in the roots of the oldest tree.

He is not blocking it, exactly. He is simply here, as he has always been here — at the threshold, at the end of the animal realm, where the path changes.

His gaze crosses your party without hurry, taking careful measure.

BLUE Approach peacefully and bow

Requires: Yoga 2+

You approach slowly and bow — low and long. When you rise, he has not moved, but something in his posture has changed: the calculation has left it.

'You have learned something here,' he says, in a voice like the ground settling. 'Go forward. Don't waste it.'

He stands and walks aside. The portal is clear.

Effects: XP 50 · Karma: Animal -10, Human +5, God +5

YELLOW Offer tribute worthy of a king

Roll: Charm, 16 difficulty

If it succeeds:

You present what you have with the ceremony the moment deserves. He examines it without touching it — not the goods, but the gesture.

'Adequate,' he says. He steps aside without further ceremony. 'The realm of humans is expecting something. Try not to disappoint it.'

Effects: XP 30

If it fails:

He looks at what you have brought for a long, unhurried moment.

'You have given me,' he says, 'what you could spare.' There is no anger in it. That is the difficulty — there is nothing in it at all. 'Tribute is what you cannot spare. Otherwise it is only tidying.'

He returns it. The goods are yours again and worth rather less than they were.

Effects: mind: Earth -12

GREY Prove your worth in combat

Combat: Animal Boss Simha King (boss)

He rises slowly — no urgency, no anger. He has simply agreed to your terms. His voice carries one last note before the charge:

'Good. I wanted to see if you could.'

YELLOW Attempt to find another way through

Roll: Finesse, 18 difficulty

If it succeeds:

You study the roots, the shadows, the angles. There is a gap — not much of one, but enough.

As you slip through, his voice reaches you from the center of the clearing: 'Clever. But you'll find cleverness has limits, further on.'

He does not pursue.

Effects: XP 20

If it fails:

The gap is there. It is exactly where you judged it to be, and it closes while you are still committed to it.

He has not moved quickly. He has simply been in the place you were going to be, for some time, waiting to see whether you had understood the ground as well as you believed.

'No,' he says, almost kindly. 'Again, or not at all.'

Effects: mind: Space -10

Naga Patrol animal_ocean_naga_patrol

Four naga rise out of the channel in formation, coils turning slow circles to hold position against the current. The lead wears a collar of hammered silver and carries no weapon — she does not appear to think she needs one.

"You are walking on the roof of someone's house," she says. "State whose permission you carry."

GREY Answer with steel

Combat: Animal Naga Patrol (hard)

Karma: Animal +4, Asura +3

GREY Say you carry no one's permission and ask for hers

The honesty surprises her into stillness. "No one says that." She considers you for a long moment, then flicks her tail and the formation opens. "Walk quickly. Someone less patient holds the next channel."

Effects: XP 6 · Karma: Human +4, Animal +2

BLUE Greet her in the old water-tongue

Requires: Water Magic 3+

You shape the greeting the way the current shapes stone — slowly, with the vowels drowned. Her whole posture changes.

"You were taught properly. By whom?" You do not answer, and she decides not to press. She gives you the safe line through the reef and the name of a tidal pool worth visiting.

Effects: XP 14; items: Water Charm Common · Karma: Animal +4, God +2

YELLOW Wait for the current to turn and slip through behind them

Roll: Finesse, difficult difficulty

If it succeeds:

The tide changes and their formation drifts three lengths downstream to compensate. You are across the open water before it closes.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: Animal +3

If it fails: Combat: Animal Naga Patrol (hard)

The lead's head turns before you have taken four steps. "They always try the tide," she says, almost bored.

Karma: Animal +2

Reef Guardian animal_ocean_karka_standoff

A karka the size of a fishing boat has wedged itself into the only gap in the reef wall. Its shell is crusted with a century of coral growth — it has been here long enough to become part of the reef.

One claw opens. Closes. It has not decided about you yet.

GREY Force the gap

Combat: Animal Karka Vent (hard)

Karma: Animal +4, Asura +2

GREY Set food on the rock and step back

Cost: Food (small)

The claw takes the offering with a delicacy that seems impossible for something that size. It shifts perhaps a hand's width — enough, if you go sideways and do not touch the shell.

Effects: XP 8 · Karma: Animal +4, Human +2

BLUE Read the growth on its shell and speak to its age

Requires: Learning 3+

You count the coral bands aloud — the lean years, the warm years, the year something tore a notch from its left claw. By the time you finish it has lowered itself flat to the rock, which you understand is not submission but welcome. Behind it, in a hollow it has clearly been guarding, are things the sea brought and it never ate.

Effects: XP 16; items: Item Random; supplies: Scrap 4 · Karma: Animal +5, Human +3

YELLOW Climb the reef wall over the top of it

Roll: Strength, normal difficulty

If it succeeds:

Coral opens your palms in a dozen places but the karka never looks up. You come down on the far side bleeding and past it.

Effects: XP 8; HP loss (light, random) · Karma: Animal +2

If it fails: Combat: Animal Karka Vent (hard)

A handhold gives. You land badly, directly in front of it, and the claw is already opening.

Karma: Animal +2

Matsya Hunters animal_ocean_matsya_ambush

The water on both sides of the sandbar goes suddenly, completely still — the stillness of a great many things deciding to stop moving at once.

Then the matsya break surface in a ring around you, spears already levelled. They have done this before. They are not in a hurry.

GREY Fight your way off the sandbar

Combat: Animal Matsya Ambush (hard)

Karma: Animal +4, Asura +3

GREY Put down your packs and let them take what they want

Cost: Gold (moderate)

They take methodically, without malice, leaving you your water and one blade between you. As they sink away the nearest one taps her spear twice on the sand — which you will later learn is how the matsya say 'nothing personal'.

Effects: XP 5 · Karma: Hungry Ghost +3, Human +2

BLUE Compliment the ambush — the placement, the patience, the silence

Requires: Guile 3+

You describe their own trap back to them: the two swimmers who went wide an hour ago, the deliberate noise upstream, the way they let you commit to the bar before closing. The ring loosens. Professionals recognising a professional. They let you go and, unprompted, tell you where the next three ambushes are set.

Effects: XP 16 · Karma: Animal +4, Asura +2

YELLOW Pick the weakest point in the ring and charge it

Roll: Strength, difficult difficulty

If it succeeds:

You go through the youngest of them shoulder-first and are in deep water before the ring can turn. They do not follow past the drop-off.

Effects: XP 12 · Karma: Asura +3, Animal +2

If it fails: Combat: Animal Matsya Ambush (hard)

The young one you chose is not the weak point. He was bait.

Karma: Animal +2

Makara Feeding animal_ocean_makara_feeding

Something enormous is feeding in the shallows ahead. The makara's back breaks the surface in a long slow arc, over and over, as it works through a shoal that has nowhere left to go. The water is pink for fifty paces.

It has not noticed you. It is, for the moment, extremely busy.

GREY Attack while it is distracted

Combat: Animal Makara Titan (very_hard)

Karma: Animal +5, Asura +4

GREY Lie flat and wait for it to finish

It takes most of an hour. You spend it face-down on hot rock listening to a thing the size of a barge eat. When the water finally stills, you find the shoal's survivors stranded in the pools — more fish than your party can carry.

Effects: XP 8; supplies: Food 12 · Karma: Animal +3, Human +2

BLUE Read the water and time your crossing between its passes

Requires: Water Magic 4+

The makara's rhythm is written in the current as clearly as a heartbeat. You cross in the trough of each pass, four paces at a time, and are on the far shore before it lifts its head. It never knew you were there — which, you reflect, is the only victory available here.

Effects: XP 18 · Karma: Animal +4, God +3

YELLOW Dart in and take what it has driven ashore

Roll: Finesse, difficult difficulty

If it succeeds:

You work the tideline while it works the deep, and you are gone with an armload before the arc of its back turns your way.

Effects: XP 12; supplies: Food 8; items: Item Random · Karma: Animal +3, Hungry Ghost +2

If it fails: Combat: Animal Makara Titan (very_hard)

The arc of its back does turn your way. It has been aware of you for some time and simply had not finished eating.

Karma: Animal +3

Makara's Toll animal_ocean_makara_tribute

A line of poles has been driven into the seabed across the whole width of the channel, and from each hangs an offering — fish, coins, a bronze bell, a child's carved boat. At the centre, coiled in water too deep to see the bottom of, something very large is waiting to see what you add to the line.

GREY Hang gold on the empty pole

Cost: Gold (moderate)

The coil beneath shifts once, settling, and the channel is simply open. Whatever governs this arrangement, it is scrupulous about its side of it.

Effects: XP 6 · Karma: Animal +3, Hungry Ghost +2

GREY Walk the line without adding anything**Combat: Animal Makara With Guard (hard)**

You are two poles along when the water beneath you stops being water and starts being throat.

Karma: Animal +3, Asura +3

BLUE Make the offering properly — with the words, not just the goods

Requires: Ritual 3+

You hang the offering and then speak over it, naming the water, the channel, and the thing beneath by the titles owed to something that has held one place since before the reef existed. The response is not sound. It is the entire channel going warm, all at once, like a held breath released. On the far bank you find a second offering waiting: yours, returned, with something added.

Effects: XP 20; items: Water Charm Middling; gold 60 · Karma: God +6, Animal +3

BLUE Somebody set this toll. Tolls have terms.

Requires: Trait: Debtor

They do, and the poles record them — the makara's terms are carved on the landward side of the third post, which nobody reads because nobody thinks of a makara as an institution.

It turns out you have already overpaid by walking this far, and you say so.

Effects: XP 20; gold small

YELLOW Take from the poles instead of adding to them

Roll: Finesse, very_difficult difficulty

If it succeeds:

You lift the bronze bell and three purses without disturbing the line, and are across and gone. Somewhere behind you the coil sleeps on. You have gotten away with it. That is not the same as it not counting.

Effects: XP 14; gold 120 · Karma: Hungry Ghost +8, Animal +4

If it fails: Combat: Animal Makara With Guard (hard)

The bell rings. Of course the bell rings. That is what the bell is for.

Karma: Hungry Ghost +5

Naga Court

animal_ocean_naga_court

The court convenes in a natural amphitheatre of coral, the assembled naga arranged by age with the oldest lowest and deepest. They are hearing a grievance: two families, one oyster bed, four generations of argument.

The proceedings pause. Every head turns. A visitor is, apparently, more interesting than the oyster bed.

GREY Bow and watch the proceedings in silence

You sit through four hours of argument conducted entirely in a register of extreme courtesy, and understand perhaps a third of it. At the end nobody has won and everybody seems satisfied. The naga consider this an excellent outcome and are pleased you stayed.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: Animal +3, Human +2

GREY Ask leave to trade with the court**Opens: Naga Palace**

An attendant is detached from the proceedings to deal with you — politely, and with the air of someone glad of the excuse.

BLUE Offer an outsider's judgment on the oyster bed

Requires: Persuasion 5+

You propose that the bed be worked by both families and the harvest split by the tide that brought it — an arrangement neither could have offered without losing face, but which a stranger can suggest freely. There is a very long silence. Then the eldest laughs, a sound like a cave flooding, and the court adopts it on the spot. Four generations, settled by someone who will be gone by evening.

Effects: XP 24; gold 90 · Karma: Human +8, God +4, Animal +3

BLUE The court is deciding where to put you.

Requires: Trait: Attractive

It decides quickly and it decides well, and the seat you are given has a view of the proceedings that a trade delegation would have argued for.

You are aware this has nothing to do with anything you have done. It is still the better seat.

Effects: XP 15

BLUE A court is only people, and people are your subject.

Requires: Trait: Flirt

Within an hour you are on genuinely warm terms with two junior members of a delegation and one archivist, and the archivist is the one who matters.

What you learn from her is not on the agenda and would not have been raised at it.

Effects: XP 20

BLUE Ask the eldest what the naga remember of the realms above

Requires: Awareness 14+

"We remember all of it," she says. "That is the affliction. Your kind forgets and calls it healing." She tells you three things about the world above the water. Two of them you already knew. The third rearranges something.

Effects: XP 16; learns a spell (Water Magic) · Karma: God +4, Human +2

Pearl Merchant animal_ocean_pearl_merchant

She has set out her stock on a square of blue cloth weighted at the corners with stones: pearls, mostly, but also polished shell, sea-glass, and a few things that are clearly older than her trade and probably not hers to sell.

"Everything here came out of something living," she says cheerfully. "Prices reflect that."

GREY Look over the stock**Opens: Pearl Merchant**

She names prices without haggling and watches your hands the entire time.

GREY Nothing you need today

"Come back when the tide's out," she says. "Better stock, worse prices."

BLUE Point out that one of her 'pearls' is a carved bone bead

Requires: Trade 4+

She goes very still, then picks up the bead and turns it over twice. "Sold to me as a deep-water pearl. Three years ago." She is not angry with you. She is calculating something. Then she hands you a genuine one — small, flawed, real. "For the education. I have an appointment to keep with a man in the shallows."

Effects: XP 14; items: Item Random · Karma: Human +4, Animal +2

BLUE Pearls have a price and it is not the one on the cloth.

Requires: Trait: Scrimper

You go through the stock stone by stone, noting the flaws out loud in a tone of mild regret.

By the end she has halved two prices to stop you doing it to the rest, which is exactly the mechanism you were relying on.

Effects: gold small; XP 20

YELLOW Ask which bed the good ones come from, and go get your own

Roll: Constitution, difficult difficulty

If it succeeds:

She tells you, laughing, certain the depth will beat you. It nearly does. You come up grey-lipped and shaking with three good ones in your fist, and she buys two on the spot at a price that suggests she has revised her opinion.

Effects: XP 16; gold 70; items: Item Random · Karma: Animal +3, Asura +2

If it fails:

The pressure turns you back twice, and the third time something large moves past you in the dark and you surface with nothing but a great deal of respect for her profession.

Effects: XP 5; HP loss (light, random) · Karma: Animal +2

Shell-Wright's Stall animal_ocean_karka_merchant

The karka has built his workshop out of his own moults — a spiral of discarded shells, each larger than the last, the oldest ones worn smooth as furniture. Inside, he is fitting plate to a customer's cracked carapace with the total absorption of a craftsman who has forgotten there is a world.

He raises one claw: *wait*. Then, a moment later: *now*.

GREY See what the shell-wright has made**Opens: Shell-Wright's Stall**

He lays out work in shell, chitin and salvaged metal, and names prices in a clicking dialect that somehow leaves no ambiguity.

GREY Leave him to his work

He has already forgotten you. The claw moves; the plate settles a hair truer.

BLUE Offer a smith's technique in trade for a shell-wright's

Requires: Smithing 4+

You show him how a lap joint is scarfed in metal; he shows you how a moult is scored so it splits along a chosen line instead of the line it wants. Neither of you can fully use the other's craft. Both of you leave better. He presses salvage on you and will not discuss payment.

Effects: XP 16; supplies: Scrap 10; items: Item Random · Karma: Human +4, Animal +3

GREY Commission a repair on your own gear

Cost: Gold (moderate)

He works on your armour for two hours without once looking at you, and hands it back better than it was when it was new. There is a small spiral scored inside the collar. His mark, presumably. Or a joke.

Effects: XP 6; buff: Armor +3 · Karma: Human +2

Sunken Ship animal_ocean_sunken_ship

A trading vessel lies on her side in four fathoms, close enough to shore that her upper rail breaks the surface at low tide. She has been down long enough to grow a garden and not long enough for the cargo to have rotted.

Something has been at the hull. The tear in her side is not from rock.

GREY Leave the dead their ship

You walk the shoreline past her. At the low point of the tide the rail shows for a moment, like something surfacing to look.

GREY Work the accessible upper decks

The upper cabins are stripped — someone has been here — but the deck fittings are bronze and nobody bothered with them.

Effects: XP 8; supplies: Scrap 8; gold 30; gains trait: Covetous · Karma: Hungry Ghost +2

YELLOW Dive the flooded hold

Roll: Constitution, difficult difficulty

If it succeeds:

Three trips down, lungs burning each time. The hold's manifest was accurate: bolts of oiled cloth still dry inside their wrapping, a strongbox, and a case of somebody's carefully packed instruments.

Effects: XP 16; gold 140; items: Item Random · Karma: Hungry Ghost +2, Animal +2

If it fails:

A hatch swings shut above you in the dark and it takes a very bad half-minute to find the other way out. You surface with nothing, and stay sat on the rocks for a while.

Effects: XP 5; HP loss (moderate, random); mind: Water -10 · Karma: Animal +2

BLUE There is a hold. Everything good is in the hold.

Requires: Trait: Greedy

There is, and it is, and the water in it is black and the angle is wrong and you go down anyway.

You come up with more than the upper decks would have given and rather less breath than you went down with.

Effects: gold moderate; items: Item Random; HP loss (light, random); XP 18

BLUE Speak the rites for the crew before touching anything

Requires: White Magic 3+

You say the words over the water. Nothing visible happens, which is how it usually goes. But the hold, when you enter it afterwards, is simply a room full of goods rather than the other thing it had been — and the tear in the hull, you notice, is on the inside. Something got out. Whatever it was, it is long gone.

Effects: XP 18; gold 90; items: Item Random; gains trait: Mourner · Karma: God +5, Human +3

Sunken Temple animal_ocean_naga_temple

The temple was built on dry land. That was a long time ago. Now the sea comes in through the doorway at every tide and goes out again, and the carvings on the inner walls have been polished featureless from the waist down and remain razor-sharp above.

The upper registers show naga teaching. The lower, worn away, presumably showed who they were teaching.

GREY This is not yours to enter

You leave it to the tide, which has been more patient with it than any worshipper.

GREY Explore the dry upper chambers

Salt, silence, and a stone box someone left behind in a hurry a very long time ago.

Effects: XP 8; items: Item Random · Karma: Animal +2

BLUE Read what remains of the teaching registers

Requires: Learning 4+

The sequence is a commentary on desire, carved by people who lived where the water always took things back. The final panel is worn to nothing, but the panel before it shows the teacher's hands open and empty, and you find you do not need the last one.

Effects: XP 20; learns a spell (Water Magic) · Karma: God +6, Human +2

BLUE It is a temple. The water is a detail.

Requires: Trait: Pilgrim

You go down and do the circuit, which underwater takes longer and hurts more and is in every other respect identical. The naga who find you doing it are so thoroughly disarmed that the conversation afterwards starts from a position no negotiation would have reached.

Effects: XP 20 · Karma: God +3, Animal +3

BLUE Sit through a full tide in the flooded nave

Requires: Yoga 4+

The water comes to your chest and goes away again and comes back. Somewhere in the fourth hour the distinction between the tide's patience and your own stops being useful. You get up when it is over without any clear sense of having decided to.

Effects: XP 22; mind: Water +30, Space +20 · Karma: God +8

Thermal Vents animal_ocean_thermal_vents

Where the seabed cracks, the water boils. A forest of pale chimneys vents black smoke into cold water, and around each one lives a whole crowded world that has never seen the sun and would die within sight of it.

The karka farm these. There are tool-marks on the nearest chimney.

GREY Give the vents a wide berth

The water shimmers behind you for a long way.

GREY Harvest what grows on the cooler chimneys

The growth comes away in sheets, strange and rubbery and — according to every alchemist you have ever met — extremely valuable.

Effects: XP 8; supplies: Reagents 8 · Karma: Animal +2

BLUE Work the hot vents properly, with a chemist's care

Requires: Alchemy 4+

You take from the seam where the boiling water meets the cold, which is where the interesting compounds precipitate and where a careless hand gets scalded to the bone. It takes hours. What you bring up is worth the hours.

Effects: XP 18; supplies: Reagents 16, Herbs 6; items: Item Random · Karma: Human +3, Animal +2

YELLOW Dive between the chimneys to reach the deep seam

Roll: Awareness, difficult difficulty

If it succeeds:

You read the plumes — which vent is steady, which is about to surge — and thread between them to the seam floor, where the good material has been collecting since before anyone was counting.

Effects: XP 16; supplies: Reagents 12; gold 60 · Karma: Animal +3

If it fails:

A vent you had judged steady surges as you pass. The water is instantly, unsurvivably hot for about a second and a half, and you are only at the edge of it.

Effects: XP 5; HP loss (moderate, random); wound: Deep Cut · Karma: Animal +2

Strong Current animal_ocean_current_crossing

The channel here runs fast and cold between two rock shelves. It is not deep. It is simply moving faster than a person can stand up in, and it goes somewhere you cannot see.

GREY Take the long way around

Half a day of walking and no drama whatsoever. There is something to be said for it.

Effects: XP 3 · Karma: Human +2

YELLOW Rope together and wade it

Roll: Strength, normal difficulty

If it succeeds:

Four in a line, each holding the next, moving on the count. Halfway across the current takes the smallest of you off their feet and the rope does exactly what rope is for.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: Human +3

If it fails:

The rope holds. The packs do not. You reach the far shelf intact and noticeably lighter.

Effects: XP 4; supplies: Food -6 · Karma: Animal +2

BLUE Cross on the surface

Requires: Water Magic 3+

You walk over water that is trying very hard to be somewhere else, and it does not get a vote. The others follow in your footprints, which hold just long enough.

Effects: XP 14 · Karma: God +3, Animal +2

BLUE Somebody has to be the anchor and it is obviously you.

Requires: Trait: Strong

You take the upstream end and plant yourself, and the cold gets into your legs and stays there while five people cross a rope you are personally holding in place.

You go last. You are shaking by then and it does not matter.

Effects: XP 15

BLUE Roped or not, the bottom here is round stones.

Requires: Trait: Clubfooted

Round stones and a fast current and a foot that has never once been reliable on either.

You go down mid-channel and the rope saves you, which is what the rope is for, and the pack you were carrying is not saved by anything.

Effects: supplies: Food -5; mind: Earth -8; XP 22

BLUE Find the slack line the fish are using

Requires: Awareness 13+

There is a seam of nearly-still water behind a submerged boulder, and a queue of patient fish holding station in it. You use their road. It is knee-deep and calm the whole way.

Effects: XP 12 · Karma: Animal +4

Drowned Caravan animal_ocean_drowned_caravan

The tide has gone out over a mudflat and left a caravan standing in it — carts, packs, a cooking pot still upright on its stones. Everything is exactly where it was set down. Nothing is broken.

There are no bodies, and no tracks leading away.

GREY Take what you can carry and move on quickly

You load up fast and do not look at the cooking pot, which has three bowls set beside it.

Effects: XP 8; gold 70; supplies: Food 8 · Karma: Hungry Ghost +4, Animal +2

GREY Set the packs upright, say something, and leave it be

You do not know their names or their rites. You say the words you do know, badly, and go. The tide comes back in behind you and takes the cooking pot.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: God +4, Human +4

BLUE Read the mud — find out what happened here

Requires: Logistics 3+

No struggle, no scatter, no drag-marks. Everyone set down what they were holding and walked into the water together, in step, and the last set of prints is the smallest. You take nothing from the caravan after that. Further up the flat you find a cache they had buried before it happened — the only thing here that was hidden rather than surrendered.

Effects: XP 18; gold 100; items: Item Random; mind: Water -15 · Karma: Human +4, Hungry Ghost +2

BLUE Feel for what is still standing here

Requires: Black Magic 3+

They have not gone. They are standing exactly where they stood, in the same arrangement, facing the water, and they have been standing there through every tide since. One of them notices you noticing. She raises a hand — not a warning. A greeting, from someone with nothing left to warn anyone about. You leave the goods and go.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Water -20, Space +15 · Karma: Hungry Ghost +4, God +4

Rakshasa Ambush animal_forest_rakshasa_ambush

The birds stopped a hundred paces back. You noticed, and kept walking, because there was nowhere else to walk.

He drops out of the canopy directly into your path — a rakshasa, orange-eyed and unhurried, blocking the trail with the relaxed posture of something that has already counted you and likes the number.

GREY Meet him

Combat: Animal Rakshasa Lone (hard)

Karma: Animal +4, Asura +3

GREY Back down the trail without turning around

You retreat facing him, slowly, for two hundred paces. He follows for one hundred and fifty of them and then simply stops, having established whatever he needed to establish. You go the long way.

Effects: XP 5 · Karma: Animal +3, Human +2

BLUE Make yourself expensive — show him the arithmetic

Requires: Might 4+

You do not threaten him. You simply plant, shift your grip, and let him read what taking you would cost. Rakshasa are predators, not gamblers. He tilts his head, makes a sound that might be a laugh, and steps off the trail to let you pass — then follows at fifty paces for an hour, just to be sure you leave.

Effects: XP 14 · Karma: Asura +4, Animal +3

BLUE The birds stopped a hundred paces back. You stopped too.

Requires: Trait: Hunter

You stopped with them, which is why the party is already off the trail and in cover when the rakshasa commits to a charge at where you were going to be.

It is very fast. It is not faster than being somewhere else.

Effects: XP 20

YELLOW He is too relaxed — look for the other one

Roll: Awareness, difficult difficulty

If it succeeds:

There. Above and behind, flattened along a branch, the actual ambush. You point at her without looking away from him, and the whole shape of the encounter collapses. Caught out, they withdraw with what dignity they can — and leave the kill they had been guarding.

Effects: XP 16; supplies: Food 10; items: Item Random · Karma: Animal +4, Asura +2

If it fails: Combat: Animal Rakshasa Maneater Encounter (hard)

You are still looking for the second one when she lands behind you.

Karma: Animal +3

Marked Territory animal_forest_marjara_territory

Claw-marks at head height on every fourth trunk, running as far as you can see in both directions. The marks are fresh, deliberate, and evenly spaced — this is not an animal scratching. It is a boundary, maintained.

The forest beyond the line is very quiet.

GREY Cross the line

Combat: Animal Marjara Lone (hard)

You are forty paces past the marks when the pale shape detaches from a trunk that it had, until that moment, appeared to be part of.

Karma: Animal +4, Asura +3

GREY Follow the boundary until it ends

It takes most of a day. The line ends at a river, and something pale watches you from the far bank the whole time you are fording — but the marks stop at the water, and so does she.

Effects: XP 6 · Karma: Animal +4

BLUE Add your own mark beside hers and wait

Requires: Might 3+

You cut your mark at the same height, the same depth, and sit down with your back to it. She comes within the hour. For a long time she just looks at the two marks side by side. Then she cuts a third — above both — and withdraws. You have been given passage and put in your place simultaneously, which is, you gather, the marjara way of being generous.

Effects: XP 16 · Karma: Animal +6, Asura +2

BLUE Cross without leaving a trace

Requires: Guile 4+

Downwind, on stone and root, never breaking a stem. You are through her range and out the other side and she never knows — which is worth more than her permission would have been, and cost more to earn.

Effects: XP 18 · Karma: Animal +3

Gana Pack animal_forest_gana_pack

They do not surround you so much as *arrive around* you — six gana, drifting out of the undergrowth at intervals, each one taking a position that closes an option you had not yet realised you were relying on.

The last to appear is the smallest, and she is the one the others keep glancing at.

GREY Fight the pack

Combat: Animal Gana Wolves (hard)

Karma: Animal +4, Asura +3

GREY Put meat on the ground and keep walking

Cost: Food (moderate)

They let the food sit until you are forty paces on. Behind you there is a brief, businesslike scuffle over shares, and then nothing. You are not followed.

Effects: XP 6 · Karma: Animal +3, Human +2

BLUE Speak to the small one — the others already are

Requires: Leadership 4+

You ignore the big males entirely and address the small female directly, which is both correct and clearly unexpected. She holds your eye for an uncomfortably long time. Then she yawns — enormous, deliberate, a gesture of dismissal that is also a gesture of safe-conduct — and the whole pack loses interest at once. One of them walks you to the ridge, for reasons of its own.

Effects: XP 18 · Karma: Animal +5, Human +3

BLUE This is not an ambush. This is a working formation.

Requires: Trait: Hunter

It is the shape you would use yourself, if you had six people and needed them to arrive around something at once.

You say so, out loud, with the technical terms. The gana stop what they are doing and reconsider you from the beginning.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Air +8

YELLOW Stand absolutely still and let them lose interest

Roll: Constitution, difficult difficulty

If it succeeds:

Twenty minutes. Nobody moves; nobody blinks first, exactly, but the pack's attention frays the way attention does, and one by one they are simply elsewhere.

Effects: XP 12 · Karma: Animal +4

If it fails: Combat: Animal Gana Wolves (hard)

Someone's nerve goes. A foot shifts. That is all it takes.

Karma: Animal +2

Varaha Charge animal_forest_varaha_charge

You have walked into the middle of a sounder and the middle of a sounder is where the young are.

The boar between you and the trail is not large. The one coming through the undergrowth behind her at considerable speed is.

GREY Brace and meet the charge

Combat: Animal Varaha Sounder (hard)

Karma: Animal +4, Asura +2

GREY Get everyone up a tree, immediately

Undignified, effective. The sounder mills below for half an hour, working itself down from fury to irritation to boredom, and moves off. Someone's pack does not survive the experience.

Effects: XP 8; supplies: Food -4 · Karma: Animal +3, Human +2

BLUE Read the charge line and move the party off it

Requires: Awareness 14+

A varaha charge is a commitment, not a decision — she is going to arrive exactly where she is pointed. You get everyone four paces left and she goes past close enough to feel, and does not turn, because turning is not part of it. The sounder follows her through and the trail is clear.

Effects: XP 14 · Karma: Animal +5

BLUE Do not climb. Stand.

Requires: Trait: Brave

Standing still in front of a charging sounder is a terrible idea that happens to be the correct one, and you are the only person present capable of doing it.

The matron breaks off four feet short. She was never going to commit; she needed to see whether you would.

Effects: XP 12; mind: Air +12

BLUE Greet the matron the way a varaha would

Requires: Persuasion 4+

You go down on one knee, put your eyes below hers, and make the low sound the old ones make when the sounder is settling for the night. The charge does not stop so much as forget itself. She stands over you breathing hard, and then, with enormous dignity, pretends none of it happened and shepherds her young past you into the trees.

Effects: XP 16 · Karma: Animal +6, Human +2

Vanara Toll animal_forest_vanara_toll

A rope bridge crosses the gorge, and it is in excellent repair, which in this forest means somebody maintains it, which means somebody charges for it.

Four vanara are sitting on the far anchor. One of them is holding your water-skin. You are still wearing your pack.

GREY Take the bridge by force

Combat: Animal Vanara Troop (normal)

Karma: Animal +3, Asura +4

GREY Pay the toll

Cost: Gold (small moderate)

The coins vanish. The water-skin comes back. So, unexpectedly, does a knife you had not noticed was missing, and a small carved bird that was never yours. "Overpayment," says the one holding it, with the air of someone who considers this a serious matter.

Effects: XP 6; items: Item Random · Karma: Animal +2, Human +2

BLUE Take something of theirs first

Requires: Thievery 4+

By the time you reach the far anchor you are holding the toll-keeper's belt, her tally-string, and the pin from the bridge's tensioner — which you hand back immediately, because you are not insane. The vanara are delighted. This is the funniest thing that has happened to them this season. You cross free and they wave you off like family.

Effects: XP 16; gold 40 · Karma: Animal +4, Asura +2

BLUE Tell them what you did at the last bridge.

Requires: Trait: Braggart

None of it happened. The vanara are, however, professionals of the form, and they can tell a good account from a true one and prefer the former.

You cross for a story instead of a coin. They will be telling your version by winter, improved.

Effects: XP 20

BLUE Make them laugh

Requires: Comedy 3+

It is not a good joke. It is a joke about a monkey, told to four monkeys, by someone standing over a very deep gorge — and the sheer nerve of it lands where wit would not have. They let you cross on the strength of it and demand you tell it again to the elder.

Effects: XP 12 · Karma: Animal +3, Human +3

Mycelium Tender animal_forest_mycelium_tender

The varaha is on her knees in the leaf-litter with her snout an inch from the ground, doing something that is unmistakably horticulture. Around her, over perhaps an acre, the forest floor has been coaxed into patterns — fruiting bodies in arcs and spirals, each species where it does best.

"Don't step there," she says without looking up. "That one took nine years."

GREY Step carefully back the way you came

"Good," she says, still not looking up. It is the warmest thing anyone has said to you all week.

GREY Ask whether any of it is for trade

"Some." She sells you the ones that fruit fast and refuses to discuss the others. The transaction takes ten minutes and eight words.

Effects: XP 6; supplies: Herbs 8, Reagents 4 · Karma: Human +2

BLUE Offer to help with the nine-year patch

Requires: Medicine 4+

She tests you with one question about rot, decides you are not a fool, and puts you to work. You spend an afternoon thinning a fungal bed under instruction from a boar with better hands than yours. At the end she gives you a wrapped bundle and tells you what each one treats, twice, until you have it.

Effects: XP 18; supplies: Herbs 14, Reagents 8; Medicine +1 · Karma: Human +5, Animal +3

BLUE She is doing something specific. Get down and look.

Requires: Trait: Curious

The varaha does not stop or explain. She does move over slightly, which is permission.

What she is doing is grafting — one network into another, at a join she has prepared over what must be months. Nobody in the party had known this was a thing that could be done.

Effects: XP 8

BLUE Ask what the mycelium is connected to

Requires: Earth Magic 4+

She looks up for the first time. "Everything. That is the whole point." And she shows you: hands flat on the soil, the slow enormous conversation running under the entire forest, older than the trees standing in it, patient beyond any possible use. You take your hands off the ground eventually. She lets you sit with it for as long as you need.

Effects: XP 20; learns a spell (Earth Magic); mind: Earth +25 · Karma: God +5, Animal +4

The Sounder Matron animal_forest_sounder_matron

She is enormous, grey around the snout, and lying in a wallow with the contentment of someone who has nothing left to prove to anybody. Two dozen varaha of assorted sizes are arranged around her in the mud.

One eye opens. "You are in my forest," she observes, without any particular concern about it.

GREY Apologise and withdraw

"Mm," she says, and closes the eye. The audience is over.

GREY Ask her the safe way through

She tells you, in detail, with landmarks, and includes which stretches are contested and by whom and at what hours. It is the single most useful conversation you have had since arriving in this realm.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: Animal +3, Human +2

BLUE Sit down in the mud and stay a while

Requires: Yoga 3+

You get into the wallow. It is warm and appalling and after ten minutes you understand it completely. Nobody says anything for two hours. Piglets walk over you. When you finally rise, the matron says: "You may come back," which from a varaha of her standing is close to adoption.

Effects: XP 16; mind: Earth +30, Fire +15 · Karma: Animal +5, God +3

BLUE She is lying in a wallow, not guarding a pass. Approach accordingly.

Requires: Trait: Beast-tender

You come in downwind, slowly, at an angle, and you stop at the distance she chooses rather than the one you would prefer. She lets you stop there. For a sounder matron with young in the trees behind her, this is an extraordinary concession, and both of you know it.

Effects: XP 20 · Karma: Animal +4

BLUE You know exactly how this goes if it goes wrong.

Requires: Trait: Hunter

You have seen what a sounder does to something that got between the matron and the young, and the memory is specific enough to be useful.

You take the party the long way without arguing about it, and nobody finds out how it would have gone.

Effects: XP 20

BLUE Ask her advice on leading people

Requires: Leadership 4+

"Eat last," she says. "Sleep where they can see you. Never explain a decision twice — they stop believing the first one." She has run a sounder of forty for thirty years. You take notes, mentally, and use them for the rest of your life.

Effects: XP 18; Leadership +1 · Karma: Human +4, Animal +2

Vanara Elder animal_forest_vanara_elder

The troop's elder holds court in the crown of a strangler fig, surrounded by an accumulated lifetime of stolen objects: brass buckles, a broken astrolabe, forty-odd single boots, a temple bell with no clapper.

"Sit," he says, indicating a branch. "Tell me something I don't know. Then you may have one thing."

GREY Decline the game politely

"Everyone's in a hurry," he says sadly, and goes back to sorting buckles.

GREY Tell him what you have seen in this realm

You describe the reef wall, the standing stones, the state of the northern trails. He listens with total attention and interrupts twice for detail. At the end he considers, then hands you a boot. Then, seeing your face, he laughs and gives you something better.

Effects: XP 10; items: Item Random · Karma: Animal +3, Human +2

BLUE Tell him something about his own troop he doesn't know

Requires: Awareness 15+

"Your second-youngest is not stealing food for herself. She has been running it up the east ridge every third day for a month." The elder goes completely still. Then he is gone through the canopy without a word, and comes back an hour later much older and much gentler, and gives you three things instead of one, and asks you not to mention it.

Effects: XP 22; items: Item Random; gold 80 · Karma: Human +5, Animal +3

BLUE Show him a sleight he has never seen

Requires: Thievery 5+

You palm his own tally-stick, produce it from behind a piglet's ear, and return it with the notches recut into a joke about him. The canopy comes apart with noise. He declares you troop-adjacent, grants you the freedom of every bridge in the forest, and immediately begins trying to learn the palm, badly.

Effects: XP 20; items: Item Random · Karma: Animal +4, Asura +2

High Canopy Perch animal_forest_high_canopy_perch

A shyena is perched at the very top of the tallest tree in sight, motionless, looking out over the whole forest canopy. She has clearly been there for hours.

When she notices you at the base she does not startle. She simply looks down, once, and returns to looking out — which somehow communicates, precisely, that you are welcome to climb if you think you can.

GREY Leave her to her watch

She does not look down again.

GREY Call up and ask what she can see

"Everything," she calls back, unhelpfully. Then, relenting: the smoke to the north-east, the migration two days out, the gap in the ridge that the maps do not have. She gives it freely and goes back to watching.

Effects: XP 8 · Karma: Animal +2, Human +2

YELLOW Climb up and join her

Roll: Finesse, difficult difficulty

If it succeeds:

Forty minutes of climbing to sit beside something that got there in nine seconds. She says nothing about it, which is its own kind of courtesy. From up here the forest is not trees; it is one continuous green surface with weather moving over it, and you can see the ridge, the meadow, the sea. You stay until the light goes.

Effects: XP 18; mind: Air +25, Space +15 · Karma: Animal +4, God +3

If it fails:

You get two-thirds up before a branch you had committed to informs you it is dead. The fall is survivable, mostly because of the branches you hit on the way. From above, faintly, comes what is unmistakably laughter.

Effects: XP 5; HP loss (moderate, random) · Karma: Animal +2

BLUE Do not call up to it. Wait until it comes down.

Requires: Trait: Bird Lover

Everyone calls up. That is why the shyena is at the top of the tallest tree and not talking to anyone.

You sit at the base for two hours. It comes down in its own time, which is the only time it was ever going to come down in.

Effects: XP 20 · Karma: Animal +3

BLUE Ask her what the sky-people make of the ground-people

Requires: Air Magic 4+

"That you live in a tunnel and call it a world." She says it without cruelty — it is simply the view from up there. Then she describes the wind-roads: the thermals, the standing waves off the ridge, the column over the meadow that will lift a body a thousand feet if it is patient. You will never use them. You are glad to know they are there.

Effects: XP 18; learns a spell (Air Magic) · Karma: Animal +3, God +3

Healer's Camp animal_forest_healer_camp

Someone has strung a canvas between four trees and turned the space under it into a clinic. There is a queue: a gana with a bad leg, two vanara holding a third between them, a varaha piglet being extremely brave about something.

The healer — a gana, grey-muzzled, working fast — glances at your party and evidently sees nothing urgent. "Back of the line."

GREY Take your place in the queue

Opens: Healer's Camp

It takes two hours. When she gets to you she is thorough, blunt, and charges exactly what the work is worth.

GREY Leave the queue to those who need it

You go. Behind you the piglet is informed it has been very brave, which it clearly already knew.

Effects: XP 4 · Karma: Human +3

BLUE Roll up your sleeves and work the queue with her

Requires: Medicine 3+

She hands you the gana's leg without discussion and watches your first two minutes out of the corner of her eye. After that she stops watching. You work until the light goes. When the last patient limps off she treats your party for free, restocks your kit from hers, and says "come back" in a tone that means it.

Effects: XP 18; supplies: Herbs 12; full restore; gains trait: Merciful · Karma: Human +6, God +3

BLUE You know how to wait in a queue like this.

Requires: Trait: Chronic Pain

You do, and you do it without complaining, which the healer notices from the other end of the line and files away.

When your turn comes she spends longer on you than the queue can really afford, and does not mention why.

Effects: full restore; XP 15

BLUE Somebody here is worse off. You have had worse than this.

Requires: Trait: Scarred

You give up your place, and then the next one, and by the end of the afternoon you have not been treated at all and have carried four people to the front of the line.

The healer finds you at dusk and treats you without being asked.

Effects: full restore; XP 20 · Karma: Human +4, Animal +2

GREY Pay for the queue's treatment and move on

Cost: Gold (large)

You settle the whole line's account and leave before anyone can make it into a moment. The healer catches you at the treeline anyway and presses herbs into your hand, scowling, as though you had done something inconvenient.

Effects: XP 12; supplies: Herbs 8; gains trait: Generous · Karma: God +8, Human +5

Hedonist's Camp animal_forest_hedonist_camp

Someone has been living extremely well out here. There is a fire, a great deal of fermented something in gourds, the remains of a genuinely impressive meal, and a marjara lying on his back in the middle of it all, utterly at peace.

"You look," he says, "like people who have been walking."

GREY Decline and keep walking

"Suit yourselves," he says, wounded on your behalf rather than his own, and pours another.

Effects: XP 3 · Karma: Human +2

GREY Stay the night

It is a very good night. It is a considerably less good morning. You lose most of a day and some indeterminate amount of money, and the party is in a better mood than it has been in weeks.

Effects: XP 8; full restore; mind: Fire +20, Water +15; gains trait: Gourmand · Karma: Animal +5, Hungry Ghost +3

YELLOW Match him gourd for gourd

Roll: Constitution, very_difficult difficulty

If it succeeds:

At some point around the fourth gourd he stops treating it as a joke. At the sixth he concedes with enormous grace, declares you a person of substance, and gives you the good stuff — the sealed one he had not been intending to open for anybody.

Effects: XP 16; items: Item Random; supplies: Reagents 6; gains trait: Night Drinker · Karma: Animal +4, Asura +3

If it fails:

You do not remember the end of the contest. He does, and tells everyone in the forest about it for the next several years.

Effects: XP 5; mind: Earth -15 · Karma: Hungry Ghost +4, Animal +2

BLUE You have opinions about this camp and you keep them to yourself.

Requires: Trait: Ascetic

You decline everything — the gourd, the cushions, the extremely good food — politely and without comment, and your host finds this so novel that he follows you to the edge of the clearing asking questions.

He is, under all of it, lonely. You had guessed that from the size of the camp.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Fire +12

BLUE He is pouring and you are not going anywhere.

Requires: Trait: Drunk

You are not. The evening is genuinely excellent and the following day is not, and somewhere in the middle you agreed to something you cannot reconstruct.

Your host, when you leave, looks briefly like someone watching a colleague go.

Effects: gold -30; mind: Fire -12, Space -8; XP 30

BLUE He has more than drink out here and you can smell it.

Requires: Trait: Bhang Enjoyer

He does. The two of you spend an hour agreeing about a number of things that will not survive contact with morning, and one thing that will: he tells you where the good stands are, and he is not wrong.

Effects: supplies: Herbs 5; XP 20; mind: Water +8

BLUE Ask what he is drinking away

Requires: Yoga 4+

The question lands like a dropped plate. For a moment the whole performance is visible from the inside — the fire, the gourds, the impressive meal, all of it built nightly against a silence he cannot sit in. He does not answer. But he stops pouring, and after a while he asks you how one learns to sit still, and you tell him, and he listens.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Fire +15, Space +15; gains trait: Composed · Karma: God +6, Human +4

Gana Ceremony animal_forest_gana_ceremony

The clearing is full of gana, arranged in concentric rings, and every one of them is dancing — not chaotically, but in a slow interlocking pattern that has clearly been going on for hours and shows no sign of ending.

Nobody is watching. That is not what it is for.

GREY Watch from the treeline

You stay for an hour, understanding none of it, moved anyway. When you leave nobody has acknowledged you, and it does not feel like a slight.

Effects: XP 8; mind: Earth +10 · Karma: Animal +3, God +2

GREY Go around the clearing without disturbing it

You add an hour to the day's walk and disturb nothing. The drumming follows you for a long way.

BLUE Join the outer ring

Requires: Grace 4+

You step in on the beat and the ring absorbs you without breaking stride. It is harder than it looks and then, abruptly, much easier — the pattern does the thinking if you let it. Somewhere in the third hour you stop being a visitor. At dawn the eldest presses her forehead to yours and says nothing at all.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Earth +25, Water +20; gains trait: Celebrant · Karma: Animal +6, God +4

BLUE Whatever it is for, they are glad about it. Be glad too.

Requires: Trait: Celebrant

You do not know the steps and you join the outer ring anyway, and the outer ring is precisely where people who do not know the steps are supposed to be.

By the third round you have most of it. By the fifth you are being corrected, kindly, by a gana half your height.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Air +12, Fire +8 · Karma: Animal +4

BLUE Work out what the ceremony is for

Requires: Ritual 4+

The rings are moving at different rates — outer fast, inner slow, the centre almost still. It is a calendar. They are dancing a year, and the still figure at the centre is the year that has ended. It is a funeral. You take your hat off and stay until it finishes.

Effects: XP 18; Ritual +1 · Karma: God +5, Human +3

Rakshasa Den animal_forest_rakshasa_den

The cave mouth is screened by hanging root and would be invisible from ten paces. Inside, the floor is dry sand, deliberately swept, and the walls are stacked with what a rakshasa considers worth keeping.

The den is empty. The bedding is warm.

GREY Leave now, quickly

You are a quarter-mile away before you let yourself breathe properly. It is, on reflection, the best decision you have made today.

Effects: XP 5 · Karma: Human +2

GREY Take what you can and go

You grab from the nearest stack and are out in ninety seconds. Something calls, far off and unhurried, and you do not stop moving for an hour.

Effects: XP 10; gold 110; items: Item Random; gains trait: Covetous · Karma: Animal +3, Asura +2

YELLOW Search it properly — the good things will be buried

Roll: Awareness, very_difficult difficulty

If it succeeds:

Under the sand at the back, where the sweeping is most careful, there is a hollow lined with cloth. What is in it has nothing to do with hunting and everything to do with whatever this rakshasa was before it came out here to be a predator.

Effects: XP 20; gold 200; items: Item Random · Karma: Animal +3, Hungry Ghost +3

If it fails: Combat: Animal Rakshasa Maneater Encounter (very_hard)

You are elbow-deep in the sand at the back of the cave when the light from the entrance changes shape.

Karma: Animal +4

BLUE Prepare the den before its owner returns

Requires: Guile 5+

You do not steal anything. You rearrange: the bedding, the stacks, the sand, all of it shifted an inch or two out of true. Then you wait outside. The rakshasa comes home, stops dead in the entrance, and spends the next twenty minutes in a state of profound existential unease. It leaves the valley that night. You take the den at your leisure.

Effects: XP 24; gold 180; items: Item Random · Karma: Asura +4, Animal +3

Mushroom Maze animal_forest_mushroom_maze

The fruiting bodies here are the size of buildings, and they have grown close enough together to make corridors. The light under them is the colour of weak tea, the air is thick with spores, and sound does not carry the way it should.

After twenty minutes you pass the same distinctively split cap for the second time.

GREY Retrace your steps and go around

It takes an unnerving amount of time to find the edge again, but you find it. The party is quiet for a while afterwards.

Effects: XP 5; mind: Space -10 · Karma: Human +2

YELLOW Push on and trust your sense of direction

Roll: Awareness, difficult difficulty

If it succeeds:

You keep the slope on your left and refuse to be argued out of it, and the corridors eventually run out of ways to disagree with you. You come out the far side having crossed in a third of the time the detour would have taken — and having gathered a great deal on the way.

Effects: XP 14; supplies: Reagents 10, Herbs 6 · Karma: Animal +3

If it fails:

Hours. The spores get into everything, and by the end at least two of you are seeing things in the corridors that the others are not. You come out somewhere you did not intend to be, tired and rattled.

Effects: XP 6; HP loss (light, all); mind: Space -20 · Karma: Animal +2

BLUE Work the maze deliberately for what grows here

Requires: Alchemy 4+

You stop trying to get out and start trying to get value, which turns out to be the correct relationship with the place. Half a day later you leave by the entrance you came in, loaded, having mapped the good stands by the smell of the air in each corridor.

Effects: XP 18; supplies: Reagents 18, Herbs 10 · Karma: Human +3, Animal +2

BLUE There is something to be heard here and you are not going to hear it.

Requires: Trait: Hard of Hearing

The others stop and tilt their heads and go quiet, and you watch them do it and understand only that something has been heard.

By the time it has been explained the thing that made the sound has moved, and the party's route with it.

Effects: mind: Air -8; XP 22

BLUE Nobody is getting lost in here on your watch.

Requires: Trait: Fastidious

You mark every third turning, consistently, on the same side, at the same height.

It is fussy and slow and the party complains about it right up until the point where you walk everyone back out in a fifth of the time it took to walk in.

Effects: XP 12

BLUE Stop moving and listen to the maze

Requires: Space Magic 4+

The corridors are not a maze. They are one organism's idea of a shape, and it is not trying to trap you — it has simply never had a reason to consider the concept of a straight line. Once you stop expecting corridors to behave like corridors, the way out is obvious, and always was.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Space +25 · Karma: God +4, Animal +2

Ancient Banyan

animal_forest_banyan_hollow

The banyan has been walking for a thousand years — dropping roots, standing on them, letting the original trunk rot away — and what is left is a hollow cathedral of living wood a hundred paces across, with a floor of soft mast and a roof you cannot see.

Things have been left here. Not hidden. Left.

GREY Take nothing, disturb nothing

You walk through and out the other side. The quality of the silence stays with you for days.

Effects: XP 6; mind: Earth +10 · Karma: God +3

GREY Take what has been left

Coins, tools, a folded cloth with something heavy inside. Nobody stops you. Nothing happens at all, which somehow makes it worse.

Effects: XP 8; gold 130; items: Item Random · Karma: Hungry Ghost +6, Animal +2

GREY Leave something of your own and take something in exchange

Cost: Gold (moderate)

You set down coin and lift a small carved thing in its place, and the exchange feels correct in a way you could not defend to anyone. The banyan does not comment.

Effects: XP 12; items: Item Random · Karma: Animal +3, Human +3

BLUE Address the tree properly

Requires: Summoning 4+

You call, and something enormous and extremely slow turns a fraction of its attention toward you. It is not a spirit inhabiting the banyan; it is the banyan, thinking, at a speed that makes a human life look like a spark. It permits you one question. You are still deciding whether you asked the right one.

Effects: XP 24; learns a spell (Summoning); mind: Earth +30, Space +20 · Karma: God +8, Animal +3

Cliff Aerie

animal_forest_cliff_aerie

The nest is a cartload of branches wedged into a fissure two hundred feet up a limestone face, and it has been in continuous use for generations — the bones of a great many meals are cemented into its base by weather.

The adults are out. Something in the nest is not.

GREY Leave the aerie alone

You are a mile off when two shapes cross the sun on their way home. Good timing, you reflect.

YELLOW Climb and take what the nest has collected

Roll: Finesse, very_difficult difficulty

If it succeeds:

Two hundred feet of limestone and then a nest full of two generations of shiny things nobody has ever come to reclaim. You are down and gone before the adults return. Your hands will not stop shaking for an hour.

Effects: XP 20; gold 190; items: Item Random · Karma: Animal +4, Asura +3

If it fails: Combat: Animal Shyena Dive (hard)

You are eighty feet up and fully committed when the shadow crosses you, and shyena do not need to land to fight.

Karma: Animal +3

BLUE The chick is tangled — free it

Requires: Medicine 3+

It has gotten a leg through a gap in the branch weave and has been there long enough to be past panic. Freeing it takes an hour of very careful work at a height that does not bear thinking about. The adults arrive while you are doing it, and hang in the air twenty feet out, watching, and do not attack. When you finish, one of them escorts you down — pacing your descent, ledge by ledge, the whole way.

Effects: XP 22; items: Item Random · Karma: God +6, Animal +5, Human +3

BLUE Look at what is in the nest, not at the nest.

Requires: Trait: Bird Lover

Bone, wool, a length of dyed cord that did not come from anywhere nearby, and — under all of it — the thing the cord was tied to.

The aerie's owner has been collecting from a settlement that is not on your map, and the direction it must lie in is now obvious.

Effects: XP 20; items: Item Random

BLUE Read the face for the updraught and go up on it

Requires: Air Magic 4+

There is a standing column against the rock that will take a light body most of the way if it is not fought. You ride it up, take what is loose, and step off into it again on the way down. Whether the shyena saw you is unclear. If they did, they seem to have approved of the method.

Effects: XP 18; gold 120 · Karma: Animal +3

Forest Merchant animal_forest_jungle_merchant

His entire stock is on his back and his back is enormous. A varaha trader, three days out from anywhere, working a circuit that he clearly holds entirely in his head.

"You're the second party this month," he says, delighted. "Business is booming."

GREY See what he is carrying**Opens: Forest Merchant**

He unpacks with practiced speed, laying everything out on a groundsheet in an order that makes his own sense.

GREY Wish him luck and move on

"Tell people I'm out here!" he calls after you. "Nobody knows I'm out here!"

BLUE Trade him route information for stock

Requires: Trade 4+

You give him the state of the ridge crossings and where the marjara boundary now runs; he gives you a price no one else in this forest will ever see, and adds two items to the pile that were not for sale. Both of you leave convinced you got the better end of it, which is the mark of a good trade.

Effects: XP 16; items: Item Random; gold 50 · Karma: Human +4, Animal +2

GREY Walk with him as far as your roads agree

Half a day of company. He talks the entire time — prices, gossip, a long involved grievance about a vanara bridge toll — and when your roads part he presses supplies on you and refuses payment on the grounds that conversation is worth more than goods out here.

Effects: XP 10; supplies: Food 10, Herbs 4 · Karma: Human +4, Animal +2

Yaksha Challenge animal_meadow_yaksha_challenge

He has planted his spear in the ground across the trail and is standing beside it with his arms folded — a yaksha of considerable size and, evidently, considerable free time.

"Nobody crosses my ground without giving me something to remember them by," he announces. "Gold, a fight, or a story. Your choice. I'd prefer the fight."

GREY Give him the fight

Combat: Animal Yaksha Patrol (hard)

Karma: Asura +4, Animal +3

GREY Give him the gold

Cost: Gold (moderate)

He takes it with visible disappointment and stands aside. "That's the boring one," he says. "Everyone picks the boring one."

Effects: XP 4 · Karma: Hungry Ghost +3

BLUE Give him the story

Requires: Performance 3+

You tell him about the hell realms — the frost, the Warden's gate, a thing with four arms that judged souls at a doorway. He sits down halfway through and does not move again until you finish. When you do, he pulls his spear out of the ground, hands you a drinking-horn from his belt, and asks whether you would consider coming back this way.

Effects: XP 16; items: Item Random · Karma: Animal +4, Human +3

BLUE There is a spear in the ground across the trail.

Requires: Trait: Duelist

There is, and there is only one thing a spear planted across a trail has ever meant, and you have been walking all morning. The yaksha is pleased. The bout is formal, brief, and settled on a technicality that you both agree to call a win for him.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Fire +10

BLUE Accept the fight, but set the terms

Requires: Might 4+

First fall, no weapons, no grudge. He lights up like a festival. You lose — he is enormous — but you lose well enough that he hauls you up laughing and declares the toll paid twice over, then walks you to the edge of his ground telling you about every fight he has had this year.

Effects: XP 14; HP loss (light, random) · Karma: Asura +5, Animal +3

Dura Patrol animal_meadow_dura_patrol

The ground gives slightly under your boot, and then a great deal more, and you are standing knee-deep in the roof of somebody's corridor.

Six dura come up out of the break in perfect order, mandibles first. They are not surprised. They have clearly done this exact drill many times.

GREY Fight clear of the breach

Combat: Animal Dura Soldiers (hard)

Karma: Animal +4, Asura +2

GREY Withdraw slowly and let them repair it

You back off twenty paces and sit down, hands visible. Within the hour the breach is sealed by a work party that ignores you completely. The patrol watches you until the repair is done, then goes back down without a word.

Effects: XP 8 · Karma: Animal +4, Human +2

BLUE Help shore up the collapse

Requires: Smithing 3+

You cut and set a timber brace across the break before they can decide what to do about you, and the work party arrives to find the roof already held. There is a long silence. Then the patrol leader taps her mandibles twice — the dura acknowledgement — and someone brings up worked metal from below and puts it in your hands.

Effects: XP 18; supplies: Scrap 12; items: Item Random · Karma: Human +5, Animal +3

BLUE Recognise the drill and stand where a friendly would

Requires: Logistics 4+

This is a containment formation, not an attack formation — they are protecting the corridor, not hunting you. You move to the position a dura auxiliary would take on the flank and simply hold it. The whole patrol relaxes at once. You are, briefly and administratively, part of the colony.

Effects: XP 16 · Karma: Animal +4, Human +2

Khadga Charge animal_meadow_khadga_charge

The grass ahead is flattened in a long straight line, and at the far end of it a khadga is turning around.

There is no cover between you and it. There is no cover behind you either. It lowers its head.

GREY Stand and meet the charge

Combat: Animal Khadga Lone (hard)

Karma: Asura +4, Animal +3

GREY Scatter — it can only follow one of you

The party breaks in five directions. It commits to one, misses, ploughs a hundred paces of grass, and by the time it has turned everyone is somewhere else. You regroup a mile on, minus one pack and most of your composure.

Effects: XP 8; supplies: Food -5 · Karma: Animal +3

YELLOW Hold until the last moment, then step off the line

Roll: Finesse, difficult difficulty

If it succeeds:

You wait until you can see the individual hairs on its horn and then take one long pace left. It goes past close enough to knock you flat with the wind of it, and keeps going, because that is what a committed khadga does.

Effects: XP 14 · Karma: Animal +4, Asura +2

If it fails: Combat: Animal Khadga Lone (hard)

You step the wrong way. It adjusts. They can adjust, it turns out, right at the end.

Karma: Animal +2

BLUE You will not need to hold until the last moment. You are faster than the last moment.

Requires: Trait: Quick

You step off the line with time to spare, and having time to spare means you can watch the whole thing go past from a yard away, which almost nobody gets to do.

It is enormous. You will be describing it for weeks.

Effects: XP 12; mind: Air +10

BLUE You are already running and it has not started yet.

Requires: Trait: Timid

You are, and the running is the problem — a khadga follows movement, and you have supplied the only movement on the plain.

It follows you a long way before losing interest. The party finds you eventually.

Effects: HP loss (light, random); mind: Air -12; XP 22

BLUE Do not move at all

Requires: Yoga 4+

A khadga charges movement. You stop being movement. It comes to a halt six feet away, snorting, genuinely confused, and stands there for a full minute trying to resolve you into something worth hitting. Then it wanders off to eat. The rest of the party unfreezes considerably later than you do.

Effects: XP 18; mind: Earth +20 · Karma: Animal +5, God +2

Bhramara Swarm animal_meadow_bhramara_swarm

The sound arrives before anything else — a low chord in three parts, coming from a shadow on the grass that is moving against the wind.

The swarm is perhaps four thousand strong. It has noticed you. The chord changes key.

GREY Fight the swarm

Combat: Animal Bhramara Cloud (hard)

Karma: Animal +4, Asura +2

GREY Burn damp grass and go through the smoke

Cost: Herbs (small)

Smoke makes them sluggish and, more importantly, makes the chord fall apart — a swarm that cannot hear itself is just a lot of individual insects. You walk out through the confusion, coughing.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: Animal +3, Human +2

BLUE Answer the chord

Requires: Performance 4+

You find the root note and hold it, and then the fifth, and the swarm — which is a single distributed mind conducting a conversation with itself — abruptly has something else to talk to. The chord resolves into something almost welcoming. They escort you across their range in a loose column and peel away at the boundary, still singing.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Air +25 · Karma: Animal +6, God +3

BLUE Do not run from a swarm. Nobody has ever outrun one.

Requires: Trait: Beast-tender

You stop, and you make everyone else stop, which is much harder.

The chord passes over and around and does not descend, because nothing in the party is behaving like something worth descending on.

Effects: XP 20

BLUE Break the swarm's formation with moving air

Requires: Air Magic 4+

You put a shear across their line of advance. The swarm is not hurt — it is **edited**, the coherent shape torn into six shapes that have to spend the next several minutes deciding which of them is in charge. You are long gone before they settle it.

Effects: XP 16 · Karma: Animal +3, Asura +2

Patanga Ascetic animal_meadow_patanga_ascetic

He is standing in the open with his wings fully spread, facing directly into the sun, and has evidently been doing so since it rose. The grass around him is scorched in a perfect circle.

"Don't stand in front," he says pleasantly. "You'll shade me."

GREY Step out of his light and go

"Thank you," he says, without moving. "Very few people think of it."

GREY Ask what the practice is for

"To want the fire and not enter it. Anyone can burn. Standing at the edge is the discipline." He has been at it, he mentions, for eleven years. His wings are scarred to lace.

Effects: XP 10; mind: Fire +10 · Karma: God +3, Animal +2

BLUE Stand with him until sundown

Requires: Yoga 5+

Nine hours. The heat is unspeakable and the boredom is worse and somewhere in the seventh hour the two stop being different from each other. At sundown he folds his wings and looks at you for the first time. "You wanted to leave at the fourth hour," he says. "You stayed. That is the whole teaching. There is nothing else."

Effects: XP 24; mind: Fire +35, Space +20; gains trait: Ascetic · Karma: God +8, Human +2

BLUE You know what he is doing. Stand in it with him.

Requires: Trait: Ascetic

Wings spread, in the open, in full sun, until sundown. It is a stupid practice and you both know it is a stupid practice and that is not an argument against it.

When the light goes he folds his wings and says one sentence to you, and it is not about the practice.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Fire +15

BLUE You have already given up more than a day of sun.

Requires: Trait: Renunciate

You stand past sundown, which he does not, and he comes back at moonrise to find out what you are doing.

The conversation that follows is the first one in months in which neither of you has to explain the premise.

Effects: gains trait: Renunciate; XP 20; mind: Fire +15

BLUE Argue that the discipline is just a slower burning

Requires: Learning 4+

You put it to him: that standing at the edge for eleven years is not restraint but an extended indulgence, the wanting kept alive deliberately because he is afraid of what he would be without it. He is silent for a very long time. Then: "Yes." Just that. He folds his wings and walks away north, and you never learn where he goes.

Effects: XP 22; mind: Fire -10, Space +20 · Karma: God +5, Human +4

Yaksha Shaman animal_meadow_yaksha_shaman

She has laid out a divination on a hide: knucklebones, seed-pods, a scatter of bright beetle-wings, all of it arranged in a pattern that is clearly precise and entirely opaque.

"Sit down," she says. "You're in it. You've been in it since yesterday."

GREY You would rather not know

"Sensible," she says, and sweeps the beetle-wings into her palm. "Most of it is weather anyway."

Effects: XP 4 · Karma: Human +2

GREY Sit down and hear it

She tells you three things. One is about the road north and is immediately useful. One is about somebody in your party and you decide not to repeat it. The third she will not explain at all — "It hasn't got a shape yet" — but she writes it on a scrap of bark and makes you take it.

Effects: XP 12; items: Item Random · Karma: Animal +3, God +2

BLUE Read the pattern alongside her

Requires: Ritual 4+

You know a different system, but the grammar is the same, and for an hour the two of you argue happily about correspondences like colleagues at a conference. She teaches you her reading of the beetle-wings; you show her something about the seed-pods that genuinely surprises her. She insists on gifting you her spare set.

Effects: XP 20; items: Item Random; Ritual +1 · Karma: Human +4, God +3

BLUE Watch her hands, not the bones.

Requires: Trait: Clear-eyed

The bones land where she puts them. That is not a fraud — she is not pretending otherwise, and when she sees you watching her hands she nods as though a question has been settled.

What she tells you afterwards, without the bones, is the useful part.

Effects: XP 15

BLUE Ask her what she can see of where you are going after this life

Requires: Yoga 5+

She looks for a long time. Then she gathers the bones up without answering and says, gently: "It is not fixed. That is the good news, and it is also the only news." You get the distinct impression she saw something and chose kindness over accuracy — and that she was right to.

Effects: XP 18; mind: Space +20 · Karma: God +6

Dura Artisan animal_meadow_dura_artisan

The surface entrance to the warren has been decorated — and not modestly. Somebody has spent years carving the entire rim into an interlocking relief of the colony's history, and is currently, delicately, adding to it.

"Careful of the edge," she says. "It's wet."

GREY Admire the work and say so

She is entirely unembarrassed by praise and walks you through forty years of colony politics rendered in bas-relief, including two wars, a schism, and a section she describes flatly as "the mistake".

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: Human +3, Animal +2

GREY Commission a piece

Cost: Gold (moderate)

She takes your measure — literally, with a length of knotted cord — and produces a small carved token in under an hour. It is a likeness. It is uncomfortably good.

Effects: XP 8; items: Random Common Talisman · Karma: Human +3

BLUE Ask to add a panel of your own

Requires: Smithing 5+

She hands you a chisel and a corner of blank rim and does not offer advice, which is the highest compliment available. You carve the hell-gate: frost, the four-armed judge, the door. When you finish she studies it for a long while and then cuts her own mark beside yours — colony work, permanent, load-bearing history. Some dura in two hundred years will wonder who you were.

Effects: XP 22; items: Item Random; Smithing +1 · Karma: Human +5, Animal +4

BLUE Look at the work rather than the doorway.

Requires: Trait: Collector

It is very good work. It is also, you notice, made from about nine different things that do not occur within a hundred miles of here.

You say so. The artisan is delighted — nobody has ever recognised the sourcing before, only the arrangement.

Effects: XP 20; items: Item Random

BLUE Read "the mistake" panel carefully

Requires: Learning 4+

The colony sealed a corridor with a work party still inside it, to stop a flood, and saved nine hundred lives. The panel does not editorialise; it simply records, in the same careful hand as everything else, each of the forty-one names. "We carve it so nobody has to argue about whether it happened," she says. "Only about whether it was right."

Effects: XP 16; mind: Earth +15, Water -10 · Karma: Human +4, God +2

Cliff Oracle animal_meadow_cliff_oracle

The uluka is upside down in the mouth of a cliff hollow, wings folded, eyes closed, and has been described to you by three separate strangers as the only honest oracle in the meadow.

"I only answer questions people don't want answered," she says, without opening her eyes. "It saves everyone's time."

GREY Leave her hanging

"Wise," she says. It does not sound entirely like a compliment.

GREY Ask something practical anyway

She sighs, opens one eye, and answers your dull question about the northern route accurately and at length, with the air of a scholar asked to fetch tea. The information is excellent. She is visibly disappointed in you.

Effects: XP 8 · Karma: Human +2

BLUE Ask the one you have been avoiding

Requires: Charm 14+

Both eyes open. She listens to the whole question, including the part you did not mean to say out loud, and then answers it in one sentence that you will be turning over for months. It is not comforting. It is, unmistakably, true.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Space +20, Water -10 · Karma: God +5, Human +3

BLUE An upside-down owl in a cliff. Ask the question properly.

Requires: Trait: Superstitious

There is a way of asking, and you know it, because you have always known these things without being able to say where from.

The uluka answers the question you asked rather than the one you meant, which is the risk you accepted by asking properly.

Effects: XP 15

BLUE Offer her an omen of your own in trade

Requires: Black Magic 4+

You show her the death you have been carrying since the last realm — the shape of it, not the fact. Uluka trade in ill omens the way other people trade in grain, and this is good stock. She takes it off you, which is a service you did not know you needed, and pays for it besides.

Effects: XP 18; gold 90; mind: Water +20 · Karma: Hungry Ghost +3, God +3

Dura Warren animal_meadow_dura_warren

The entrance slopes down out of the sunlight into a corridor that is perfectly round, perfectly smooth, and perfectly dark. Warm air comes up out of it smelling of earth and formic acid.

Somewhere below, a great many things are working.

GREY Not today

The warm air follows you for the first hundred paces, like a held breath.

GREY Explore only the upper galleries

Storage. Rank on rank of it, meticulously sorted, and nobody in this section to object to a modest withdrawal.

Effects: XP 10; supplies: Food 10, Scrap 8 · Karma: Animal +2, Hungry Ghost +2

YELLOW Go deep, toward the sound

Roll: Awareness, very_difficult difficulty

If it succeeds:

Four levels down you find the treasury — not gold; *metal*, worked and stockpiled over generations, the colony's entire strategic reserve. You take what two people can carry and navigate back out by the draught, and nothing ever knows you were there.

Effects: XP 22; supplies: Scrap 25; gold 150; items: Item Random · Karma: Animal +4, Hungry Ghost +4

If it fails: Combat: Animal Dura Burrower Encounter (very_hard)

You take a wrong branch and come out into a gallery that is not storage. The soldiers here are bigger.

Karma: Animal +3

BLUE Announce yourself at the entrance and request an audience

Requires: Persuasion 5+

You do it properly: stand at the threshold, state your names and your business, and wait. It takes three hours. Then a delegation comes up and conducts you down to trade, with an escort, through galleries no thief would ever have found. The colony deals fairly and at volume, and you leave through the front door.

Effects: XP 20; supplies: Scrap 18, Food 8; gold 60; items: Item Random · Karma: Human +5, Animal +4

Bhramara Hive animal_meadow_bhramara_hive

The hive is built around a dead tree and has entirely replaced it — forty feet of grey papery architecture humming at a pitch you feel in your teeth.

There is a doorway. It is guarded, but it is unmistakably a doorway, which suggests visitors are a category that exists here.

GREY Admire it from a safe distance

The hum changes pitch as you withdraw. Acknowledgement, possibly. Or just weather.

GREY Trade at the doorway

The guards will not let you in, but they will exchange: your metal for their stores, at a rate they clearly consider generous and you cannot argue with because you cannot argue.

Effects: XP 8; supplies: Food 12, Reagents 8 · Karma: Human +2, Animal +2

BLUE Enter as the hive-mind's guest

Requires: Summoning 4+

You touch the wall and let the hum have you, and the distributed mind on the other side takes an interest. Inside there is no darkness — the whole structure glows faintly with worked wax — and the hive shows you its nurseries, its stores, its dead, with the unselfconsciousness of something that has never had a private thought in its existence. You come out three hours later, changed in a way that takes weeks to name.

Effects: XP 24; supplies: Reagents 14; mind: Air +30, Earth +15 · Karma: God +6, Animal +4

BLUE Whatever else this is, it is also the best food in the realm.

Requires: Trait: Gourmand

It is. You trade properly for it rather than raiding, because you are greedy and not stupid, and you are given a comb still warm from the wall.

You make it last four days. Everyone else in the party gets some, eventually, after negotiation.

Effects: XP 20; supplies: Food 8; mind: Fire +10

BLUE Ask whether taking it costs the hive anything.

Requires: Trait: Sworn Vegetarian

Nobody asks. The hive-mind takes some time over the answer, which is itself interesting, and the answer is: some, but not much, and less than you would think, and thank you for asking.

You are given more than the traders get.

Effects: XP 20; supplies: Food 6 · Karma: Animal +4

YELLOW Take from the outer stores at night

Roll: Finesse, very_difficult difficulty

If it succeeds:

Cold night, slow hive, and a clean cut through the papery outer wall into a store gallery. You are away with a fortune in worked honey and wax before the temperature comes back up.

Effects: XP 18; gold 160; supplies: Reagents 14; gains trait: Covetous · Karma: Hungry Ghost +5, Animal +3

If it fails: Combat: Animal Bhramara With Soldier (hard)

The wall is not as cold as you judged, and the hum coming through it is rising.

Karma: Hungry Ghost +3

Standing Stones animal_meadow_yaksha_standing_stones

Nine stones in a ring, each taller than a khadga, each carved with a face that has weathered to a suggestion. The grass inside the ring is a different species from the grass outside it.

The yaksha put these up. Nobody currently alive remembers why.

GREY Walk around the ring

You give it a wide berth, and are aware of doing so, and cannot entirely say why.

GREY Walk into the ring

It is markedly quieter inside. Not silent — quieter, as though the ring holds a slightly smaller amount of world. Nothing happens. You leave feeling that something declined to.

Effects: XP 8; mind: Space +10 · Karma: Animal +2

BLUE Wake the ring

Requires: Earth Magic 5+

You put your hands on the northern stone and give it what it has been waiting a long time for. The nine faces do not move — they simply become, briefly, faces again, and the ring remembers that it is a ring. For about four heartbeats you are standing somewhere else, in a much older meadow, among a great many yaksha who are all looking at you with enormous surprise. Then it is a field with rocks in it.

Effects: XP 26; learns a spell (Earth Magic); mind: Earth +30, Space +25 · Karma: God +8, Animal +4

BLUE Nine stones. Count them again.

Requires: Trait: Superstitious

You count them again. There are nine. You count a third time from the other direction and there are nine, and the fact that you needed to check three times is the thing worth paying attention to.

You make the offering at the one you kept losing.

Effects: XP 22; mind: Space -5, Air +8

BLUE Work out what the ring was for

Requires: Learning 5+

The stones are not aligned to the sun. They are aligned to each other, in a pattern that only makes sense if you assume a tenth stone that is no longer there. Something was held in this ring, by nine, and one of the nine failed. You do not find the tenth stone. You do find, at its position, a hollow where nothing will grow.

Effects: XP 20; items: Item Random; mind: Space -15 · Karma: Human +3, Hungry Ghost +3

Patanga Cloud animal_meadow_patanga_cloud

A column of patanga is rising off the warm ground in a slow spiral, thousands of them, catching the light — the whole thing perhaps two hundred feet high and turning like something being poured upward.

They are not going anywhere. This appears to be the entire activity.

GREY Walk on past

The column is still turning when you look back an hour later.

GREY Stop and watch it for a while

Twenty minutes of doing nothing at all, in good light, watching something beautiful that has no purpose. The party is measurably better afterwards.

Effects: XP 6; mind: Fire +12, Air +12 · Karma: God +3, Human +2

YELLOW Walk through the column

Roll: Constitution, easy difficulty

If it succeeds:

Wings against every inch of exposed skin, light coming through in fragments, absolute disorientation for about ninety seconds. You come out the far side laughing and covered in scale-dust that will not brush off for a week.

Effects: XP 10; mind: Fire +20 · Karma: Animal +4

If it fails:

Somebody inhales. There follows a great deal of coughing, some panic, and an undignified exit at speed.

Effects: XP 3; HP loss (light, random) · Karma: Animal +2

Khadga Herd animal_meadow_khadga_herd

Forty khadga, grazing, spread across a mile of grassland directly across your route. Individually each one could end your afternoon. Collectively they are entirely occupied with eating and have not looked up.

GREY Go around — the long way

Four extra hours and total safety. Nobody complains, which tells you something about the party's opinion of khadga.

Effects: XP 4 · Karma: Human +2

YELLOW Walk straight through at grazing pace

Roll: Charm, difficult difficulty

If it succeeds:

The trick, it turns out, is to move exactly as slowly as they do and never once change direction. It takes ninety minutes to cross a mile. Two calves follow you for part of it out of curiosity. Nothing else happens at all, which is a triumph.

Effects: XP 14 · Karma: Animal +5

If it fails:

A bull on the flank decides he does not care for the shape of you and makes a short, emphatic demonstration run. Nobody is gored. Everybody runs. The crossing is abandoned.

Effects: XP 5; HP loss (light, random) · Karma: Animal +2

BLUE **Forty animals and one of them is doing the watching.**

Requires: Trait: Hunter

Second rank, north side, not grazing. Everything the herd will do in the next minute is already decided by her.

You plan the crossing around one animal instead of forty, and the herd never breaks.

Effects: XP 20

BLUE **Walk in slowly. They will make room.**

Requires: Trait: Beast-tender

They make room. It is not tameness — nothing here is tame — it is that you are moving at a speed that reads as weather rather than as threat.

The party follows in your wake, and the crossing takes an hour instead of a day.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Earth +8 · Karma: Animal +3

BLUE **Something in that herd is not a khadga.**

Requires: Trait: Sharp-eyed

Third group from the left, lying down, wrong shoulder line.

It has been in among them for some time and the herd has accepted it, which tells you considerably more about the thing than about the herd.

Effects: XP 15

BLUE **Read the herd and cross behind the matriarchs**

Requires: Awareness 14+

The old cows set the herd's mood, and they are downwind and settled. You cross in their lee, where the bulls take their cues from and therefore will not initiate anything, and are through in twenty minutes.

Effects: XP 12 · Karma: Animal +4

The Migration animal_meadow_migration

It has been passing for two days and shows no sign of ending: a river of bodies, twenty species deep, moving north across the entire visible width of the meadow. Predators walk in it openly, unmolested, because during the migration that is the arrangement.

You need to be on the other side.

GREY **Camp and wait it out**

Another day and a half. You spend it watching, and eat well — the migration sheds food the way a cart sheds straw.

Effects: XP 8; supplies: Food 12 · Karma: Human +2, Animal +2

YELLOW **Cross through the flow**

Roll: Finesse, difficult difficulty

If it succeeds:

You go with the current at an angle, never against it, the way you would ford a river. Forty minutes inside a moving wall of animals that mostly ignore you. You come out a mile north of where you meant to and entirely intact.

Effects: XP 14 · Karma: Animal +4

If it fails:

Somebody stumbles and the party fragments. You spend the rest of the day being carried north by a river of grazers and the following morning walking back south.

Effects: XP 5; HP loss (moderate, random) · Karma: Animal +2

BLUE It is going somewhere. That is the part that gets you.

Requires: Trait: Homesick

Two days of animals that know exactly where they are going and why, and will be there by a particular week, and have been doing it since before anyone was counting.

You watch a good deal more of it than the crossing requires.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Water +8, Space +5

BLUE Walk with the migration as long as it goes your way

Requires: Grace 4+

You match the pace and join it, and for six hours you are simply part of the thing, walking north among a hundred thousand animals under the truce. A marjara walks beside you for a mile. Neither of you acknowledges the other. It is, on later reflection, one of the great experiences of the run.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Earth +20, Water +20; gains trait: Beauty-struck · Karma: Animal +6, God +3

Grassfire animal_meadow_grassfire

The smoke line is on the southern horizon and it is wider than it was ten minutes ago. Grassfire moves faster than a running person when the wind is behind it, and the wind is behind it.

There is a rocky rise a mile east. There is a river two miles north. Neither is close enough to be comfortable.

GREY Run for the river

You make it, barely, and stand chest-deep watching a mile-wide front of fire go past on both banks. Somebody's pack is gone. Everybody's eyebrows are gone.

Effects: XP 10; supplies: Food -6; HP loss (light, all); gains trait: Harrowed · Karma: Animal +3

BLUE Burn a firebreak and shelter in the black

Requires: Logistics 4+

You light your own fire downwind and let it eat a patch bare, then stand in the ash while the main front arrives and finds nothing to eat. It is loud, and hot, and completely survivable, and the party looks at whoever suggested it with new respect.

Effects: XP 18 · Karma: Human +5, Animal +2

BLUE Take the fire in hand

Requires: Fire Magic 5+

You do not put it out — it is a mile wide and older than your involvement. You persuade it to part. Two walls of flame go by on either side of a corridor thirty feet across, and for about four minutes the party walks through the middle of a grassfire in perfect safety and total terror.

Effects: XP 22; mind: Fire +25 · Karma: Animal +3, Asura +3, God +2

BLUE A fire front is a line. You have worked a line before.

Requires: Trait: War-hardened

You stop the party from running, which is the entire job, and then you give four people four tasks in the order they need doing.

It is not courage. It is that panic is a thing you stopped being able to do some years ago, and it turns out to be worth more than courage here.

Effects: XP 15

BLUE There are animals in front of that fire.

Requires: Trait: Pet-lover

There are, and you are already moving toward them, and the argument about whether this is sensible happens behind you at volume.

You get perhaps a third of them out. The third is a real number of living things and you decline to be told otherwise.

Effects: XP 30; HP loss (light, random); mind: Water +12 · Karma: Animal +6, Human +3

BLUE Drive the trapped grazers out ahead of the front

Requires: Leadership 4+

There is a pocket of young khadga penned against a gully and no time to do this and get clear yourself. You do it anyway, shouting and waving and running the gully line until they break the right way. You reach the river with the front close enough to read by. Later, in the meadow, khadga will not charge you. Word travels.

Effects: XP 20; HP loss (moderate, all); gains trait: Merciful · Karma: God +8, Animal +6, Human +4

Thermal Column animal_meadow_thermal_column

A bare patch of dark rock in the middle of the grass throws up heat all afternoon, and everything with wings in the meadow knows it. Shyena, kapota and uluka circle in a lazy stacked column half a mile high, none of them flapping, all of them going up.

At ground level it is simply a warm rock. It makes a good place to stop.

GREY Rest on the warm rock

An hour in the sun on hot stone with birds turning overhead. The party's aches ease and nobody says anything of consequence the entire time.

Effects: XP 6; full restore; mind: Fire +10, Air +10 · Karma: Human +2

GREY Keep moving while the light holds

You make good distance. The column is still there behind you at dusk, thinning as the rock cools.

BLUE Signal the birds down

Requires: Air Magic 3+

You put a twist in the thermal — a stutter in the rising air that reads, to anything riding it, as an invitation. A kapota comes down to see what happened. She carries messages for a living, is intensely curious about ground-walkers, and trades you an hour of the meadow's news for the novelty of the conversation.

Effects: XP 14; items: Item Random · Karma: Animal +3, Human +2

Plains Merchant animal_meadow_merchant

The cart is enormous, the draught animal is a khadga in a padded harness, and the merchant is a yaksha who has clearly been doing this route for decades.

"Don't touch the wheels," she says by way of greeting. "Everything else is negotiable."

GREY See what she carries

Opens: Plains Merchant

The cart opens out into a shop-front with practiced efficiency.

GREY Move on

"Suit yourself. I'll be at the standing stones in four days if you change your mind."

BLUE Haggle properly

Requires: Trade 4+

Forty minutes of extremely enjoyable commerce. She opens by insulting your boots; you close by pointing out that her khadga is favouring a foreleg and she is four days from anyone who can shoe it. You both leave delighted. Your prices are excellent.

Effects: XP 14; gold 60; items: Item Random · Karma: Human +4, Hungry Ghost +2

BLUE Offer to see to the khadga's foreleg

Requires: Medicine 4+

There is a stone bruise under the plate and the beginnings of an abscess. You open it, drain it, pack it, and explain the aftercare twice. The merchant watches the whole thing without a word, then loads your packs with whatever you point at and refuses money. "That animal is my business," she says. "You just saved my business."

Effects: XP 18; items: Item Random; supplies: Food 10, Herbs 6 · Karma: Human +6, Animal +4

22. Human, Asura and God

These three realms have no map, no enemies, no shops and no events yet. What exists is a set of **births** and design notes. This is the part of the game most in need of writing, and where a fresh pair of eyes will do the most good.

Human realm

The most dialogue-heavy realm: a mix of quests, towns and negotiation, with three zones and a different tone for each:

- **West: the steppe of Oddiyana and Gandhara.** Scythian-style nomads and cavalry; a country of riders, archers and raiders. Skills favoured: Ranged, Guile, Daggers.
- **North-east: Zhang-Zhung.** The proto-Tibetan land of shamanic Bön: yak herders, ritual specialists, high pastures. Skills favoured: Ritual, Yoga, Earth magic.
- **South-east: coastal trade cities.** Cosmopolitan and mercantile: harbours, caravanserais, bazaars. Skills favoured: Trade, Persuasion, Alchemy.

Births already defined: Human, Nomad, Mountain Folk, Trader.

Asura realm

The realm of the jealous gods, locked in endless war with the gods above. Intended to be **competitive**: duels, tournaments, rivalry, a society organised around status and the constant sting of envy. Births defined: Tsen, Rudra.

God realm

Almost no combat. A realm of **diplomacy and trade**: refined courts, bargaining over beauty and time, and the quiet dread of those who know the bliss will end. Births defined: Gandharva, Apsara, Planetary Deity.

What each realm needs

For each of the three: a map with regions and landmark places; a bestiary (enemy types); a pool of events (the existing realms have 80–150 each); companions (the existing realms have 23–24 each); backgrounds specific to their births; shops and guilds; a boss and a pass-guardian; and a set of place and personal names.

Realm-specific mechanics to bear in mind while writing: the Human realm is the one where practice becomes possible, so Yoga and Ritual choices should matter more there; the Asura realm rewards confrontation; the God realm rewards diplomacy and punishes pride.

23. Events across the realms

33 events are not tied to one realm. Some are the **domain events**: rare places that teach a domain's spells (chapter 8). Others are **camp events**, occurring on a rest night, and **trait events** and **relationship events**, which are about a particular character or a pair of companions and use {a} and {b} for their names.

The Pit the_pit

Domain: Mud · Rarity: Rare

The path descends into a vast muddy hollow. Dozens of mudlings — squat, glistening figures of animated muck — mill about in the thick brown sludge below. They have a crude camp of sorts: stacked bones, offerings of rusted metal, a clumsily drawn circle of wet earth in the center.

One large mudling turns its featureless face toward you. A sound like bubbling tar rises from its throat. The others still.

GREY **Attack. Clear the pit.**

Combat: Mudling Colony (hard)

Karma: Hell +5, Asura +3

GREY **Offer most of your food stores as tribute — seeds, grain, everything you can carry forward.**

Cost: Food Percent (75)

Opens: Teachings of the Pit

The large mudling reaches out a dripping limb and takes the sacks. One by one they are passed back through the colony and buried reverently in the central circle — seeds going into the earth, the way things are supposed to go. The mudlings make a sound like a long satisfied exhale of thick air. The elder turns back to you, willing to share what it knows.

Karma: Animal +4, Human +3

BLUE **Demonstrate mastery of earth. Let them see what the deep stone knows.**

Requires: Earth Magic 7+

Opens: Teachings of the Pit

You call stone and soil to your hands and let the deep vibration speak. The mudlings go utterly still. Then, one by one, they prostrate themselves in the mud. The elder rises and presses both palms against your chest — it recognises a peer, and is willing to teach.

Karma: God +4, Human +3, Animal +2

BLUE **They are not a mob. Look at how they are arranged.**

Requires: Trait: Beast-tender

They are arranged the way a nesting colony is arranged — the small ones inward, the big ones facing out, and the whole thing pointed away from something rather than toward you.

You back out along the line they are not watching, and nothing follows.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Air +8

YELLOW Stage an impromptu mud puppet play — a heroic epic specifically about the mudlings. Their ancient glories. Their terrible battles. The beauty of their mud.

Performance 5+; Roll: Charm, easy difficulty

If it succeeds: Opens: Teachings of the Pit

You give them heroes. You give them tragedy. You give them a protagonist who is unmistakably the large elder mudling, whose courage is legendary, whose mud is the finest mud in all the realms. The colony erupts into a sound like a dozen geysers firing at once. Applause. The elder mudling — visibly moved, perhaps slightly embarrassed — gestures toward the central circle. You are welcome to learn.

Karma: Human +5, Animal +4

If it fails:

Your puppet stumbles. Your plot collapses. The mudlings watch politely for a moment, then begin pelting you with clods. You flee the pit covered head to toe — but oddly, not harmed.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: Animal +2

Crystal Cave crystal_cave

Domain: Crystal · Rarity: Rare

The cave mouth is unremarkable — a crack in a hillside. Inside, it opens into something else entirely. Formations of crystal the height of houses catch what little light enters and multiply it into thousands of beams, filling the space with cold, sourceless radiance.

At the centre, seated in perfect stillness on bare stone, is a man. He is old. He is completely naked. He is meditating, and does not appear to notice you at all.

BLUE Sit down and meditate alongside him.

Requires: Yoga 5+

Opens: Teachings of the Crystal Cave

You sit. The cave does the rest. After some time — minutes or hours, it is impossible to say — the yogi opens his eyes. He looks at you the way people look at someone they recognise from a long time ago.

'You already know some of this,' he says. 'Let me show you the rest.'

Karma: God +5, Human +3

BLUE Ask him about the secrets of this cave.

Requires: Earth Magic 6+; Space Magic 6+

Opens: Teachings of the Crystal Cave

He opens one eye. He looks you over slowly. Then he smiles — not warmly, exactly, but as if amused by something he's been waiting to see.

'You speak the right language,' he says. 'Then you will understand what I am about to tell you.'

Karma: God +4, Human +2

GREY Leave him offerings and ask for a blessing.

Cost: Gold (small), Food (small)

You set down what you have brought — a little gold, a little food — and bow. The yogi does not open his eyes. But something in the cave shifts. The light settles differently on you.

You feel cleaner, somehow. Sharper. You carry the blessing forward.

Effects: buff: Awareness +2, Focus +2, Luck +2 · Karma: God +4, Human +3, Animal +1

BLUE Do the offering properly before asking for anything.

Requires: Trait: Pilgrim

You set it out in the correct order, which takes a while and which he watches without comment.

When you finally do ask, he answers as though you had been introduced, rather than as though you had arrived.

Effects: XP 20 · Karma: God +3, Human +2

GREY Attack him.

You raise your weapon. He opens his eyes.

The cave is gone. You are standing on the hillside in the open air. There is no crack in the rock, no crystal, no yogi. Only a very faint impression of sadness that may be yours or may be his — it is difficult to tell.

Effects: gains trait: Blood-handed · Karma: Hell +8, Asura +5, Human -5, God -5

Glass Mountain glass_mountain

Domain: Glass · Rarity: Rare

A mountain of glass rises from the plain — not metaphor, not illusion. Pure fused silica, facets the size of houses catching the light and throwing it in every direction. The surface is perfectly smooth and perfectly vertical. There is no path up. There is no grip.

At the summit, something moves.

YELLOW Attempt to scale the glass face.

Roll: Finesse, difficult difficulty

If it succeeds: Opens: Secrets of the Glass Mountain

Your fingers find edges too fine to see, your weight shifts by instinct rather than thought. Slowly, impossibly, you climb. At the summit: glass spirits drifting in slow, glitching arcs — each movement a fraction out of time with the last, refracting light into cascades that should not be possible. They do not speak. They seem to notice you the way light notices a prism. Something passes between you.

Karma: God +3, Human +3

If it fails: Leads to: Glass Mountain

You slip. The glass offers nothing to hold and less to forgive — you slide and tumble, cutting yourself on the way down. The mountain stands unchanged.

Effects: HP loss (moderate, random) · Karma: Human +1

BLUE Let the air carry you up.

Requires: Air Magic 5+

Opens: Secrets of the Glass Mountain

You step off the ground and let the wind take you — drifting upward along the face of the mountain, close enough to see your own distorted reflection in every facet. At the summit, glass spirits dance in slow, glitching loops, throwing light in directions that make no sense. One drifts close and holds the shape of something familiar — your face, perhaps, or the memory of one. Then it disperses, chiming softly.

Karma: God +4, Human +2

BLUE Speak to the glass as stone. It was sand once — and before that, it was earth.

Requires: Earth Magic 5+

Opens: Secrets of the Glass Mountain

You press your hands to the surface and speak to what it used to be. There is a long moment. Then the glass does not open exactly — it simply stops being a wall in the way that it was. You walk through and up, the mountain permitting. At the summit, glass spirits spiral in their slow broken arcs. They feel very old. They feel like they have been waiting.

Karma: God +4, Human +3

BLUE Sing to the mountain.

Requires: Performance 6+

Opens: Secrets of the Glass Mountain

You begin to sing — nothing composed, just what comes. The mountain answers. A harmonic rises from somewhere inside the glass, and then another, and footholds crystallise along the face as if the mountain is remembering how to be climbed. At the summit the glass spirits dance faster for a moment, producing tones you can almost hear. A faint luck settles on you like dust: the mountain was pleased.

Effects: buff: Luck +1 · Karma: God +5, Human +4, Animal +1

BLUE Sit at the base and meditate. Stop trying to climb.

Requires: Yoga 5+

Opens: Secrets of the Glass Mountain

You sit. The mountain does not move. You stop expecting it to. At some point — you cannot say when — you are at the summit, seated in the same posture, and the glass spirits are circling you in their glitching arcs, throwing light across your closed eyelids in patterns that carry meaning. You have not climbed the mountain. You have stopped being someone who needed to.

Effects: gains trait: Beauty-struck · Karma: God +6, Human +3

BLUE It is a mountain made of glass. Note it and go around.

Requires: Trait: Incurious

You go around. It takes an extra day and involves no revelation of any kind, which is precisely the outcome you were after.

Effects: mind: Space -8; XP 22

BLUE Stop. Do not climb it, do not speak to it. Look at it.

Requires: Trait: Beauty-struck

You have seen something like this before — that is the trouble with having been struck once. You know what it is you are looking at.

You stay until the light moves off it. Nobody hurries you.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Space +12, Fire +8

GREY Stand and look at it for a while. Some things teach by being looked at.

You stand at the base of the mountain and look up. The light changes as you watch — slowly, the way a day changes, but condensed. Somewhere in the complexity of the refracted surface is something you cannot name but will not forget.

Effects: XP 15; gains trait: Beauty-struck · Karma: Human +1

The Smoking Mirror the_smoking_mirror

Domain: Smoke · Rarity: Rare

In a clearing where ash drifts like snow, a mirror stands alone — black obsidian framed in tarnished silver, taller than a person, tilted slightly as if to catch a sky it has no interest in showing you.

The surface does not reflect. It smokes. Slow dark coils rise from the glass and dissipate without smell or warmth. Where your reflection should be, there is only depth — and somewhere in that depth, something moves.

YELLOW Look into the mirror.

Roll: Focus, normal difficulty

If it succeeds: Opens: Vision of the Smoking Mirror

You hold its gaze. The smoke parts. You see yourself — but wrong: every flaw given a face, every hidden thing laid bare. You do not flinch. Something dissolves, and something else rises in its place. When you look away you understand smoke in a way you did not before. The mirror has nothing more to show you.

Effects: gains trait: Harrowed · Karma: Human +3, God +2

If it fails: Opens: Vision of the Smoking Mirror

You hold its gaze too long. The smoke parts and shows you something you were not ready to see — and a piece of yourself goes with it, drawn into the depth. The knowledge of smoke rises in you regardless. The price was a piece of yourself. The mirror does not seem to care.

Effects: attribute_loss: {"which": "random", "amount": 1} · Karma: Human +2, Hell +2

BLUE Recognize the mirror for what it is. Hold up your own mirror to face it.

Requires: Ritual 5+

Opens: Vision of the Smoking Mirror

You have seen this described in the old texts: a Tezcatlipoca-mirror, a devourer of reflections. You produce your own mirror — polished bronze, consecrated — and hold it to face the black glass.

The two mirrors lock. The smoke rushes between them in a furious loop, finds no victim, and exhausts itself. The obsidian surface is still. In the silence, the knowledge of smoke rises in you like cooling ash.

Effects: buff: Awareness +1 · Karma: God +5, Human +3

BLUE Recognise the mirror for what it is. Don't look at the surface — look at what the surface is doing.

Requires: Yoga 5+

Opens: Vision of the Smoking Mirror

You see the mirror without seeing what it shows. The smoke coils and finds no purchase — there is no self presented to be consumed. The mirror continues smoking. You absorb its nature without being changed by its contents.

Effects: buff: Focus +1; gains trait: Clear-eyed · Karma: God +5, Human +3

GREY Strike the mirror. Whatever is in there, drag it out.**Combat: Smoking Mirror Combat (hard)****After victory: Opens: Vision of the Smoking Mirror**

The last imp dissolves. The mirror lies in shards, each one still faintly smoking. From the fragments, patterns of ash rise and arrange themselves — the knowledge of smoke, offered at last in defeat.

Karma: Asura +4, Hell +3

GREY Turn away. Do not look.

You turn your back on it and walk. The smoke coils behind you. Whatever it wanted to show you, it keeps.

The Cloud Palace cloud_palace

Domain: Cloud · Rarity: Rare

A palace materialises before you — or perhaps you have drifted into it without noticing. Its halls are open to the sky, its floors are cloud made solid underfoot. Through gaps in the floor, far below, you can see the tops of mountains. Through gaps in the ceiling, open sky.

Slithering through the amber light, singing to one another in voices like slow rain on stone, are nagas — a rare breed that rules the clouds and weather. Vast and iridescent, utterly absorbed in their song. They have not yet noticed you.

BLUE Listen carefully and join their chorus.

Requires: Performance 6+

Opens: Teachings of the Cloud Palace

You find the thread of the melody and follow it in. One naga turns a great head toward you — eyes like water, expression unreadable — and then returns to the song. You have been included. When the chorus ends, the nagas coil and settle, regarding you with something that might be warmth. There are things they are willing to teach.

Karma: God +5, Human +4, Animal +2

BLUE Listen in, then step forward and set out offerings: fruits, perfumed water, their favourite herbs and spices.

Requires: Ritual 3+ · Cost: Gold (moderate), Food (small), Herbs (small), Reagents (small)

Opens: Teachings of the Cloud Palace

The song does not stop, but it shifts — a new note braided in, low and enquiring. One naga descends to inspect the offerings. It touches each item with the tip of its tongue. A long pause. Then it looks at you with those water-coloured eyes and the song shifts again, opening a space for you to enter. You have been acknowledged. They are willing to share something of what they know.

Karma: God +4, Human +3, Animal +3

GREY Walk inside and try to talk to them.

Leads to: Cloud Palace Inner

You step through into the heart of the palace. The song reverberates in your chest. The nagas slither in vast arcs around the pillars, absorbed completely in their chorus — and then, one by one, they notice you.

GREY Walk inside and try to pocket some of their jewels while they are distracted.

Combat: Cloud Naga Pack (hard)

Your hand closes around something that feels like a frozen raindrop cut into a gem the size of a fist. The song stops. They are not slow.

Effects: gains trait: Covetous · Karma: Hungry Ghost +6, Animal +3, Human -3

GREY Attack them.

Combat: Cloud Naga Pack (hard)

The song stops. The nagas uncoil.

Karma: Hell +8, Asura +4, Human -4, God -4

The Cloud Palace — Inner Hall cloud_palace_inner

Domain: Cloud · Rarity: Follow Up Only

The song stops. Every naga in the palace has turned to regard you. The silence is the silence of held weather.

The largest — coiled around a pillar of frozen cloud, scales catching the amber light like hammered silver — opens its mouth.

"Who daresss interrupt the sssong?"

BLUE Breathe, settle, and let the song you were interrupting continue through you.

Requires: Yoga 5+

Opens: Teachings of the Cloud Palace

You close your eyes and stop resisting the sound. The song fills you and passes through you, using you briefly as an instrument. The nagas relax — one by one, they return to their spiralling. The largest turns those water-coloured eyes on you and inclines its head. You have not interrupted the song. You have become, briefly, a part of it. They are willing to teach.

Effects: gains trait: Beauty-struck · Karma: God +6, Human +3

BLUE Bow low and explain, with all the words you have, why you have come and what you offer.

Requires: Persuasion 5+

Opens: Teachings of the Cloud Palace

You speak carefully and at length. The nagas listen with the patience of creatures that measure time in rainstorms. The large one's tail shifts — once, then again. At last it makes a sound like distant thunder and the others settle.

"Sso. You have a tongue worth hearing." They are willing to teach.

Karma: Human +5, God +2

YELLOW Smile, open your hands, and try to win them over on pure charm.

Roll: Charm, difficult difficulty

If it succeeds: Opens: Teachings of the Cloud Palace

You have spent years learning how to walk into rooms that do not want you and leave them differently. The large naga blinks — a slow, contemplative gesture — and something shifts in its posture.

"You," it says, "are either very brave or very foolish." It sounds like a compliment. They are willing to teach.

Karma: Human +4, God +1

If it fails:

The naga stares at you for a long, terrible moment. Then it opens its mouth, and what comes out is not words. It is weather. When you come back to yourself you are standing outside, alone. The palace is gone. Your bones ache with a deep cold.

Effects: buff: Constitution -3

GREY "Is that any way to treat a guest?"

There is a pause that contains weather systems.

"A guesssst," the large naga says, very softly, "iss invited."

What comes next is not words. When you come back to yourself you are standing outside. The palace is gone. The sky above is the particular grey of something that has already decided to rain.

Effects: buff: Constitution -3 · Karma: Human -1

The Waterworks waterworks

Domain: Steam · Rarity: Rare

A low wooden building rises from the mist, every surface slick and steaming. Above the entry hangs a sign painted with a frog holding a cup of tea. Through the latticed panels you can see shapes moving in pale mineral water — people, perhaps, or creatures that resemble them. The smell of cardamom and sulfur drifts toward you.

The door is open.

GREY Pay the entry fee and use the baths

Cost: Gold (small moderate)

Leads to: Waterworks Inner

You hand over the coins, receive a worn linen towel, and are waved through. The water is exactly the right temperature. Somewhere, a flute plays a tune you almost recognize. When you finally climb out, you feel entirely new.

Effects: full restore · Karma: Human +2

BLUE Ask whether they serve tea on the hot side. They will.

Requires: Trait: Tea Ritualist

They do, and it is served in the manner of a place that has been serving it to the same twelve people for three hundred years.

You are, briefly, extremely comfortable. It is not an experience this realm offers often.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Water +12, Fire +5

GREY Leave without going in

You walk on. The sound of splashing water and low voices fades behind you.

The Bathhouse Floor waterworks_inner

Domain: Steam · Rarity: Follow Up Only

Clean, rested, and wrapped in borrowed linen, you survey the room. A pair of river spirits play dice in the corner. Two monks argue quietly over a plate of dumplings. A large toad in a silk robe sips tea with the focused air of someone who has been doing this for several centuries.

On low tables between the pools: small plates of pickled plum, pale cakes, and pale green tea. Nobody looks at you with any particular suspicion.

GREY Order tea and snacks for the whole room — your coin, your treat

Cost: Gold (100)

Opens: Secrets of the Bathhouse

A small stir runs through the room. The toad in the silk robe sets down its cup, turns its enormous amber eyes toward you, and slowly crosses the floor.

'Generosity in a bathhouse,' it says, in a voice like water over smooth stone. 'That's rarer than you'd think.' It settles beside you. 'I know a trick or two. Buy something, and I'll show you.'

Karma: God +3, Human +3

BLUE Hold the room with tall tales of your travels

Requires: Performance 5+; Comedy 5+

Opens: Secrets of the Bathhouse

You begin with the time you crossed the frozen bridge over the River of Ash. By the second story, even the monks have stopped arguing. By the third, the toad in the silk robe is leaning forward with those great amber eyes half-closed in something like delight.

'You've been places,' it says, when you finish. 'I've been a few places myself. A trade seems fair.'

Karma: Human +4

BLUE Say nothing and let the room talk over you.

Requires: Trait: Gossip

A bathhouse is the most porous building ever devised. In ninety minutes you learn who is in debt to whom, which official is not returning, and one thing that is very obviously a lie and therefore worth more than the rest of it.

Effects: XP 20; gold small

BLUE The entry fee is negotiable. It always is.

Requires: Trait: Scrimper

It is not negotiable, and you negotiate it anyway, on the grounds that you will not be using the oils, the towels, or the attendant.

They take a third off to be rid of the conversation.

Effects: gold small; XP 20

YELLOW Slip away and quietly go through the bags left unattended near the changing room

Roll: Thievery, easy difficulty

If it succeeds:

Everyone is very relaxed and nobody is watching the changing room closely. You move quickly and quietly. Coins, a small charm, and then you're back in your seat before anyone looks up. The dice players argue. The monks argue. The toad sips its tea.

Effects: gold 25; items: Water Charm Common · Karma: Hungry Ghost +4, Animal +2

If it fails:

You're doing well until a pale hand closes around your wrist. The room goes quiet. In short order you are dressed and deposited outside, the door clicking shut behind you. The painted frog on the sign stares at you with what might be disappointment.

Karma: Hungry Ghost +6

Snow-Capped Hermitage snowcapped_hermitage

Domain: Tummo · Rarity: Rare

On an exposed ridge, in full sight of the howling wind, a group of yogis sit cross-legged in the snow. They wear nothing but thin white linen. Steam rises from their bodies in visible wisps, melting the snow in a circle around each of them.

The oldest sits at the centre, utterly still, eyes open but seeing elsewhere. Slightly apart, the youngest shivers — barely perceptibly, but his toes have gone the faint blue of someone fighting a losing battle with the cold.

BLUE Approach, bow deeply, and ask for teachings.

Requires: Yoga 5+

Opens: The Hermit's Fire

The eldest yogi opens his eyes and regards you for a long moment. He nods once. The youngest, still shivering, looks up at you with something like relief — perhaps he will learn more if you are here too.

The teachings begin.

Karma: God +5, Human +3

YELLOW You have some knowledge of inner heat yourself. Show them — not as a challenge, because you cannot help it.

Fire Magic 5+; Roll: Focus, easy difficulty

If it succeeds: Opens: The Hermit's Fire

You let it rise — the warmth from the secret place below the navel, imperfect but real. The youngest yogi's eyes go wide. The eldest smiles: not at the technique, which is rough, but at the unmistakable sincerity behind it.

'You have found the door,' he says. 'Come, let us show you what is behind it.'

Karma: God +4, Human +4

If it fails:

The warmth flickers and goes out. The eldest yogi watches, patient and kind.

'The fire is there,' he says. 'But it needs tending before it can burn steadily. The doors of this hermitage will be open to you when you return, more mature in your practice, young sadhaka.'

Something in his words leaves a warmth in you that your technique could not produce.

Effects: buff: Focus +2 · Karma: Human +2

YELLOW Challenge them to a contest of cold resistance. They seem so untouchable — surely it cannot hurt to test them.

Water Magic 5+; Roll: Focus, difficult difficulty

If it succeeds: Opens: The Hermit's Fire

Your mastery of water is formidable — the cold bends to your will, and the youngest yogi has gone very still watching you. The eldest meets your eyes throughout, unshaken.

'Impressive,' he says at last. 'But your attitude is poisoned by arrogance. What you sought was not knowledge — it was victory. We will teach you anyway, because the fire does not care why you came, only that you did. But you will pay more for what arrogance has cost.'

Karma: Asura +3, Human -1

If it fails:

The cold defeats you well before it touches them. The eldest yogi says nothing for a long time. When he speaks, there is no cruelty in it.

'You are not ready for the dharma taught in this place. Return once your merit grows.'

Karma: Asura +2, Human -1

YELLOW Say nothing. Sit down in the snow beside them and see how long you last.

Roll: Constitution, normal difficulty

If it succeeds: Opens: The Hermit's Fire

You have no technique. You have only stubbornness and the refusal to move. Minutes pass. The cold becomes a presence, then a voice, then a kind of silence. When you open your eyes, the eldest is looking at you.

'No technique,' he says, 'but something that technique cannot give. Sit closer. There is something we can show you.'

Karma: Human +5, God +2

If it fails:

The cold defeats you. You last longer than seems reasonable, but it defeats you. The youngest yogi — still shivering himself, toes still blue — gives you a small, sympathetic look as you scramble to your feet.

You carry the cold in your bones for a while after.

Effects: buff: Constitution -2 · Karma: Human +1

GREY Circumambulate the group, set out small offerings, and leave them in peace.

Cost: Gold (small), Food (small)

You walk the circle three times, quietly, and place what you have brought at the edge of their warmth. None of them acknowledge this directly. But as you turn to leave, the youngest yogi's shivering has stopped.

Something of their steadiness travels with you.

Effects: buff: Constitution +2, Focus +2 · Karma: God +3, Human +3

BLUE You have sat in worse for less reason.

Requires: Trait: Ascetic

You sit. The cold does what cold does and you let it, and at some point the distinction between enduring it and not minding it stops being available.

One of them opens their eyes at the end and gives you a single nod, which appears to be the local currency.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Fire +12, Space +10

GREY Leave them to their practice.

You walk on. The sound of the wind returns. The steam rising from their circle diminishes behind you.

Dark Cave dark_cave

Domain: Luminosity · Rarity: Rare

No light reaches the depths of this cave. The darkness is not empty — it has a quality to it, a density that suggests something is happening inside it.

At the back wall, barely visible, is a small opening the size of a fist. Beside it, a shallow bowl, worn smooth.

GREY Ask her for teachings.

Leads to: Dark Cave Interior

A voice comes from the other side of the wall — unhurried, neither welcoming nor unwelcoming.

'The dark will teach you, if you sit with it long enough.'

Silence.

BLUE Sit on this side of the wall and wait. Without expectation.

Requires: Yoga 5+

Opens: Teachings of the Dark Cave

You sit. The dark settles around you. Visions begin — first muddled and confused, images and sounds without coherence, then gradually clarifying, like sediment falling through still water.

After some hours, a quiet laugh from the other side of the wall.

'You've shown the purity of your intent. I'll teach you a little — but keep practicing on your own.'

Karma: God +6, Human +3

BLUE Still your perception. Not the stone — the quality of what is in the stone.

Requires: Space Magic 5+

Opens: Teachings of the Dark Cave

You let your perception settle and expand. The stone is there — cold, dense, indifferent. And then, not through it but somehow alongside it: a quality of light that is not light, sourceless, neither warm nor cold, bleeding outward through the rock without diminishing.

A pause from the other side of the wall. Then, quietly: 'I see you have some eyes of your own.' The sound of something being moved. 'Come then. Let's compare notes.'

Karma: God +5, Human +3

GREY Push some food through the opening in the wall.

Cost: Food (small)

'Thank you, child.'

The bowl on your side is already empty. On the other side, the sound of something being received with care.

Effects: buff: Awareness +1, Luck +1; gains trait: Generous · Karma: God +3, Human +3

GREY Push some money through the opening in the wall.

A pause.

'I don't need this, child.'

The coins reappear in the bowl on your side, one by one.

Effects: gold_returned: true

BLUE She has not spoken in thirty years. You can manage an hour.

Requires: Trait: Secret-bearer

You wait. You do not fill the silence, which is apparently the examination.

What comes through the wall eventually is four words long. You will be thinking about it for some time.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Space +12

GREY Leave the cave.

You step back into the light. The cave says nothing. The darkness continues its practice without you.

Dark Cave dark_cave_interior

Domain: Luminosity · Rarity: Follow Up Only

The silence continues. The darkness has the same quality as before — dense, inhabited. The small opening in the wall. The worn bowl.

BLUE Sit on this side of the wall and wait. Without expectation.

Requires: Yoga 5+

Opens: Teachings of the Dark Cave

You sit. The dark settles around you. Visions begin — first muddled and confused, images and sounds without coherence, then gradually clarifying, like sediment falling through still water.

After some hours, a quiet laugh from the other side of the wall.

'You've shown the purity of your intent. I'll teach you a little — but keep practicing on your own.'

Karma: God +6, Human +3

BLUE Still your perception. Not the stone — the quality of what is in the stone.

Requires: Space Magic 5+

Opens: Teachings of the Dark Cave

You let your perception settle and expand. The stone is there — cold, dense, indifferent. And then, not through it but somehow alongside it: a quality of light that is not light, sourceless, neither warm nor cold, bleeding outward through the rock without diminishing.

A pause from the other side of the wall. Then, quietly: 'I see you have some eyes of your own.' The sound of something being moved. 'Come then. Let's compare notes.'

Karma: God +5, Human +3

GREY Push some food through the opening in the wall.

Cost: Food (small)

'Thank you, child.'

The bowl on your side is already empty. On the other side, the sound of something being received with care.

Effects: buff: Awareness +1, Luck +1 · Karma: God +3, Human +3

GREY Push some money through the opening in the wall.

A pause.

'I don't need this, child.'

The coins reappear in the bowl on your side, one by one.

Effects: gold_returned: true

GREY Leave the cave.

You step back into the light. The cave says nothing. The darkness continues its practice without you.

Skygazing Gompa skygazing_gompa

Domain: Rainbow · Rarity: Rare

On the open terrace of a small gompa, a yogi sits gazing single-pointedly at the sky. A soft rainbow shimmer is reflected in their eyes. As you approach, they smile and greet you with a gesture.

BLUE "Please teach us about the Great Perfection."

Requires: Yoga 5+

Opens: Teachings of the Skygazing Gompa

Gladly, the yogi explains the workings of the mind as swirling reflections of rainbow light in a crystalline prism. The teaching opens doors you did not know were closed.

Effects: gains trait: Touched by Grace

GREY "Please bless us for this life and the next, master."

The yogi's eyes soften. They place their hands together and murmur a mantra, then touch each of you lightly on the crown of the head. A warmth radiates outward.

Effects: buff: Awareness +2

BLUE "What is the source of the shimmer in your eyes I can't help but notice, master?"

Requires: Space Magic 5+

Opens: Teachings of the Skygazing Gompa

The yogi just laughs — a clear, boundless sound — and gestures you inside. There, arranged on low tables, are things you have never seen offered anywhere else.

GREY "What are you doing here?"

"Observing the unceasing movement of the stream of the sky, friend." The yogi says nothing more, but the simplicity of the answer lingers with you long after you leave.

Effects: XP 10

BLUE Ask the question you stopped asking years ago.

Requires: Trait: Lapsed

It comes out badly. It comes out, which is more than it has done in a long while.

The answer does not resolve anything. It does establish, quite gently, that the question was always allowed.

Effects: XP 15; mind: Space +15; loses trait: Lapsed

GREY Bow, place some offerings, and leave.

Cost: Gold (small), Food (small)

You place what you can afford at the foot of the yogi's seat. They incline their head in acknowledgment. A faint warmth accompanies you as you descend the terrace steps.

Effects: buff: Luck +1

The Court of the Musician Prince court_of_the_musician_prince

Domain: Sound · Rarity: Rare

A lavish building rises before you, its doors open to the warm air. Inside, a half-naked man sits in a carved chair, eyes closed, strumming a sitar with total absorption. He does not appear to notice your arrival.

A servant materializes at your elbow, inclining his head politely. 'Welcome. How may I serve you?'

GREY Ask about the prince and the state of his court.

'My lord always had the soul of an artist first, and ruler only second,' the servant says, with unmistakable pride. 'Some years ago, an itinerant yogi came to court and taught him that the path to awakening need not pass through renunciation — that music itself, heard rightly, is a door. The yogi has since moved on, as such men do. My lord has not moved at all.'

He glances toward the prince with something between concern and devotion. 'We manage.'

Effects: XP 10

BLUE Take out your instrument and play alongside him.

Requires: Performance 5+

Opens: The Gandharva's Gift

The servant hesitates, then steps aside. You take a seat near the prince and begin to play. A long moment passes. Then, without opening his eyes, the prince adjusts his melody to harmonize with yours — a conversation with no words in it. When you finally stop, he opens his eyes and looks at you directly for the first time.

'Stay a while,' he says. 'I have something to show you.'

Karma: Human +5, God +3

BLUE Sit and listen. Not to the notes — to what is between them.

Requires: Yoga 5+

Opens: The Gandharva's Gift

You find a place to sit and simply listen. The music is complex past comprehension — and then, quite suddenly, it isn't. You hear through it to something else: the source of the sound, the silence inside each note. After some time, the prince opens one eye. He looks at you with faint surprise, then nods curtly, as if settling a question he had been asking himself. 'Yes,' he says. 'Come.'

Karma: God +5, Human +3

GREY Ask if they need any hired hands.

'I'm afraid my lord has very little in the way of worldly affairs to attend to anymore,' the servant says, pleasantly but with a finality that suggests the topic is closed.

GREY Ask if they could spare anything for travelers.

The servant blinks, as if the question has surprised him from a great distance. He produces a few coins from somewhere about his person and presses them into your hand with the vague goodwill of someone performing a gesture they have been taught. You find yourself outside. The door closes quietly.

Effects: gold 8

BLUE He is playing a form. Answer it in the form.

Requires: Trait: Poet

You do not have his hands. You do have the shape of the thing, and you give him back the second half of a line he had left open — badly, in the wrong metre, and unmistakably the right line.

He stops playing. Then he starts again, from your version.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Fire +10, Air +10

BLUE Tell the court who has just arrived.

Requires: Trait: Braggart

The court is composed entirely of people who do this professionally, and they recognise a colleague.

You are given a seat, a drink, and a reputation you will have to spend the rest of the evening defending.

Effects: XP 20; gold small

GREY Leave without disturbing them.

You step back into the open air. Inside, the music continues without interruption.

A Dream Between Watches camp_night_vision

Trigger: camp · Rarity: Uncommon

In the deep hours of the night, one of the party stirs from sleep with something vivid and strange behind their eyes.

BLUE Hold onto the vision — it felt like a warning.

Requires: Yoga 3+

The image is clear: a path, a figure, a moment yet to come. Whether prophecy or fancy, it burns itself into memory. The dreamer rises feeling purposeful.

Effects: XP 20 · Karma: Hell -5

GREY Let it fade — dreams are just noise.

By morning it is gone. Just a dream, probably. The camp breaks in ordinary silence.

A Visitor in the Night camp_wandering_spirit

Trigger: camp · Rarity: Uncommon

The fire has burned low. In the outer dark, something moves — not threatening, not quite gone. A presence lingers at the edge of the light.

GREY **Leave a small offering of food at the fire's edge.**

In the morning, the offering is gone. The camp feels lighter somehow. Something difficult has passed through and moved on.

Karma: Hungry Ghost -10

BLUE **Speak to it — ask what it wants.**

Requires: Ritual 2+

It does not answer with words, but it turns toward the sound of your voice and then recedes, as if the acknowledgement itself was enough. A small thing done well.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: Hungry Ghost -15

BLUE **Set out a place for it. Properly.**

Requires: Trait: Mourner

You do it the way it is done at home: a place, not an offering. Somewhere to sit rather than something to take.

It sits. That appears to have been the whole request, and in the morning the fire has burned down more slowly than it should have.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Water +12 · Karma: Hungry Ghost -5, Human +3

GREY **Drive it off with noise and light.**

It retreats into the dark. The camp is quiet after, but something about the night feels heavier.

Figures in the Smoke camp_fire_omen

Trigger: camp · Rarity: Uncommon

The campfire flares without fuel. In the smoke, shapes coil and reform — faces, or something like faces — watching.

YELLOW **Watch the smoke and try to read it.**

Roll: Awareness, 14 difficulty

If it succeeds:

The smoke forms something unmistakable — a path you haven't taken, a face you'll encounter, a moment of decision that has not yet arrived. The fire dims and the vision closes.

Effects: XP 25

If it fails:

The shapes shift too fast. By the time anything resolves, the fire has died back to coals. You saw something, but cannot say what.

GREY **Smother the fire. You don't want to see.**

The smoke curls and dissipates into the dark. The camp is cold for the rest of the night. Nothing comes of it, but nothing was risked either.

The Fire Speaks camp_ember_voices

Trigger: camp · Rarity: Uncommon

Deep in the night, the campfire rises without reason. Between the popping of burning wood, something close to words — close enough that three people heard three different things.

BLUE Sit quietly and listen for meaning.

Requires: Yoga 2+

The words aren't in any language, but the meaning arrives whole: a route, a danger, a name that matters. Whether this realm is warning you or baiting you, the information feels true.

Effects: XP 20 · Karma: Hell +5

YELLOW Answer it — ask what it wants.

Roll: Awareness, 12 difficulty

If it succeeds:

The fire brightens, then settles. Something received your address. The embers arrange and rearrange in patterns that suggest approval. You feel, briefly, observed and acknowledged.

Effects: XP 15 · Karma: Hell +10

If it fails:

The fire goes out. All of it, without smoke or cooling, just gone. It takes a long time to relight. No one speaks much after.

GREY It's the heat. Go back to sleep.

By morning the fire is cold ash. Whether anything was there or not, it is settled now.

At the Edge of the Light camp_guardian_threshold

Trigger: camp · Rarity: Uncommon

Something stands at the very limit of the firelight. It has been there for some time. It is not threatening — it simply waits, in the particular way that a very old grievance waits.

BLUE Invite it to speak. A grievance aired is one less thing blocking the path.

Requires: Persuasion 2+

It speaks, or something like speaking happens. The story is circular and old — a wrong done long before any of you were born, compounding through each retelling. You acknowledge it without agreeing. The presence recedes satisfied, or at least finished.

Karma: Hell +15

BLUE Perform a brief warding. Give it a boundary rather than an audience.

Requires: Ritual 2+

The ritual is imperfect but sincere. The presence retreats from the boundary you've established. By morning it is gone, and the camp feels marginally warmer for it.

GREY Watch it until dawn. It has to leave with the light.

It does leave with the light. One of the party barely slept. The camp breaks in an uneasy silence that no one names.

What Was Left Out camp_whispered_offering

Trigger: camp · Rarity: Uncommon

You wake to find the camp's food supplies disturbed. Nothing taken — but arranged. Placed. A small portion of each item separated from the rest, set near the fire's edge, as if left for someone who didn't eat.

GREY Leave a proper offering — deliberately, this time.

You set it out with care. By the next morning, the portion is gone, and whatever sorted your supplies has not returned.

Karma: Hungry Ghost -15

BLUE Consecrate the offering properly with a brief ritual.

Requires: Ritual 2+

Consecrated food reaches further in this realm than it has any right to. The arrangement disappears, and for a moment you catch something at the periphery of the firelight that might have been gratitude.

Effects: XP 10 · Karma: Hungry Ghost -25

GREY Secure the supplies and post a watch.

Nothing more is disturbed that night. In the morning the small arranged portion is still there, untouched.

The Outstanding Balance camp_creditor

Trigger: camp · Rarity: Uncommon

A figure in a creditor's sash steps into the firelight. It looks like no one in particular. It knows exactly who you are.

BLUE Enter into negotiation — there is always a way to restructure.

Requires: Trade 3+

Three rounds of negotiation in the cold air. You emerge with an arrangement no one is happy with, which is the mark of a good deal. The creditor departs without incident. The ledger, as far as you can tell, now balances.

Karma: Hungry Ghost -10

GREY Pay what it asks without argument.

It accepts payment. It looks faintly disappointed that there was nothing to argue about. It leaves. The camp feels lighter.

Karma: Hungry Ghost -5

BLUE You have had this conversation before, with worse.

Requires: Trait: Debtor

You know the form: never deny the debt, never accept the figure, and always counter-propose a schedule.

It works on the dead as well as it works on the living, which is either reassuring or extremely bleak.

Effects: XP 20; mind: Air +10

GREY Tell it you don't recognise the debt.

It notes this down in a ledger you cannot see. It does not argue. It leaves, which is somehow worse than if it had.

The Same Dream camp_shared_dream

Trigger: camp · Rarity: Uncommon

In the morning it becomes clear that every member of the party dreamed the same thing. The details vary — but the place, the light, the unspoken pressure of it — identical.

BLUE Sit together and map the differences. There's something in the overlap.

Requires: Yoga 2+

The point where all accounts agree is a detail no one remarked on individually — a mark, a position, a quality of attention. When you locate it, something like recognition moves through the group. A shared dream properly examined becomes a kind of preparation.

Effects: XP 25 · Karma: Hell -5, Hungry Ghost -5

BLUE Record what you remember before it fades.

Requires: Learning 2+

Committed to paper, the dream becomes a document. Whether it's useful or not, it's no longer just a feeling in the air between you — it's a record, and records have a way of meaning something eventually.

Effects: XP 15

BLUE You dream like this most nights. Take the lead.

Requires: Trait: Dreamer

The others describe a dream. You describe the *shape* of one, which turns out to be the thing they were all failing to say. Once it has a shape, the differences between the four accounts become the interesting part.

Effects: XP 15; mind: Space +10

GREY Say nothing. Dreams are not decisions.

The camp breaks in ordinary silence. Whatever the dream was trying to say, it did not say it.

Another Light camp_stranger_fire

Trigger: camp · Rarity: Uncommon

A light on the hillside — too steady and too warm to be a spirit. Another camp. They haven't signalled, but they haven't hidden either.

YELLOW Walk over and introduce yourself.

Roll: Charm, 11 difficulty

If it succeeds:

Traders, or something close to traders — three of them, neutral in disposition, willing to part with supplies at a fair price. You part on workmanlike terms.

Effects: gold 20; XP 10

If it fails:

They receive you with flat unfriendliness. Not hostile — but by the time you've returned to your own fire, you've gained nothing and spent an awkward hour.

GREY Signal peacefully and wait to see if they respond.

They signal back — a single lamp moved twice. Then nothing more. Whoever they are, they're occupied or cautious. You sleep well enough anyway.

BLUE Of course you are going to go and find out who they are.

Requires: Trait: Gossip

They are three traders, badly lost, and delighted to see anyone at all.

By the time you go back to your own fire you have their route, their prices, and an unflattering account of a guard captain two days ahead.

Effects: XP 20; gold small

BLUE Keep watch and observe without contact.

Requires: Logistics 2+

Their fire goes out before yours. Two of them — moving efficiently, no wasted motion. Scouts or couriers, from their routine. Nothing threatening. The knowledge costs you some sleep but not much.

Effects: XP 10

A Game at the Next Fire trait_gambler_game

Trigger: trait · Concerns a character with trait: Gambler · Rarity: Uncommon

There is another fire within sight of yours, and around it, the unmistakable rhythm of a game — the pause, the clatter, the noise people make when someone loses badly. {a} has been looking at it for some time now.

BLUE Let {a} play, but set a limit before they go.

Requires: Persuasion 3+

{a} agrees to the limit with the easy sincerity of someone who has agreed to limits before. This time, remarkably, they keep it — and come back with more than they left with, and with the name of a man who buys things quietly.

Effects: gold small; XP 15

YELLOW Let it run. {a} knows what they are doing.

Roll: Luck, moderate difficulty

If it succeeds:

It goes late. It goes badly, and then very well, and then the other fire goes quiet in the way fires do when the stranger is winning.

{a} walks back before anyone decides to discuss it further.

Effects: gold moderate; XP 20

If it fails:

The game turns. It turns the way games do when someone else at the fire has also been doing this for years.

{a} comes back with empty hands and a story about the light being bad.

Effects: mind: Earth -10

GREY Nobody is playing anything. We move at dawn.

{a} does not argue, which is worse than arguing. They sit with their back to the other fire for the rest of the night, and are notably unrested in the morning.

Effects: mind: Fire -10

Someone Has Been Asking trait_debtor_collector

Trigger: trait · Concerns a character with trait: Debtor · Rarity: Uncommon

A traveller shares your fire for an hour, and mentions, without any particular emphasis, that a man has been asking after someone matching {a}'s description in every settlement between here and the pass. He is described as patient. That is the word the traveller uses. Patient.

GREY Send the money ahead with the traveller.

It is most of what you have. The traveller takes it with the blank courtesy of a man who has carried worse.

Whether it arrives is another question, but {a} sleeps properly for the first time in a while.

Effects: mind: Air +15

BLUE Have {a} send word: terms, and a date.

Requires: Trade 4+

The letter is careful. It admits the debt, proposes a schedule, and contains one line that a certain kind of creditor will recognise as an offer rather than a plea.

The asking stops for a while.

Effects: XP 20

GREY Let him ask. The world is large.

The world is large. {a} spends the rest of the night working out exactly how large, and how many roads there are through it, and how few of them a patient man would need to watch.

Effects: mind: Air -12

The Long Night trait_ascetic_fast

Trigger: trait · Concerns a character with trait: Ascetic · Rarity: Uncommon

{a} has not eaten since yesterday, and does not intend to eat today either. They have taken the far side of the fire and gone somewhere behind their own face. It is not clear whether this is discipline or something that has stopped being discipline a while ago.

GREY Sit up with them. Say nothing.

You sit. The fire goes down. Around the fourth hour {a} says one sentence about their teacher, and then nothing else, and in the morning something between you has been settled without being discussed.

Effects: XP 15; mind: Space +10

BLUE Give the fast a shape — make it a practice, not a punishment.

Requires: Yoga 4+

You give them the frame: the hours, the posture, what to do with the part of the mind that starts bargaining around midnight.

By dawn {a} is hollow-eyed and unmistakably clearer.

Effects: XP 30; mind: Fire +15, Space +10

GREY Put food in their hands and stand there until it is gone.

They eat, because you are standing there. They are steadier for it in the morning and quietly furious with you for three days.

Effects: full restore

Nearly Said trait_secret_bearer_slip

Trigger: trait · Concerns a character with trait: Secret-bearer · Rarity: Uncommon

Late, with the fire low and everyone half-asleep, {a} begins a sentence. It is four words long and it stops. Whatever the fifth word was going to be, it has been put back.

GREY Pretend not to have heard.

You let it lie. {a} is grateful in the particular way of someone who has just been spared, and sits a little closer to the fire afterwards.

YELLOW Ask gently. Some things want carrying together.

Roll: Charm, moderate difficulty

If it succeeds:

It takes an hour and it costs them something.

What comes out is smaller than you expected and much heavier than it looks, and {a} is a different kind of tired at the end of it — the kind that heals.

Effects: XP 25; mind: Water +20

If it fails:

They talk around it for a while, pleasantly, and tell you nothing at all. By the end you are not certain there was ever a sentence.

Effects: mind: Space -5

GREY Push. Whatever it is, it is walking with us.

{a} closes like a door. Whatever was nearly said is now considerably further from being said than it was an hour ago.

Effects: mind: Air -10

A Stone Off the Road trait_pilgrim_detour

Trigger: trait · Concerns a character with trait: Pilgrim · Rarity: Uncommon

{a} has noticed something the rest of you walked past: a marker stone, half-swallowed, with the remains of offerings at its base. Someone tended this within living memory. Nobody has for a while.

GREY Clear it properly. It costs an hour.

You clear the base, straighten the stone, leave what can be spared. {a} does the words from memory.

The hour is gone and something about the party's footing is better for the rest of the day.

Effects: XP 15; mind: Earth +10 · Karma: Human +3, God +2

BLUE Read what is carved there.

Requires: Learning 4+

The script is three languages old and mostly worn, but enough survives: a name, a direction, and a warning that was specific once.

{a} copies it down. It will mean something later.

Effects: XP 30

GREY Note it and keep walking.

You keep walking. {a} looks back twice, and then makes a point of not looking back again.

Effects: mind: Space -8

It Has Decided trait_beast_tender_stray

Trigger: trait · Concerns a character with trait: Beast-tender · Rarity: Uncommon

Something has attached itself to the camp — thin, wary, and entirely certain about which member of the party it intends to belong to. {a} has already fed it, which settles the matter as far as it is concerned.

GREY It can come. It eats what we can spare.

It comes. It is useless in every way that can be measured and the camp is measurably better for it.

Effects: mind: Water +10, Fire +5 · Karma: Animal +4

GREY Drive it off before it starves with us.

{a} does it themselves, which is the kindest way it can be done and does not appear to help.

Effects: mind: Water -10

BLUE Anything that eats can earn.

Requires: Logistics 3+

Within three days it is walking point, and doing it better than anyone you would have assigned.

Effects: XP 25 · Karma: Animal +2

The Ledger trait_grudge_bearer_ledger

Trigger: trait · Concerns a character with trait: Grudge-bearer · Rarity: Uncommon

{a} is awake, and has been for some time, going over something in the dark with the thoroughness of a clerk. You have seen this before. It is never nothing, and it is never recent.

GREY Ask who it is. Let them say the name.

They say it. Then they say it again, with the details, and the details have not softened by a single degree in however many years it has been.

Saying it out loud does not fix it. It does make the night shorter.

Effects: mind: Water +8

BLUE Tell them plainly what carrying it is costing.

Requires: Yoga 4+

It lands badly and then, some hours later, it lands properly.

{a} does not forgive anyone. But they put the ledger down for the night, which is not nothing.

Effects: XP 25; mind: Water +15

GREY Let it sharpen. There will be a use for it.

You leave them to it. In the morning {a} is rested in the specific way of someone who has spent the night deciding something.

Effects: mind: Water -10, Fire +5 · Karma: Hell +3

It Knows the Weather trait_scarred_weather

Trigger: trait · Concerns a character with trait: Scarred · Rarity: Uncommon

The cold has got into {a}'s old wound, the way it does, and they are pretending with some effort that it has not. It will pass by midday. It always passes by midday.

BLUE Work on it properly before it stiffens.

Requires: Medicine 3+

Heat, pressure, and twenty patient minutes. {a} is functional by dawn instead of by noon, and says so in about four words.

Effects: XP 15; full restore

GREY Ask how they got it.

They tell it flatly, which is how the bad ones get told. It is shorter than you expected and there is a second story underneath it that does not get told tonight.

Effects: mind: Water +5

GREY Say nothing and set an easy pace tomorrow.

You set the pace without mentioning why. {a} notices, and does not mention that either. This is apparently how it is done.

Effects: mind: Earth +8

It Has Been Building rel_rivals_flashpoint

Trigger: relationship · Relationship: rival · Rarity: Uncommon

{a} and {b} have been circling something for days, and tonight it arrives — over nothing, over a pot and whose turn it was, in the way these things always arrive over nothing. The rest of the camp has gone very quiet.

GREY Let them have it out. Words only.

It is ugly and thorough and it takes about twenty minutes.

At the end of it they are not friends, but the thing that was under the surface is now above it, where everyone can see it, which is safer.

Effects: mind: Fire -5

BLUE Get between them and make them each say the actual grievance.

Requires: Persuasion 5+

You make them do it properly, one at a time, no interruptions.

It emerges that they are angry about two entirely different things, and have each spent a week being furious about the wrong one.

Effects: XP 30; mind: Air +10

BLUE End it. Both of you, opposite sides of the fire, now.

Requires: Leadership 4+

They obey, because of how you said it.

Nothing is resolved. Nothing gets worse tonight either, which was the immediate problem.

Effects: XP 15

Second Watch rel_sworn_watch

Trigger: relationship · Relationship: sworn · Rarity: Uncommon

{a} takes second watch, which is {b}'s. No discussion, no announcement — they simply do not wake them. In the morning {b} works it out from the burn-down of the fire and says nothing about it, which is its own kind of answer.

GREY Leave them to it.

Whatever the two of them have built, it does not require your supervision. The party moves a little easier for the rest of the week.

Effects: mind: Water +10, Earth +5

BLUE Two who trust each other that far should be fighting together.

Requires: Leadership 4+

You put them on the same flank and spend an evening on what each of them is going to assume the other is doing.

It shows almost immediately.

Effects: XP 30; buff: Initiative +3

Neither of Them Will Say It rel_cool_thaw

Trigger: relationship · Relationship: cool · Rarity: Uncommon

{a} and {b} are not fighting. They are doing the other thing — the scrupulous politeness, the passing of the water skin at arm's length. It has been four days of this and the whole camp is tired of it.

GREY Give them a job that needs both of them and walk away.

It takes them most of the morning, mostly in silence.

They come back having not discussed it at all, and having somehow discussed it entirely.

Effects: XP 15

BLUE Talk to each of them separately. Find out what it actually is.

Requires: Persuasion 4+

It is, as it usually is, one remark made two weeks ago that one of them does not remember making and the other has not stopped hearing.

Effects: XP 25; mind: Air +8

GREY They are adults. Leave it.

They are adults, and it does not improve. The politeness gets a little more scrupulous.

Effects: mind: Water -5

23.1 Domain teachers

After a domain event, the party can find someone who teaches that domain's spells. Each has a name and a greeting, shown when the shop opens.

Secrets of the Bathhouse steam_domain_shop

The old frog settles onto the edge of the pool, pours two cups of tea, and begins to talk. What it knows about steam and the place where water meets fire cannot be found in any guild.

Teachings of the Skygazing Gompa rainbow_domain_shop

The yogi shares what they know of the rainbow body and the prismatic nature of mind. These spells cannot be found in any guild.

The Hermit's Fire tummo_domain_shop

The hermit teaches the inner fire — the heat that blazes upward from the secret chakra and melts the crown. These practices cannot be found in any guild.

Teachings of the Dark Cave luminosity_domain_shop

The unseen teacher shares what they know of the clear light. These practices cannot be found in any guild.

The Gandharva's Gift sound_domain_shop

The gandharva prince teaches the art of sound — mantra, resonance, and the spaces between notes. These arts cannot be found in any guild.

Vision of the Smoking Mirror smoke_domain_shop

The mirror teaches, in the way mirrors do — by showing rather than telling. What it shows about smoke, shadow, and the nature of reflected things cannot be found in any guild.

Teachings of the Pit mud_domain_shop

The mudlings share what they know of deep earth — the patience of silt, the memory of clay, the slow power of things that have been compressed for a very long time. These arts cannot be found in any guild.

Teachings of the Cloud Palace cloud_domain_shop

The gandharvas and apsaras of the Cloud Palace teach the sky arts — what it means to move like weather, to see from altitude, to become the medium through which lightning travels. These arts cannot be found in any guild.

Secrets of the Glass Mountain glass_domain_shop

The mountain teaches through its own nature — perfect transparency, perfect hardness, perfect memory of having once been scattered sand. What it knows about clarity and cutting cannot be found in any guild.

Teachings of the Crystal Cave crystal_domain_shop

The elder yogi has been here long enough to have grown into the crystals themselves — or the crystals have grown into him. Either way, what he knows about resonance, focus, and geometric mind cannot be found in any guild.

Part IV: Births, Backgrounds and Companions

24. How a character begins

A new life is built from three things:

1. **A realm**, chosen by karma (chapter 5).
2. **A birth**: the kind of being you are reborn as. This is the largest decision: a dura of the animal realm, a red devil of the hells, a rolang of the hungry ghosts. A birth shapes the body, the temperament, the innate talents and the starting emotional state. Some are common, some rare.
3. **A background**: what that being did before the story begins: a hunter, a guard, an infernal scribe, a charnel yogi. A background grants starting skills and gear. Some backgrounds are open to all, others belong to one or a handful of births.

On top of these: a rolled set of inborn traits (chapter 9), the birth's own racial traits, a few starting skills and spells. From there the player spends experience however they like.

The player's own life is made this way, and so are **companions**, who are hand-written with a birth and background of their own. A good companion usually makes the combination *mean* something: a mantis "who has become a monk", a devil who showed mercy and was exiled.

The next three chapters print the full catalogue: 47 births, every background, and all 99 companions.

25. Birth catalogue (47 births)

A birth is what you were reborn as. Each entry gives the birth's description exactly as the player reads it, followed by a short reference line summarising its leanings. The leanings are for orientation only.

25.1 Hell births (6)

Red Devil red_devil

Hot-headed and driven by anger and lust, red devils are the finest warriors in the Hells.

Gifted in: Strength, Focus | **Weaker in:** Awareness, Finesse, Charm, Luck | **Elemental lean:** Fire | **Starts with:** Might | **Innate traits:** Hell-born, Armory Rights

Typical backgrounds: Warrior, Berserker, Guard, Raider, Torturer

Companions of this birth: Brother Karnak, Serji, Red Peony, Raktamatta, Jawbreaker, Tejasimha

Blue Devil blue_devil

Cold and calculating, blue devils keep grudges long after they were forgotten in the realms above.

Gifted in: Finesse, Awareness | **Weaker in:** Luck, Strength, Constitution, Charm | **Elemental lean:** Water | **Starts with:** Water Magic | **Innate traits:** Hell-born

Typical backgrounds: Warrior, Hunter, Executioner, Soul Jailer, Guard

Companions of this birth: Water Lily, Dvijihva, Yaga Mataji, Niyamendra

Yellow Devil yellow_devil

Greedy and proud, yellow devils tend to cluster wherever wealth changes hands.

Gifted in: Luck, Constitution | **Weaker in:** Strength, Finesse, Focus, Awareness, Charm | **Elemental lean:** Earth | **Starts with:** Logistics, Trade | **Innate traits:** Hell-born, Hoarder's Instinct

Typical backgrounds: Merchant, Raider, Guard, Infernal Scribe, Torturer

Companions of this birth: Kanjus, Sarpatailaka, Shiny Needle

Green Devil green_devil

Quick-witted and paranoid, green devils make for excellent operatives and terrible friends.

Gifted in: Finesse, Awareness, Luck | **Weaker in:** Constitution, Strength, Focus, Charm | **Elemental lean:** Air | **Starts with:** Air Magic | **Innate traits:** Hell-born

Typical backgrounds: Hunter, Raider, Infernal Scribe, Spy

Companions of this birth: Leraya, Samvibrahmi, Vāyuvega, Angulimāla

Black Devil black_devil

Spawned from the Outer Dark, black devils live off confusion and fear.

Gifted in: Awareness, Focus, Finesse | **Weaker in:** Constitution, Charm, Luck | **Elemental lean:** Space | **Starts with:** Black Magic, Ritual, Space Magic | **Innate traits:** Hell-born, Void Touched

Typical backgrounds: Executioner, Torturer, Infernal Scribe, Penitent

Companions of this birth: Princess Spiderface, Sineater Thirteen, Dyūtapati, Coolhead Hotblood

White Devil white_devil

Lazy and a bit ditzy, white devils make pleasant company as far as hell's denizens go.

Gifted in: Charm, Finesse, Constitution, Luck | **Weaker in:** Strength, Focus, Awareness | **Elemental lean:** Space | **Starts with:** Persuasion, Space Magic | **Innate traits:** Hell-born

Typical backgrounds: Wanderer, Merchant, Penitent, Diplomat, Infernal Scribe

Companions of this birth: Ayurmangala, Amlamarjari, Vimohini

25.2 Hungry Ghost births (14)

Rolang rolang

The newly dead of the hungry ghost realm. Rolangs have been in the world of the dead for a relatively short time and are the least conscious of its inhabitants. Young walking dead are dim and animalistic — rigid, slow, moving in a jerky jiangshi-like manner — and only over long ages do some begin to develop awareness of their condition. Most rot away into skeletons. A rare few are preserved by alchemical and yogic arts and become the lords of their kind.

Gifted in: Strength, Constitution | **Weaker in:** Charm, Finesse, Focus, Awareness | **Elemental lean:** Earth | **Starts with:** Might, Unarmed | **Innate traits:** Undead

Typical backgrounds: Shambler, Former Soldier, Plague Victim, Preserved, Bog Warden

Companions of this birth: Tsering, Drupchen

Preserved preserved

Alchemical oils, mantras, and mineral compounds have halted your decay while others rotted to bone. The lords of their kind among the Rolang — rare, aware, and dangerous. You remember considerably more than most of your kind, and have had long years of stillness to put that memory to use.

Gifted in: Awareness, Constitution | **Weaker in:** Finesse, Charm | **Elemental lean:** Earth | **Starts with:** Alchemy, Black Magic | **Innate traits:** Undead

Typical backgrounds: Preserved, Charnel Yogi, Scholar, Former Soldier

Companions of this birth: Rasabhava, Saka, Mehr, Khedrup

Skeleton skeleton

Freed from the needs of the flesh by unstoppable decay, skeletons have had time to think. Most maintain the dryness of their sprawling catacombs and praise the blessings of abundant calcium with cheerful enthusiasm. Conscious skeletons are far more common than among the newly dead — the long wait in the grave strips away the animal confusion and leaves something clear-eyed and surprisingly sociable behind.

Gifted in: Focus, Awareness, Charm, Luck | **Weaker in:** Constitution, Strength | **Starts with:** Armor, Black Magic | **Innate traits:** Undead

Typical backgrounds: Warrior, Guard, Former Soldier, Catacomb Keeper, Bone Dancer, Charnel Yogi, Penitent

Companions of this birth: Nurse Bones, Hustle Bones

Dralha dralha

Warrior-kings who refused to relinquish their power at death and rebuilt their dominion from beyond the grave. Dralha are former chieftains, generals, and conquerors who linger in the charnel grounds surrounded by the spirits of those who served them in life. They lead through force and presence, wielding weapons with the same authority they carried in the living world.

Gifted in: Strength, Charm, Constitution | **Weaker in:** Finesse, Focus, Awareness | **Elemental lean:** Fire | **Starts with:** Leadership, Might | **Innate traits:** War Banner

Typical backgrounds: Warrior, Former Soldier, Noble, Raider, Guard

Companions of this birth: Temba

Gyelpo gyelpo

Powerful tantric practitioners and sorcerers who accumulated enough spiritual force in life to persist after death as kings of the spirit world. Where dralha rule through arms and loyalty, gyelpos rule through binding oaths, ritual contracts, and the weight of accumulated power. Shugden is the archetype: a sorcerer who refused to dissolve, who built a new throne from obligation and fear.

Gifted in: Focus, Awareness, Charm | **Weaker in:** Strength, Constitution, Luck | **Elemental lean:** Space | **Starts with:** Black Magic, Leadership, Ritual | **Innate traits:** Ancient Memory, Sovereign Grudge

Typical backgrounds: Charnel Yogi, Scholar, Priest, Penitent

Companions of this birth: Durvasa, Gomchen

Dré dre

Ghosts in the oldest and most literal sense: consciousness that has shed its body but not its attachments, drifting through the charnel grounds like smoke through bone. Dré are the most dissolved of the preta, barely present in the physical world. They feel little of its violence but remain bound to it by the thread of whatever they could not let go.

Gifted in: Focus, Awareness | **Weaker in:** Strength, Constitution | **Elemental lean:** Space | **Starts with:** Black Magic, Guile | **Innate traits:** Incorporeal

Typical backgrounds: Charnel Yogi, Penitent, Wanderer

Companions of this birth: Chōki, Nangwa

Vetala vetala

Highly intelligent and curious tricksters who inhabit the charnel grounds. Vetala are ambivalent towards the living and arbitrary in their dealings — sometimes helpful, sometimes dangerous, always keeping their own counsel. They drain life force through magic rather than physical violence, produce vivid illusions, and have a natural propensity for the arcane arts. Their propensity for rhetoric, humor, and meditation means they can usually talk their way out of a fight, though they rarely feel obliged to.

Gifted in: Focus, Awareness, Charm | **Weaker in:** Strength, Luck, Constitution | **Elemental lean:** Space | **Starts with:** Learning, Sorcery | **Innate traits:** Ancient Memory, Corpse Rider

Typical backgrounds: Trickster, Charnel Yogi, Spy, Monk, Scholar, Former Soldier

Companions of this birth: Prashan

Shaza shaza

The predators of the underworld, the shaza aggressively seek out bodies to devour.

Gifted in: Strength, Finesse | **Weaker in:** Awareness, Charm | **Starts with:** Might, Unarmed | **Innate traits:** Predator's Grace

Typical backgrounds: Warrior, Guard, Former Soldier, Hunter

Companions of this birth: Vilasa, Marmajna

Yidag yidag

Bellies distended with insatiable hunger, throats constricted to a hair's width — these beings are the most unfortunate embodiment of the karma that created their world.

Gifted in: Finesse | **Weaker in:** Charm, Luck | **Starts with:** Guile, Thievery | **Innate traits:** Insatiable

Typical backgrounds: Thief, Wanderer, Beggar, Penitent

Companions of this birth: Kripaṇa, Yasha

Silver Skeleton skeleton_silver

Not many withstand the trials of the underworld without losing their compassion. Those who have managed that feat remain as healers and helpers, looking with hope for the future to the worlds far above.

Gifted in: Awareness, Charm | **Weaker in:** Strength, Constitution | **Starts with:** Medicine, White Magic | **Innate traits:** Undead

Typical backgrounds: Healer, Monk, Charnel Yogi, Penitent

Companions of this birth: Nyingje

Copper Skeleton skeleton_copper

Skeletons born of molten copper mirrors in the court of the Skeleton King of the Setting Sun find themselves especially attuned to the arts of power and magnetism.

Gifted in: Charm, Focus | **Weaker in:** Strength, Constitution | **Starts with:** Fire Magic, Persuasion | **Innate traits:** Undead

Typical backgrounds: Sorcerer, Noble, Courtier, Bone Dancer

Companions of this birth: Shantipala

Golden Skeleton skeleton_golden

Gleaming in the flickering light of the crypt cities, golden skeletons are respected nobles among their people.

Gifted in: Charm, Luck | **Weaker in:** Strength, Constitution | **Starts with:** Leadership, Trade | **Innate traits:** Undead

Typical backgrounds: Noble, Merchant, Catacomb Keeper

Companions of this birth: Peldon

Iron Skeleton skeleton_iron

Born of broken weapons on endless battlefields of the multiverse, iron skeletons are hard and unyielding, the most serious and driven of their kin.

Gifted in: Strength, Focus | **Weaker in:** Constitution, Luck | **Starts with:** Might, Sorcery | **Innate traits:** Undead, Armored

Typical backgrounds: Warrior, Former Soldier, Guard, Charnel Yogi

Companions of this birth: Iron Oath

Turquoise Skeleton skeleton_turquoise

Prancing cheerfully in their rainbow skirts and flowery headdresses, turquoise skeletons serve as jesters, dancers and, often enough, grand viziers to the Great Bone Kings.

Gifted in: Charm, Luck | **Weaker in:** Strength, Constitution | **Starts with:** Comedy, Performance | **Innate traits:** Undead

Typical backgrounds: Bone Dancer, Noble, Wanderer, Catacomb Keeper

Companions of this birth: The Chronicler

25.3 Animal births (18)

Naga naga

Before the first apes descended from the trees, these serpentine beings raised their glimmering cities with ingenuity and wisdom.

Gifted in: Awareness, Focus, Finesse, Charm | **Weaker in:** Strength | **Starts with:** Enchantment, Persuasion, Water Magic | **Innate traits:** Serpentine, Hoard Keeper

Typical backgrounds: Coral Guard, Vizier of the Deep Court, Sea-Silk Dancer, Gleaner of Drowned Palaces, Seer of Currents, Herbalist

Companions of this birth: Shesharati, Anavatapta

Yaksha yaksha

Something is being guarded — a spring, a hoard, a promise older than the hill it was sworn on. Ask which, and the answer arrives with the weight of a matter settled long before you were born.

Gifted in: Finesse, Awareness, Charm, Focus | **Weaker in:** Strength | **Elemental lean:** Air, Earth | **Starts with:** Air Magic, Persuasion, Ritual | **Innate traits:** Guardian's Geas

Typical backgrounds: Caravan Guard, Still Hunter, Pollen Rishi, Meadow Ward, Herbalist, Ancestor Priest

Companions of this birth: Sthanumati

Bhramara bhramara

The nature of the relationship between a bhramara and their hive eludes the grasp of even the most empathetic of other beings. What is obvious is their coordination and refinement.

Gifted in: Awareness, Finesse, Focus, Charm | **Weaker in:** Strength | **Elemental lean:** Air, Earth | **Starts with:** Air Magic, Logistics, Ritual, Summoning | **Innate traits:** Colony Mind

Typical backgrounds: Hive Architect, Node of the Queen's Web, Far Scout, Honey-Keeper, Caravan Guard, Swarm Caller, Herbalist

Companions of this birth: Madhuvrata

Karka karka

Armoured, unhurried, and entirely uninterested in your schedule. The karka hold the reef passes the way a door holds a frame, and no one has yet argued one out of the way.

Gifted in: Constitution, Strength | **Weaker in:** Finesse, Focus, Charm | **Elemental lean:** Earth | **Starts with:** Armor, Might | **Innate traits:** Aquatic, Armored

Typical backgrounds: Coral Guard, Gleaner of Drowned Palaces, Herald of the Undersea Roads, Vent Warden, Keel Rider, Herbalist

Companions of this birth: Kambu, Vajradanti

Matsya matsya

In the ocean, the slow and unwary quickly become a meal. The matsya are the children of those who lived, and they will do their best to make their ancestors proud.

Gifted in: Finesse, Awareness | **Weaker in:** Strength, Luck | **Elemental lean:** Water | **Starts with:** Grace, Guile, Water Magic | **Innate traits:** Aquatic, Predator's Grace

Typical backgrounds: Coral Guard, Sea-Silk Dancer, Hunter of the Open Current, Gleaner of Drowned Palaces, Herald of the Undersea Roads, Herbalist

Companions of this birth: Minakshi

Makara makara

Deep beneath the waves dwell creatures strange and old, wielding weird magic and practicing yogas that only make sense for the cephalopod body.

Gifted in: Focus, Strength, Constitution, Finesse, Awareness | **Weaker in:** Charm, Luck | **Elemental lean:** Water, Space | **Starts with:** Enchantment, Sorcery, Water Magic | **Innate traits:** Aquatic, Deep Current

Typical backgrounds: Coral Guard, Vizier of the Deep Court, Hunter of the Open Current, Gleaner of Drowned Palaces, Walker Between Worlds, Herbalist, Blood Drinker

Companions of this birth: Timingila, Setubandha

Dura dura

Patient and persistent, the Dura have been here longer than most things that walk. They have long mastered the secrets of the earth and became famous as farmers, traders and sturdy warriors.

Gifted in: Constitution, Strength | **Weaker in:** Finesse, Focus, Awareness | **Elemental lean:** Earth | **Starts with:** Earth Magic, Smithing, Trade | **Innate traits:** Armored

Typical backgrounds: Caravan Guard, Tunneler, Tunnel Merchant, Root Shaper, Shell Wright, Herbalist

Companions of this birth: Valmika

Khadga khadga

The blade-limbed mantis, the dragonfly, the ambush grasshopper. They live by the first strike, unconquered in their weight class.

Gifted in: Finesse, Awareness | **Weaker in:** Constitution, Charm | **Elemental lean:** Air | **Starts with:** Grace, Martial Arts, Yoga | **Innate traits:** Predator's Grace

Typical backgrounds: Caravan Guard, Still Hunter, Blade Contemplative, Jaina, Herbalist

Companions of this birth: Tikshnashringa, Nirvikalpa

Patanga patanga

Poison, silk, iridescence, and a tendency to appear where least expected, the Patanga know how to kindle fear and wonder alike.

Gifted in: Focus, Finesse, Awareness | **Weaker in:** Constitution, Charm | **Elemental lean:** Air, Space | **Starts with:** Air Magic, Alchemy, Guile

Typical backgrounds: Far Scout, Flame-Seeker, Pollen Rishi, Herbalist

Companions of this birth: Agnishikha

Rakshasa rakshasa

Shape-shifting lords of the jungle, presiding over the ancient cults of the hunt. What a tiger becomes, given lifetimes.

Gifted in: Strength, Constitution, Finesse, Focus, Awareness | **Weaker in:** Charm, Luck | **Elemental lean:** Fire | **Starts with:** Might, Unarmed, Yoga | **Innate traits:** Hunter's Yoga

Typical backgrounds: Lord of the Range, The Hungry, Maneater, Hedonist, Herbalist, Realm Walker, Blood Drinker, Ancestor Priest, The Sensate

Companions of this birth: Nishkasita, Khara, Krudha, Kabandha, Takshari, Unmatta

Varaha varaha

Not looking for a fight, and not stepping off the trail either. Polite, in the way of a thing that could open you end to end and would rather not. No strength wasted, and never far from kin.

Gifted in: Constitution, Strength | **Weaker in:** Finesse, Focus, Awareness, Charm | **Elemental lean:** Earth | **Starts with:** Armor, Might | **Innate traits:** Armored, Bulky

Typical backgrounds: Old Tusk, Sounder Guard, Mycelium Tender, Sounder Matron, Herbalist, Ancestor Priest, Young Brave, Truffle Hunter

Companions of this birth: Ekadamshta, Kandali, Phulla, Mrichha, Runborn, Ghoraka, Vasuda

Marjara marjara

The patch of warm dappled light is their home, whatever they want at the moment their possession. Ever on the go, solitary and ungovernable, marjara can be found wandering in the least expected places.

Gifted in: Finesse, Strength, Awareness | **Weaker in:** Constitution, Luck | **Elemental lean:** Fire | **Starts with:** Daggers, Grace, Thievery | **Innate traits:** Predator's Grace, Venom Ward

Typical backgrounds: Cache Master, Canopy Ambush, Forest Drifter, Hedonist, Herbalist, Blood Drinker, Smuggler, Pleasure Dancer, Witch, Cutpurse, Cat Burglar

Companions of this birth: Chitrangada, Kshanaka, Sthiraka, Niloka, Varika, Mandaka, Rupaka

Gana gana

Alone, a middling thing with good teeth. Together, nothing in the forest outruns us.

Gifted in: Finesse, Strength, Awareness | **Weaker in:** Constitution, Charm | **Elemental lean:** Air, Fire | **Starts with:** Daggers, Guile, Unarmed | **Innate traits:** Colony Mind

Typical backgrounds: Strangler, Quiet Tooth, Bonfire Dancer, Herbalist, Elder Voice, Range Reader, Forest Singer, Blood Drinker, Ancestor Priest

Companions of this birth: Dirghajihva, Saramaya, Dhvanika, Sphotana, Ghoshaka, Nadaka

Mriga mriga

The feeling of dew on your antlers, the juicy new leaves of spring, the kinship of the herd! It is a good life.

Gifted in: Awareness, Finesse, Charm | **Weaker in:** Strength, Constitution | **Elemental lean:** Earth, Air | **Starts with:** Grace, Performance, Persuasion | **Innate traits:** Colony Mind, First to Know

Typical backgrounds: Antler Speaker, Songline Guide, Slope Herbalist, Scarred Lead, Range Reader, Forest Singer, Herbalist

Companions of this birth: Enakshi, Shrutidhara, Trinavati, Nayanika, Himasara, Vishanin, Chapala, Sarangi

Vanara vanara

Nothing in the canopy is fastened down, and anything that is merely constitutes the opening of a project. They are funny deliberately, which is the part people underestimate.

Gifted in: Finesse, Focus, Awareness, Luck | **Weaker in:** Strength, Constitution | **Elemental lean:** Air | **Starts with:** Comedy, Guile | **Innate traits:** Nimble Mischief

Typical backgrounds: Troop Elder, Shrine Keeper, Jugaad, Forest Thief, Treetop Wit, Herbalist

Companions of this birth: Brihannala, Phalgun

Shyena shyena

The stoop is one decision, made at height and never revised. From up there the world sorts cleanly into things worth the dive and things that are not.

Gifted in: Strength, Awareness, Constitution | **Weaker in:** Charm | **Elemental lean:** Air, Fire | **Starts with:** Air Magic, Ranged, Unarmed | **Innate traits:** Flying, Armored, Taloned Strike

Typical backgrounds: Sky Lord, Stoooper, Jessed Hawk, Herbalist, Blood Drinker, Ancestor Priest

Companions of this birth: Balavardhana

Kapota kapota

Every message that mattered was carried by something small and grey that nobody thought to stop. The kapota remember all of them, and they remember who was lying.

Gifted in: Awareness, Charm, Luck, Finesse | **Weaker in:** Strength, Constitution | **Elemental lean:** Air | **Starts with:** Air Magic, Grace, Learning, Persuasion | **Innate traits:** Flying, Predator's Grace, Swift Wing

Typical backgrounds: Post Runner, Temple Dove, Conference Pilgrim, Waypoint Gossip, Herbalist

Companions of this birth: Phenaka

Uluka uluka

They ask questions in the tone of someone who already has the answer and is deciding whether you deserve it. Nothing that hunts in silence is ever entirely trusted.

Gifted in: Awareness, Focus, Finesse | **Weaker in:** Strength, Constitution | **Elemental lean:** Space, Air | **Starts with:** Air Magic, Learning, Ritual | **Innate traits:** Flying, Night Vision

Typical backgrounds: Night Scholar, Ill Omen, Fortune Seeker, Herbalist

Companions of this birth: Kshudraka

25.4 Human births (4)

The realm itself has no content yet; these births are defined and waiting.

Human human

Beings of potential and choice, balanced in all aspects

Gifted in: Luck

Typical backgrounds: Wanderer, Scholar, Merchant, Monk, Noble, Warrior, Farmer

Nomad nomad

TODO: Fill in description

Mountain Folk mountain_folk

TODO: Fill in description

Trader trader

TODO: Fill in description

25.5 Asura births (2)

The realm itself has no content yet; these births are defined and waiting.

Tsen tsen

TODO: Fill in description

Rudra rudra

TODO: Fill in description

25.6 God births (3)

The realm itself has no content yet; these births are defined and waiting.

Gandharva gandharva

TODO: Fill in description

Apsara apsara

TODO: Fill in description

Planetary Deity planetary_deity

TODO: Fill in description

26. Background catalogue (120 backgrounds)

A background is what a character did before the story begins. 33 are open to every birth; the other 87 belong to specific births. Descriptions are exactly as the player reads them.

26.1 Open to every birth (33)

Apothecary apothecary

Everything is a poison. The dose is the whole of the argument.

Teaches: Alchemy, Medicine

Apprentice apprentice

Three years of fetching, one of watching, and a fortnight of being allowed to try.

Teaches: Sorcery, Learning

Brawler brawler

No school, no forms, no weapon. A very great deal of practice.

Teaches: Unarmed, Might

Charm Seller charm_seller

Half of it is the charm. Half is knowing who needs one, and what they are afraid of.

Teaches: Enchantment, Persuasion

Conjurer's Hand conjurers_hand

You do not call a thing you cannot send back. This is taught early, and usually twice.

Teaches: Summoning, Ritual

Dancer dancer

The floor is not the point. The moment before the floor is the point.

Teaches: Grace, Performance

Diplomat diplomat

A speaker between peoples, trained to find common ground in the most hostile of rooms.

Teaches: Persuasion, Learning

Farmer farmer

A worker of the land, with tireless endurance and practical knowledge.

Teaches: Logistics, Axes

Firekeeper firekeeper

It does not go out. That is the whole of the office, and it is harder than it sounds.

Teaches: Fire Magic, Ritual

Grave Tender grave_tender

Someone digs, someone speaks, someone remembers where. Out here it is all the same someone.

Teaches: Black Magic, Medicine

Guard guard

A protector of places and people, trained to hold ground and outlast attackers.

Teaches: Spears, Armor

Healer healer

Trained in white magic and the medical arts, devoted to the restoration of body and spirit.

Teaches: White Magic, Medicine

Herbalist herbalist

The forest speaks of cures and poisons, if you know how to listen. When you break a branch, you see little. They see the weather, time, soil, animals and fungi, spirits and the dead.

Teaches: Medicine, Earth Magic

Hunter hunter

A tracker and killer of prey, patient and precise at range.

Teaches: Ranged, Guile

Merchant merchant

A trader of goods and services, sharp-tongued and sharper-eyed for opportunity.

Teaches: Trade, Persuasion

Monk monk

A practitioner of spiritual disciplines, attuned to inner forces most ignore.

Teaches: Yoga, Martial Arts

Musician musician

Someone has to be playing when the thing happens, or nobody remembers it right.

Teaches: Performance, Comedy

Noble noble

Born to privilege and power, accustomed to commanding others.

Teaches: Persuasion, Leadership, Swords

Penitent penitent

A suffering soul who turned their torment inward and found something unexpected: clarity. Frail at first, but possessed of a spiritual awareness that others in hell have entirely forgotten.

Teaches: Yoga, Medicine

Priest priest

A servant of the divine, trained in ceremony and in the healing and harmful uses of sacred power.

Teaches: White Magic, Ritual

Psychic psychic

It began with knowing who was at the door. It did not stop there.

Teaches: Space Magic, Yoga

Quarrier quarrier

Stone gives at one angle only. Finding it is the work. The hitting is the easy part.

Teaches: Maces, Might

Reveler reveler

A social creature of feasts, festivals, and flattery. Charm opens more doors than keys.

Teaches: Performance, Persuasion, Leadership

Scholar scholar

A student of ancient texts and wisdom, more at home with scrolls than swords.

Teaches: Learning, Ritual

Smith smith

Heat, then shape, then cold. Everything else is opinion.

Teaches: Smithing, Might

Spy spy

An operative who trades in information, deception, and precisely timed violence. Trusted by no one, useful to everyone.

Teaches: Daggers, Guile

Storm Watcher storm_watcher

The weather tells you first, if you are outside enough to be told.

Teaches: Air Magic, Learning

Temple Warden temple_warden

A protector of sacred places, combining martial readiness with spiritual discipline.

Teaches: Spears, White Magic, Armor

Thief thief

Locks are a conversation. Most of them are not very good at it.

Teaches: Thievery, Guile

Wanderer wanderer

A traveler who has seen many places and learned to read people and terrain alike.

Teaches: Learning, Might

Warrior warrior

Trained in the arts of combat, body hardened by years of drill and battle.

Teaches: Swords, Armor, Might

Water Carrier water_carrier

Uphill full, downhill empty, and nobody in the village has ever once said thank you.

Teaches: Water Magic, Logistics

Witch witch

Some find the power to resist in the very rejection of all imposed authority.

Teaches: Sorcery, Black Magic

26.2 Specific to Hell births (1)

Soul Jailer soul_jailer

A warden of the condemned, guarding souls sentenced to suffer. Brutal and disciplined in equal measure.

Open to: Red Devil, Blue Devil, Yellow Devil, Green Devil, Black Devil, White Devil | **Teaches:** Spears, Armor, Black Magic

26.3 Specific to Hungry Ghost births (9)

Bog Warden bog_warden

Long years of standing knee-deep in the same patch of swamp have made you territorial and surprisingly canny about it. You know every root and current. Others stumble; you do not.

Open to: Rolang | **Teaches:** Unarmed, Guile

Bone Dancer bone_dancer

You rattle with purpose where others grimace. A drum, a flourish, a joke at the right moment — you discovered that morale is its own kind of magic, and yours is inexhaustible.

Open to: Skeleton | **Teaches:** Performance, Comedy

Catacomb Keeper catacomb_keeper

You tend the dry places. You know where every bone is, who it belonged to, and how long they have been here. The catacombs are yours and you maintain them with cheer and precision.

Open to: Skeleton | **Teaches:** Logistics, Earth Magic, White Magic

Charnel Yogi charnel_yogi

You meditate where death is most concentrated. The proximity to dissolution, to rot and impermanence, has sharpened your understanding of the mind and weakened your attachment to the body.

Open to: Vetala, Skeleton, Gyelpo, Dré | **Teaches:** Yoga, Ritual

Former Soldier former_soldier

Death did not end their service. Muscle memory survives the grave.

Open to: Rolang, Skeleton, Vetala, Dralha | **Teaches:** Swords, Armor

Plague Victim plague_victim

Carries the sickness that killed them. Even in death, the rot spreads.

Open to: Rolang, Skeleton, Vetala, Gyelpo | **Teaches:** Black Magic

Preserved preserved

Alchemical arts halted your decay. Oils, mantras and mineral compounds have kept you intact while others rotted to bone. You remember considerably more than most of your kind.

Open to: Rolang | **Teaches:** Alchemy, Black Magic

Shambler shambler

Barely conscious, driven by hunger. What remains of a person after death strips everything else away.

Open to: Rolang | **Teaches:** Unarmed

Trickster trickster

You live for the moment the illusion lands. Misdirection, impossible vanishings, arguments that fold in on themselves — you treat confusion as both art form and survival strategy.

Open to: Vetala, Dré | **Teaches:** Guile, Space Magic, Comedy

26.4 Specific to Animal births (72)

Ancestor Priest ancestor_priest

The chiefs and heroes are laid to rest with the trophies of their most glorious hunts and offered blood mead when the moon is full.

Open to: Rakshasa, Gana, Varaha, Shyena, Yaksha | **Teaches:** White Magic, Black Magic, Ritual

Antler Speaker antler_speaker

The young ones duel for dominance, the mature ones gather the kin with presence and speech.

Open to: Mriga | **Teaches:** Performance, Grace

Blade Contemplative blade_contemplative

The mantis holds perfectly still before it moves. So do you. The strike is not an act of violence — it is the end of a very long thought.

Open to: Khadga | **Teaches:** Martial Arts, Yoga

Blood Drinker blood_drinker

This is not their first incarnation in this body, and probably not the last, looking on how they savour the hunt.

Open to: Rakshasa, Marjara, Gana, Shyena, Makara | **Teaches:** Might, Guile, Black Magic

Bonfire Dancer bonfire_dancer

These? They make a clinking sound when I move, and these here are to reflect lights and sparkle, and this one is —

Open to: Gana, Mriga | **Teaches:** Performance, Ritual, Persuasion

Cache Master cache_master

Wherever they go in the forest, they know a spot. A bag hidden here, food stashed in a tree stump there, a safehouse when you need it.

Open to: Marjara | **Teaches:** Thievery, Guile, Logistics

Canopy Ambush canopy_ambush

They look for traps on the ground, listen for rustling in the leaves behind. The joke's on them, I've been watching from the treetops for hours.

Open to: Marjara | **Teaches:** Daggers, Martial Arts, Grace

Caravan Guard caravan_guard

The trade roads between hive-cities need walking. You walk them heavy and slow, and nothing touches the cargo.

Open to: Dura, Khadga, Bhramara, Yaksha | **Teaches:** Armor, Spears, Might

Cat Burglar cat_burglar

Up the wall, over the sill, and out again before the lamp is even lit. The name writes itself, and they have heard the joke.

Open to: Marjara | **Teaches:** Thievery, Grace

Conference Pilgrim conference_pilgrim

You made the journey. The thirty gathered at the highest waypoint — the one above the clouds that is on no one's map — and found what was there. Some say the Simurgh was not there. Some say the Simurgh was exactly there. You came back, and it is difficult to explain what you found, except that you are no longer looking for it.

Open to: Kapota | **Teaches:** Yoga, Space Magic

Coral Guard coral_guard

You held a post at the outer walls of the palace. The tidal patterns of watch-change are in your bones.

Open to: Naga, Karka, Matsya, Makara | **Teaches:** Armor, Spears

Cutpurse cutpurse

Marjara stole nothing, marjara is innocent of this crime!

Open to: Marjara | **Teaches:** Thievery, Daggers

Elder Voice elder_voice

Not the fastest, not the strongest, but the one who can keep the pack alive the longest.

Open to: Gana | **Teaches:** Leadership, Persuasion, Logistics

Far Scout far_scout

The hive's eyes go further than its walls. You mapped the meadow in pollen-language and brought it home in your body.

Open to: Bhramara, Patanga | **Teaches:** Air Magic, Logistics

Flame-Seeker flame_seeker

The flame is a teacher. You have studied it your whole life. It has not yet consumed you.

Open to: Patanga | **Teaches:** Fire Magic, Yoga

Forest Drifter forest_drifter

A hunt when hungry, a trade when bored, a long sleep in a warm patch of sunlight when neither seems worth the effort.

Open to: Marjara | **Teaches:** Thievery, Trade, Comedy

Forest Singer forest_singer

On moonlit nights, the song carries further than you can see, the answer coming back from somewhere unexpected.

Open to: Gana, Mriga | **Teaches:** Performance, Comedy, Grace

Forest Thief forest_thief

The settlements at the forest edge have interesting things — bright cloth, sweet foods, objects whose purpose I don't understand but which catch the light magnificently. I know which dogs bark and which don't. I know when the guards sleep.

Open to: Vanara | **Teaches:** Thievery, Guile

Fortune Seeker fortune_seeker

The hollow log three wing-lengths off the ground, just off the north pass — there is silver in it. You know this the way you know where the mice run. The buried thing, the hidden cache, the lost object — they have a particular quality in the dark that found and visible things lack. Lakshmi moves in circles you can follow.

Open to: Uluka | **Teaches:** Thievery, Trade, Guile

Gleaner of Drowned Palaces wreck_gleaner

The surface-folk build ships and lose them to the deep. You have walked through more of their halls than any of them ever did.

Open to: Naga, Karka, Matsya, Makara | **Teaches:** Thievery, Learning, Trade

Hedonist hedonist

...the feast after the hunt, the fear on a stranger's face, the music from the village fire that reaches the treeline — all this is the blood of experience, and I will have my fill!

Open to: Rakshasa, Marjara | **Teaches:** Performance, Black Magic, Grace

Herald of the Undersea Roads current_herald

News travels fast in the deep. You are faster.

Open to: Matsya, Karka | **Teaches:** Air Magic, Guile, Logistics

Hive Architect hive_architect

The comb is not built — it grows, cell by cell, through ten thousand coordinated decisions. You were one of them.

Open to: Bhramara | **Teaches:** Earth Magic, Logistics, Smithing

Honey-Keeper honey_alchemist

The honey is not food. It is memory, medicine, and slow fire. You know the difference between a healing batch and a poisoned one.

Open to: Bhramara | **Teaches:** Alchemy, Medicine

Hunter of the Open Current deep_hunter

You roam the deep water alone. What others call the hunt is to you a long meditation in moving silence.

Open to: Matsya, Makara | **Teaches:** Spears, Daggers

Ill Omen ill_omen

You have been appearing before catastrophes since before you can remember. You arrive; something happens. You learn not to take it personally. Eventually you learn to take it very personally — to arrive where you choose, and let the catastrophe follow from that. An omen is only uncontrolled prophecy.

Open to: Uluka | **Teaches:** Black Magic, Performance

Jaina jaina

You looked at your blades and understood the problem. They were made for one thing only, and that thing leaves a mark on the soul. You chose the longer road: discipline, the practice of not-harming, and finally the great fast that others call death but you know as the last purification.

Open to: Khadga | **Teaches:** Yoga, Ritual, Learning

Jessed Hawk jessed_hawk

Trained, hooded, tethered, fed by hand. You learned the wrist and the lure, the falconer's whistle, the particular quality of patience that humans confuse with obedience. You watched their settlements from above for years before you understood what you were seeing. Now you are neither fully wild nor fully tame, and you know things that neither world suspects.

Open to: Shyena | **Teaches:** Guile, Learning

Jugaad jugaad

The camp near the river has a forge. I watched them for a season before I went in. They thought I wanted food. I wanted to understand what they were doing with fire and metal. The first tool I made was better than theirs. The seventh one they couldn't explain. I take requests now, in exchange for food and a formal agreement with their dogs.

Open to: Vanara | **Teaches:** Guile, Learning, Smithing

Keel Rider keel_rider

You found that boats go places if you hold on to the underside and wait. You have been to ports whose names you cannot pronounce. You have watched markets from below the dock pilings. You know more about distant trade than the merchants who paid for passage, and you got there for free.

Open to: Karka | **Teaches:** Learning, Trade, Comedy, Grace

Lord of the Range lord_of_the_range

Every tree in three valleys is marked. When lesser things feel watched, they are right.

Open to: Rakshasa | **Teaches:** Might, Martial Arts

Maneater maneater

They tell bedtime stories to their children about her, unable to see her dark silhouette lurking behind the window.

Open to: Rakshasa | **Teaches:** Guile, Unarmed

Meadow Ward meadow_ward

You are bound to a place. The meadow's health is your health. Strangers who wish safe passage learn to speak to you first.

Open to: Yaksha | **Teaches:** Earth Magic, Ritual, Persuasion

Mycelium Tender mycelium_tender

You may find them sitting quietly in the clearing, listening to the mycelium sharing stories you couldn't even fathom.

Open to: Varaha | **Teaches:** Earth Magic, Alchemy

Night Scholar night_scholar

The waypoint at midnight is a different place than the waypoint at noon. The day-birds leave things: messages, feathers, the warm impressions of bodies on stone. You read it all. You know more about what happens in the light hours than any creature who was there for them. Knowledge accumulates in the dark.

Open to: Uluka | **Teaches:** Learning, Black Magic

Node of the Queen's Web network_node

You held a position in the real-time flow of the hive's collective mind. Not a soldier, not a builder — a relay, a processor, a voice in the continuous hum.

Open to: Bhramara | **Teaches:** Ritual, Water Magic, Yoga

Old Tusk old_tusk

Forty seasons in these hills. I know which hollows flood in the rains, where the healing clay is, where the truffle runs deepest.

Open to: Varaha | **Teaches:** Earth Magic, Medicine, Logistics

Pleasure Dancer pleasure_dancer

The cat folk know many find their grace and lack of morals quite delightful, at least before they wake from the reverie and find their purse missing.

Open to: Marjara | **Teaches:** Persuasion, Guile

Pollen Rishi pollen_rishi

You move between the flowering nodes of the meadow's invisible geography, accumulating knowledge the way a wing accumulates dust.

Open to: Patanga, Yaksha | **Teaches:** Learning, Space Magic, Yoga

Post Runner post_runner

The peak where two passes cross. The lone horn of rock three days east. The great cliff above the frozen lake. You know every one — the approach thermals, the best perches, who is likely to be there. The route is not how you travel. The route is who you are.

Open to: Kapota | **Teaches:** Logistics, Grace

Quiet Tooth quiet_tooth

A tooth is a knife that is always with you, quick and quiet when you spot a straggler, a weakling, one lost.

Open to: Gana | **Teaches:** Daggers, Guile

Range Reader range_reader

When I run, I am eyes, I am ears, I am heart. I notice the colour that does not belong, the shadow that holds still while the leaves move.

Open to: Gana, Mriga | **Teaches:** Ranged, Grace

Realm Walker realm_walker

He has traveled far, in this world and beyond. He learned a lot, tricked many and ate quite a few, too.

Open to: Rakshasa | **Teaches:** Enchantment, Might, Logistics

Root Shaper root_shaper

The tuber doesn't know it's being guided. The root finds the right direction because the direction is good, and you make the direction good. Enchantment is not force — it is a very patient suggestion.

Open to: Dura | **Teaches:** Enchantment, Earth Magic

Scarred Lead scarred_lead

Every carnivore that tried left a mark and a lesson. The crowd follows him towards the safe water.

Open to: Mriga | **Teaches:** Leadership, Persuasion, Logistics

Sea-Silk Dancer sea_dancer

In the crystal hall you moved like a current through still water. The court watched. The King smiled.

Open to: Naga, Matsya | **Teaches:** Performance, Grace, Guile

Seer of Currents tide_seer

The naga lineages carry old knowledge. You read futures in the way water moves around stone.

Open to: Naga | **Teaches:** Water Magic, Black Magic, Ritual

Shell Wright shell_wright

The shed carapace is not waste. It is material — harder than wood, lighter than iron, shaped already by the body that wore it. You learned to work it: to cut, to layer, to join. What you make fits the one who will wear it because you understand what it is to be armoured from birth.

Open to: Dura | **Teaches:** Armor, Smithing

Shrine Keeper shrine_keeper

The great fig tree has been sacred since before memory. I leave offerings at the roots — a smooth stone, a bright beetle, a length of vine arranged just so. I do not know why. My mother did it. And hers.

Open to: Vanara | **Teaches:** Ritual, Yoga

Sky Lord sky_lord

Three valleys. Every road, field, and creature visible at once from the high thermal. Others look at their feet and call that seeing. You look at everything from above and call it home. The ground is not the world. The ground is what you look at when you want to know where you are.

Open to: Shyena | **Teaches:** Unarmed, Might, Logistics

Slope Herbalist slope_herbalist

I know where the bitter herb grows. I know the clay that draws out poison.

Open to: Mriga | **Teaches:** Medicine, Earth Magic

Smuggler smuggler

I prefer to call it free trade, friend. Care for some supplies, arms — or perhaps something more exciting for a gentleman of such discerning tastes?

Open to: Marjara | **Teaches:** Trade, Guile

Songline Guide songline_guide

Listen, how the ancestors ran those paths where we run, how they drank where we drink, how they sang where I sing!

Open to: Mriga | **Teaches:** Performance, Persuasion, Logistics

Sounder Guard sounder_guard

The piglets run to me when they're scared, and not once have I failed them.

Open to: Varaha | **Teaches:** Maces, Armor

Sounder Matron sounder_matron

You might fight a wolf, but just try raising your voice against the mother.

Open to: Varaha | **Teaches:** Leadership, Might

Still Hunter still_hunter

You do not chase. You find the right place, and you wait. The prey comes to you eventually. It always does.

Open to: Khadga, Yaksha | **Teaches:** Daggers, Guile

Stooper stooper

Two hundred wing-lengths of silent fall. The wind becomes a pressure, then a scream, then nothing — because at the end of the stoop there is no more thinking, only the moment of contact. Everything else you do in your life is preparation for this or recovery from it.

Open to: Shyena | **Teaches:** Unarmed, Martial Arts

Strangler strangler

At first it takes strength to grip so tightly. In time it becomes patience.

Open to: Gana | **Teaches:** Unarmed, Might

Swarm Caller swarm_caller

The hive can extend beyond the hive. You learned to ask rather than just know — to reach through the network and draw a portion of it toward you. The swarm comes when called. It is not a weapon. It is a form of speech.

Open to: Bhramara | **Teaches:** Summoning, Air Magic

Temple Dove temple_dove

Hatched in the temple courtyard, fed on offerings, trained to carry prayers tied to your leg between shrines. You never needed to find food. You never needed to know where you were going — the route was always already known. You are out in the wider world now, and it is strange: loud, directionless, full of things that were not in the prayers.

Open to: Kapota | **Teaches:** Ritual, Yoga

The Hungry the_hungry

The hunger is not a problem. It is the condition of becoming.

Open to: Rakshasa | **Teaches:** Unarmed, Martial Arts, Guile

The Sensate the_sensate

They left the forests a lifetime ago, for the delights only civilized life can offer. Now they hunt by seduction, by art, by magic — and their prey hides in silks and perfume, and seems rather excited to be hunted.

Open to: Rakshasa | **Teaches:** Persuasion, Performance, Fire Magic

Treetop Wit treetop_wit

The line between funny and frightening is a matter of timing. You work both sides of it from a height, with an audience that can't easily leave. The fall is never accidental. The recovery is always the point.

Open to: Vanara | **Teaches:** Comedy, Performance, Grace

Troop Elder troop_elder

I know which fig ripens first and which mango is always bitter. I know who should not sit next to whom at the sleeping tree, which young males are building coalitions, which females are calculating. The troop is a city in the canopy.

Open to: Vanara | **Teaches:** Persuasion, Learning

Truffle Hunter truffle_hunter

One starts seeking the morsels out by smell, then by intuition, finally by the psychic imprint of the burgeoning mycelium.

Open to: Varaha | **Teaches:** Earth Magic

Tunnel Merchant tunnel_merchant

The surface roads belong to those who fear nothing. The tunnel roads belong to you. Your caravan of great beetles moves slow and sure through passages older than memory, and the surface predators never knew you passed.

Open to: Dura | **Teaches:** Trade, Logistics

Tunneler tunneler

You dig. What others call the underworld is simply where you work. The roots of the meadow are familiar as a face.

Open to: Dura | **Teaches:** Earth Magic, Might, Smithing

Vent Warden vent_warden

The chimneys are older than memory — older than the coral palace, older than the names of the ocean-born. Where the thermal vents breathe, life clusters around the heat. You hold the threshold. You were not appointed to this. You are the threshold.

Open to: Karka | **Teaches:** Sorcery, Maces, Armor

Vizier of the Deep Court palace_vizier

You attended the Naga King, drafted proclamations in brine-script, and read the omens in current-patterns.

Open to: Naga, Makara | **Teaches:** Persuasion, Learning, Water Magic

Walker Between Worlds boundary_walker

You have always lived at the edge where ocean meets sky, where river meets sea. The in-between is home.

Open to: Makara | **Teaches:** Water Magic, Space Magic, Ritual

Waypoint Gossip waypoint_gossip

Messages are cargo. Stories are currency. You carry both and charge for neither, because the one who gives freely is the one everyone is glad to see at the waypoint. You know more about what is happening across three mountain ranges than any of the people it is happening to.

Open to: Kapota | **Teaches:** Comedy, Persuasion, Learning

Young Brave young_brave

First bulk, then cut. This youngster has bulked impressively indeed.

Open to: Varaha | **Teaches:** Might

26.5 Shared by births of several realms (5)

Berserker berserker

A warrior who fights with uncontrolled fury, trading precision for annihilating force.

Open to: Human, Nomad, Mountain Folk, Tsen, Rudra, Bhramara, Yaksha, Red Devil, Green Devil, Skeleton, Gana | **Teaches:** Axes, Unarmed

Executioner executioner

One who delivers final judgment. Efficient, dispassionate, feared.

Open to: Human, Tsen, Rudra, Red Devil, Black Devil, Yellow Devil, Skeleton | **Teaches:** Axes, Black Magic

Infernal Scribe infernal_scribe

A keeper of sins and karmic ledgers. In hell, bureaucracy is its own form of torment — and these figures wield it like a weapon.

Open to: Red Devil, Blue Devil, Yellow Devil, Green Devil, Black Devil, White Devil, Tsen, Rudra | **Teaches:** Learning, Ritual, Persuasion

Raider raider

One who takes what they want by force, quick to strike and quicker to vanish.

Open to: Human, Nomad, Tsen, Rudra, Bhramara, Yaksha, Red Devil, Blue Devil, Green Devil, Yellow Devil, Skeleton, Vetala, Gana | **Teaches:** Axes, Guile, Thievery

Torturer torturer

A professional in the application of suffering. Methodical, knowledgeable about bodies and their limits, and utterly without sentiment.

Open to: Red Devil, Blue Devil, Yellow Devil, Green Devil, Black Devil, White Devil, Tsen, Rudra | **Teaches:** Axes, Black Magic, Medicine

27. Companion catalogue (99 companions)

Companions are the characters the player can recruit. Each entry shows the name (with its meaning, where one is recorded), birth and background, the full bio exactly as the player reads it, then a reference line of traits and strongest skills. They are grouped by realm and then by birth.

27.1 Hell companions (24)

Red Devil

Brother Karnak karnak

Name: Karnak — "fortified village" (ancient Egyptian place name)

Red Devil · Guard

A red devil cast out of the Infernal Guard for showing mercy to a damned soul. He carries the contradiction quietly.

Traits: Devout, Brave | **Strongest skills:** Martial Arts, Unarmed, Yoga

Jawbreaker jawbreaker

Name: English nickname — one who breaks jaws

Red Devil · Raider

Fast, reckless, and deeply committed to the principle that the best defence is a fractured orbital bone. Also picks pockets while they're down.

Traits: Quick, Gambler | **Strongest skills:** Unarmed, Daggers, Thievery

Raktamatta raktamatta

Name: "Blood-Mad" / "Drunk on Blood" (Sanskrit: *rakta* = blood, *matta* = intoxicated)

Red Devil · Farmer

A law-abiding butcher who followed every regulation, filed every permit, and enjoyed his work with a thoroughness that made inspectors nervous.

Traits: Fastidious, Stubborn | **Strongest skills:** Axes, Spears, Smithing

Red Peony red_peony

Name: The red peony — a flower associated with passion and fierceness

Red Devil · Former Soldier

She carries a two-handed club the size of a small tree and moves like she knows exactly how much space she takes up. A lot.

Traits: Strong, Hot-tempered | **Strongest skills:** Maces, Might, Armor

Serji serji

Name: "Golden" (Tibetan)

Red Devil · Former Soldier

The biggest man in the hot hell gym — and the one who walked out. Not because he won, but because winning there stopped meaning anything.

Traits: War-hardened, Composed | **Strongest skills:** Unarmed, Might, Leadership

Tejasimha tejasimha

Name: "Radiant Lion" / "Fire Lion" (Sanskrit: *teja* = fire/radiance, *simha* = lion)

Red Devil · Raider

First matches, then houses, then whole districts. He died laughing in a fire he started — hearty, genuine laughter, right to the end.

Traits: Curious, Vain | **Strongest skills:** Fire Magic, Ritual, Sorcery

Blue Devil

Dvijihva dvijihva

Name: "Two-Tongued" (Sanskrit: *dvi* = two, *jihvā* = tongue) — the forked tongue of a snake; a liar

Blue Devil · Scholar

A sorcerer for hire who worked for two rival clients simultaneously, studying both thoroughly. He was killed when they compared notes. He considers this an occupational hazard.

Traits: Greedy, Stubborn | **Strongest skills:** Enchantment, Sorcery, Learning

Niyamendra niyamendra

Name: "Lord of Rules" (Sanskrit: *niyama* = rule/regulation, *indra* = lord)

Blue Devil · Noble

Court bureaucrat of a petty king, who found his true calling in the invention of regulations. He can freeze any ordinary process in place — paperwork is eternal.

Traits: Fastidious, Patient | **Strongest skills:** Persuasion, Logistics, Water Magic

Water Lily water_lily

Name: The water lily — a flower that blooms on the surface of still water, rooted in mud

Blue Devil · Farmer

A village girl drowned as punishment for being found in bed with another girl. She has been very quiet ever since, but her stillness is not grief.

Traits: Composed, Brave | **Strongest skills:** Water Magic, Yoga, White Magic

Yaga Mataji yaga_mataji

Name: "Honored Mother of Rites" (Sanskrit: *yāga* = ritual sacrifice, *mātājī* = revered mother)

Blue Devil · Merchant

An old innkeeper who poisoned guests she found sinful. Her criteria were specific, her dosing was precise, and she kept excellent records.

Traits: Fastidious, Suspicious | **Strongest skills:** Alchemy, Black Magic, Ritual

Yellow Devil

Kanjus kanjus

Name: "Miser" (Hindi/Urdu: *kanjūs* = penny-pincher, tightwad)

Yellow Devil · Merchant

Owner of a textile manufactory, maximiser of profit, minimiser of worker wellbeing. In hell he applies the same efficiency to whatever operation he finds himself part of.

Traits: Greedy, Stubborn | **Strongest skills:** Logistics, Trade, Smithing

Sarpatailaka sarpatailaka

Name: "Snake Oil" (Sanskrit: *sarpa* = snake, *tailaka* = oil/unguent) — literally

Yellow Devil · Merchant

A trader in snake oil and false cures, who offered hope where real treatment was available. The daggers are for customers who want a refund.

Traits: Greedy, Gambler | **Strongest skills:** Trade, Daggers, Earth Magic

Shiny Needle shiny_needle

Name: English — a needle bright enough to catch the eye; something sharp disguised as something decorative

Yellow Devil · Noble

She prided herself on being the prettiest. When age threatened that, she found an elegant solution — draining the life force of rivals through carefully rehearsed enchantments. She called it skincare.

Traits: Vain, Addiction | **Strongest skills:** Performance, Enchantment, Earth Magic

Green Devil

Angulimāla angulimala

Name: "Garland of Fingers" (Sanskrit: *aṅguli* = finger, *māla* = garland/necklace) — a famous Buddhist outlaw who collected the fingers of his victims

Green Devil · Executioner

Executioner of a crime syndicate, known for a particular professional habit involving fingers. He is fast, precise, and oddly graceful about it.

Traits: Fastidious, Sharp Memory | **Strongest skills:** Swords, Grace, Ranged

Leraya leraya

Name: Possibly Tibetan for "swift one" or a regional name meaning "the pursuer"

Green Devil · Hunter

A huntsman who grew bored with animals and started tracking people instead. The challenge was the point. He is still tracking.

Traits: Curious, Stubborn | **Strongest skills:** Ranged, Guile, Daggers

Samvibrahmi samvibrahmi

Name: "Perfectly Bewildered" (Sanskrit: *sam* = completely, *vibhrāmī* = one who is confused/erring)

Green Devil · Noble

Driven by constant suspicion of assassination, he prepared obsessively for every conceivable threat. He was ultimately killed by a cabbage cart. He still doesn't know how they did it.

Traits: Paranoid, Suspicious | **Strongest skills:** Guile, Daggers, Learning

Vāyuvega vayuvega

Name: "Speed of the Wind" (Sanskrit: *vāyu* = wind/air, *vega* = velocity/force)

Green Devil · Former Soldier

Battle mage for a gang in life — a firm believer in hitting hard first and letting the questions sort themselves out among the survivors.

Traits: Hot-tempered, Brave | **Strongest skills:** Air Magic, Sorcery, Ritual

Black Devil

Coolhead Hotblood coolhead_hotblood

Name: English — a contradiction; the calm exterior over the boiling interior

[Black Devil](#) · [Infernal Scribe](#)

A people-pleasing librarian who let frustration build in his innards like an alchemical retort. One day the seal broke. He found the experience clarifying.

Traits: Hot-tempered, Sharp Memory | **Strongest skills:** Black Magic, Sorcery, Unarmed

Dyūtapati dyutapati

Name: "Lord of Gambling" (Sanskrit: *dyūta* = game of dice/gambling, *pati* = lord/master)

[Black Devil](#) · [Merchant](#)

Owner of a casino in hell — cigar always lit, odds always in his favour, smile always present. The house wins. He is the house.

Traits: Greedy, Patient | **Strongest skills:** Persuasion, Trade, Guile

Princess Spiderface princess_spiderface

Name: English — a noble title paired with a bluntly descriptive epithet

[Black Devil](#) · [Noble](#)

Actually rather nice, though the face doesn't help first impressions. She calls the spirits she summons by name and asks how they've been.

Traits: Generous, Trusting | **Strongest skills:** Space Magic, White Magic, Persuasion

Sineater Thirteen sineater_thirteen

Name: English — a ritual figure who absorbs the sins of others; the number thirteen the count of identities consumed

[Black Devil](#) · [Penitent](#)

Born from a splinter of dark energy left when a primordial Srid was shattered by a wrathful Buddha. It has absorbed twelve previous identities and is still hungry.

Traits: Haunted, Curious | **Strongest skills:** Black Magic, Space Magic, Ritual

White Devil

Amlamarjari amlamarjari

Name: "Sour Cat" (Sanskrit: *amla* = sour/acidic, *mārjārī* = cat)

[White Devil](#) · [Reveler](#)

Party girl who found ways to patch up her comrades long after they couldn't go on. Her healing is excellent. Her bedside manner is chaotic.

Traits: Generous, Night Drinker | **Strongest skills:** White Magic, Comedy, Alchemy

Ayurmangala ayurmangala

Name: "Auspicious Life" / "Blessed Lifespan" (Sanskrit: *āyur* = life/lifespan, *maṅgala* = auspicious/fortunate)

[White Devil](#) · [Scholar](#)

Fascinated by humanoid anatomy the way a botanist is fascinated by plants. Can be persuaded to forego vivisection of party members — keeping them alive is, after all, a more interesting experiment.

Traits: Curious, Fastidious | **Strongest skills:** Medicine, Daggers, Alchemy

Vimohini vimohini

Name: "The Great Enchantress" / "She Who Bewilders All" (Sanskrit: *vi* = intensifier, *mohinī* = one who enchants/deludes)

White Devil · Penitent

In life, a mystic whose visions were so vivid that entire communities reshaped themselves around her prophecies. She wasn't lying. She genuinely saw another reality. In hell, the visions have teeth.

Traits: Dreamer, Haunted | **Strongest skills:** Enchantment, Summoning, Guile

27.2 Hungry Ghost companions (23)

Rolang

Drupchen drupchen

Name: "Great Achiever" / "Great Practice" (Tibetan: *sgrub chen*)

Rolang · Monk

Performed every ritual, recited every text, accumulated every merit point. Believed none of it. He is in the hungry ghost realm, which he finds philosophically interesting now that he can no longer attribute it to coincidence.

Traits: Lapsed, Stubborn | **Strongest skills:** Ritual, Yoga, Maces

Tsering tsering

Name: "Long Life" (Tibetan: *tshe ring*)

Rolang · Shambler

Worked every day of his life with diligence and nothing to show for it. No time to rest, no time to reflect. He is still moving, still laboring. He is not entirely sure why.

Traits: Stubborn, War-hardened | **Strongest skills:** Axes, Armor, Logistics

Preserved

Khedrup khedrup

Name: "Accomplished Scholar" (Tibetan: *mkhas grub* = learned one who has achieved)

Preserved · Charnel Yogi

Treated the dharma as a system to be optimized. Found every multiplying formula, every auspicious day, every legitimate shortcut. He preserved himself flawlessly. He is still in the hungry ghost realm. He is reviewing his calculations.

Traits: Stubborn, Superstitious | **Strongest skills:** Alchemy, Ritual, Black Magic

Mehr mehr

Name: "Sun" / "Love" (Persian: *mehr*)

Preserved · Priest

Tall, one-eyed, recovered from a tar pit with most of her prophecies intact. The one that failed was accurate. The court simply did not want to hear it.

Traits: Sharp-eyed, Brave | **Strongest skills:** Fire Magic, Space Magic, Medicine

Rasabhava rasabhava

Name: "Essence of Being" / "Becoming of Mercury" (Sanskrit: *rasa* = essence/juice/mercury in alchemy, *bhava* = being/existence)

Preserved · Charnel Yogi

His formula for eternal preservation was correct in every detail. He finished mixing it the night before he died. He has had some time to consider the timing.

Traits: Curious, Composed | **Strongest skills:** Alchemy, Summoning, Enchantment

Saka saka

Name: "Arrow" (Tibetan) — also the name of an ancient steppe people

Preserved · Hunter

Desiccated by the white salt flats of a desert that keeps its dead well. Still carrying the composite bow he carved from horn and sinew. Still knows which direction the game runs.

Traits: Patient, Stubborn | **Strongest skills:** Ranged, Guile, Logistics

Skeleton

Hustle Bones hustle_bones

Name: English — a trader who never stops dealing, even after death

Skeleton · Merchant

Has traded his finger joints for better deals, his ribs for bulk discounts, and one femur for something he won't discuss. Still in profit, last he checked.

Traits: Greedy, Gambler | **Strongest skills:** Trade, Logistics, Earth Magic

Nurse Bones nurse_bones

Name: English — a healer reduced to her most literal form

Skeleton · Healer

Non-violent by choice. She patches up whoever needs patching up, including enemies, which the party finds occasionally inconvenient.

Traits: Generous, Devout | **Strongest skills:** White Magic, Medicine, Grace

Dralha

Temba temba

Name: "The Teaching" / "Dharma" (Tibetan: *bstan pa* = the doctrine of the Buddha)

Dralha · Warrior

Outcast at twelve. Followed at twenty. United the clans at thirty-five through sheer force of demonstrated possibility — showing them what happened when people stopped fighting each other long enough to eat. He never stopped being the outcast kid trying to feed people through a bad winter.

Traits: Generous, Brave | **Strongest skills:** Leadership, Swords, Armor

Gyelpo

Durvasa durvasa

Name: "Hard to Live With" (Sanskrit: *dur* = difficult, *vāsa* = dwelling/abiding) — the name of a legendarily wrathful sage in Hindu mythology

Gyelpo · Plague Victim

Professional curse-caster, contract work only, reliable until his final commission. His target had a solid practice of the Devourer of Curses. The invoice was never collected.

Traits: Blood-handed, Stubborn | **Strongest skills:** Sorcery, Air Magic, Ritual

Gomchen gomchen

Name: "Great Meditator" (Tibetan: *sgom chen*)

Gyelpo · Monk

A master of ten thousand sutras who found that political dominance within the monastery walls required a different kind of mastery. He acquired it. He was very good at it. He is here.

Traits: Lapsed, Vain | **Strongest skills:** Ritual, Sorcery, Leadership

Dré

Chöki choki

Name: "Dharma Joy" / "Joyful in the Teaching" (Tibetan: *chos skyid*)

Dré · Wanderer

Left to gather in the forest. Came back to find the village gone — a flash flood, no warning, nothing left. Drowned herself in the same river three days later. Still here, still not sure what she is waiting for.

Traits: Grief-struck, Melancholic | **Strongest skills:** Water Magic, Enchantment, Logistics

Nangwa nangwa

Name: "Light" / "Appearance" / "Clarity" (Tibetan: *snang ba*)

Dré · Scholar

Died mid-sentence, mid-proof, mid-thought. The argument is almost certainly sound. He just needs a moment to finish it. He has needed this moment for quite some time now.

Traits: Curious, Stubborn | **Strongest skills:** Learning, Space Magic, Enchantment

Vetala

Prashan prashan

Name: "The Question" (Sanskrit: *praśna* = question, riddle)

Vetala · Scholar

Spent centuries asking riddles at crossroads. When the charnel grounds ran short of interesting passersby, he went looking for them. He is still looking for the question no one can answer.

Traits: Curious, Sharp Memory | **Strongest skills:** Learning, Persuasion, Ritual

Shaza

Marmajna marmajna

Name: "Knower of Vital Points" (Sanskrit: *marma* = vital point/vulnerable spot, *jñā* = one who knows)

Shaza · Healer

A physician of genuine skill who understood the body as a system of resources. He began with cadavers. The logic that followed was, he still insists, impeccable. Exactly where the line was — he is still working on that.

Traits: Curious, Stubborn | **Strongest skills:** Medicine, Alchemy, Sorcery

Vilasa vilasa

Name: "Playful Grace" / "Coquetry" (Sanskrit: *vilāsa* = sport/play/charm/dalliance)

Shaza · Noble

Boredom is a dangerous condition in a man without constraints and an unshakeable certainty of his own superiority. He passed through every conventional pleasure and kept going. By the end, the only question was what came next.

Traits: Vain, Greedy | **Strongest skills:** Persuasion, Guile, Black Magic

Yidag

Kripana kripana

Name: "Miser" / "The Wretched One" (Sanskrit: *kṛpaṇa* = miser, pitiable person)

Yidag · Merchant

A wealthy man who spent nothing, ate little, and wore his clothing until it dissolved. He died sitting on his gold. In the hungry ghost realm, the gold is gone. The hunger is not.

Traits: Greedy, Addiction | **Strongest skills:** Trade, Thievery, Daggers

Yasha yasha

Name: "Fame" / "Glory" (Sanskrit: *yaśas* = renown, reputation)

Yidag · Bone Dancer

Always one performance away from being truly seen, truly remembered. Still performing. The halls are empty now but the hunger for recognition does not consult the audience.

Traits: Vain, Melancholic | **Strongest skills:** Performance, Persuasion, Comedy

Silver Skeleton

Nyingje nyingje

Name: "Compassion" (Tibetan: *snying rje*)

Silver Skeleton · Monk

Made a vow to remain until every being in this realm found its way out. Still here. Still trying. Probably the oldest being in the charnel grounds, and the least troubled by it.

Traits: Patient, Devout | **Strongest skills:** Yoga, White Magic, Medicine

Copper Skeleton

Shantipala shantipala

Name: "Guardian of Peace" (Sanskrit: *śānti* = peace, *pāla* = protector)

Copper Skeleton · Diplomat

Brokered peace between enemies by naming what each side secretly needed and daring them to deny it out loud. Now performs the same service at the Skeleton King's copper mirror court, with mixed results.

Traits: Trusting, Generous | **Strongest skills:** Persuasion, Leadership, Fire Magic

Golden Skeleton

Peldon peldon

Name: "Glorious Lamp" (Tibetan: *dpal sgron*)

Golden Skeleton · Merchant

Ran the village market for forty years. Knew every price, every shortage, every family's circumstances. Indispensable and invisible in equal measure. She finds she cannot stop being useful.

Traits: Generous, Patient | **Strongest skills:** Logistics, Trade, Medicine

Iron Skeleton

Iron Oath iron_oath

Name: English — a vow made in iron; unbreakable and unyielding

Iron Skeleton · Former Soldier

His commanding officer fell in battle three hundred years ago. The order to stand down was never transmitted. He kept his post. He is not pleased about having been relieved of it.

Traits: Stubborn, War-hardened | **Strongest skills:** Swords, Might, Armor

Turquoise Skeleton

The Chronicler the_chronicler

Name: English — one who records history

Turquoise Skeleton · Bone Dancer

Remembers the genealogies of peoples who left no other trace anywhere in the six worlds. Recites them anyway. Someone has to.

Traits: Sharp Memory, Melancholic | **Strongest skills:** Learning, Performance, Comedy

27.3 Animal companions (52)

Naga

Anavatapta anavatapta

Naga · Vizier of the Deep Court · Ocean

Forty years of naga court administration and not one raised voice. He can find the sentence that ends an argument, and he has never once enjoyed using it.

Traits: Patient, Composed | **Strongest skills:** Persuasion, Water Magic, Grace

Shesharati shesharati

Naga · Seer of Currents · Ocean

Reads the tide the way other people read faces, and has stopped pretending this is a metaphor. She left the palace because the court wanted prophecies and she only had weather.

Traits: Patient, Curious | **Strongest skills:** Water Magic, Sorcery, Enchantment

Yaksha

Sthanumati sthanumati

Yaksha · Meadow Ward · Meadow

Maintains the standing stones nobody else remembers the purpose of. She does not know either. She maintains them anyway, on the grounds that somebody clearly meant it.

Traits: Devout, Stubborn | **Strongest skills:** Armor, Maces, Earth Magic

Bhramara

Madhuvrata madhuvrata

Bhramara · Swarm Caller · Meadow

One voice in a hive of four thousand, seconded to the surface for reasons the hive has not explained to them either. Sings in three parts by themselves.

Traits: Curious, Night Owl | **Strongest skills:** Performance, Summoning, Comedy

Karka

Kambu kambu

Karka · Coral Guard · Ocean

Held one gap in the reef wall for nineteen years. Nothing got past. He does not consider this an achievement — it was simply his place in this life.

Traits: Stubborn, Brave | **Strongest skills:** Armor, Spears, Might

Vajradanti vajradanti

Karka · Vent Warden · Ocean

Farms the boiling seams where the water comes up from under the world. Everything she knows about sorcery she worked out alone, at depth, with only the spirits to correct her.

Traits: Hard of Hearing, Iron Stomach | **Strongest skills:** Fire Magic, Water Magic, Sorcery

Matsya

Minakshi minakshi

Matsya · Sea-Silk Dancer · Ocean

Dances the shoal-turns that keep a school alive — a thousand bodies changing direction as one. Out of the water she is merely extraordinary.

Traits: Attractive, Quick | **Strongest skills:** Performance, Water Magic, Grace

Makara

Setubandha setubandha

Makara · Walker Between Worlds · Ocean

Walks the line between salt and fresh, deep and shallow, this realm and the next. Claims the boundaries are the only places where anything real happens.

Traits: Curious, Night Owl | **Strongest skills:** Water Magic, Black Magic, Space Magic

Timingila timingila

Makara · Hunter of the Open Current · Ocean

Hunts alone in water where the light does not reach. Speaks rarely and with long pauses, as though surfacing between each sentence.

Traits: Quick, Suspicious | **Strongest skills:** Spears, Ranged, Water Magic

Dura

Valmika valmika

Dura · Tunneler · Meadow

Digs. Braces. Digs again. Has opinions about load-bearing timber that she will share whether or not you have expressed interest in load-bearing timber.

Traits: Stubborn, Iron Stomach | **Strongest skills:** Might, Maces, Enchantment

Khadga

Nirvikalpa nirvikalpa

Khadga · Jaina · Meadow

Will not eat anything that had a face and will not walk where she cannot see the ground, in case of insects. Weighs two thousand pounds. Has never harmed anything.

Traits: Devout, Patient | **Strongest skills:** Yoga, White Magic, Persuasion

Tikshnashringa tikshnashringa

Khadga · Blade Contemplative · Meadow

Charges in a straight line and meditates on why. Twenty years of practice have not made him stop charging; they have made him extremely precise about when.

Traits: Composed, Stubborn | **Strongest skills:** Swords, Might, Yoga

Patanga

Agnishikha agnishikha

Patanga · Flame-Seeker · Meadow

Stands facing the sun with his wings spread until sundown, every day, for eleven years. Wants the fire. Does not enter it. That is the whole practice and there is nothing else.

Traits: Devout, Addiction | **Strongest skills:** Yoga, Fire Magic, Ritual

Rakshasa

Kabandha kabandha

Rakshasa · Lord of the Range · Forest

Three valleys, every tree marked, and not one of them argued about it. Finds the party's habit of walking through places baffling.

Traits: Stubborn, Composed | **Strongest skills:** Might, Martial Arts, Armor

Khara khara

Rakshasa · Maneater · Forest

The one from the stories. She is aware there are stories, and has opinions about which of them are accurate.

Traits: Patient, Hunter | **Strongest skills:** Guile, Unarmed, Grace

Kruddha krুদ্ধha

Rakshasa · Blood Drinker · Forest

Taking such delight in the hunt, in the kill, in the tearing of flesh, must have a downside. But this is for the philosophers to ponder another day.

Traits: Hot-tempered, Hunter | **Strongest skills:** Might, Guile, Black Magic

Nishkasita nishkasita

Rakshasa · Hedonist · Forest

A rakshasa who stopped hunting and started entertaining. His reasons are as mysterious as his past, but some things may be gleaned from how he handles a knife when cutting an onion.

Traits: Vain, Haunted | **Strongest skills:** Performance, Daggers, Grace

Takshari takshari

Rakshasa · Ancestor Priest · Forest

Keeps the trophies, pours the mead, remembers which hero did what and to whom. The dead are less trouble than the living and better company.

Traits: Superstitious, Mourner | **Strongest skills:** Ritual, White Magic, Black Magic

Unmatta unmatta

Rakshasa · The Sensate · Forest

Came down from the hills for one season of silk and wine and has not gone back in nine years. Insists he could stop. Nobody has asked him to.

Traits: Flirt, Gourmand | **Strongest skills:** Persuasion, Fire Magic, Performance

Varaha

Ekadamshttra ekadamshttra

Varaha · Sounder Matron · Forest

Ran a sounder of forty for thirty years and handed it on cleanly, a rare event indeed. She eats last, sleeps with one eye open.

Traits: Patient, Generous | **Strongest skills:** Might, Earth Magic, Logistics

Ghoraka ghoraka

Varaha · Ancestor Priest · Forest

When the wolves killed his sounder, he found a source of power deep in the grief and bloodlust. Now the wolves keep their distance, seeing the oily smoke seeping from his eyes.

Traits: Grudge-bearer, Mourner | **Strongest skills:** Black Magic, Ritual, Earth Magic

Kandali kandali

Varaha · Mycelium Tender · Forest

Cultivates the fungal network under nine acres of forest floor and speaks about it the way other people speak about family. Do not step on the nine-year patch.

Traits: Fastidious, Patient | **Strongest skills:** Medicine, Earth Magic, Alchemy

Mrichha mrichha

Varaha · Truffle Hunter · Forest

Disappearing from one clearing and appearing in another, bringing food and medicine. Others say they travel through the roots and hyphae.

Traits: Patient, Pilgrim | **Strongest skills:** Earth Magic, Space Magic, Yoga

Phulla phulla

Varaha · Mycelium Tender · Forest

They started out with oyster mushrooms, then learned the way of the morel, finally graduated to the little ones that speak. Now, they work healing and miracles, insisting the power flows through, not from them.

Traits: Ascetic, Warm-hearted | **Strongest skills:** White Magic, Alchemy, Earth Magic

Runborn runborn

Varaha · Young Brave · Forest

Exiled from the sounder for killing a brother in a fit of rage. Now they seek redemption and self-discipline.

Traits: Hot-tempered, Homesick | **Strongest skills:** Might, Unarmed, Yoga

Vasuda vasuda

Varaha · Hunter · Forest

Born too early, she was the weakest in the sounder. She found inventive ways to pull her weight and protect her kin.

Traits: Quick, Frail | **Strongest skills:** Ranged, Armor, Logistics

Marjara

Chitrangada chitrangada

Marjara · Canopy Ambush · Forest

Pale as limestone, silent as weather, entirely without malice. Killing is what a cat does, isn't it?

Traits: Quick, Brave | **Strongest skills:** Unarmed, Guile, Grace

Kshanaka kshanaka

Marjara · Pleasure Dancer · Forest

How can you resist her eyes, her hips, her laughter? Wait — what did you say happened to her last master?

Traits: Attractive, Flirt | **Strongest skills:** Persuasion, Guile, Grace

Mandaka mandaka

Marjara · Cat Burglar · Forest

Third storey, no rope, and back down with the thing before the dog finished turning its head. Considers locks a personal challenge.

Traits: Quick, Covetous | **Strongest skills:** Thievery, Guile, Grace

Niloka niloka

Marjara · Healer · Forest

I'm here to patch you up, child. Why? And why do you care, pray tell?

Traits: Secret-bearer, Clear-eyed | **Strongest skills:** White Magic, Medicine, Black Magic

Rupaka rupaka

Marjara · Witch · Forest

They tried to change her into a proper little lady and failed. She tried to change them into newts and succeeded.

Traits: Stubborn, Suspicious | **Strongest skills:** Sorcery, Black Magic, Enchantment

Sthiraka sthiraka

Marjara · Monk · Forest

The changing texture of the light is enough to keep him entertained. Better not bother him without a good reason, though.

Traits: Patient, Ascetic | **Strongest skills:** Martial Arts, Yoga, Grace

Varika varika

Marjara · Smuggler · Forest

This, my lord? How did I acquire it? Oh, from a middle aged person of no particular characteristics, of course!

Traits: Greedy, Gossip | **Strongest skills:** Trade, Thievery, Daggers

Gana

Dhvanika dhvanika

Gana · Herbalist · Forest

She may be old, but she is far from senile — a glint in her eye, and in the knife she keeps half hidden.

Traits: Patient, Sharp Memory | **Strongest skills:** Water Magic, Medicine, Daggers

Dirghajihva dirghajihva

Gana · Elder Voice · Forest

She has never given an order; she yawns at the right moment and the argument ends. Now, greater challenges await her and the pack is fretful to see her go.

Traits: Composed, Brave | **Strongest skills:** Ranged, Persuasion, Leadership

Ghoshaka ghoshaka

Gana · Warrior · Forest

Born on a city wall a long way from any forest, and paid up as of last spring. Now he has come to the homeland of his ancestors for the first time in his life.

Traits: Stubborn, Pilgrim | **Strongest skills:** Armor, Swords, Spears

Nadaka nadaka

Gana · Forest Singer · Forest

They were always a strange kid, unnerving others unable to figure out what it is that they really think, behind all those jokes and evasion.

Traits: Curious, Secret-bearer | **Strongest skills:** Comedy, Space Magic, Guile

Saramaya saramaya

Gana · Herbalist · Forest

Gathers what grows on the ridge and treats whatever she finds hurt. Charges nothing, accepts everything, and so today again she went to sleep on an empty stomach.

Traits: Generous, Trusting | **Strongest skills:** Medicine, White Magic, Earth Magic

Sphotana sphotana

Gana · Monk · Forest

He woke from a nightmare to see his lair and his fur on fire, spreading from the dream into the world through his eyes and his breath. Now exiled, Sphotana seeks a way to contain his gifts.

Traits: Homesick, Dreamer | **Strongest skills:** Fire Magic, Sorcery, Yoga

Mriga

Chapala chapa'la

Mriga · Spy · Forest

Born between two wheels on a road nobody names. Prices everything, respects nothing, and is already somewhere else.

Traits: Flirt, Gossip | **Strongest skills:** Daggers, Trade, Performance

Enakshi enakshi

Mriga · Antler Speaker · Forest

Has held the clearing eleven seasons running and has never once had to touch anyone to do it.

Traits: Vain, Duelist | **Strongest skills:** Performance, Grace, Persuasion

Himasara himasara

Mriga · Merchant · Forest

Comes down from the snow every second season with moss, antler-glue and prices. Has never once been cold in your presence and finds your fire excessive.

Traits: Scrimper, Iron Stomach | **Strongest skills:** Trade, Medicine, Spears

Nayanika nayanika

Mriga · Reveler · Forest

Taken young, sold south, came back in silk with rings on every point. Holds your eye a moment past comfortable. Answers nothing.

Traits: Attractive, Secret-bearer | **Strongest skills:** Enchantment, Performance, Yoga

Sarangi sarangi

Mriga · Scholar · Forest

Comes back to the same meadow every dozen years for the tea and the grass, in that order. Remembers the meadow better than the meadow remembers itself.

Traits: Ascetic, Tea Ritualist | **Strongest skills:** Earth Magic, White Magic, Alchemy

Shrutidhara shrutidhara

Mriga · Scarred Lead · Forest

Wrong twice in thirty years, and she will tell you about both before she tells you her name. Walks at the back now, where she can see everyone.

Traits: Patient, Sharp Memory | **Strongest skills:** Leadership, Persuasion, Logistics

Trinavati trinavati

Mriga · Slope Herbalist · Forest

Knows the slope, the clay, and which of the two you need. Will not be hurried down a mountain.

Traits: Warm-hearted, Early Riser | **Strongest skills:** Medicine, Earth Magic, White Magic

Vishanin vishanin

Mriga · Antler Speaker · Forest

Met a boar head-on once and has been dining out on it since. The scar is real. So, annoyingly, is the boar's.

Traits: Brave, Braggart | **Strongest skills:** Unarmed, Might, Grace

Vanara

Brihannala brihannala

Vanara · Troop Elder · Forest

Retired from leading a troop of sixty and now collects stolen objects and unlikely stories with equal enthusiasm. Will trade you either for something you don't know.

Traits: Curious, Sharp Memory | **Strongest skills:** Thievery, Learning, Trade

Phalguna phalguna

Vanara · Jugaad · Forest

Can build anything out of anything given an afternoon and no supervision. Every solution is temporary, every temporary solution has now been load-bearing for six years.

Traits: Curious, Forgetful | **Strongest skills:** Smithing, Sorcery, Ranged

Shyena

Balavardhana balavardhana

Shyena · Sky Lord · Meadow

Holds a thermal over the meadow as his personal fief. Comes down only to settle things, and settles them quickly.

Traits: Hot-tempered, Brave | **Strongest skills:** Grace, Might, Swords

Kapota

Phenaka phenaka

Kapota · Post Runner · Ocean

Carries messages up and down four hundred miles of coast and knows every waypoint, every teahouse, and everyone's business. Delivers all of it, whether or not it was the message.

Traits: Quick, Curious | **Strongest skills:** Grace, Ranged, Logistics

Uluka

Kshudraka kshudraka

Uluka · Fortune Seeker · Meadow

Trades in omens, debts, and things people would rather forget they said. Nocturnal, immaculately polite, and never once has she been the one holding the loss.

Traits: Greedy, Night Owl | **Strongest skills:** Guile, Black Magic, Space Magic

Part V: Writing for Six Worlds

28. What is written, and what needs you

This is a practical list of where writing is wanted, from Olaf's own to-do list, reworded for you.

1. Prose in the existing realms

- **A human pass over AI-drafted prose.** The animal realm's 47 zone events, the hungry ghost realm's 34 gap-filling events, the three hungry-ghost boss and pass-guardian events, and all 24 animal-realm companion bios were drafted by an AI assistant, not by Olaf. They are functional but want a human voice. This is the largest single item.
- **Events with no checks.** 53 events have only grey choices. The target is at least two meaningful (blue or yellow) options per event.
- **Perk flavour.** About 500 of 600 perks have no flavour line at all.

2. New events

- **Hell event chains** from Olaf's original list that were never written: a soul caravan ambush, a devil deserter, a contraband deal, a corrupted simple, a chained pilgrim, a rival party.
- **More trait events and relationship events** (chapter 13). Only eleven exist.
- **Realm-specific rest events:** "something stirs in the night" scenes for resting in hell and in the hungry ghost realm.
- **Quests.** There are three, all in Hell. The hungry ghost and animal realms have none. A quest is a short chain of steps tracked on a board.
- **Boss and miniboss scenes.** Hungry ghost candidates: the Bone Lord (an earth-magic undead commander), the Great Devourer (a shaza), the Mirror of the Setting Sun (a copper construct), the Matriarch of All Longing (a yidag).

3. Whole realms

Human, Asura and God (chapter 22). Each needs the full set: map, bestiary, events, companions, backgrounds, shops, bosses, names.

4. Systems waiting for content

- **Realm-specific wounds and diseases.** Five exist; ten would be better. Wanted: an arrow wound, a poisoned wound, spiritual corruption (which medicine cannot fix and needs ritual or yoga), hungry-ghost malnutrition, animal parasites, hell frostbite and burns.
- **Consumables and equipment with realm flavour.** Legendary items exist but ordinary gear is thin on character.
- **Spells:** astrological spells (Space), a divination-and-eclipse family for the Sun Priestess companion, and prosperity spells (Earth) that give teeth to merchant builds.
- **Ritual implements' special properties** (a conch's pacifying aura, a bone's life-drain, sky-iron's void field).
- **Yidam and Dharmapala:** a full roster of deities (translated names, mantras, spells, masks, offerings, vows) and a quest chain for each.
- **Masks:** a whole design space (wrathful, peaceful, animal-form, ritual, deity masks) for the face slot.

5. Open design questions your writing may inform

- Should Yoga let the player glimpse their karma, or should it stay mysterious?
- What should it cost to bring someone back from the dead in an event?
- Should the world move without the player (external events, rival parties, changing places)?
- Should battlefields be marked after a fight?

29. Style guide

Names

- **Place names** are compounds in Tibetan and Sanskrit. Hell uses short Tibetan roots for what the place *is*: *ro* corpse, *nag* black, *dur* charnel, *trak* blood, *mun* darkness, *jik* fear, *shi* death, *bar* blazing, *me* fire, *gang* glacier, *drang* cold, *drag* fierce; joined to place endings such as *khar* (fort), *thang* (plain), *yul* (land), *lung* (valley), *ri* (mountain), *dzong* (citadel), *pura* (city). Examples: Rokhar, Nagthang, Krodhapura.
- **Companion names** come with a meaning. Hell and hungry-ghost companions draw on Tibetan, Sanskrit and other sources (even Egyptian or English) and each has a note on the root. A name that sounds like what the person is, or ironically unlike it, is a good one.
- **Animal-realm births name themselves by their own philosophy** (Appendix C): what parents wish over a child, what a place is called. Follow the logic of the birth.

Sacred things

- Deities' names are **translated**, not transliterated ("Adamantine Terrifier"); this respects the tradition without publishing what is held to be secret, while keeping the meaning.
- Mantras, offerings and rites should be shown accurately and without mockery. Humour should come from *people* (their vanity, bureaucracy, appetites), not from the practice itself.

Voice

- Short, concrete, a little dry. One telling detail beats a paragraph of description.
- Choices are written in the imperative or as a short action: "Draw your weapon and attack", "Give teachings".
- Outcome text answers the choice immediately. It can be a single line of dialogue.
- Dialogue uses straight double quotes and speech in the characters' own idiom.
- Never state the karmic or moral meaning of a choice in the text.

Karma guidelines used so far

- Feeding, sharing, compassion, release, practice: God and Human.
- Greed, hoarding, clinging: Hungry Ghost.
- Violence against the weak or against the dead: Hell, Asura.
- Trickery and theft: Animal, Hungry Ghost.
- Buddhist practice (Yoga, Ritual): God.

Skill and attribute names to use for gates

Blue choices need a requirement. Use the 35 skill names in chapter 7 and the seven attributes in chapter 6; or a trait by name (chapter 9). A requirement should make narrative sense: a ritual needs Ritual, a lie needs Guile or Persuasion, a bargain needs Trade.

30. How to send work back

Write however is comfortable: a document, a spreadsheet, plain text. What matters is that each piece of text can be matched to the thing it replaces or extends. Every event, companion, birth, background, trait and shop in this guide carries an `id` in small grey type; quote it and the text can be put in its place.

Editing existing text

Copy the `id`, then give the new version of whichever fields you changed (title, body, a choice, an outcome, a companion's bio). Fields you do not mention stay as they are.

New events

Use the structure of the printed ones: a title; a body; choices, each marked grey, blue or yellow; for blue, the requirement (a skill and level, an attribute and number, or a trait); for yellow, what is being rolled on and *two* outcomes; and an outcome for each. Add a suggested karma line if you have a view; Olaf will check it.

New companions

A name (with its meaning), a birth, a background, up to three or four traits from chapter 9, the three skills they are strongest in, and the short bio. Check the birth and background are compatible: backgrounds listed for specific births can only be taken by those births.

Notes for Olaf

Anything that feels off (a requirement that does not suit the scene, a choice that never opens, a missing path) is worth flagging in the margin, not silently changing. The game is untested end to end; fresh eyes will catch things that checks cannot.

Appendices

Appendix A: Glossary

Asura	The jealous gods, titans who war with the gods. Fifth realm on the wheel in this game's order.
Background	What a character did before the story begins. Grants starting skills and gear.
Birth	The kind of being a character is reborn as; formerly called 'race' in the code.
Bön	The indigenous shamanic religion of the Tibetan plateau that predates Buddhism.
Charnel ground	A place where corpses are left; a meditation site in Tibetan Buddhism and a region of the Hungry Ghost realm.
Dharmapala	A protector deity. In the game, a worldly, transactional relationship built by offerings at shrines.
Domain	A special spell group born where two elements meet; learned only through rare events.
Element	One of five: Space, Air, Fire, Water, Earth. Each skill belongs to one.
Event	A short scene with choices, met on the map or at camp.
Karma	A hidden score for each realm. The highest at death decides the next birth.
Klesha	A mental poison: delusion, desire, aversion, pride, envy.
Mandala	A sacred diagram or circle. In the game, a ritual construction that boosts spells.
Mantra	A sacred utterance repeated in practice. Accumulates at camp.
Naraka	The hell realms.
Perk	A purchased ability unlocked by a skill level.
Pretaloka	The realm of hungry ghosts (pretas).
Pressure	The push on a character's mind that events and fights apply.
Sadhana	A spiritual practice. In the game, a camp activity that purifies karma.
Thangka	A Tibetan painting on cloth, with an ornate frame. The game's visual model.
Tiryakloka	The animal realm.
Trait	A standing fact about a character: inborn, racial or acquired.
Vajra	A thunderbolt-diamond ritual implement; a symbol of indestructibility.
Wisdom	The pure state each klesha can become: openness, warmth, clarity, equanimity, skilful action.
Yidam	A personal meditational deity. In the game, a deity practice with five relationship stages.

Appendix B: The realms at a glance

Realm	Births	Events	Companions	Enemy types	Places
Hell	6	79	24	45	32
Hungry Ghost	14	150	23	23	19
Animal	18	86	52	43	30
Human	4	0	0	0	0
Asura	2	0	0	0	0
God	3	0	0	0	0

Plus 33 cross-realm events, 3 enemy types shared across realms, and 10 special spell domains.

Appendix C: Animal realm naming lore

How each animal-realm birth names itself and its world: the philosophy behind its names, what parents wish over a newborn, the personal names in use and the places it has named. This is the source the realm's generated names and much of its event prose draw on. Printed as stored.

Ocean

The ocean as the naga, karka, matsya, and makara experience it — ancient, territorial, layered by depth and current. Nothing here is accidental. Every feature has been claimed or contested.

Shared geography

Shared ocean geography. These names appear in any ocean zone event text.

- **The Long Current:** The main channel — naga measure sovereignty by how much of it they hold
- **The Narrow Claim:** The coral barrier pass — karka territory
- **The Bright Below:** The bioluminescent zone in deep water — beautiful and disorienting
- **The Deep Above:** What ocean creatures call the shallows — disconcertingly lit, too exposed
- **The Path Between Worlds:** The submarine migration route from coast to deep ocean
- **The Oldest Wall:** An ancient submarine cliff claimed by makara as territorial marker
- **The Upwelling:** Where cold deep water rises — primary makara feeding ground
- **Before the Reef:** The open water approach to the coral barrier — contested, dangerous

Naga naga

Naming Philosophy. Naga hold lineage as the deepest form of identity — a name is an inheritance, a claim, a record. Children are named for what the parent hopes they will carry into the future: a current, a memory, a way of holding still. Naga names are fluid, vowel-heavy, sinuous in the mouth. A naga who has held the same thermal current for a century may rename themselves after it. Place names are events remembered: not where something is, but what happened there and who was present.

Parent Wishes: May you hold your current; May the reef remember you; May you carry the old water; May your coils be long; May nothing slip your memory

Personal Names:

- **Vasuni:** treasure-bearer; one who carries wealth of knowledge
- **Sheshara:** on the path of Shesha; one who endures at the foundation
- **Nilava:** blue-deep; one of the dark water
- **Ananthi:** endless; one without terminus
- **Srotasi:** of the current; current-born
- **Varuni:** Varuna's own; under the protection of the ocean lord
- **Kumudha:** water-lotus; one who blooms in the dark
- **Velaka:** wave-maker; one who sets things in motion
- **Sagaraka:** ocean-natured; one who holds great depth calmly
- **Timidhi:** whale-bearer; one who moves in the wake of giants

Place Names:

- **The Remembering Place:** A thermal vent where naga meet annually to recite lineage records aloud
- **The First Reef:** The ancestral territory of the oldest lineage — technically contested, practically not
- **Where the Water Changed:** Site of an ancient boundary dispute; still avoided
- **Three Coils Resting:** A particular reef formation that resembles sleeping naga — sacred, do not enter
- **The Sixty-Year Claim:** Territory held continuously by one family for sixty years — remarkable and named for it
- **The Forgetting Pool:** A disorienting current that scrambles scent trails and memory of routes — dangerous to the young

Karka karka

Naming Philosophy. Karka value endurance above all things — what is built, what is held, what does not crack. Names are given late, after the child's shell has begun to harden into its characteristic pattern. A name given too early is considered bad luck: you have named a thing before it has proven itself. Karka parents say: 'May nothing crack you.' Place names are functional and precise — defined by thermal output, structural integrity, depth to bedrock.

Parent Wishes: May your shell grow thick; May the vent sustain you; May nothing crack you; May what you hold outlast you; May the warmth find you

Personal Names:

- **Kavika:** armored one; bearing natural fortress
- **Pashanaki:** stone-natured; one of the deep rock
- **Dridava:** firm and lasting; one who does not yield
- **Kavachi:** shell-keeper; guardian of the inner form
- **Staraka:** layer-upon-layer; one built from accumulated time
- **Kholara:** shell-voice; one whose presence resonates
- **Kutaka:** of the peak; one who holds the high point
- **Durgaki:** fortress-born; one difficult to reach
- **Sthiraka:** stable one; the unmoved
- **Patharaka:** of the bedrock; deepest foundation

Place Names:

- **The Warm Arch:** Primary thermal vent complex — most productive, most contested
- **The Shell Wall:** The coral barrier reef face — karka ancestral territory
- **The Long Vigil:** A pass they have guarded for so long that 'the Long Vigil' is also a measure of time
- **The Cracking Place:** Where a notable elder's shell finally failed — remembered with respect, not grief
- **The First Warmth:** The original thermal vent the karka settled; ancestral
- **The Work Cave:** The primary shell-wright workshop; open to all karka, by tradition

Matsya matsya

Naming Philosophy. Matsya are the most present-tense of all births — they live in the immediate movement of the shoal, in the collective turn. Individual names are given by the shoal, not the parents, and usually describe the child's behavior in their first week. A matsya who always turns left at the decision point becomes Leftward. A matsya who sees the shadow first becomes Shadowwatch. Names are short because they need to carry fast across water.

Parent Wishes: May the shoal know your turn; May you be fast without hesitation; May the light find you in deep water; May you always be in the middle; May the shoal carry you

Personal Names:

- **Vela:** wave; born in the rising water
- **Tirtha:** the crossing; one who leads through difficult passages
- **Jalaki:** water-child; fully of the element
- **Tarini:** she who crosses; navigator
- **Nirupa:** formless; moves like water itself
- **Meena:** fish; the pure kind
- **Srotika:** current-rider; always in the flow
- **Tulaka:** balance; the one who holds the center of the school
- **Vegika:** swift; first in every turn
- **Hradika:** deep-hearted; goes further than the others

Place Names:

- **The Bright Wall:** The reef face where sunlight meets depth — primary hunting ground
- **The Turn:** Their regular circuit route — spoken of as a direction, not a place
- **The Deep Edge:** The depth below which the shoal does not go; understood without discussion
- **The Plenty:** A rich feeding ground; no permanent name, moves with the season
- **Below the Ship:** The sunken wreck — avoided, but useful as a landmark
- **The Open Crossing:** The exposed water gap in migration — fear and necessity together

Makara makara

Naming Philosophy. Makara are so ancient and solitary that their naming traditions are barely traditions — more like geological habits. They rarely name children; often a young makara goes unnamed until they have held a territory for a season, at which point they name themselves after its most characteristic feature. Place names are simple, definitive, and never change. 'The Trench' has been the Trench for longer than anything else in the ocean has a name.

Parent Wishes: May you be unmoved; May the deep receive you; May you outlast the current; May you become the current; May you need no one

Personal Names:

- **Gambhira:** profound depth; one of the serious deep
- **Jaladhi:** ocean-holder; one who contains multitudes
- **Mahajala:** great water; of the vast kind
- **Arnav:** ocean; not a creature of it but an expression of it
- **Timingila:** whale-swallower; one who exceeds what seems possible
- **Abdhini:** ocean-born; from nothing but depth
- **Samudra:** meeting of waters; where all currents converge
- **Talapriya:** beloved of the bottom; at home in the deep dark

Place Names:

- **The Trench:** The deepest point. No other name needed.
- **The Upwelling:** Where the cold rises — primary feeding ground, claimed
- **The Oldest Wall:** The ancient submarine cliff — makara territorial boundary since before memory
- **Before the Reef:** The open approach water — the makara's anteroom
- **The Stillness:** A zone of no current — disliked but used for ambush

Forest

The forest as eight overlapping territories — no creature sees the whole of it. Every tree is a claim, every stream a boundary. The forest is not a place; it is an aggregate of contested presences.

Shared geography

Shared forest geography visible across births.

- **The Canopy:** The upper world — vanara territory, shyena hunting ground, marjara observation post
- **The Old Root Hall:** Where the largest tree's roots create natural chambers — dura burrow below, vanara sleep above
- **The Contested Mud:** A wetland zone where varaha and rakshasa territories overlap uneasily
- **The Scent Line:** The invisible boundary between predator territories — every species reads it differently
- **The River Ford:** The crossing point — temporary neutral ground; all know not to hunt here
- **The Mycelium Net:** The dura name for the underground fungal network; others sense it but don't discuss it
- **The Fruiting Season Place:** The vanara name for any tree producing right now — location changes, name is permanent

Rakshasa rakshasa

Naming Philosophy. Rakshasa are intensely solitary and dislike compound identities. A name should be one clean word, like a strike. Parents name children late — not at birth but at the first successful hunt, which is when a rakshasa becomes someone worth naming. Before that, they are simply 'the young one.' Place names are possessives: not 'The Ridge' but 'My Ridge.' Not 'The Territory' but 'My Territory.' They use personal place names rarely, only when speaking to others.

Parent Wishes: May you be the one who is not found; May your hunger be clean; May you be solitary and sufficient; May the mark distinguish you; May you need no one and want for nothing

Personal Names:

- **Vikrama:** valor; one who proves themselves by action
- **Khara:** sharp; the precision of the predator
- **Kruddha:** the fierce one; intensity as identity
- **Dravaka:** the runner; speed without hesitation
- **Takshari:** maker-of-marks; the one who shapes the world around them
- **Kabandha:** the trunk; formidable presence without explanation
- **Unmatta:** the frenzied one; unstoppable once started
- **Mrigavah:** hunter; using the prey-word for the predator, which is deliberate
- **Shatru:** the enemy; to be feared before known

Place Names:

- **The Three-Day Territory:** Their current hunting circuit — defined by travel time, not landmarks
- **The Mango Kill:** A remembered hunt site near a fruiting tree — told to other rakshasa as coordinates
- **The Ridge Where They Wait:** Their primary ambush position
- **The Long Hunger:** A stretch of poor territory between productive ones — a warning, not a name
- **The Wrong Side:** Anywhere they do not go; attributed to another's territory without acknowledgment
- **The Scratch Tree:** The territorial marker tree; the scratches are the claim

Varaha varaha

Naming Philosophy. Varaha are deeply communal — the sounder is the unit of identity, not the individual. Names are given at birth and reflect the circumstances: the quality of the earth beneath the birth-site, what the sounder was doing, what the weather was doing. A child born during heavy rain near good tubers might become Mudblessed. A child born when the sounder was moving fast through danger becomes Runborn. Names are warm, round, earthy.

Parent Wishes: May you root deep; May your sounder be strong; May the earth tell you its secrets; May you be steadfast; May the mud welcome you

Personal Names:

- **Bhumika:** earth-natured; of the ground, always
- **Medaka:** rich-earth-born; from the fat soil
- **Vasuda:** earth-giver; one who finds nourishment for others
- **Ghoraka:** deep and formidable; takes up space in the world
- **Mudrika:** of the seal; one who marks and is marked
- **Phulla:** blooming-open; expanding outward with confidence
- **Mrichha:** earth-born truly; arrived from below
- **Sthana:** the place; one who belongs where they are
- **Stamba:** the pillar; holds the sounder together

Place Names:

- **The Deep Mud:** The best wallowing site — seasonal, but returned to every year
- **The Sounder's Path:** Their regular rooting circuit — memorized by every member
- **Where Mother Found the Truffle:** A specific spot, remembered by name across generations
- **The Old Roots:** Ancient forest floor with rich tubers — the sounder's most productive ground
- **The Safe Hollow:** Where the sounder sleeps; location changes seasonally but always called this
- **Where Tusk-Elder Was Born:** Ancestral birthplace of the lineage matriarch; visited ceremonially

Marjara marjara

Naming Philosophy. Marjara are solitary and precise. They pay close attention to light — the quality of dappled forest light is the aesthetic foundation of their world, both for hunting and for beauty. Names often refer to moments of perception: the instant before action, the quality of stillness, the particular light of a given hour. A parent says: 'May you see and not be seen.' Place names describe functional qualities of terrain: cover quality, sight-line distance, how the light falls at different hours.

Parent Wishes: May you see and not be seen; May your markings be precise; May you wait without urgency; May the spotted light find you; May the moment be yours

Personal Names:

- **Chitraka:** the spotted one; identity through pattern
- **Drishika:** of the sight; defined by what they perceive
- **Avadhana:** full attention; the quality of being completely present
- **Kshanaka:** of the moment; always in the exact instant
- **Sthiraka:** the still one; patience made physical
- **Mandaka:** the slow and deliberate; not slow but deliberate
- **Varika:** the precious and chosen; quality over quantity
- **Niloka:** dark medicine; healing that works in shadow
- **Rupaka:** of the form; aware of their own presence in space

Place Names:

- **The Patient Rock:** Their primary scouting boulder — good sight-lines, excellent cover
- **The Crossing:** The deer ford they watch — reliable prey approach
- **The High Branch:** Their territory's main marker — highest reachable point
- **The Spotted Light:** The forest section where dappled light through canopy creates ideal ambush conditions
- **The Long Wait:** A territory claimed after months of patient observation — named for the effort
- **The Scent Ridge:** The territorial boundary where their markings end — and another's begin
- **The Hollow Where Nothing Comes:** Poor territory, dry and avoided; named as a warning

Gana gana

Naming Philosophy. Gana name children for resonance: what the pack will hear of them. A name is meant to carry across a valley and come back changed by the distance, so the good ones are built out of sound before they are built out of meaning. A gana who has not yet been heard at range is not considered fully named.

Parent Wishes: May the pack know your voice; May your howl carry the valley; May the song live in you; May the hunt find you worthy

Personal Names:

- **Vrikavah:** wolf-voice; the howl that defines the pack
- **Nadaka:** sound-maker; one who fills the valley
- **Dhvani:** resonance; the echo after the sound
- **Ghoshaka:** the voice; announcement of presence
- **Svana:** the sound itself; presence as vibration
- **Chandraka:** moon-child; runs at night under cold light
- **Sambhrama:** ardor; speed and intensity together

Place Names:

- **The Echo Hollow:** Where howls multiply — the pack gathers here to call across distance
- **The Pack Ridge:** Territorial high point; visible from everywhere in the range
- **The Fast Run:** The chase-down terrain — open enough for full speed
- **The Singing Rock:** Where the pack convenes for ceremony; the howl here carries farthest

Mriga mriga

Naming Philosophy. Mriga name children for alertness: what they will notice that others miss. The name is a claim about attention, and it is tested early — a fawn is called by it from out of sight, and how fast the head comes up settles whether it fits. Like the gana they hold that a name should carry across a valley, but for the opposite reason: theirs has to be heard by someone already running.

Parent Wishes: May you hear what others miss; May the alarm sound through you; May the trail hold your memory; May you be first to know and last to be found

Personal Names:

- **Mriga:** the animal; pure creature-nature, neither predator nor prey
- **Rutika:** cry-born; arrived with a sound
- **Ena:** antelope-born; the dark-eyed one, seen at the edge of the clearing
- **Sarana:** the run; flight understood as a form of judgement, not fear
- **Chapala:** quick-moving; never still long enough to be settled on
- **Shruti:** the heard thing; alertness received as an inheritance
- **Trina:** grass-born; sustained by what everyone else walks over
- **Nayana:** the eye; the one who sees it first and says so

Place Names:

- **The Safe Smell:** An area with consistent wind direction — always know what is upwind
- **The Clear Ground:** Open meadow where predators can be seen at distance
- **The Alarm Tree:** The tree near which the warning bark always sounds; others know to listen
- **The Old Trail:** The ancestral migration path — walked so long it is part of the body
- **The Three-Day Run:** The distance covered in a good season's migration

Vanara vanara

Naming Philosophy. Vanara naming is semi-serious — they understand names matter but cannot resist making the moment funny. A child named at birth gets a formal aspirational name. A child who does something memorable in their first year often acquires a second name that sticks better. The formal name is used in ceremony; the second name is used in everything else. Parents say: 'May you laugh last,' which sounds like a blessing but is also practical advice.

Parent Wishes: May you find the high branch; May the trick come easy; May you be too quick for consequence; May you laugh last; May the fruit be there when you arrive

Personal Names:

- **Chanchal:** quick and restless; cannot be held in one place
- **Chatura:** clever; four-directional thinking
- **Vrinda:** the multitude; many things at once
- **Kalika:** bud; mischief in potential
- **Taranga:** wave-leaping; always in motion
- **Kelika:** play; defined by the game
- **Laghima:** lightness; the quality of being almost nothing, so cannot be caught
- **Phullika:** blooming and bouncing; excessive enthusiasm
- **Kapisha:** tawny-lord; the old honorific, used ironically

Place Names:

- **The Long Bridge:** A canopy route between two fruiting areas — vanara maintain it by keeping branches connected
- **Where the Trick Was Done:** Site of a famous escape or prank; coordinates used in storytelling
- **The High Place:** Simply: the highest accessible point in their territory
- **The Good Fruit Tree:** Self-explanatory. Location shifts seasonally but the name stays.
- **The Falling Place:** Where a notable fall happened — told with varying degrees of sympathy depending on the audience
- **The Old Alliance:** Where this troop meets with another; neutral ground, old agreement

Meadow

The meadow as five very different births experience it — open sky, exposed ground, no cover. Existence here is negotiated differently than in the forest: everything can see everything. Territory is marked with more desperation and defended with more commitment.

Shared geography

Shared meadow geography.

- **The Great Watering Hole:** The universal truce-point — every species drinks here, the truce is older than any current inhabitant
- **The Migration Road:** The path worn by thousands of years of seasonal movement; visible from above
- **The Termite Cathedral:** The great mound; not a landmark but a place of gathering for practitioners
- **The Open Ground:** Meadow beyond meadow — featureless to outsiders, rich in meaning to those who live here
- **The Kopje:** A rocky outcrop rising from the plain — khadga dust-wallow below, yaksha marker above, shyena hunting perch above that
- **The Seasonal Flood Line:** The furthest reach of the wet-season water; everything within is temporarily different

Yaksha yaksha

Naming Philosophy. Yaksha are guardians by nature — they define themselves by what they hold, not what they pursue. Names are formal, often compound, and describe a function as much as a person. A yaksha child is named at the moment they first demonstrate awareness of a boundary — when they stand at the edge of something and know, without being told, that they must not let it be crossed. Place names are ancient, maintained across generations, and often coincide with actual boundary markers.

Parent Wishes: May you guard what matters; May the boundary hold; May nothing cross that you did not allow; May you be remembered at the contract; May your word bind as well as stone

Personal Names:

- **Shailaka:** of the mountain-stone; permanent as the earth itself
- **Vanaraksha:** forest-guardian; the protector at the boundary of wildness
- **Kshetraka:** of the sacred field; one who knows what is cultivated and what is not
- **Rakshaka:** protector; the function as the name
- **Dharanaka:** the holding one; maintenance as identity
- **Maryadaka:** boundary-keeper; the one who knows the line
- **Palaka:** guardian; brief and final
- **Samraksha:** complete protection; total in their vigilance
- **Sthapanaka:** the establisher; one who sets things in place

Place Names:

- **The Sacred Boundary:** The line they hold; any Yaksha territory's primary name is this
- **The Old Contract:** Where an ancient territorial agreement was struck; the terms are still in force
- **The Offering Ground:** Where tribute is left by those passing through; accepted without thanks, which is the etiquette
- **The Judgment Place:** Where disputes between territories are resolved; both sides must approach from downwind
- **The Eastern Post:** Directional boundary markers; each direction has its Post, visited in rotation
- **The Guardian Tree:** The single tree at the center of the territory; often ancient, always marked

Dura dura

Naming Philosophy. Dura measure everything in depth and duration. A name should describe what endures — what goes below, what is made carefully, what roots support. Children are named at the moment they first help dig: they take a stone from the tunnel, they carry earth up and out, and in that moment the sounder watches to see how they work. The name comes from the quality of that first effort. A deliberate child becomes Careful-Layer. A strong child becomes Deep-Strike.

Parent Wishes: May the earth receive you; May your tunnels be true; May what you make outlast you; May the roots guide you; May you know what is below

Personal Names:

- **Khanaka:** the digger; one who makes the way
- **Staraka:** layer-by-layer; built from accumulated careful work
- **Garbhika:** of the interior; most at home in the deep
- **Mulaka:** root-seeker; follows what holds things together
- **Prithvika:** of the broad earth; sees the whole stratum
- **Khataka:** excavated; shaped by the work of digging
- **Nilara:** blue-dark earth; the richest soil, deep down
- **Adhaka:** the below one; always headed further down
- **Mritika:** of the good soil; knows quality earth by feel

Place Names:

- **The Deep Warren:** The main tunnel complex — named for depth, not breadth
- **The Root Hall:** Where the largest tree's root system creates natural chambers; coolest and quietest
- **The Seven Exits:** A complex junction designed for escape — the number is the guarantee
- **The Dry Level:** Upper tunnels used in wet season — less comfortable, safer from flooding
- **The First Dig:** The ancestral burrow site; always maintained even when no longer primary
- **The Breathing Hole:** Emergency ventilation shaft; everyone knows its location, no one mentions it to outsiders

Khadga khadga

Naming Philosophy. Khadga are in no hurry — they name children slowly, watching first. A newborn khadga may go unnamed for an entire season while the parent observes. When the name comes, it is final and heavy, like a footfall. Khadga do not give children aspirational names; they name what they see. A calm child: Stillness. A heavy child: The Great Weight. A child who charges the wall of their enclosure repeatedly: Perhaps the Wall Matters.

Parent Wishes: May you be unmovable; May the mud cool you; May your horn be long; May nothing require urgency; May the plain be sufficient

Personal Names:

- **Baladhara:** strength-bearer; the one who holds force without deploying it
- **Ghanaka:** the dense and heavy; occupying space completely
- **Dhritaka:** steadiness itself; will not be moved by argument or urgency
- **Tushara:** tough and fibrous; does not break, ever
- **Sthulaka:** the massive one; presence as statement
- **Vajraka:** diamond-born; impenetrable
- **Sthirava:** stability; the ground beneath the ground
- **Maheshaka:** of the great; one who does not need to prove it

Place Names:

- **The Good Mud:** The best wallow — visited in seasonal rotation, remembered across years
- **The Claim:** Their current territory; not named further, the claim is enough
- **The Thorn Wall:** Natural thornscrub boundary — they did not build it but they maintain it by not breaking through
- **The Long Shade:** A particular stand of trees that provides afternoon relief — crucial in dry season
- **Where the Horn Broke:** Site of an old territorial battle — remembered as landmark even by those who didn't witness it
- **The Deep Drink:** The waterhole — visited at exact same time every day, by individual habit of each khadga

Bhramara bhramara

Naming Philosophy. Bhramara individual names are ceremonial constructions given by the hive mind collectively. What the hive names you is what you are. Names describe roles compressed into sounds — a long title reduced to something that can be waggle-danced in seconds. The individual barely matters; the function matters entirely. Place names are extremely precise: defined by flower species, altitude, humidity, and time of day.

Parent Wishes: May the hive dream you; May your dance be understood; May the flower know your name; May you find the right flower; May the hive never lose you

Personal Names:

- **Madhuka:** honey-carrier; the essential function
- **Bhramari:** wandering one; the scout, the finder
- **Pushpaka:** flower-keeper; maintains the relationship with the source
- **Rasika:** essence-seeker; extracts the fundamental
- **Kosaka:** comb-builder; architecture of the collective
- **Nrityaka:** dancer; communicates what cannot be spoken
- **Gunaka:** thread-holder; the quality that connects all parts
- **Samajaka:** of the assembly; defined by belonging to the whole

Place Names:

- **The Flower Mountain:** A hillside rich in the hive's preferred species — primary foraging ground
- **The Dance Floor:** The interior chamber where recruitment dances orient the foragers
- **The Dry Crossing:** Dangerous territory between flower sources — no landmarks, high exposure
- **The Enemy Tree:** A location they defend against; not feared, just contested
- **The Sweet Ridge:** Most productive foraging zone; name is also a direction communicated in dance

Patanga patanga

Naming Philosophy. Patanga naming is aspirational to the point of ecstasy. They name children for what the child will burn toward. A name is a trajectory. To name a child 'Flame-Seeker' is not prediction; it is summoning. Patanga names are given at the moment of first strong light-response — when the infant turns instinctively toward any source of brightness. That first turn is the name.

Parent Wishes: May the light find you worthy; May you spiral without fear; May you choose the fire that illuminates; May your offering be accepted; May you burn completely

Personal Names:

- **Jyotika:** light-seeker; defined by what they move toward
- **Dipaka:** lamp-born; arrived in illumination
- **Tapasvi:** the austerity-one; heat as spiritual practice
- **Ulkika:** meteor-child; a trajectory, not a destination
- **Prakasha:** illumination; not the light but the effect of light
- **Tejasa:** brilliance-born; the quality of fire before the fire
- **Jvalita:** blazing; fully committed
- **Havanaka:** offering-born; came into existence as a gift

Place Names:

- **The Flame That Continues:** The eternal fire temple — seen from outside as the only reliable light source in the meadow
- **The Last Light:** Metaphorical: the point of the journey, whatever form it takes
- **The Offering Ground:** Where past patanga have gone to the flame; remembered without sadness
- **The Cold Place:** Anywhere they do not go; an anti-name, a direction to avoid

Sky births (found in every region)

Sky births live across all three zones but share a vertical orientation — they measure the world in altitude, thermal quality, and wind. Their place names are mostly aerial; their ground-level place names are functional minimums.

Shared geography

- **The Good Thermal:** A reliable rising air column — different birds name different thermals; same name, different location
- **The Assembly Tree:** The conference tree on the ridge between forest and meadow — visible from both territories
- **The High Seat:** Any primary nesting site — shyena use this as a proper noun; kapota use it as a category
- **The Migration Flyway:** The aerial corridor used by all migrating species; everyone knows it, no one owns it
- **The Storm Approach:** The direction from which weather comes — all bird cultures orient by this

Shyena shyena

Naming Philosophy. Shyena measure the world in height and angle. Their territory is not the ground below but the airspace above it — measured in altitude bands, thermal columns, and sight lines. A name should describe either a quality of speed or a quality of vision. Children are named at first flight: what the parent saw in the first stoop tells them the name.

Parent Wishes: May the stoop be clean; May the thermal hold you; May the sky be loyal; May you arrive first; May your eye be exact

Personal Names:

- **Shyeni:** hawk-born; the pure kind
- **Pratapin:** burning swift; speed as fire
- **Drishtara:** far-seeing; the eye that reaches
- **Kshepa:** the hurler; released downward at speed
- **Drutaka:** swift one; first in every moment
- **Urdhvaka:** the upward one; always gaining altitude
- **Antariksha:** sky-space; not in the sky but of it
- **Vegaka:** velocity; the state before impact

Place Names:

- **The Good Thermal:** A reliable rising column — named per location, this is the best one in range
- **The High Seat:** Main nesting site; a cliff ledge with unobstructed approach and retreat
- **The Stooping Ground:** Hunting territory below — named from the air, looking down
- **The Ridge Wind:** A reliable updraft on a cliff face — used for gaining altitude without effort
- **The First Light:** The position where the morning hunt begins — a compass direction more than a place
- **The Wrong Altitude:** An airspace controlled by another — acknowledged without confrontation

Kapota kapota

Naming Philosophy. Kapota name things by the history of information that passed through them. A tree is named for the most important message ever relayed from it. A waypoint is named for the journey that established it. Personal names commemorate arrivals and departures — the moment of return is considered most naming-worthy. 'The One Who Came Back' is always an honored name. In the Conference of the Birds, every pilgrim is renamed upon arrival.

Parent Wishes: May the message reach; May you know all the routes; May the flock gather at your call; May you be the one who comes back; May your news be good

Personal Names:

- **Kapoti:** dove-pure; the essential form
- **Dutaka:** messenger; function as identity
- **Pathaka:** route-holder; carries the map in the body
- **Agamaka:** the arriving one; always in motion toward
- **Mitraka:** friend-born; the relational one
- **Vartaka:** news-carrier; the medium is the message
- **Yatraka:** pilgrim; the journey is the form
- **Samaptika:** the completer; the one who finishes

Place Names:

- **The Assembly Tree:** The conference location — both a specific tree and a category
- **The Safe Roost:** Reliable overnight stop on a long route; evaluated by predator pressure, not comfort
- **Where the News Came From:** Origin point of an important piece of information — used as coordinates
- **The Welcome Branch:** Where returning pilgrims are greeted; a specific branch of the Assembly Tree
- **The First Waypoint:** The start of the established route; most pilgrims begin here
- **The Long Route:** The difficult migratory path — named for its character, not its length

Uluka uluka

Naming Philosophy. Uluka are the most deliberate namers of all births. They watch a child for a full season before naming. What is observed in that season becomes the name — not what is hoped, but what is seen. 'You cannot name what you haven't watched,' they say. Place names are named for specific events of perception: what was heard there, what was seen from there, what was understood in that location for the first time.

Parent Wishes: May you see what others miss; May the night be generous; May you carry the knowledge; May silence serve you; May you understand before you act

Personal Names:

- **Uluki:** owl-pure; the complete form of the birth
- **Nishaka:** night-born; arrived in the generous dark
- **Jnanaka:** knowledge-bearer; carries it as identity
- **Drishti:** sight; vision as the whole self
- **Munika:** the silent sage; speaks rarely, nothing lost in the silence
- **Ratriki:** night-child; the dark is home
- **Viveka:** discernment; the exact quality that distinguishes the uluka
- **Nishadaka:** night-dweller; fully inhabited in darkness

Place Names:

- **The Silent Rock:** Primary perch — chosen for the quality of the surrounding silence
- **The Hunting Dark:** Night territory — not a place but a time-within-place
- **The Hollow Where I Heard:** A specific discovery site — personalised, not transferable
- **The Old Tree:** Ancestral roost; old enough that no uluka alive remembers who first claimed it
- **The Dreaming Point:** Where they wait for dawn — a specific spot, used by many generations
- **The Bright Danger:** The open daylight meadow — avoided, disorienting, remembered as warning